

THE COMPLETE HERMETIC
& ROSICRUCIAN GRIMOIRE

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*Being an account of the Hermetic, alchemical, Solomonic and
Rosicrucian traditions — with the sources of each dated and
attributed, and the practices set out so that they may be
performed*



TWENTY-NINE CHAPTERS · WITH FIFTY-TWO DIAGRAMS AND
THREE PLATES

The Complete Hermetic & Rosicrucian Grimoire. This edition is assembled from primary and scholarly sources, each of which is dated and attributed in the Sources & Bibliography. Where a source is out of copyright this is marked; where it is not, it is cited rather than reproduced at length.

The text of the Emerald Tablet in Chapter 6 is Isaac Newton's, from Keynes MS 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, in the transcription of *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton* (Indiana University, 2010). The ritual texts in Chapters 7, 8, 15 and 20 are drawn from Mathers's translation of the *Key of Solomon* (1889) and from Crowley's *Liber O* (1909), both in the public domain. The planetary herbs in Chapter 20 are Culpeper's, from *The Complete Herbal* (1653). All diagrams were drawn for this book.

Four rounds of source verification were carried out on this text, the later ones adversarial. What they found — including the errors they found in the corrections themselves — is recorded in the note at the head of the bibliography rather than quietly removed.

Presented for historical, educational and research purposes as part of humanity's spiritual heritage.

When a source tells you a text is ancient, check the date yourself. It is often findable in a few minutes, and it is frequently not what you were told.

THE CLOSING ADVICE OF THIS BOOK

⚠ Important Safety Warning

This grimoire describes practices drawn from living and historical traditions. Approach it with care:

- Proper preparation and protection are essential
- Use only for ethical intentions
- Respect the forces involved
- Follow all safety protocols
- Begin with beginner-level content only

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Every source in this grimoire is **dated and attributed**. Where a teaching commonly presented as ancient turns out to be medieval, early-modern or modern, the chapter says so and gives the date. This is not scepticism for its own sake — it is the only way a book claiming to rest on primary sources can be checked. Knowing that a practice was written in 1888 rather than in remote antiquity takes nothing away from it; it tells you what you are actually holding.

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Introduction to Hermetic Philosophy

The Hermetic tradition is one of the most enduring systems of spiritual thought in Western history. Rooted in the meeting of Greek philosophy and Egyptian religion in Roman Alexandria, and transmitted through Arabic, Byzantine and Renaissance hands before reaching us, it offers a framework for thinking about the nature of reality, the structure of consciousness, and the relation between the human being and the divine. Its central conviction is that the cosmos is intelligible, that it is ordered by correspondence rather than by accident, and that a person willing to work at it can come to know that order directly rather than on authority.

That tradition is genuinely old. Some of what is taught in its name is not, and this book's whole method is to say, at every step, which is which.

The name on the door

The tradition is named for **Hermes Trismegistus** — Hermes the Thrice-Greatest — and the name is itself a summary of the meeting that produced it. In Ptolemaic Egypt the Greek settlers identified their Hermes, god of speech and writing, with Thoth, the ibis-headed Egyptian god of the moon, of reckoning and of the scribal art, lord of the sacred word. The epithet grew out of Egyptian usage rather than Greek: Egyptian piety intensified a god's greatness by repeating it, and the decree carved on the Rosetta Stone still calls him, in its Greek, "Hermes the great and great" — Mead's study of the epithet traces the path from that doubled "great" to the superlative "thrice-greatest," and finds Hermes already *trismegas* in a Greek magical prayer and thrice-blessed in inscriptions. To late antiquity he was not a god so much as the most ancient of sages: the books that circulated under his name were held to preserve the primordial wisdom of Egypt, older than Plato, older than Moses.

The Renaissance believed exactly that, and built on it; the belief was wrong, and Chapter 2 tells the story of how it was formed and how it fell. What matters here is the shape of the claim: a body of writing whose authority rested on its supposed antiquity, and whose actual content — late-antique, Greek-Egyptian, philosophically serious — turned out to matter more than the false date ever did.

The primary text speaks

Before any modern summary, hear the corpus itself. The first treatise of the *Corpus Hermeticum* — the *Poimandres*, in Mead’s English the “Man-Shepherd” — opens the whole literature with a scene of instruction:

It chanced once on a time my mind was meditating on the things that are, my thought was raised to a great height, the senses of my body being held back — just as men are who are weighed down with sleep after a fill of food, or from fatigue of body. Methought a Being more than vast, in size beyond all bounds, called out my name and saith: What wouldst thou hear and see, and what hast thou in mind to learn and know? And I do say: Who art thou? He saith: I am Man-Shepherd, Mind of all-masterhood; I know what thou desirest and I’m with thee everywhere. [And] I reply: I long to learn the things that are, and comprehend their nature, and know God. This is, I said, what I desire to hear. He answered back to me: Hold in thy mind all thou wouldst know, and I will teach thee.

That is the tradition’s mission statement — *to learn the things that are, and comprehend their nature, and know God* — and it is put as a request any reader can make. The eleventh treatise states the method, in the most audacious passage the corpus contains. Mind is speaking to Hermes:

If, then, thou dost not make thyself like unto God, thou canst not know Him. For like is knowable to like [alone]. Make, [then,] thyself to grow to the same stature as the Greatness which transcends all measure; leap forth from every body; transcend all Time; become Eternity; and [thus] shalt thou know God. Conceiving nothing is impossible unto thyself, think thyself deathless and able to know all, — all arts, all sciences, the way of every life. ... Think that thou art at the same time in every place, — in earth, in sea, in sky; not yet begotten, in the womb, young, old, [and] dead, in after-death conditions. And if thou knowest all these things at once, — times, places, doings, qualities, and quantities; thou canst know God. But if thou lockest up thy soul within thy body, and dost debase it, saying: I nothing know; I nothing can; I fear the sea; I cannot scale the sky; I know not who I was, who I shall be; — what is there [then] between [thy] God and thee?

Everything else in this book — the meditations, the rituals, the tables of hours and herbs, the laboratory — descends from some historical attempt to take those two passages seriously: to treat the knowledge of the order of things as a practice rather than an opinion. The square brackets in both quotations are Mead's own editorial marks, and the ellipsis omits one sentence on collecting the senses of all creatures into oneself.

The shape of the literature

“Hermetic” covers more ground than any one shelf. Scholarship divides the ancient material into the *philosophical* Hermetica — the treatises on God, cosmos and mind quoted above — and the *technical* Hermetica: astrology, alchemy, the properties of stones and plants, and the making of talismans, all likewise under Hermes' name and often older than the philosophical treatises. The later tradition kept both streams and added its own. This book covers the whole span, and the map is worth one table:

STRATUM	WHAT IT IS	WHERE IN THIS BOOK
Philosophical Hermetica	Greek treatises on mind, cosmos and ascent, c. 100–300 CE	I–II
Technical Hermetica	astrology, alchemy, stones, plants, talismans, under the same name	V–VI, XX–XXIII
The magical papyri	working spells of the same Greek-Egyptian world	IX
The Solomonic and demonological literature	mediaeval and early modern conjuring books and their catalogues	X–XI
Kabbalah and its Christian adoption	the Hebrew mystical stream the Renaissance joined to Hermes	IV
Rosicrucian and Enochian episodes	the seventeenth century’s inventions and their fruits	XII, XIV
The modern systematisation	the Golden Dawn synthesis and its descendants	XIII, XV, XXVII
The working apparatus	rites, correspondences, materials, timing, and the laboratory	VII–VIII, XVI–XIX, XXIV–XXVI, XXVIII– XXIX

How to use this book

Every chapter heading carries one of three tags. **Beginner** chapters assume nothing and are safe to work from directly. **Advanced** chapters assume the beginner material and, where they are operative, assume the protections that go with it. **Reference** chapters are history and apparatus — they are for reading and checking rather than working. Two honest paths run through the book. The reader’s path takes the chapters in order, and the book is arranged so that every claim is dated before it is used. The practitioner’s path is shorter and starts with four weeks of foundations: first the regimen of Chapter 16 and

a working journal, with the breathing and the vibration of a divine name from Chapter 7; second, the opening and closing of Chapter 8, performed plainly until they are familiar; third, the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram from Chapter 15, daily; fourth, the Middle Pillar of Chapter 13 added to the banishing, and the first review of the journal against the month’s record. Everything further — talismans, scrying, the hours, geomancy, evocation — builds on that footing, and each chapter states its own prerequisites. Neither path requires belief; both require the journal, because the tradition’s own test is whether the record bears the claim out.

The seven principles that almost every modern introduction — including the earlier version of this book — puts first are the right place to see the book’s method in action, because they are the tradition’s most famous summary and its most instructively misdated one.

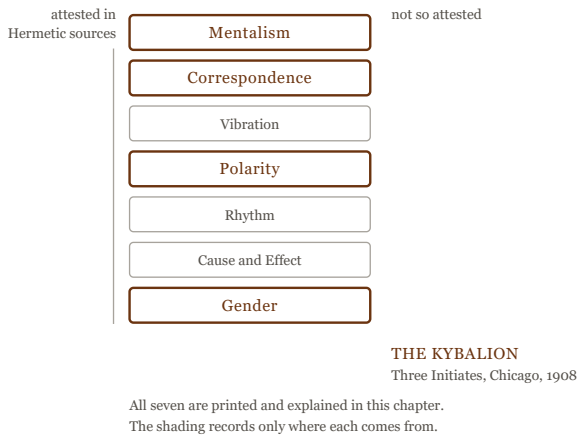


FIG. 1 — THE SEVEN PRINCIPLES, AND HOW MUCH OF EACH IS OLD. On Nicholas Chapel’s analysis, four of the seven have real footing in ancient and medieval Hermetic writing; three do not, and Vibration he traces to eighteenth-century associationist psychology rather than to Hermeticism at all. The chapter keeps all seven, because a source is not made worthless by being younger than advertised — but it says which is which. Drawn for this book from the analysis cited below.

The Seven Hermetic Principles

1. The Principle of Mentalism: “The All is Mind; the Universe is Mental.” The fundamental nature of reality is mental, and all phenomena are manifestations of a Universal Mind.

2. The Principle of Correspondence: “As above, so below; as below, so above.” There is harmony and correspondence between the different planes of existence, such that what is learned of one informs understanding of another. (This is the principle with the deepest pedigree of the seven, and the familiar wording is itself a modern compression of it, as Chapter 6 sets out; three others are also attested in the ancient material, as the note below explains.)

3. The Principle of Vibration: “Nothing rests; everything moves; everything vibrates.” All matter and energy exist in constant motion, differing in frequency rather than in kind.

4. The Principle of Polarity: “Everything is dual; everything has poles; everything has its pair of opposites.” Opposites are identical in nature and different only in degree, so that heat and cold, or love and hate, are positions on a single scale.

5. The Principle of Rhythm: “Everything flows, out and in; everything has its tides; all things rise and fall.” Phenomena manifest in cycles, and the pendulum swing in one direction implies its return.

6. The Principle of Cause and Effect: “Every cause has its effect; every effect has its cause.” Nothing happens by chance; what looks like chance is a cause not yet perceived.

7. The Principle of Gender: “Gender is in everything; everything has its masculine and feminine principles.” All creation proceeds from the interaction of an active and a receptive principle, on every plane and not merely the physical.

WHERE THESE PRINCIPLES ACTUALLY COME FROM

These seven principles derive from *The Kybalion*, published in 1908 under the pseudonym “Three Initiates” and generally attributed to William Walker Atkinson (1862–1932), a pioneer of the American New Thought movement. They are not found as a set in the ancient Hermetic writings.

Some of the material has genuine ancestry. Nicholas E. Chapel, in the most detailed study of the question, finds at least four of the seven principles clearly attested within Hermetic sources — mentalism, correspondence, polarity and gender have real footing in ancient and medieval Hermetic texts. Others do not. Chapel’s specific claim about vibration is an argument about origin: the principle “originated in the middle of the 18th century with the British philosopher and medical doctor David Hartley (1705–1757),” and is by now so common in modern spiritual writing “that it bears no comment.” That derivation is Chapel’s own reconstruction across some hundred and sixty years; his supporting citation is to a study of Hartley’s associationism rather than to anything linking Hartley to Atkinson, so it is given here as his argument rather than as a documented line of descent. His overall conclusion is that “the longstanding supposition that *The Kybalion* is consonant with Hermetic philosophy as an historical current is one that is erroneous and in need of revision.”

The title is itself a puzzle. Chapel notes that the word “takes the form of a Greek noun, but has no meaning in that language or any other,” and judges it “the more likely explanation that the title was chosen as an allusion” to Kabbalah or to Cybele, “to insinuate a link to antiquity.”

None of which means the seven principles are worthless. They are a lucid, teachable summary that has introduced more people to Hermetic thinking than any ancient text ever did, and they are set out above in full for that reason. But they are a 1908 formulation, and a book that claims to rest on primary sources has to say so. Chapter 2 deals with the attested ancient material.

What the tradition is for

Beneath the various formulations, ancient and modern, the Hermetic project is consistent in its aims. It holds that the universe is not inert — that it has structure, intelligence and direction, and that these can be investigated. It holds that the human being stands in a peculiar position, participating in both the material and the intelligible orders, and is therefore capable of understanding a cosmos that most of what exists cannot. And it holds that this understanding is transformative: to know the order of things truly is to be altered by knowing it.

This is why the tradition has always been simultaneously philosophical and practical. The meditations in Chapter 7 and the ritual structures in Chapter 8 are not decorations on the philosophy; they are how the philosophy is meant to be tested. The Hermetic claim is not that you should believe the cosmos is ordered, but that you can find out.

On ethics

The ethical position of this literature deserves stating directly, because it is easy to lose among the warnings and the symbolism. Every serious current in this tradition treats knowledge as inseparable from the character of the person holding it. The Hermetic texts frame ascent as purification: what has to be put down is not ignorance in the abstract but greed, deceit, cruelty, self-importance. The Rosicrucian manifestos made the healing of the sick without payment their first practical commitment. Agrippa insisted the magus must also be a devout philosopher, and drew a hard line against sorcery. The *Ars Notoria* asks for memory and understanding, not for power over anyone.

The practical form this takes is simple enough to state and difficult to keep. Do not work to coerce, injure, deceive, or override another person's will — this rules out a considerable amount of what the historical grimoires happily supply, which is one reason this book presents that material descriptively. Do not treat other people's crises as an opportunity. Do not charge the desperate.

Do not confuse the sensation of insight with the fact of it, and keep the habit of checking your conclusions against something outside your own enthusiasm. Where a practice touches on health, treat it as a complement to medicine and never a substitute; Chapter 16 returns to this.

These are not rules imposed on the tradition from outside. They are what the sources themselves say, when read carefully — and they are considerably more demanding than any warning box.

Sources: G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (London and Benares, 1906) public domain — the *Poimandres* opening from vol. II, pp. 3–4, and the eleventh treatise (“Mind unto Hermes”) from vol. II, pp. 187–188, both read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan [thricegreatesthe02hermuoft](https://www.archive.org/details/thricegreatesthe02hermuoft); the square brackets are Mead’s editorial marks and are retained, and each ellipsis is declared where it stands. The account of the epithet — the Rosetta Stone’s “Hermes the great and great,” the Egyptian intensive behind “thrice-greatest,” *trismegas* in a magical prayer — is Mead’s, from the prolegomena in vol. I, and is reported here rather than quoted; Mead’s scholarship is a century old and Theosophically inflected, which is why the dating of the treatises rests on the modern authorities cited in Chapter 2. Three Initiates [William Walker Atkinson], *The Kybalion: A Study of the Hermetic Philosophy of Ancient Egypt and Greece* (Chicago, 1908) public domain. Nicholas E. Chapel, “The Kybalion’s New Clothes,” *Journal of the Western Mystery Tradition* No. 24, Vol. 3 (2013) — for the four principles attested in Hermetic sources, the David Hartley origin of vibration, and the reading of the title. The reading paths and the four-week foundation are this book’s own arrangement of its own chapters.

The Hermetica and Their Transmission

The genuine foundation of Hermetic philosophy is a body of Greek writing attributed to Hermes Trismegistus — “Hermes the Thrice-Greatest,” a figure identified with the Egyptian Thoth and understood by his readers as an ancient Egyptian sage. These are the *Hermetica*. They are real, they are substantial, and their history of transmission is one of the more remarkable episodes in European intellectual life, largely because for two centuries everybody was wrong about how old they were.

What the Corpus Hermeticum is

The *Corpus Hermeticum* is a selection of **seventeen Greek treatises** — numbered I to XVIII, with no treatise XV transmitted. It survives as a collection whose date and compiler are unknown; it is first attested in Byzantium, in the writings of Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078), who is a reader of the collection rather than its compiler, and the surviving manuscripts are late medieval and later. The religio-philosophical *Hermetica* themselves were, for the most part, produced in a relatively short span: **between the late first and the third century CE** on the common dating, though Christian Bull argues that some of the underlying material is older, stemming from at least as early as the first century BCE. They are the product of Roman-era Alexandria — Greek in language and philosophical vocabulary, Egyptian in much of their religious frame, and shaped by the Platonism of their period.

Alongside the *Corpus* proper stand several related texts. The *Asclepius* survives mainly in a Latin translation, with some Greek and Coptic fragments. The Nag Hammadi discovery yielded three Hermetic tractates in Codex VI: *The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6); the Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with its Scribal Note (VI,7a) — and that prayer also appears among the

Greek Magical Papyri, a connection worth noting; and a single continuous excerpt of the *Asclepius*, chapters 21–29 (VI,8). Further material survives as excerpts in Stobaeus — among them the long *Kore Kosmou*, the “Virgin of the World” — and as papyrus fragments.

The seventeen treatises

Because the collection is small enough to know whole, here it is whole. Mead numbers the treatises by his own count and gives the common numbering in parentheses — the difference exists because the second treatise of the old editions, the General Sermon, is lost, and because no treatise XV was ever transmitted. The one-line summaries are this book’s.

NO.	TITLE, AS MEAD'S EDITION GIVES IT	IN BRIEF
I.	Pœmandres, the Shepherd of Men	the vision: creation, fall, ascent and commission
(II.)	The General Sermon	lost; its place is marked in Mead's edition
II. (III.)	To Asclepius	space as plenum; God the cause of all
III. (IV.)	The Sacred Sermon	the creation recapitulated in brief
IV. (V.)	The Cup or Monad	the baptism of mind, offered to all who will
V. (VI.)	Though Unmanifest God Is Most Manifest	reading God from the order of the world
VI. (VII.)	In God Alone Is Good and Elsewhere Nowhere	the doctrine of the Good
VII. (VIII.)	The Greatest Ill Among Men Is Ignorance of God	the street-preaching, continued
VIII. (IX.)	That No One of Existing Things Doth Perish	change mistaken for death
IX. (X.)	On Thought and Sense	perception and understanding distinguished
X. (XI.)	The Key	the doctrine summarised whole
XI. (XII.)	Mind unto Hermes	the ascent in imagination, quoted in Chapter 1
XII. (XIII.)	About the Common Mind	the mind at work in all beings
XIII. (XIV.)	The Secret Sermon on the Mountain	rebirth; the corpus's initiation text

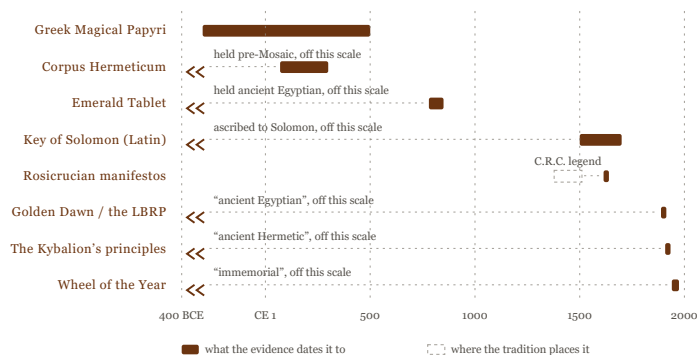


FIG. 1 — WHAT IS OLD, AND WHAT IS SAID TO BE OLD. Solid bars are the dates the evidence supports; dashed outlines are where the tradition has placed the same material. The distance between them is the subject of this book. Only the Greek Magical Papyri need no second bar. Note that the gap is not a measure of worth — the Kybalion is a useful book and the Wheel of the Year is a workable calendar; they are simply not what they are usually said to be. Compiled from the datings given in each chapter.

The Prayer of Thanksgiving

This book has referred three times to the one piece of Hermetic liturgy that survives complete — at Nag Hammadi, among the papyri of Chapter 9, and in the Latin *Asclepius* — without ever printing it. Here it is, from the close of the *Asclepius*, in G. R. S. Mead's translation of 1906.

The frame deserves to be kept with it. As the prayer is about to begin, Asclepius whispers a suggestion: that they add incense and unguents. Trismegistus is appalled — “this is like to profanation of our sacred rites... For naught is there of which He stands in need, in that He is all things, or all are in Him. But let us worship, pouring forth our thanks. For this is the best incense in God's sight, — when thanks are given to Him by men.” A tradition that filled Chapter 20 with suffumigations begins from a text that refuses them.

[We give] Thee grace, Thou highest [and] most excellent! For by Thy Grace we have received the so great Light of Thy own Gnosis.

O holy Name, fit [Name] to be adored, O Name unique, by which the Only God is to be blest through worship of [our] Sire, — [of Thee] who deignest to afford to all a Father's piety, and care, and love, and whatsoever virtue is more sweet [than these], endowing [us] with sense, [and] reason, [and] intelligence; — with sense that we may feel Thee; with reason that we may track Thee out from the appearances of things; with means of recognition that we may joy in knowing Thee.

Saved by Thy Power divine, let us rejoice that Thou hast shown Thyself to us in all Thy Fullness. Let us rejoice that Thou hast deigned to consecrate us, [still] entombed in bodies, to Eternity. For this is the sole festival of praise worthy of man, — to know Thy Majesty.

We have known Thee, yea, by the Single Sense of our intelligence, Thy Light supreme, — O Thou true Life of life, O Fecund Womb that giveth birth to every nature! We have known Thee, O Thou completely filled with the Conception from Thyself of Universal Nature! We have known Thee, O Thou Eternal Constancy!

For in the whole of this our prayer in worship of Thy Good, this favour only of Thy Goodness do we crave; — that Thou wilt keep us constant in our Love of knowing Thee, and let us ne'er be cut off from this kind of Life.

Text: *Asclepius* 41, in G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes*, vol. II (London and Benares: Theosophical Publishing Society, 1906), pp. 389–90; Mead translated Hildebrand’s Latin text of 1842 public domain. The square brackets are Mead’s, marking words supplied by the translator. After the prayer the text ends: “With this desire we [now] betake us to [our] pure and fleshless meal” — the shared vegetarian supper that closed the observance. The same prayer survives in Coptic at Nag Hammadi (VI,7) and in Greek in the Mimaout papyrus (PGM III); those versions have no public-domain translation, and Mead’s Latin-based rendering is used here for exactly that reason. Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XVIII.39, in the translation of Marcus Dods, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, ser. 1, vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (Buffalo, 1887) public domain — the words quoted above, *and even after Moses himself*, were collated against that text for this edition.

The Divine Pymander

The first treatise of the *Corpus*, the *Poimandres* or Divine Pymander — the “Divine Shepherd” — describes the creation of the cosmos and the nature of the divine, and it remains the best entry point to the collection. Its teaching, in summary:

- The Divine Mind, *Nous*, is the source of all creation
- Human beings contain a divine element capable of being awakened
- Knowledge of the divine comes through direct experience rather than through belief
- The path to that knowledge runs through purification and contemplation

What makes the *Poimandres* compelling is that it is written as a report rather than a doctrine. The narrator describes an experience — a vision, a voice, a sequence of understandings — and the reader is invited to a method, not asked for assent. That posture runs through the whole collection and explains a great deal about the tradition it founded.

The ascent through the zones

The *Poimandres* ends with the two passages that organised everything after them. The first is the ascent: after death, the narrator is taught, the man of Gnosis rises through the seven planetary zones, and at each he hands back the vice that zone had lent him:

To the first zone he gives the Energy of Growth and Waning; unto the second [zone], Device of Evils [now] de-energized; unto the third, the Guile of the Desires de-energized; unto the fourth, his Domineering Arrogance, [also] de-energized; unto the fifth, unholy Daring and the Rashness of Audacity, de-energized; unto the sixth, Striving for Wealth by evil means, deprived of its aggrandisement; and to the seventh zone, Ensnaring Falsehood, de-energized. And then, with all the energizings of the Harmony stript from him, clothed in his proper Power, he cometh to that Nature which belongs unto the Eighth, and there with those-that-are hymneth the Father.

Every planetary ladder in this book — the hours of Chapter 20, the sphere-by-sphere ascent of the Middle Pillar in Chapter 13, the very idea that the planets index stages of a work — has this passage for an ancestor, with one difference worth noticing: here the planets are not powers to be courted but customs posts, and what is paid at each is a vice. The second passage is the commission. Told that the end of those who have Gnosis is to be made one with God, the narrator hears:

Why shouldst thou then delay? Must it not be, since thou hast all received, that thou shouldst to the worthy point the way, in order that through thee the race of mortal kind may by [thy] God be saved?

And the treatise closes with the narrator in the street: “O ye people, earth-born folk, ye who have given yourselves to drunkenness and sleep and ignorance of God, be sober now, cease from your surfeit, cease to be glamourous by

irrational sleep!” The philosophical corpus, in other words, understands itself as a teaching with an obligation attached — the knower points the way — and that is the frame in which every practice in this book was originally imagined.

The transmission, and the great misdating

Here is where the story becomes genuinely interesting. Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) had been set to translate the complete works of Plato into Latin for his patron Cosimo de’ Medici — a commission of enormous significance for the Renaissance — when a manuscript of the *Corpus Hermeticum* reached Florence and Cosimo ordered him to translate Hermes first. The exemplar survives: Laurentianus LXXI, 33. He completed that translation — treatises I–XIV only, titled *Liber de potestate et sapientia Dei* and known ever after as the *Pimander* — in **1463**, dedicating it to Cosimo, who died the following year. It was first printed at Treviso by Gerardus de Lisa on 18 December **1471**, in an edition Ficino neither prepared nor authorised; that printing date is the one usually quoted, and it is not the date of the translation. Lodovico Lazzarelli (1447–1500) worked on the material as well.

Ficino interrupted Plato because he believed these texts were far older than Plato: the work of an Egyptian sage of remote antiquity, first of the *prisci theologi*, the ancient theologians, and the ultimate source from which Plato’s own theology descended. Recovering them was therefore more urgent than translating a comparatively recent philosopher.

A CORRECTION TO A STORY OFTEN TOLD ABOUT FICINO

It is frequently said — and this book said it in an earlier version — that Ficino believed the *Hermetica* *older than Moses*. He did not. Following Augustine's genealogy, which he reproduces at the head of his own preface, Ficino placed Hermes Trismegistus several generations *after* the time of Moses's birth. Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XVIII.39, has Hermetic philosophy flourishing long before the sages and philosophers of Greece but after Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph, "and even after Moses himself." The exact number of steps is not recoverable: the genealogy is corrupt in the received text of Augustine, and Yates calls Ficino's version of it garbled. The pre-Mosaic dating was one position available in Renaissance Hermeticism, and various later Hermetists and magi held it, but it should not be attributed to Ficino himself. What Ficino claimed was priority over the *Greeks*, not over scripture — which was quite enough to place these texts at the centre of European thought.

He was mistaken, and the correction came from Isaac Casaubon (1559–1614), the classical scholar. In his *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, 1614) — written against Baronius's *Annales* — Casaubon argued that the Greek *Hermetica* were written not in ancient Egypt but partly out of Plato and the Platonists and partly out of Christian scripture, and that their vocabulary was later than the Greek current even around the birth of Christ. The English here is a summary of his argument rather than a translation of any single sentence; his own dating formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*, "in those first centuries of nascent Christianity." He gives no numeric range, and the ones often quoted in his name are modern glosses. The philology was decisive. The *Hermetica* were not primordial Egyptian revelation but Graeco-Egyptian writing of the Roman period.

THE MISDATING IS THE REASON THE TRADITION EXISTS

It would be easy to file Casaubon's finding as a debunking and move on. That would miss the most important thing about it. *The error is what made Hermeticism matter.*

Had Ficino known these were second-century texts — roughly contemporary with the Church Fathers, plainly indebted to Platonism — he would very likely have finished the Plato first, and the *Corpus Hermeticum* might have remained a minor curiosity of late antique philosophy. Because he believed he was recovering the oldest wisdom in the world, the Hermetica were placed at the centre of Renaissance thought, and from there they shaped Ficino, Pico, Agrippa, Bruno, Dee, the alchemists, the Rosicrucian authors, and eventually every tradition covered in this book.

The dating was wrong. The influence was entirely real. And a tradition secure enough to record how it was founded on a philological mistake is in a stronger position than one that cannot mention it.

The Emerald Tablet

One short text deserves separate treatment, and gets it: the Emerald Tablet, the *Tabula Smaragdina*, is the single most quoted item in the entire Hermetic literature, and Chapter 6 gives its full text, its transmission and its commentary tradition. The essential point belongs here, though, because it bears directly on the question of what “ancient Hermetic” means. The Tablet is not ancient Egyptian. It is **first attested in Arabic**, in the *Kitāb Sirr al-khalīqa wa-ṣanʿat al-ṭabīʿa* (the Book of the Secret of Creation), of the **late eighth or early ninth century**.

This places the Tablet firmly in the Arabic-Islamic tradition that preserved, developed and transmitted so much of this material to medieval Europe — a debt Western esoteric writing has often obscured. The Latin versions on which every later European reading depends are translations from Arabic, beginning in the twelfth century. When the Tablet is described as a text of remote Egyptian antiquity, an entire and decisive stage of the tradition is being erased.

Reading the Hermetica today

For a reader who wants the primary texts rather than summaries, the standard modern scholarly translation is Brian Copenhaver's *Hermetica* (1992), which gives the Greek *Corpus* and the Latin *Asclepius* with a substantial introduction and notes; M. David Litwa's *Hermetica II* (2018) covers the Stobaeian excerpts, papyrus fragments and ancient testimonies. Walter Scott's four-volume *Hermetica* (1924–36) — completed after his death by A. S. Ferguson, who wholly authored the fourth volume — is older and its editorial choices are now contested, but it remains foundational. G. R. S. Mead's *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) is out of copyright and widely available online, which is why it is the version most readers encounter — but it is a Theosophically-inflected translation from before Scott's work, and it should be read alongside Copenhaver rather than instead of him.

Sources: *Corpus Hermeticum*, 17 Greek treatises (numbered I–XVIII, no XV transmitted), composed between the late first and the third century CE. The treatise table follows the titles of G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes*, vol. II (1906), read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *thricegreatesthe02hermuoft* at the contents leaves (pp. v–vii, x–xi); the scan wants the contents leaf for treatises IX–XIII, and those five titles were confirmed at the sermons’ own openings, “Mind unto Hermes” on the page image at p. 187 and the rest in the text layer, which is stated because the book’s standard is to say so. The ascent and the commission are quoted from the *Poimandres* at vol. II, pp. 16–17, read on the page images; the square brackets are Mead’s and the street-preaching follows on p. 17. Christian H. Bull, *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus* (Brill, 2018), pp. 24, 330, 457, for the dating, for the older underlying material, and for Psellos as reader rather than compiler. Ficino’s Latin translation of treatises I–XIV (the *Pimander*), completed 1463 on Cosimo’s order, from Laurentianus LXXI, 33; first printed Treviso, 18 December 1471. Paul Oskar Kristeller, *Studies in Renaissance Thought and Letters*, p. 223, is the pioneering study of the translation. Lazzarelli (1447–1500). Casaubon, *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, 1614), Exercitatio I sect. X, on the dating; his formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*. Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078) for the collection’s first attestation. Copenhaver, *Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius* (Cambridge, 1992) — in copyright. Litwa, *Hermetica II* (2018). Scott and A. S. Ferguson, *Hermetica*, 4 vols (1924–36). Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) public domain. Emerald Tablet — first attested in the *Sirr al-khalīqa*, late 8th / early 9th c. Nag Hammadi *Hermetica: Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6), Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with Scribal Note (VI,7a), *Asclepius* 21–29 (VI,8).

CHAPTER III

Sacred Geometry & Symbols

Sacred geometry is the study of the forms and proportions that recur throughout the natural world, understood in this tradition as evidence of an ordered cosmos. The claim is not that shapes possess power in themselves, but that certain forms appear so persistently — in crystal, in shell, in orbit, in the branching of plants — that they can be treated as the vocabulary in which the order of things is written. Symbols in this tradition are compressed arguments. Learning to read them is learning to hold a set of relations in mind at once, which is why they were taught as objects of contemplation rather than as decoration.

The fundamental forms

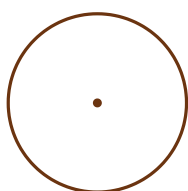
The Circle represents unity, wholeness and the infinite. Having neither beginning nor end, it stands for the eternal, and for that which contains without being contained. In practice it is also the boundary: the ritual circle of Chapter 8 and the Solomonic tradition is this figure put to work, defining an inside and an outside.

The Triangle represents the threefold structure that recurs across the tradition — heaven, earth and the human realm; or in alchemical terms the three principles of Chapter 5. Its orientation carries meaning: point upward for the ascent of the volatile and the aspiration of spirit, point downward for descent, manifestation and the fixed.

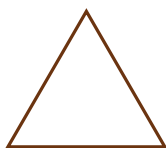
The Square represents stability, foundation, and the four elements. It is the figure of the material world and of earthly manifestation — four walls, four directions, four winds. Where the circle bounds, the square builds.

The Pentagram represents the five elements — the four with a fifth, quintessence or spirit, added — and the human microcosm. Drawn with a single unbroken line, it stands for the human being as a reflection of the cosmos, arms and legs and head at the five points. It is the central figure of the banishing practice in Chapter 15, where its specific documented history is given.

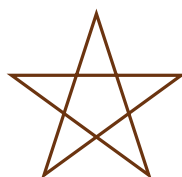
The Hexagram, two interpenetrating triangles, represents the union of the ascending and descending currents — the visual statement of “as above, so below.” In alchemical contexts it also encodes the elements by their combination of upward and downward triangles with and without a bar.



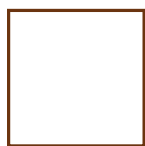
CIRCLE
unity, the boundary



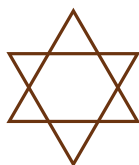
TRIANGLE
the threefold



PENTAGRAM
microcosm, five elements



SQUARE
the four elements



HEXAGRAM
macrocosm, above and below



VESICA
the two made one

FIG. 1 — THE FUNDAMENTAL FORMS. The vocabulary described in this section. Each is a compressed argument rather than a decoration, and each recurs operatively later in the book: the circle as the ritual boundary of Chapter 8, the pentagram as the figure traced in Chapter 15, the hexagram as the six-rayed star of the same rite. Drawn for this book.

The Tree of Life

The diagram that organises most Western ceremonial practice is the Qabalistic Tree of Life: ten *sephiroth*, or emanations, connected by twenty-two paths. It came into this tradition from Jewish mysticism, was extensively reworked by Christian Cabalists of the Renaissance — Agrippa among them — and reached modern practice through two translations and an order: Knorr von Rosenroth's Latin of the 1670s and 80s, Mathers's English of 1887, and then the Golden Dawn, which mapped tarot, astrology, colour and Hebrew letter onto every path. Chapter 4 follows that route with the dates, and says what the diagram is a picture of.

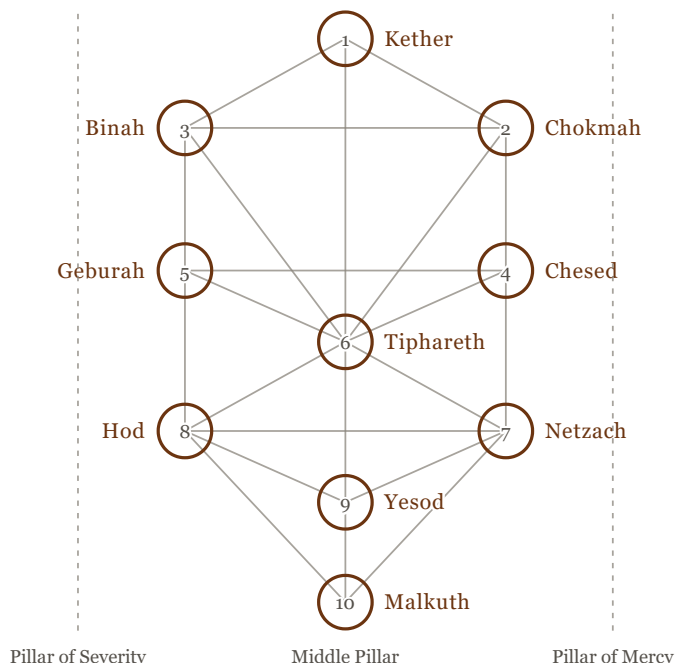


FIG. 2 — THE TREE OF LIFE. Ten sephiroth and the twenty-two paths that join them, arranged in three pillars. The numbering descends from Kether (1) to Malkuth (10). The path-count of twenty-two, matching the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, is standard in the Qabalistic literature; the assignment of particular tarot trumps and colours to particular paths is a Golden Dawn construction of the 1890s, as the paragraph below notes. Diagram drawn for this book.

Two points of honesty are owed here. First, the Christian and occult Cabala of the Renaissance is a genuine tradition with real intellectual achievements, but it is not identical to Jewish Kabbalah and should not be presented as though it speaks for it; the correspondences layered on by nineteenth-century orders are their own contribution. Second, the elaborate tables of correspondence familiar from modern handbooks — this path to that tarot trump, that sephirah to this planet and colour — are largely Golden Dawn constructions of the late nineteenth century. They are coherent, they are useful, and they are not ancient.

Constructions, not decorations

The forms above are usually met as pictures. They were originally met as *constructions* — things you make with a compass and a straightedge, in a fixed order, where each step is forced by the last. That difference matters, because a figure you have built has taught you something a figure you have looked at has not.

The foundational one is the **vesica piscis**, and it is the first proposition of Euclid. Draw a circle. Put the compass point anywhere on its circumference and draw a second circle of the same radius. The two overlap in a pointed oval, the vesica; and if you join the two centres to either point of the oval, you have an equilateral triangle, exactly, without having measured an angle. Euclid opens the *Elements* with this construction because it is the cheapest way to get a known shape out of nothing but a repeated radius.

Everything else follows cheaply. Keep stepping the same radius around the first circle and it divides the circumference into exactly six — the hexagon, and the six-petalled rosette that fills the pattern the popular literature calls the Flower of Life. The tradition read enormous significance into the fact that the radius measures its own circle six times. It is a fact about circles. Whether it is more than that is a question this chapter cannot settle, but the fact itself is free, checkable in two minutes, and genuinely surprising the first time.

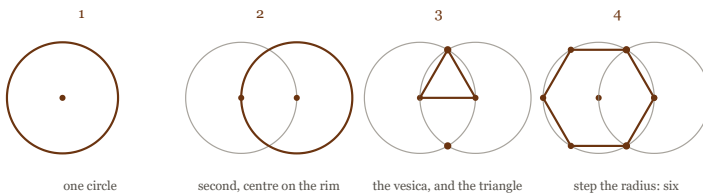


FIG. 3 — THE CONSTRUCTION, STEP BY STEP. Compass and straightedge only. The equilateral triangle in the third panel was not drawn — it was already implied by two circles of the same radius, which is Euclid's first proposition and the reason the *Elements* opens with it. In the fourth, the radius stepped round its own circle meets exactly six times. Drawn for this book.

THE CONSTRUCTION, AS A CONTEMPLATION

1. **Compass, straightedge, paper.** No ruler markings, no protractor. The constraint is the practice.
2. **Draw the first circle.** Note where you chose to put the centre, and that nothing determined it.
3. **Second circle,** centre on the first circle's edge, same radius. The vesica appears.
4. **Join the two centres to one point of the vesica.** You now have an equilateral triangle, and you did not construct it — it was already implied by the two circles.
5. **Step the radius round** the first circle: six marks, meeting exactly. Join them for the hexagon.
6. **The pentagon, which does not come free.** The radius steps round its circle six times exactly — never five. To divide a circle in five, the line must first be cut in the golden section, which is why Euclid must build the whole of Book II before the pentagon of Book IV. The working construction: draw a diameter, and a second diameter at right angles to it (bisect the straight angle at the centre). Mark the midpoint of one radius. Set the compass on that midpoint, open it to the top of the vertical diameter, and swing an arc down to cut the horizontal diameter. The distance from the top of the vertical to that cut is the side of the inscribed pentagon; step it round the circle five times, and it closes exactly. Join every second point for the pentagram.
7. **Stop and look before interpreting.** The tradition holds that the order of the figures is not arbitrary and that this is worth sitting with. Test that against what you have drawn rather than against the claim. Note what the two constructions have

taught between them: six is native to the circle, and five must be earned — which is a fact of geometry, whatever else the tradition made of it.

The five solids

The three-dimensional counterpart is the set of **Platonic solids**: the five convex figures whose faces are all the same regular polygon. There are five and there cannot be a sixth — a proof, not a doctrine, and it closes Euclid's *Elements*. Plato assigns four to the elements in the *Timaeus* and the fifth to the whole:

SOLID	FACES	ASSIGNED TO
Tetrahedron	4 triangles	fire — the sharpest, the most cutting
Cube	6 squares	earth — the most stable, the one that stacks
Octahedron	8 triangles	air
Icosahedron	20 triangles	water — the roundest, the most mobile
Dodecahedron	12 pentagons	the whole — the heavens, the fifth thing

The assignments are Plato's reasoning about shape and behaviour, not measurements: fire is the tetrahedron because it is the most acute, earth the cube because it alone tiles space. This is not physics and was never quite meant as physics. It is the correspondence principle of Chapter 1 applied to solid geometry, and it is the direct ancestor of the elemental attributions used in the ritual chapters of this book.

Where the ten and the twenty-two come from

This book uses the Tree of Life in eight chapters, and this is the one that says where its numbers come from. What the diagram is a picture of — the doctrine of emanation it descends from — is Chapter 4. The numbers come

from one short, strange, very early text: the *Sepher Yetzirah*, the Book of Formation. It is not a Hermetic work and it is not a grimoire; it is a Jewish cosmological treatise, its date disputed across several centuries, and it is the reason every diagram in this tradition has ten circles and twenty-two lines.

It opens by announcing both numbers at once:

In thirty-two wonderful Paths of Wisdom did Jah, Jehovah Tzabaoth, the God of Israel, the Elohim of the living, the King of ages, the merciful and gracious God, the exalted One, the Dweller in eternity, most high and holy — engrave his name by the three Sepharim: Numbers, Letters, and Sounds.

Ten are the ineffable Sephiroth. Twenty-two are the Letters, the Foundation of all things; there are Three Mothers, Seven Double and Twelve Simple letters.

Thirty-two paths, made of ten and twenty-two. That is the entire architecture of the diagram in Fig. 2, stated in two sentences perhaps sixteen centuries before the Golden Dawn drew it. The ten are the *sephiroth*, and the twenty-two are the letters of the Hebrew alphabet — which is why the paths of the Tree are lettered rather than merely numbered, and why the correspondences of Chapter 22 attach to letters at all.

The subdivision matters as much as the total. **Three Mothers, seven Double, twelve Simple:** three letters for the elements, seven for the planets, twelve for the signs of the zodiac. Every correspondence table in this book — the planetary hours of Chapter 20, the elemental attributions of Chapter 15, the sigil work of Chapter 22 — is a descendant of that three-way division. It is the oldest layer of the system, and it is doing the structural work everywhere.

“TEN AND NOT NINE, TEN AND NOT ELEVEN”

The text is emphatic on the number in a way that reads oddly until you notice what it is guarding against. Section 4: *“Ten is the number of the ineffable Sephiroth, ten and not nine, ten and not eleven. Understand this wisdom, and be wise in the perception.”*

That insistence bears directly on a problem the later tradition never resolved. The Middle Pillar exercise of Chapter 13 uses a centre at the throat called **Daath** — which is not one of the ten. Later Qabalah calls it the non-sephirah, the empty place on the Tree, and the manoeuvre is transparently a way of having eleven while insisting on ten. The *Sepher Yetzirah* saw the temptation coming and forbade it by name. Whether the later tradition was right to do it anyway is a real question; that it was doing something the founding text prohibits is not.

Two images from the text are worth carrying, because they say more about how this diagram was originally meant than any modern commentary. The sephiroth, it says, “have the appearance of the Lightning flash, their origin is unseen and no end is perceived” — a sequence of descent, not a static chart. And: their “ending is even as their origin, as a flame arising from a burning coal.” The Tree in Fig. 2 is drawn as furniture. Its source describes it as something happening.

The glyphs of the seven and the four

One family of symbols is used on almost every page of this book’s tables and has not yet been read as symbols: the sigils of the seven planets, and the four element-triangles. The element signs are pure geometry — the two triangles of the hexagram, barred and unbarred: fire points up, water points down, air is fire barred, earth is water barred; superimpose all four and the hexagram returns. The planetary glyphs are compounds of three strokes: the circle, the crescent and the cross. The Sun is a circle about a point; the Moon a crescent; Venus a circle over a cross; Mars a circle driven into an arrow; Mercury all

three strokes at once — crescent, circle and cross in a column; Jupiter a crescent rising over a cross; Saturn a cross over a crescent, the Sun’s opposite number in the old scheme of dignities. The popular reading of the three strokes — circle for spirit, crescent for soul, cross for matter, so that each glyph diagrams a different balance of the three — is a tidy mnemonic and is used as such in the modern literature; it is a later systematisation, not an ancient doctrine, and the glyphs themselves grew by scribal abbreviation long before anyone read them this way. Both facts can be true at once: the mnemonic works, and it was applied after the fact.

THE SEVEN, AS COMPOUNDS OF CIRCLE, CRESCENT AND CROSS



THE FOUR, AS THE HEXAGRAM TAKEN APART



FIG. 4 — THE WORKING ALPHABET. The seven planetary glyphs drawn from their component strokes, and the four element-triangles that reassemble into the hexagram. These are the symbols every table in this book uses; the spirit–soul–matter reading of the three strokes is a modern mnemonic, as the text says. Drawn for this book.

Proportion

The proportional side of sacred geometry concerns ratios that recur in growth and in classical design: the relation of a diagonal to a side, the interval ratios that produce consonance in music, and above all the division of a line “in extreme and mean ratio,” as Euclid calls it — cut so that the whole is to the greater part as the greater part is to the lesser. That cut is the golden section, about 1.618 to 1, and it is not mystical in origin: it is what the pentagon is made of. Every diagonal of a regular pentagon cuts every other in exactly this ratio, and the pentagram contains a smaller pentagon, which contains a smaller pentagon, without end — the figure is self-similar, and that, not any modern diagram, is why this ratio belongs to the five-pointed star and why Euclid

needed it before he could construct the pentagon at all. The Pythagorean discovery that harmony can be expressed as simple whole-number ratios is the root of the whole enterprise, and it is the reason this tradition has always taken mathematics to be a spiritual discipline rather than a merely useful one. That a plucked string divided in half sounds the same note an octave higher is a fact about the world, and it was received as a revelation about the world.

A caution belongs here, in keeping with the rest of this book. A great deal of popular writing on sacred geometry claims to find the golden ratio in the Parthenon, the Great Pyramid, and the proportions of the human body, with a precision the measurements do not support. The genuine cases — in phyllotaxis, in certain spirals, in deliberate Renaissance design — are interesting enough without the invented ones. Contemplating a form for what it actually is remains the practice; contemplating a form for what a diagram claims about it does not.

Sources: Pythagorean ratio theory as transmitted through Platonic and Neoplatonic writing. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Books I–II, for elemental and celestial correspondence. Tree of Life correspondences in their modern form: Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (1888 onward), published in Regardie, *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40). Constructions: Euclid, *Elements* I.1 for the vesica and the equilateral triangle, and the concluding proposition of Book XIII, that no sixth regular solid exists public domain. The elemental assignment of the five solids: Plato, *Timaeus* 55d–56c. The compass-and-straightedge contemplation above is this book’s own arrangement of a standard construction. *Sepher Yetzirah*, quoted from the translation of William Wynn Westcott, *Sepher Yetzirah: The Book of Formation and the Thirty Two Paths of Wisdom*, 2nd ed. (London: Theosophical Publishing Society, 1893), ch. I, sections 1, 2, 4, 6 and 7 public domain. Note that Westcott, who translated it, is one of the three founders of the Golden Dawn in Chapter 13 — the line from this text to the modern diagram runs through him personally. The dating of the original is disputed across several centuries and no attempt is made to settle it here. A widely circulating scan of a later Westcott edition is a 1996 reset carrying its own copyright; the 1893 printing used here does not.

Kabbalah and Its Transmission

The Tree of Life is a diagram of a doctrine, and the doctrine is **emanation**: that the divine, considered as infinite and without attribute, becomes knowable only by descending through ten stages, each issuing from the one before. The diagram is drawn in Chapter 3 and is not redrawn here. What follows is the doctrine it depicts, the literature that doctrine comes from, and the route by which a body of Jewish mystical writing became the skeleton on which English ceremonial magic was built. That route has names and dates in it, and runs through three books.

The Ein Sof, and what emanation means

Behind the ten sephiroth stands the doctrine the diagram exists to depict: the **Ein Sof**, the Boundless — the divine considered as infinite, without attribute, and therefore without anything a diagram could show. The sephiroth are not parts of it. They are how it becomes knowable at all. Ginsburg, whose 1865 essay is the spine of this chapter, puts the mechanism plainly:

the medium by which the En Soph made his existence known in the creation of the world are ten Sephiroth or intelligences, which emanated from the Boundless One... At first the En Soph, or the Aged of the Aged, or the Holy Aged, as he is alternately called, sent forth from his infinite light one spiritual substance or intelligence.

Three consequences follow, and all three change how the diagram in Chapter 3 should be read.

The first is that **the Tree is a record of a descent, not a filing system.** Chapter 3 notices this already, in the *Sepher Yetzirah*'s image of the sephiroth as a lightning flash whose origin is unseen; the doctrine of the Ein Sof is why that image is the right one. Each sephirah issues from the one before. A table of correspondences can be read in any order. This cannot.

The second is that **the top of the diagram is not the top of the system.** Kether is the first emanation, not the source; the source is not on the page and cannot be. Modern handbooks that treat Kether as the divine simply lose the distinction the whole structure exists to make.

The third is that the sephiroth are, in Ginsburg's account, both infinite and finite — "infinite and perfect when the En Soph imparts his fulness to them, and finite and imperfect when the fulness is withdrawn." They are not ten things. They are one thing at ten degrees of withdrawal.

The ten by name

The ten deserve their names in the reader's hand before any correspondence is hung on them. The table gives the modern spellings beside Ginsburg's English, and the station each holds on the figure his essay prints — the *Heavenly Man*, the Archetypal Man, the ten drawn on a human body standing inside the oval of the Boundless, which his plate labels "The Endless." That plate is the ancestor of every body-centred use of the Tree, including the Middle Pillar of Chapter 13, and Ginsburg's exposition of it ends in a sentence worth the whole table: "It is this form which the prophet Ezekiel saw in the mysterious chariot, and of which the earthly man is a faint copy."

#	NAME	GINSBURG'S ENGLISH	ON THE HEAVENLY MAN
1	Kether	the Crown	the crown upon the head
2	Chokmah	Wisdom	the head, right side
3	Binah	Intelligence	the head, left side — with the first triad, “the heart or the understanding”
4	Chesed (Gedulah)	Mercy, or Love; also Greatness	the right arm, “distributing life”
5	Geburah (Pachad)	Justice; Judicial Strength	the left arm, distributing “death”
6	Tiphereth	Beauty, or Mildness	the chest, uniting the two
7	Netzach	Firmness	the right leg
8	Hod	Splendour	the left leg
9	Yesod	Foundation, or the Basis	“the basis and source of all things”
10	Malkuth	Kingdom; also Shechinah	“the harmony of the whole Archetypal Man”

Ginsburg’s arrangement of the ten is the one every later diagram keeps. The three on the right are the Pillar of Mercy; the three on the left, “representing the principle of rigour,” the Pillar of Judgment; the four in the centre, “representing mildness,” the Middle Pillar. And the ten resolve into a “trinity of triads”: the first triad “represents the intellect; hence this triad is called the Intellectual World”; the second “represents moral qualities; hence it is designated the moral or Sensuous World”; the third “represents power and stability,” the material world. Above the whole structure, later Qabalah interposed three veils between the Ein Sof and Kether, and Mathers’s introduction gives their names as the tradition received them: “the primal AIN,

Ain, the negatively existent One, and the AIN SVP, *Ain Soph*, the limitless Expansion; while of even the AIN SVP AVR, *Ain Soph Aur*, the illimitable Light, only a dim conception can be formed.”

Why one Tree is not enough: the four worlds

The ten do not happen once. In the developed system they repeat at four levels, each produced by the one above it, and each containing a complete set of ten. Ginsburg names them in the older English spellings, which are worth seeing because they are the ones the Victorian occultists read:

I. The World of Creation, or the Briatic World, also called The Throne, which is the abode of pure spirits, and which, like its parents, consists of ten Sephiroth, or Emanations. The Briatic World, again, gave rise to II. The World of Formation, or the Jetziratic World, which is the habitation of the angels, and also consists of ten Sephiroth; whilst the Jetziratic World, again, sent forth III. The World of Action, or the Assiatic World... which contains the Spheres and matter.

Above those three stands the World of Emanation, the Atziluthic. Modern writing spells them Atziluth, Briah, Yetzirah and Assiah, and the arithmetic is the point: forty sephiroth, not ten, and any statement of the form *this sephirah means that thing* is incomplete until it says which world it is in. This is the part of the system that modern correspondence tables most often flatten, and flattening it is what turns a cosmology into a lookup table.

The Zohar, and who wrote it

The central text is the *Zohar*, the Book of Splendour: a vast Aramaic commentary on the Torah, and the source of nearly everything in the two sections above. The tradition assigns it to Rabbi Simeon ben Jochai, a second-century sage. Ginsburg tells the received story without disguising that it is a story:

No one, however, dared to write it down, till Simon ben Jochai, who lived at the time of the destruction of the second Temple. Having been condemned to death by Titus, Rabbi Simon managed to escape with his son and concealed himself in a cavern where he remained for twelve years... Scarcely had his spirit departed, when a dazzling light filled the cavern, so that no one could look at the Rabbi.

It is a good story and it is the wrong century. The *Zohar* appears in Castile at the end of the thirteenth century, in the hands of one man — Moses de León — who published it, sold it, and said he was copying an ancient manuscript. Nobody else ever saw the manuscript. The case that de León wrote it was made in print by Adolph Jellinek at Leipzig in **1851** and by Heinrich Graetz at Leipzig in **1863**, and Ginsburg, reviewing the evidence in 1865, reports it as proven: he cites Graetz for the page “where other facts are given, proving that Moses de Leon is the author of the Sohar.”

The evidence is of a familiar kind. Ginsburg’s most telling item is not a document but a mistake: de León, quoting scripture in a work published under his own name, misquotes it and then explains the misquotation — and the same error, with the same explanation built on it, appears in the *Zohar*. A second-century Galilean does not inherit a thirteenth-century Spaniard’s slip of memory. Ginsburg notes drily that commentators who did not know where the blunder came from “express their great surprise that the Sohar should explain a mis-quotation.”

HOW FAR THIS BOOK FOLLOWS THAT

The dating case set out here is the one made between 1851 and 1865, because those are the sources this edition can print. A great deal of twentieth-century scholarship has gone over the same ground and is in copyright; none of it has been consulted for this chapter, and the reader should not take the absence of a modern citation as evidence that the question stopped there. What can be shown from public-domain material is narrower and still striking: the thirteenth-century attribution was argued, in print, in the standard literature, more than thirty years before the text reached English occultism — and it reached English occultism with that argument printed inside it.

How it reached the English magicians

The *Zohar* is in Aramaic, which almost no Victorian occultist read. It arrived through two translations, and knowing which two explains a great deal about what the Golden Dawn thought it was working with.

The first is **Christian Knorr von Rosenroth’s** *Kabbala Denudata*, a Latin anthology of kabbalistic material published in the 1670s and 1680s. Ginsburg records that the Latin of the *Idra Rabba* and the *Idra Suta* — the Greater and Lesser Assemblies — is in its second volume, Frankfurt-on-the-Maine, 1684. Rosenroth is the reason the material was available to Christian Europe at all, and the reason it arrived with a Christian frame already fitted to it.

The second is **S. L. MacGregor Mathers’s** *The Kabbalah Unveiled* of 1887 — the same man, and the same London publisher, as the *Key of Solomon* of 1889 in Chapter 10. Its title page is exact about what it is: three books of the *Zohar*, not the *Zohar*, “translated into English from the Latin version of Knorr von Rosenroth, and collated with the original Chaldee and Hebrew text.” The three are the Book of Concealed Mystery and the Greater and Lesser Holy

Assemblies — precisely the sections Ginsburg says Rosenroth had put into Latin. Mathers describes his own method in the preface, and it is more careful than his reputation suggests:

My translation is principally taken from the Latin version of Knorr von Rosenroth, but I have throughout collated it with the original Chaldee and Hebrew text, and in many instances have translated directly therefrom, especially whenever the Latin rendering seemed unreliable.

So: English out of Latin out of Aramaic, checked against the Aramaic where the Latin looked wrong. Not a translation at one remove exactly, and not a direct one either. A reader building an argument on a particular English word in Mathers is standing on Rosenroth unless Mathers says otherwise, and Mathers does not usually say.

The voice of the English Zohar

What the Victorian reader actually met in Mathers deserves a hearing, because it is better than its reputation. His introduction lays out the written Kabbalah in four heads — “the Sepher Yetzirah and its dependencies; the Zohar with its developments and commentaries; the Sepher Sephiroth and its expansions; the Asch Metzareph and its symbolism” — and defines its central working term in a sentence this book’s sigil chapters could take as a motto: “The term ‘path’ is used throughout the Qabalah to signify a hieroglyphical idea, or rather the sphere of ideas, which may be attached to any glyph or symbol.” Then the translation proper opens, with the first sentence of the Book of Concealed Mystery and Mathers’s own gloss upon it:

“The Book of Concealed Mystery is the book of the equilibrium of balance.” What is here meant by the terms “equilibrium of balance”? Equilibrium is that harmony which results from the analogy of contraries, it is the dead centre where, the opposition of opposing forces being equal in strength, rest succeeds motion. It is the central point. It is the “point within the circle” of ancient symbolism. It is the living synthesis of counterbalanced power. Thus form may be described as the equilibrium of light and shade; take away either factor, and form is viewless.

“The term balance,” he continues, “is applied to the two opposite natures in each triad of the Sephiroth, their equilibrium forming the third Sephira in each ternary” — which is Ginsburg’s trinity of triads, restated as a principle of design. The text then hangs the whole structure in the negative: “Equilibrium hangeth in that region which is negatively existent” — and Mathers’s gloss on negative existence is the source of the three veils quoted above. His introduction also lists the problems the doctrine addresses — the Supreme Being, the cosmogony, the creation and destiny of angels and man, the soul, the revealed law, “the transcendental symbolism of numerals,” the mysteries of the Hebrew letters, “the equilibrium of contraries” — a syllabus that maps, item for item, onto the chapters of this book’s own practicum.

The thing Mathers is not given credit for

Here is what makes the transmission worth a chapter rather than a footnote. Mathers did not conceal the dating problem. He printed it. Section 5 of his own introduction says that on the author and origin of the Qabalah he “cannot do better than give the following extract from Dr. Ginsburg’s Essay on the Kabbalah” — and then reproduces Ginsburg at length, the same Ginsburg who had just concluded that a thirteenth-century Spaniard wrote the book.

The caveat was in the English *Zohar* from its first page, put there by the man who translated it. What happened afterwards is that the tradition kept the text and dropped the introduction. That is a different failure from the one this book

usually documents, and a more interesting one: not a source that hid its dating, but a readership that skipped it.

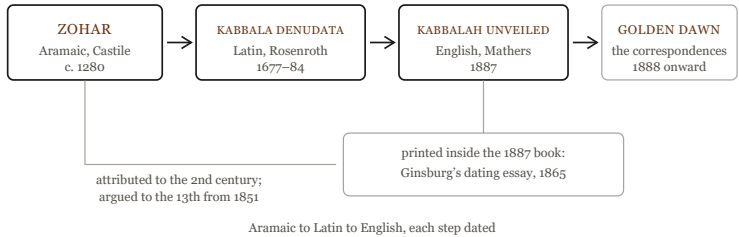


FIG. 1 — HOW THE *ZOHAR* BECAME A VICTORIAN HANDBOOK. Four stages, each with a date that can be checked. The two lower panels are the part usually left out: the thirteenth-century attribution was in print from 1851, and Mathers reproduced it in the introduction to the very translation that carried the text into English magic. The Golden Dawn box is drawn faint because what it added — the tables of planetary, tarot and colour correspondence — is its own work and not in the *Zohar* at all. Drawn for this book.

KABBALAH, CABALA, QABALAH

The three spellings are commonly said to mark three traditions: **Kabbalah** for the Jewish original, **Cabala** for the Christian adaptation of the Renaissance, and **Qabalah** for the Hermetic and occult version that runs from the Golden Dawn to the present. The convention is useful and this book follows it. It is worth knowing that it is a convention and not a rule, and that it postdates the material it sorts.

Where the *Q* comes from is documented, at least. Mathers, in 1887, noted that the word “has been spelt in a great variety of ways — Cabala, Kabbalah, &c.” and stated his own choice and his reason: “I have adopted the form Qabalah, as being more consonant with the Hebrew writing of the word.” He was making a transliteration decision, not founding a school. The school came afterwards and took the spelling with it.

What the Christian Cabala actually took

Ginsburg opens his essay by listing who in Christendom had been captured by this material, and the list is a roll-call of names already in this book: Raymond Lully, John Reuchlin, Pico della Mirandola, Cornelius Agrippa, van Helmont, Robert Fludd, Henry More. Agrippa is the author of the book that Chapter 22 catches Barrett copying; Fludd stands beside Maier in the Rosicrucian material of Chapter 12. The Christian Cabala is not a side channel to the tradition this book describes. It is one of its main arteries, and the sephiroth reached Agrippa before they ever reached an English magician.

What that adaptation did with the material is a separate question, and Chapter 3 states the caution that governs it: the Christian and occult Cabala is a genuine tradition with real achievements, and it is not identical to Jewish Kabbalah and should not be made to speak for it. This chapter adds only the mechanism. The Christian readers met the sephiroth in Latin, in an anthology assembled by a Christian Hebraist who was looking for confirmations of his own theology, and they met the *Zohar* in the same way. What reached them was already selected.

Sources: Christian D. Ginsburg, *The Kabbalah: Its Doctrines, Development, and Literature* (London, 1865) public domain — read in the verbatim reprint of the first edition, London: George Routledge & Sons, 1920, from the Cornell University copy on the Internet Archive, identifier [cu31924075115380](#). The En Soph and the emanation of the sephiroth, the four worlds in his Briatic / Jetziratic / Assiatic spellings, the legend of Simon ben Jochai in the cavern, the misquotation argument, and the citation of Jellinek (Leipzig, 1851) and Graetz (Leipzig, 1863) for the authorship of the *Zohar*, are all his. S. L. MacGregor Mathers, *The Kabbalah Unveiled* (London: George Redway, 1887) public domain — read from the Wellcome Collection copy, identifier [b24884443](#): the title page for what the book contains and what it was translated from, the preface for his account of his own method, and Introduction §5 for the spelling and for his reproduction of Ginsburg. **Three readings are repaired in the quotations above and are declared here.** The Mathers scan renders *Rosenroth* as *B-osenroth* and *Bosenroth*, its fount confusing R with B; the same confusion gives *Babbi* for *Rabbi* in the Ginsburg scan, and *creaiion* for *creation*. Nothing else in the quoted passages is altered, and the ellipses are marked. The Hebrew and Aramaic in both scans is unreadable in the text layer and none of it is reproduced here. Where the two scans carry the same sentence — Ginsburg’s opening, which Mathers reprints — the 1887 setting is the cleaner of the two, and it is the one quoted. Knorr von Rosenroth, *Kabbala Denudata* (Sulzbach and Frankfurt, 1677–84) is named on Ginsburg’s and Mathers’s authority and was not consulted for this book. Twentieth-century scholarship on the *Zohar* is in copyright and none of it has been used; the note above says so on the page rather than here. The reading of the Tree as a descent rather than a table, and the observation about the four worlds and modern correspondence tables, are this book’s own. The ten-by-name table follows Ginsburg’s plate of the Heavenly Man and his exposition of it at pp. 92–93 of the reprint, both read on the page images (the plate labels the oval “The Endless” and gives Love and Justice for the fourth and fifth); the pillars and the trinity of triads are quoted from the same pages. The four heads, the definition of “path,” the equilibrium passage with its gloss, the three veils and the list of problems are quoted from Mathers’s Introduction §§23–30, pp. 14–16, read on the page images of the same Wellcome scan.

Alchemical Foundations

Alchemy is the art of transformation, and its literature is the most systematically misread body of writing in this tradition. The popular account — that alchemists were failed chemists trying to make gold — is too crude, but the correction usually offered for it is a matter of live scholarly dispute, and this book will not pretend otherwise. Lawrence Principe and William Newman have argued, in “Some Problems with the Historiography of Alchemy” (2001) and in Principe’s *The Secrets of Alchemy* (2013), that reading alchemy as essentially an inner discipline is a nineteenth-century invention, traceable to Mary Anne Atwood in 1850 and to Ethan Allen Hitchcock, and that, in their words, they “find no indication that the vast majority of alchemists were working on anything other than material substances toward material goals.” Against them, Hereward Tilton, Wouter Hanegraaff and others hold that this corrects too far and, as Mike Zuber summarises the critics, “downplays important topics in favour of chemical content and experimental technique.” What almost nobody now defends is the sharp either/or; Stanton Linden, whom this chapter cites below, holds that all three goals — metallic, medical and spiritual — are at times simultaneously present in the same treatise. Metals are the language in which the work is described — metallurgy supplied a vocabulary of purification, dissolution and change of state that nothing else in the ancient world could match — and what else the metals were is exactly what is argued about.

One sentence often offered as evidence for the symbolic reading deserves to be traced, because this book printed it in an earlier version and it does not survive the tracing. The claim that neither Michael Maier nor Heinrich Khunrath ever claimed to have produced gold, and that their alchemy was therefore symbolic rather than operative, circulates as an unsourced sentence in the Wikipedia article on Rosicrucianism; no scholar is named for it there,

and none was named for it here. The specialists say something else. Hereward Tilton, Maier's biographer, writes that Maier "dedicated his life to the quest for the highest goal of alchemy: the philosophers' stone" — a substance held in Maier's day to "transmute lead into gold, heal the sick, and even reverse the aging process." Tilton records Maier's first laboratory experiments during his internship of 1592–95, his journey in 1603 to the gold and silver mines of Hungarian Carpathia and his first alchemical experiment at Easter 1604, his co-authorship in 1616 of Francis Anthony's printed defence of *aurum potable*, and, in the last year of his life, his having produced an *aurum potable* "far excelling" Anthony's. Peter Forshaw, reporting Tilton, notes that gold-making "may not have been the main goal of Maier's practice, which was more concerned with the use of gold as *aurum potable* (drinkable gold) in chemical medicine, but it was nevertheless part of his training and repertoire," that "many of the quotes in *Atalanta fugiens* have their sources in medieval chrysopoetic literature," and that the tendency to relegate visual forms of alchemy to a "spiritual quest" "should also be reconsidered." Nor were these two men associates: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud, a *Betrüger*. The narrow claim, that no surviving text has either man announcing a successful transmutation, may well be true. The conclusion the popular account draws from it is not one any specialist draws.

What the alchemists asked of the operator

The grimoires of Chapter 8 open with washing. The alchemical corpus opens with something harder to fake. *The Sophic Hydrolith*, one of the treatises in *The Hermetic Museum*, begins its instruction not with apparatus but with the operator's condition — and the passage is the alchemical answer to the ablutions:

In the first place, let every devout and God-fearing chemist and student of this Art consider that this arcanum should be regarded, not only as a truly great, but as a most holy Art (seeing that it typifies and shadows out the highest heavenly good). Therefore, if any man desire to reach this great and unspeakable Mystery, he must remember that it is obtained not by the might of man, but by the grace of God, and that not our will or desire, but only the mercy of the Most High, can bestow it upon us.

For this reason you must first of all cleanse your heart, lift it to Him alone, and ask of Him this gift in true, earnest, and undoubting prayer. He alone can give and bestow it.

Whatever one makes of the metaphysics, notice the structure of the claim: the work cannot be commanded, only received, and the first vessel to be cleansed is the operator. That is the same instruction the *Key of Solomon* gives as a bath and the *Heptameron* gives as six days of washing — stated here as an inward condition instead of a procedure. It is also the reason the literature is so hard to use as a manual: it keeps insisting that the decisive variable is not in the apparatus.

The three principles

Sulfur — Soul. The active principle: consciousness, will, the animating and combustible element that drives change. In the operator, that which initiates.

Mercury — Spirit. The mediating principle: intuition, imagination, the volatile element that passes between states and carries influence from one to another. In the operator, that which perceives and connects.

Salt — Body. The fixed principle: form, stability, the residue that remains after burning. In the operator, that which persists and can be built upon.

To these the tradition adds the four elements as states rather than substances — earth for the solid and fixed, water for the fluid and receptive, air for the mobile and mediating, fire for the transformative — and, in most systems, a

fifth, quintessence, standing outside the four as their principle of coherence.



FIG. 1 — THE THREE PRINCIPLES. The *tria prima* in their conventional glyphs: sulfur, mercury and salt. The three-principle scheme is Paracelsian, sixteenth-century, and is layered over the older four elements rather than replacing them. Glyphs redrawn for this book from the standard early-modern forms.

WHERE THE MATTER IS TO BE FOUND

The Glory of the World, in the same collection, answers the tradition's central riddle — what the *prima materia* actually is — by refusing to name it and telling you where to look instead:

“I will tell you where you may find it. The first spot is on the summit of two mountains; the second, in all mountains; the third, among the refuse in the street; the fourth, in the trees and metals the liquid of which is the Sun and Moon, Mercury, Saturn, and Jupiter. There is but one vessel, one method, and one consummation.”

The third of those is the famous one, and it recurs throughout the corpus: the matter of the Great Work is something universally available and universally despised — refuse in the street. Whether that points at a substance, at a psychological condition, or at nothing at all is precisely the dispute this chapter opened with, and the text is constructed so as not to settle it.

The seven metals

The alchemist's palette is seven metals, and the tradition never lists them without their planets: the metal in the crucible and the planet in the sky are the same nature at two removes, which is why the timing chapters of this book and the metal-graded seals of the Goetia use one vocabulary. Agrippa's survey of what stands under each planet — Book I of the *Occult Philosophy*, in the English of 1651 — assigns the metals with reasons attached, and the reasons are the instructive part. Under Saturn: “Amongst Metals, Lead, and Gold, by reason of its weight, and the golden Marcasite.” Under the Sun: “Amongst Metals, Gold by reason of its splendor, and its receiving that from the Sun which makes it cordiall.” The rest of the series stands in the adjacent chapters: tin — with silver and gold again, “by reason of their temperateness” — under

Jupiter; iron and “red Brass,” with “all fiery, red, and sulphureous things,” under Mars; copper under Venus; quicksilver under Mercury, “which moves all things indistinctly”; silver under the Moon.

METAL	PLANET	THE CHARACTER IT CARRIES
lead	Saturn	weight, slowness, the dark beginning — the work starts here
tin	Jupiter	temperateness; the benign, easy-working metal
iron	Mars	the fiery and sharp; the metal of edges
gold	the Sun	splendour; incorruptible, “cordiall” — the work ends here
copper	Venus	the joining metal, of mirrors and vessels
quicksilver	Mercury	the runner between states, liquid metal, neither and both
silver	the Moon	the reflective, the white stage embodied

Two things in Agrippa’s assignment repay attention. First, gold appears three times — under Saturn for its weight, under Jupiter for its temperateness, under the Sun for its splendour — which is the clearest small proof this book can offer that a correspondence is an argument about qualities and not an entry in a lookup table: the same metal answers three planets for three different reasons. Second, the series is a ladder with a direction. The work begins in lead and ends in gold; begins, that is, in Saturn and ends in the Sun — the same road the ascent of Chapter 2 climbs sphere by sphere, run through matter instead of through the soul. The doctrine beneath it, common to the whole literature, is that the metals are one substance at different degrees of maturity, ripening in the earth toward gold; the operations of this chapter are, on the tradition’s own understanding, a hastening of that ripening — and the assay of Chapter 29 shows what that belief looked like when it met the cupel.

The stages of the work

The *magnum opus* is described in stages, most often by colour. The Latin names familiar from modern writing are conventionally set beside a Greek sequence that is among the oldest technical vocabulary in the tradition — exactly, for the first three; less so for the fourth:

- **Nigredo** — the blackening, Greek *melanosis*. Putrefaction and dissolution; the breaking down of what was.
- **Albedo** — the whitening, *leukosis*. Washing and purification; what remains once the dross is gone.
- **Citrinitas** — the yellowing, *xanthosis*. The transitional stage.
- **Rubedo** — the reddening, *iosis*. The completed work; the union of what had been separated.

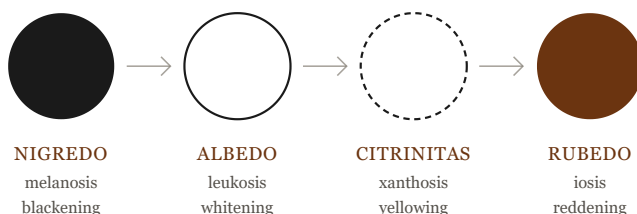


FIG. 2 — THE FOUR COLOUR STAGES. The *magnum opus* as the texts most often describe it, with the Greek terms that underlie the familiar Latin ones. The four-stage form is the older; from about the fifteenth or sixteenth century many writers absorb *citrinitas* into *rubedo* and work with three. *Iosis* is the odd one out. Liddell–Scott glosses it not as a reddening but as “refinement” — of gold, by oxidation of impurities — with a secondary sense “making of a tincture”; its root is *ios*, rust or verdigris. The familiar rendering “iosis (reddening)” descends from Jung, *Psychology and Alchemy* §333, not from a lexicon. The equation *iosis* = *rubedo* holds as a position in the sequence, both naming the last stage, rather than as a translation. Diagram drawn for this book.

Colour change of this kind is already the substance of the earliest surviving Greek alchemy. The *Physika kai mystika* attributed to pseudo-Democritus is concerned with whitening base metals to silver and yellowing them to gold; ancient testimony describes four books under the name — on gold, on silver, on stones and on purple. Whether all four of the Greek stage-names in the modern lists occur in that text is a question for its critical edition (Matteo Martelli, *The Four Books of Pseudo-Democritus*, 2013), which could not be obtained for this edition. Zosimos of Panopolis, who quotes Mary the Jewess constantly, is reported to have credited her with knowledge of the colour changes; the claim is widely repeated, and reaches this book through Raphael Patai's 1982 *Ambix* article, which could not be obtained and against which it was therefore not checked. How many stages there are was never settled. The four-colour form is the older, and from about the fifteenth or sixteenth century many writers reduced the colours to three, *citrinitas* being absorbed into *rubedo* or simply dropped — which is why modern accounts differ on whether there are three or four. That dating reaches modern readers chiefly through Jung, *Psychology and Alchemy* §333, who hedges it as “about the fifteenth or sixteenth century” and attributes the change to “inner psychological reasons” rather than to anything in the texts.

Read as an account of interior change the sequence is uncomfortably recognisable. Something held together comes apart; there is a period in which nothing is left but the fact of having come apart; what survives is smaller and cleaner than what went in; and only afterwards is there any integration worth the name. The alchemists insisted the stages cannot be skipped and cannot be hurried, and that *nigredo* is not a failure of the work but its beginning. Whatever one makes of their metallurgy, that is a serious psychological observation, and it is why this literature found readers in the twentieth century among people with no interest in furnaces at all.



PLATE I — THE PEACOCK'S TAIL. The *cauda pavonis*, the iridescence reported between the whitening and the reddening, shown as a peacock standing

in the flask. The manuscript gives it a full page, which is a fair measure of how much the colour sequence mattered to the people who worked it. This stage sits outside the four-name scheme above, and different writers place it differently — which is the inconsistency Linden warns about.

Splendor Solis, illuminated manuscript, between 1532 and 1535. Public domain; Kupferstichkabinett, Berlin, via Wikimedia Commons.

The operations

Alongside the colour stages the tradition describes sequences of *operations* — the named procedures by which the work advances. The most influential English list is George Ripley’s **Twelve Gates**, from the *Compound of Alchymy* — a poem completed in 1471 and dedicated to Edward IV, but not printed for another hundred and twenty years, when Raph Rabbards set it forth in London from Thomas Orwin’s press in 1591: calcination, solution, separation, conjunction, putrefaction, congelation, cibation, sublimation, fermentation, exaltation, multiplication, and projection. (The second gate is *Solution* in Ashmole’s *Theatrum Chemicum Britannicum* of 1652, followed here, and *Dissolution* in the 1591 print.)

A rival scheme of fourteen stages goes under the name of Samuel Norton, great-grandson of Thomas Norton: it begins with purgation, sublimation and calcination and ends with multiplication in virtue and multiplication in quantity. Where it comes from is worth stating, because it is almost always mis-cited. It is not in Norton’s English *Key of Alchemy* of 1578, which he says he “divided into eight several parts or treatises” and which contains no such list. The fourteen are the operations numbered through *Mercurius redivivus*, a Latin tract published at Frankfurt in 1630 by the York physician Edmund Deane, whose title page describes it as begun by Norton (*inchoatus*) and issued *auctor & perfectior*, enlarged and improved. How much of the numbering is Norton’s and how much Deane’s cannot be settled from the printed book; the names are Latin, and the English forms in circulation are translations.

A caution is owed here, and it comes from the scholarship rather than from scepticism. Stanton J. Linden, introducing *The Alchemy Reader* (Cambridge, 2003), p. 17, writes that “there is nothing approaching uniformity and consistency in the names assigned to these stages, or to the nature of the processes described, their order, or even their number.” Anyone presenting a single definitive sequence of alchemical operations is presenting one author’s scheme as though it were the tradition’s. Ripley’s twelve are worth knowing because they were widely copied, not because they are canonical.

What the operations do share is a shape. Something is broken down, separated into components, purified, recombined with what it was separated from, and then stabilised — with fermentation and multiplication at the end suggesting that a completed work becomes capable of propagating itself. Whether read as metallurgy or as biography, that arc is the same one the colour stages describe.



PLATE II — THE ORATORY AND THE LABORATORY. Khunrath's engraving puts the two in one room: a prayer desk at the left, a furnace and bench of glassware at the right, and a table of instruments between them. It is the best single answer to the dispute in this chapter's opening paragraphs, because it declines to take a side — the point of the image is that the praying and the distilling are one activity. Note also what it settles about Khunrath himself, whom this book once described as a symbolic rather than an operative alchemist: he drew himself a laboratory.

Hans Vredeman de Vries, from Heinrich Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae*, 1595. Public domain; digitised by the University of Wisconsin–Madison, via Wikimedia Commons.

How the heat was actually controlled

Read enough alchemical recipes and a gap opens between what they say and what you could do. They call constantly for a *gentle* heat, a *moderate* heat, a heat like that of a hen sitting — and a modern reader has no idea what that means with a stove in front of them. It is the single most practical thing missing from the tradition as it is usually presented, and it is not missing from the tradition itself. It is stated plainly, in English, in 1653.

John French — very probably the “J.F.” who two years earlier had put Agrippa into the English this book quotes in Chapter 22, though as Chapter 10 notes the initials have also been read as James Freake — published *The Art of Distillation* in London in 1653, subtitled *a treatise of the choicest spagyricall preparations*. He opens by saying that the degrees of heat are principally four, and the list is the whole control system of the art:

DEGREE	FRENCH’S SOURCE OF HEAT	WHAT IT IS FOR	IN A KITCHEN
First	Only a warmth: horse dung, the Sun, warm water and its vapour	Putrefaction and digestion — the long standing that changes a substance without driving anything off	An airing cupboard, a warm windowsill, a yoghurt maker
Second	Seething water and its vapour; also of ashes	Distilling what is subtle and moist , and rectifying any spirit or oil	A pan of simmering water — a double boiler
Third	Sand, and filings of iron	Distilling what is subtle and dry, or gross and moist	A sand bath: a tray of sand on the heat
Fourth	A naked fire — close, open, or with a blast	Metals and minerals , and hard gums such as amber	No kitchen equivalent. Chapter 29.

Three things follow from that table, and they are worth more than any recipe.

First, **the heat is chosen by what the material is, not by how fast you want to go.** A warmth for putrefaction; boiling water for the subtle and moist; sand for the dry. French is explicit that many of the lower distillations *can* be done over a naked fire and are, in a copper still — but that minerals cannot be done any other way. Heat is a tool with four settings, and the recipes assume you know which one they mean.

Second, **the second degree is Maria the Jewess's bath**, whose descent to us is set out later in this chapter — the apparatus from Berthelot's reproduction of the Greek manuscript figures, the name from the medieval Latin *balneum Mariae*. Fourteen hundred years separate the Alexandrian apparatus from the Southwark physician, and it is still the water bath, still doing the same job, and still carrying her name into every French kitchen as the *bain-marie*. Only the heart scarab of Chapter 22, in use across some two thousand years, outlasts it.

Third — and this is the useful one — **the safety line this book draws falls exactly on French's fourth degree.** That is not a coincidence and it is not modern squeamishness. His own scheme separates the operations that need only warm water from the operations that need an open forge, and the second set is the set that works on metals and minerals. Everything this book gives you is in his first three degrees. Everything it refuses is in his fourth.

The vessels, and what the operations mean in the hand

The named operations of the tradition sound abstract until you know which vessel each one happens in. French supplies the correspondence, and once you have it the recipes stop being mysterious:

- **Digestion and putrefaction** — material left standing at the first degree for a long period, commonly forty days. Nothing is driven off; the substance is allowed to change. This is the step the spagyric tincture below performs when the jar stands for a month.
- **Distillation** — in an *alembic* over the bath, or a *retort* in sand. The volatile part rises, condenses and is caught.

- **Rectification** — distilling the product again to purify it, and again. French describes taking a spirit through several rectifications.
- **Cohobation** — the distillate poured back onto what it came from, and distilled again. Repeated, this is how the tradition strengthens a spirit without adding anything to it.
- **Circulation** — the operation with the best vessel. A *pelican* is a closed glass body with one or two arms curving from the neck back into its own belly, so that what rises condenses and returns continuously without ever leaving. Sealed, at moderate heat, for a month. French says of the matter simply that it must be put in at the top, which afterwards must be closed up.

WHAT CIRCULATION IS, AND WHY THE VESSEL IS SHAPED LIKE THAT

A pelican does not remove anything and does not add anything. It takes a sealed quantity of matter and puts it through the same ascent and descent, over and over, for weeks. Nothing enters, nothing leaves, and the operator does nothing but maintain the heat.

It is difficult to look at that vessel and not see what the literature saw in it. The bird was supposed to wound its own breast to feed its young from itself; the vessel returns its own substance to itself indefinitely; and the *solve et coagula* of the whole tradition is exactly a dissolution followed by a reconstitution, repeated until something is fixed. Whatever a month in a pelican does chemically, the alchemists had an apparatus that performed their central metaphor continuously, in the corner of the room, while they waited. It is worth knowing that before deciding the imagery came first.

⚠ The fourth degree, and why this chapter stops there

French's fourth degree — the naked fire, and the metals and minerals it is for — is where the historical literature becomes genuinely dangerous, and where this chapter prints history and no procedure. Distilling minerals produces corrosive and volatile products; the seventeenth-century laboratory did it in rooms that killed people slowly, and its practitioners knew and said so. The first three degrees, applied to plants, are kitchen operations and are given in full below.

The fourth degree has its own chapter. Chapter 29 gives six metal and mineral operations — calcination, the regulus of antimony, cupellation, the strong waters, amalgamation and the corrosive sublimate — written for a reader with a real laboratory, hazard first, with the modern controls that make them survivable and the historical toll of doing them without.

The Greco-Egyptian foundation

The earliest substantial alchemical material is Greek, from Roman Egypt, and two figures dominate it.

Zosimos of Panopolis (fl. c. 300 CE) is the earliest alchemical writer whose substantial corpus survives under his own name; the *Physika kai mystika* attributed to pseudo-Democritus is older but survives incompletely and under a pseudonym. He is the channel through which nearly everything earlier survives, and his writing is a strange and compelling mixture of technical procedure and recorded vision — the dream-sequences in which he is instructed by priests at an altar are among the oldest first-person accounts of anything resembling initiatory experience in this tradition.

Mary the Jewess (Maria Hebraea), whom Zosimos quotes as an authority already of the past, worked in Greco-Roman Egypt, most likely between the first and third centuries CE — the specialist literature declines to place her in a particular city, and the usual attachment to Alexandria comes from general reference works rather than from anything Zosimos says. F. Sherwood Taylor and Edmund von Lippmann place her among the first alchemical writers, no later than the first century; others read Zosimos's manner of quoting her as evidence for a later date. Nothing narrows it further. She is credited with describing three pieces of apparatus, and the credit is technical rather than legendary: the *tribikos*, a three-armed alembic for distillation, whose technical details Zosimos says were transmitted by Mary — hers is the earliest description that survives, though Zosimos does not call it the first, and whether she devised the still or only described it is not known; the *kerotakis*, a reflux vessel in which metals laid on a heated palette were exposed to rising vapours, a luted condensing cover returning the condensate to the base — it is often called airtight and often called the ancestor of Soxhlet's extractor of 1879, and neither belongs to the specialist literature on her apparatus, the cover being vented by a small hole and Soxhlet going unmentioned in the standard survey; and the *bain-marie*, the double boiler, whose name is hers: the medieval Latin *balneum Mariae* is thought to have been introduced by Arnald of Villanova in the fourteenth century, and the lexicographers derive it from Marie-la-Juive, who is *said* to have invented or improved the technique. Said, not shown — von Lippmann pointed out that water-baths are described by Hippocrates, Theophrastus, Dioscorides and Pliny long before her. She is named among the alchemists listed in Ibn al-Nadīm's tenth-century *Kitāb al-Fihrist*. (The oddly specific figure of fifty-two, repeated in many popular accounts, could not be checked against Dodge's translation of the *Fihrist* for this edition, and is therefore not given here.)

THE TRIBIKOS SURVIVES AS A DRAWING, NOT ONLY AS A DESCRIPTION

What is easy to miss in the secondary literature is that these instruments are not merely written about. They are *drawn*, in the Byzantine manuscripts that carry the Greek alchemical corpus, and Berthelot reproduced the drawings in 1887 from the manuscript of St Mark and its relatives. His commentary on figure 15 identifies the parts, and the names are the interesting thing:

- the vessel is an *alambic à trois récipients* — a still with three receivers, the three βυκία that give the instrument its name;
- the furnace carries two words written one above the other, the place of the burning and the place of the flame;
- the flask below is a λωπάς of *unburnt sulphur*;
- and the two tubes are named for fingers — the rising one is the λιχανὸς σωλήν, the **index tube**, and the descending one the ἀντίχειρος σωλήν, the **thumb tube**.

A manifold of tubes named after the fingers of a hand is not the sort of thing a later writer invents while paraphrasing. It is workshop vocabulary, and it is the detail that lets the same instrument be recognised across manuscripts that otherwise disagree about its shape — Berthelot notes that by the time the figure is redrawn in one later copy it has drifted towards the glass alembics of his own grandfather's century.

Two sayings are attributed to her. One is a formula for union: *join the male and the female, and you will find what is sought*. The other is the celebrated Axiom of Maria: *one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth*. Neither is given in quotation marks here, and the reason is worth stating: they reach English through a chain of translations, and for the Axiom the wording everyone reproduces descends through Jung's *Psychology and Alchemy* rather than from any named translator of Zosimos.

The union formula's English has not been traced to a named translator at all. Jung took the second seriously enough to build on it at length. Not everything attached to her name is sound — the Byzantine chronicler George Syncellus, writing about 810, reports the alleged initiation of Democritus in Egypt by Ostanes, Mary the Jewess and Pammenes, which is chronologically impossible: Democritus belongs to the fifth century BCE — but the apparatus comes through Zosimos and stands. The Axiom does not: Jung traced it to the treatise ascribed to Christianos, whom Berthelot placed at about the beginning of the seventh century, and cited it from Berthelot's edition of the Greek alchemists rather than from Zosimos.



FIG. 3 — THE OUROBOROS. The serpent that eats its own tail, with the motto associated with it in the earliest Greek alchemy: *hen to pan*, one is the all. The emblem appears in the manuscript tradition of the *Chrysopoeia of Cleopatra*, among the oldest alchemical documents, and became the tradition's standing image for a work whose end is its beginning — the same claim the colour stages make in sequence form. This drawing is the book's own emblem-form, not a facsimile of any manuscript figure.

And the construction itself survives, in Zosimos's words, quoting hers. It is not an allusion. It is a specification, and a builder could work from it:

Je vais te décrire le tribikos. On appelle ainsi la construction en cuivre transmise traditionnellement par Marie. Voici en quels termes : Fabrique, dit-elle, trois tubes de cuivre laminé et aminci, d'une épaisseur dont voici la mesure : ce sera à peu près celle d'une poêle en airain, à faire cuire les gâteaux ; la longueur sera d'une coudée et demie... Après avoir luté les jointures avec de la pâte de farine, adapte aux extrémités des tubes des récipients en verre, grands et forts, afin qu'ils ne cassent pas en raison de la chaleur de l'eau qui entraîne la matière distillée.

I am going to describe the tribikos to you. So is called the copper construction handed down by tradition from Maria. Here are the terms: Make, she says, three tubes of copper, rolled and thinned, of a thickness of which here is the measure — it will be about that of a brazen pan for baking cakes; the length will be a cubit and a half... After luting the joints with flour paste, fit to the ends of the tubes glass receivers, large and strong, so that they do not break from the heat of the water that carries over the distilled matter. (English by this book, from Berthelot's French.)

Read that as an engineer would. The wall thickness is gauged *against a cake pan*, because the reader has one and does not have a micrometer. The length is a cubit and a half. The joints are sealed with flour paste. And the glass receivers are specified **large and strong so that they do not crack** — which is a failure this writer has plainly had, and is warning the next person about.

The passage the ellipsis covers is the assembly: three orifices at the end of the copper vessel, fitted to the tubes and soldered *eccentrically* to the upper receiver that takes the volatile part, with the three tubes meeting the neck of the small receiver by a pin through the thumb-tube so that the two index-tubes sit laterally. The copper vessel then stands over an earthenware matrass. This

book prints the apparatus and not an operation: what the matrass holds, and what is done with what comes over, is the chemistry, and it is outside what this chapter gives.

WHY THIS IS THE OLDEST THING OF ITS KIND

A still with *one* outlet gives you a distillate. A still with three, taken off at different heights and led to separate receivers, gives you *fractions* — different products collected separately from a single charge. That is the principle of fractional distillation, and it is being described here in the third or fourth century, transmitted from a writer earlier still, in a vocabulary borrowed from the human hand.

It is also worth noticing what the description does *not* contain: no invocation, no timing, no purity requirement, nothing of the operator's condition. Set beside the rest of this book it reads like a different literature entirely, and in an important sense it is. Somebody was building equipment.

The axioms of the serpent

The oldest surviving explanation of what the ouroboros *means* is not a modern gloss. It is a short article in the Greek corpus, and Berthelot prints it under the heading *Le serpent Ouroboros*. It opens by telling you outright that it is a cipher:

Voici le mystère : Le serpent Ouroboros (mordant sa queue), c'est la composition qui dans son ensemble est dévorée et fondue, dissoute et transformée par la fermentation. Elle devient d'un vert foncé, et la couleur d'or en dérive. C'est d'elle que dérive le rouge appelé couleur de cinabre : c'est le cinabre des philosophes.

Here is the mystery: the serpent Ouroboros (biting its tail) is the composition which as a whole is devoured and melted, dissolved and transformed by fermentation. It becomes a dark green, and the colour of gold derives from it. From it derives the red called the colour of cinnabar: it is the cinnabar of the philosophers. (English by this book, from Berthelot's French.)

The serpent is not a symbol of eternity here. It is a *diagram of a process*: one substance consuming itself and coming out changed, with the colour sequence of Fig. 2 above read off its body — the article goes on to give the beast a saffron belly, a dark green head, four feet for the four imperfect metals and three ears for the three sublimed vapours. Then, in four lines, the sentences that the whole later tradition quotes without knowing where they came from:

L'Un fournit à l'Autre son sang ; et l'Un engendre l'Autre. La nature réjouit la nature ; la nature charme la nature ; la nature triomphe de la nature ; et la nature maîtrise la nature ; et cela non pas pour telle (nature) opposée à telle autre, mais pour une seule et même nature, (procédant) d'elle-même par le procédé (chimique), avec peine et grand effort.

Or toi, mon ami très cher, applique ton intelligence sur ces matières et tu ne tomberas pas dans l'erreur ; mais travaille sérieusement et sans négligence, jusqu'à ce que tu aies vu le terme (de ta recherche).

The One furnishes the Other its blood; and the One begets the Other. Nature gladdens nature; nature charms nature; nature triumphs over nature; and nature masters nature — and that not as one nature opposed to another, but as one and the same nature, proceeding from itself by the process, with pain and great effort. Now you, my dearest friend, apply your intelligence to these matters and you will not fall into error; but work seriously and without negligence, until you have seen the end of your search. (English by this book.)

ONE WORD, AND WHY IT IS NOT THE FAMOUS ONE

The sentence everyone knows is *nature rejoices in nature*. That is not what Berthelot's French says. His verb is *réjouit*, transitive and active: nature *gladdens* nature, one thing acting on another. *Rejoices in* renders the Greek middle voice, and it reaches English through a different route than the one this book took.

The literal rendering is given above because that is what the edition in front of this book actually prints. The familiar wording is not wrong — it is arguably closer to the Greek — but it is not a translation of Berthelot, and quietly using it here while labelling it as this book's own English would be precisely the fault this chapter objects to a few pages earlier, where it declines to put the Axiom of Maria in quotation marks because the version everyone reproduces descends through a chain of translations rather than from any text.

The difference is not merely grammatical. *Nature gladdens nature* describes an action with an agent and an object, which is what the surrounding four clauses all describe — charming, triumphing over, mastering. *Nature rejoices in nature* describes a state. The first belongs to a set of operative axioms; the second reads like contemplation.

Berthelot's own footnote identifies these as *les axiomes du Pseudo-Démocrite*, which places them earlier than Zosimos and makes them among the oldest operative sayings in this book. Two things are worth drawing out. The insistence that it is **one and the same nature**, not two opposed ones, is the point on which this tradition differs from every dualism it is usually confused with. And the closing address is not doctrine at all: it is a working instruction, from one operator to another, and what it asks for is not purity or grace but *attention, seriousness, and the willingness to keep going*. That sentence would not be out of place in a laboratory notebook.

WHAT COMES NEXT IN THE ARTICLE, AND WHY IT IS NOT PRINTED

The passage above is sections 1 to 4. Section 5 follows immediately and is omitted here: it directs the operator to sacrifice a serpent, flay it, and make a footstool of the flesh. It is said outright so that the quotation is not read as complete when it is not, and it is left out under the same rule that governs the rest of this book — nothing requiring harm to an animal is printed as an operation, however old, and however plainly the whole thing is meant as an allegory of the metals.

The operative tradition and its transmission

Physical laboratory alchemy was, of course, also real, and it deserves its historical due. Its practitioners developed distillation, sublimation and crystallisation, identified acids and salts, built the apparatus — alembic, retort, athanor, the vessels above — and produced the observational groundwork on which chemistry was later built. Robert Boyle and Isaac Newton both worked in this tradition, and what kind of work it was is still argued. Lawrence Principe's *The Aspiring Adept* (1998) argues that Boyle's alchemical interests were "serious and persistent, constituting a significant and influential dimension of his life, thought, and works," that his alchemy was of a distinctly traditional type grounded in chrysopoeia, and that Boyle took a keen interest in connections between alchemy and the supernatural. Newton wrote and transcribed about a million words on alchemy — laboratory notebooks, indices of alchemical substances, and transcriptions from other sources. The papers surfaced at a Sotheby's sale in 1936, and it took the twentieth century some time to absorb what they were: William Newman reads them as experimental chymistry rather than religious search, a reading not every scholar shares.

The textual lineage runs deep. Two of the key early documents, Leyden papyrus X and the Stockholm papyrus, came out of the same reconstructed Theban group as the Greek Magical Papyri of Chapter 9 — the clearest single piece of evidence that late antique alchemy and late antique magic were one enterprise. From there the tradition passes into Arabic hands, where it was transformed and considerably advanced: Jābir ibn Ḥayyān, Ibn Umayl, Abū Bakr al-Rāzī, and the *Sirr al-khalīqa* that carries the earliest text of the Emerald Tablet — the subject of Chapter 6. Latin Europe received the whole inheritance in translation from the twelfth century onward, beginning with Robert of Chester in 1144. The great early-modern flowering — Paracelsus, Sendivogius, Maier’s *Atalanta fugiens*, the *Rosary of the Philosophers*, *Splendor Solis*, the emblem books with their images of kings drowning and suns turning black — builds on that Arabic foundation, a debt the European sources acknowledge far more readily than their modern popularisers do.

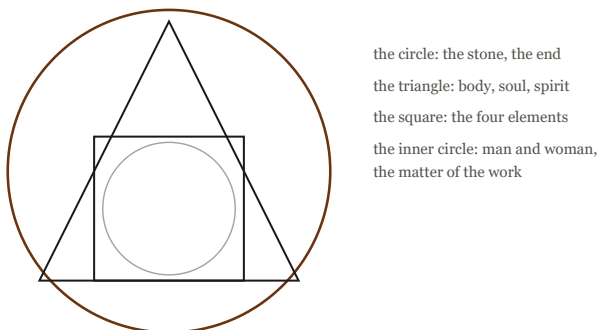


FIG. 4 — THE SQUARED CIRCLE. The geometer’s emblem of the Great Work, best known as Emblem XXI of Maier’s *Atalanta fugiens* (1617): out of the inner circle a square, out of the square a triangle, out of the triangle the perfect circle of the Stone. Maier presents it as an instruction to the alchemist phrased entirely in geometry — the four elements, the three principles of this chapter, and the one result. Redrawn schematically for this book; Maier’s engraving shows the geometer drawing it with compasses on a wall.

⚠ Safety Warning for Alchemical Practices

Spiritual and contemplative alchemical work should be undertaken with proper preparation and, ideally, guidance; the process can be intense and should be approached gradually.

Physical laboratory alchemy is a separate matter, and this chapter does not provide procedures for it. The historical recipes call for mercury, antimony, lead, arsenic compounds and corrosive acids, handled with heat in unventilated rooms. These substances cause irreversible neurological and organ damage, and the harm is frequently cumulative and unnoticed until advanced. Chronic mercury poisoning is well documented among historical practitioners. There is no traditional protection, purification or intention that alters the toxicology. Those operations are given, hazard first, in Chapter 29, which is written for a reader who already has a fume hood, a chemistry qualification and a waste-disposal route. If you do not have those three things, read the history and leave the materials alone.

The spagyric separation

There is one laboratory operation this chapter can give in full, because every step of it is kitchen-safe: the *spagyric* preparation of a plant — the three principles of this chapter applied to the one kingdom where separating them harms nobody. The word is Paracelsus's coinage, from the Greek *spao* and *ageiro*: to separate and to recombine. That pair of verbs is the whole of alchemy in miniature, and this is the honest way to experience the structure of the work with your own hands.

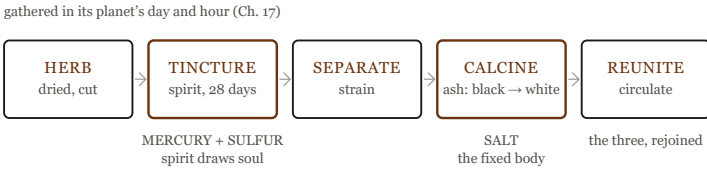


FIG. 5 — THE SPAGYRIC SEQUENCE. The whole alchemical grammar in five steps, at kitchen scale: one thing divided into three, each purified in its own way, then rejoined. The two highlighted stages are where the colour changes of Fig. 2 actually become visible — the black ash whitening in the dish is *nigredo* giving way to *albedo*, happening in front of you. Drawn for this book.

THE SEPARATION OF THE THREE PRINCIPLES IN A PLANT

1. **Choose the plant** from the table in Chapter 20, and gather or begin the work in its planet's day and hour. Use a culinary herb — rosemary, sage, melissa — nothing from the poison rows.
2. **Extract the Sulfur and Mercury.** Chop the dried herb and cover it with strong drinkable spirit in a sealed jar. In the tradition's vocabulary the alcohol is the *Mercury*, the mediating spirit, and what it draws from the plant — the aromatic, virtuous part — is the plant's *Sulfur*, its soul. Keep the jar warm and dark, shaking daily, for a philosophical month of twenty-eight days.
3. **Separate.** Strain the tincture off and set it aside, sealed. Keep the exhausted plant body — the *caput mortuum*, the dead head.
4. **Calcine the Salt.** Burn the dried plant body outdoors in a steel or earthen vessel until it is black, then keep it in the fire until the ash goes from black through grey toward white — *nigredo* to *albedo*, literally and visibly. Grind the ash fine.
5. **Recombine.** Add the ash to the tincture, seal, and let it circulate in gentle warmth for some days; then filter. The three principles, separated, purified and reunited — which is the definition the chapter opened with.

What you have made is a spagyric tincture of the sort sold in any herbalist's shop, and the point was never the product. The point is that you have now performed, in miniature and in safety, the sequence the

whole literature describes: dissolution, separation, purification by fire, recombination — and watched the colour stages happen in a dish rather than in a diagram.

MODERN PRACTICE

Contemporary practitioners work the alchemical sequence almost entirely as an interior discipline, often keeping a written record structured by the stages — noting what is dissolving, what is being washed, what has survived. Some work with plant alchemy or *spagyrics*, which uses herbal tinctures and distillation and stays within the safety envelope of ordinary kitchen chemistry. C. G. Jung's reading of the alchemical corpus as a symbolic account of individuation has been enormously influential and is how most readers now encounter this material; it is a twentieth-century interpretation of the texts rather than what their authors said they were doing, and it is worth holding both readings at once.

Sources: The metal–planet assignments and their reasons: Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* in the English of 1651, Book I, the chapters on what stands under each planet; Saturn’s metals at p. 55 and the Sun’s at p. 51 read on the page images of the Early English Books scan cited in Chapter 22, the remaining five from the scan’s text layer corroborating the standard attributions, which is stated because the book’s practice is to say which is which. The ladder reading and the table’s character column are this book’s own. Zosimos of Panopolis; pseudo-Democritus, *Physika kai mystika*; Leyden papyrus X (P. Leid. I 397) and the Stockholm papyrus (P. Holm.) — 4th c. CE, from the reconstructed Theban group, cf. Ch. 8. Jābir ibn Ḥayyān; *Sirr al-khalīqa* (late 8th / early 9th c.). Maier, *Atalanta fugiens* (1617); Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (Hamburg 1595; Hanau 1609) — the two editions differ substantially, the 1609 being much expanded. On Khunrath’s insistence that alchemy is prayed and worked at once, and on his laboratory chemistry, see Peter J. Forshaw, *The Mage’s Images: Heinrich Khunrath in His Oratory and Laboratory*, 4 vols (Leiden: Brill, 2024–25), and Forshaw, “Subliming Spirits: Physical-Chemistry and Theo-Alchemy in the Works of Heinrich Khunrath (1560–1605),” in Stanton J. Linden (ed.), *“Mystical Metal of Gold”: Essays on Alchemy and Renaissance Culture* (AMS Press). Maier and Khunrath do not form a single school: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud. Jung’s individuation reading: 20th century, interpretive. The spagyric procedure above is the common modern method stated in Paracelsian vocabulary; the arrangement is this book’s own, the tria-prima mapping is Paracelsus’s, and no historical text is quoted in it. On Mary the Jewess see Seth C. Rasmussen, “Mother of Invention: Maria the Jewess and Early Contributions to Chemical Apparatus,” *Bulletin for the History of Chemistry* 47, no. 2 (2022), 179–185 (open access), and Raphael Patai, *The Jewish Alchemists* (Princeton, 1994), ch. 5, which could not be obtained for this edition. On Ripley: the *Compound of Alchymy* was completed 1471 and first printed London, 1591, ed. Raph Rabbards (STC 21057); the fourteen operations attributed to Samuel Norton are those of *Mercurius redivivus*, ed. Edmund Deane (Frankfurt, 1630), not of Norton’s *Key of Alchemy* (1578). Berthelot on the Greek alchemical apparatus and the ouroboros article: M. Berthelot, with Ch.-Em. Ruelle, *Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs*, première livraison (Paris: Georges Steinheil, 1887) public domain — the manuscript figures and their nomenclature at Introduction pp. 139–141, and the article *Le serpent Ouroboros* at Traduction pp. 22–23, with Berthelot’s footnote attributing the axioms to pseudo-Democritus. The French is his; the English renderings are this book’s, and are therefore translations of a translation. The construction text for the tribikos is from the same collection, Traduction pp. 228–229 (treatise III.I), in the volume carrying the second and third livraisons together public domain. The volume is on the Internet Archive under a compound identifier that the obvious per-volume searches do not reach. The

degrees of fire, the vessels and the operations: John French, *The Art of Distillation, or a Treatise of the Choicest Spagyricall Preparations* (London, 1653) public domain — Wellcome Collection copy b30335255, Book I. French is very probably the “J.F.” whose 1651 Agrippa is quoted in Chapter 22, but that identification is not certain and this book does not treat it as settled. **Nothing is quoted from him verbatim here.** The available scan is OCR only and its fount defeats it, turning *putrefaction* into “putrefa&tion” and *ashes* into “afhes”; his four degrees, his vessels and his operations are therefore described in this book’s own words from a reading of that scan, and not presented as his wording. The kitchen equivalents in the fourth column are modern and are this book’s. *The Hermetic Museum, Restored and Enlarged*, trans. A. E. Waite, 2 vols (London: James Elliott, 1893) public domain — the English of the *Sophic Hydrolith* and of *The Glory of the World* quoted here is Waite’s, from the Latin *Musaeum Hermeticum* (Frankfurt, 1678). C. G. Jung, *Psychology and Alchemy*, *Collected Works* vol. 12, trans. R. F. C. Hull (Princeton: Bollingen) in copyright — cited above by paragraph number, which is the standard way of referring to the *Collected Works* and is edition-independent; no wording of Jung’s is reproduced here beyond the phrase under discussion.

The Emerald Tablet

The Emerald Tablet is the shortest text in this book and the most consequential. In a few hundred words it supplied Western alchemy with its founding statement, its governing image, and its most quoted line. Nearly every alchemical work from the twelfth century to the eighteenth cites it, glosses it, or assumes it. Newton translated it. Jung read it. It has been printed thousands of times.

It is also not what most readers are told it is. It is not ancient Egyptian, it was not carved on emerald, and the sentence everybody knows from it is not in it. All three of those facts are well established, and none of them diminishes the text — they make its actual history considerably more interesting than the legend.

The text

Below is Isaac Newton's English rendering of the Tablet, from Keynes MS 28 in King's College Library, Cambridge (ff. 2r–v). The same manuscript carries the Latin text of the vulgate and Newton's own Latin commentary; B. J. T. Dobbs argued, mainly from the handwriting, that the English was made some years after the Latin and from a French version rather than directly from the Latin — the Newton Project's catalogue points to the *Bibliothèque des philosophes* (1672–8), which Newton owned and names on the same leaf. Newton's version is given here in preference to a modern one for three reasons: it is out of copyright, it is the rendering most often reproduced in popular anthologies and online, and Newton's choices as a translator are themselves part of the commentary tradition.

Tis true without lying, certain & most true. That which is below is like that which is above & that which is above is like that which is below to do the miracles of one only thing

And as all things have been & arose from one by the mediation of one: so all things have their birth from this one thing by adaptation.

The Sun is its father, the moon its mother, the wind hath carried it in its belly, the earth is its nurse. The father of all perfection in the whole world is here. Its force or power is entire if it be converted into earth.

Separate thou the earth from the fire, the subtile from the gross sweetly with great indoustry. It ascends from the earth to the heaven & again it descends to the earth & receives the force of things superior & inferior.

By this means you shall have the glory of the whole world & thereby all obscurity shall fly from you. Its force is above all force. For it vanquishes every subtile thing & penetrates every solid thing.

So was the world created. From this are & do come admirable adaptations whereof the means (or process) is here in this.

Hence I am called Hermes Trismegist, having the three parts of the philosophy of the whole world. That which I have said of the operation of the Sun is accomplished & ended.

Text: Isaac Newton, Keynes MS. 28, King's College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v, from *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), normalised transcription by John A. Johnson. Newton's spelling and ampersands are retained. The manuscript sets the text as eleven verses; they are grouped here into seven, and the full stop after "the whole world" is editorial — the manuscript has none there, nor after "one only thing." Newton wrote "(or process)" above the line as a gloss on "the means." The folio heading, three cancelled letters before "fly from you," and Newton's closing cross-references on f. 2v are not reproduced. The third English rendering of the Tablet, given later in this chapter, is quoted inside *The Glory of the World in The Hermetic Museum, Restored and Enlarged*, trans. A. E. Waite, 2 vols (London: James Elliott, 1893) public domain; the wording is therefore Waite's, at one remove from the Latin.

Where it actually comes from

The Tablet is an Arabic text. Its oldest known recension appears in the *Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣanʿat al-Ṭabīʿa*, the *Book of the Secret of Creation and the Art of Nature*, compiled in Arabic in the late eighth or early ninth century. The precise dating is contested in the scholarship: Julius Ruska placed it in the sixth to eighth centuries, Paul Kraus around 813–833, Ursula Weisser around 750–800. The work presents itself as a translation of a treatise by Apollonius of Tyana — Balīnūs in the Arabic — which is itself a pseudepigraphic frame rather than a real attribution.

The Tablet also appears, in a somewhat shorter version with lines missing, in the *Second Book of the Element of the Foundation* (*Kitāb Uṣṭuqus al-Uss al-Thānī*) attributed to Jābir ibn Ḥayyān. And it turns up in two further Arabic settings: Ibn Umayl's tenth-century *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth*, later translated into Latin as the *Tabula Chemica*, which quotes the Tablet and glosses it clause by clause; and towards the end of the long version of the pseudo-Aristotelian *Sirr al-Asrār*, the *Secret of Secrets*, also tenth century.

That discovery narrative belongs to the *Sirr al-Khalīqa* itself, not to any later source, and it is the origin of the story every popular account repeats. Balīnūs is directed by an apparition — in Ruska’s description, the heavenly archetype of Apollonius in the form of an old man — into a dark subterranean chamber beneath a statue of Hermes, where a figure seated on a throne holds an emerald tablet and a book. It is a literary device of the eighth- or ninth-century Arabic tradition, not a record of an excavation, and it is a vault rather than a pyramid: the pyramid of the popular retellings is a later accretion.

How it reached Europe

The Latin transmission runs through several independent channels, and knowing which one a given version descends from explains most of the variation between printed texts:

- **Robert of Chester**, 1144 — the *Book on the Composition of Alchemy*, the Latin *Morienus*. Some manuscripts carry an explicit dating the translation to 11 February 1144, and that date is independent of the prologue. It is generally considered the first Latin translation of an Arabic alchemical treatise, and marks the point at which this whole literature enters Europe — but the attribution to Robert is less settled than the date: his name comes only from a prologue which Dapsens concludes is genuinely Robert’s work yet was probably not written for this text.
- **The vulgate version**, probably twelfth century, tentatively attributed to Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–1145). It survives embedded in an anonymous Latin compilation of commentaries on the Tablet — known variously as the *Book of Hermes on Alchemy*, the *Book of Dabessus* or the *Book of the Rebis* — itself translated from a now-lost Arabic original. This is the most widely circulated version and the basis of every later edition — including the version behind Newton’s English.
- **Hugo of Santalla**, c. 1145–1151 — translated the *Book of the Secret of Creation* itself, and so gives the Tablet closest to its oldest known Arabic form. It does not appear to have circulated widely: the

translation survives in a single manuscript contemporary with the translator (Paris, BnF lat. 13951) and one copy, and the Tablet spread in Europe not from this version but from the *Secret of Secrets*.

- **Philip of Tripoli**, thirteenth century — translated the *Secret of Secrets*, which became, by some measures, the most popular book of the Latin Middle Ages, carrying the Tablet along with it.

What appeared in **1541** — in *De Alchemia*, from Johann Petreius at Nuremberg, edited by “Chrysogonus Polydorus”, most likely a pseudonym for Andreas Osiander — is what the bibliographic literature calls the *editio princeps* of the Tablet, and it was the first to set the text beside the commentary of Hortulanus; that pairing shaped how the text was read for centuries. It was not, however, the Tablet’s first appearance in print. A different Latin version, the one carried inside the *Secret of Secrets*, was already in print by 1501 at the latest — Alessandro Achillini’s Bologna edition prints it complete — and possibly in the incunable editions of the 1480s, though the collations are ambiguous on the alchemy section. The two are not the same translation: the *Secret of Secrets* version opens *Veritas ita se habet et non est dubium*, the vulgate *Verum sine mendacio certum et verissimum*.

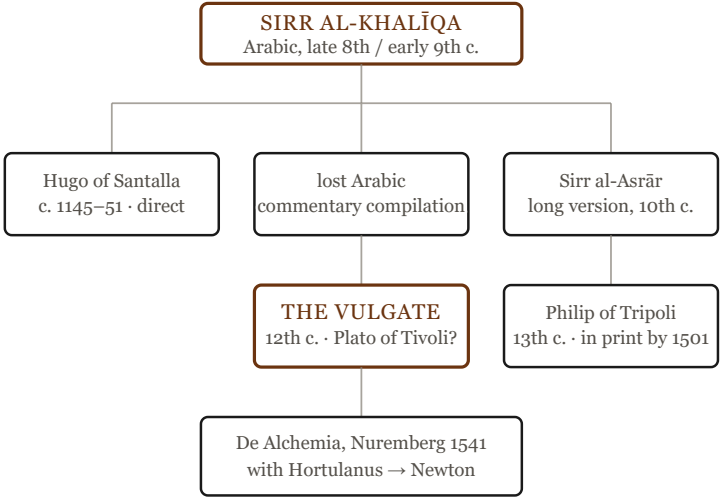


FIG. 1 — HOW THE EMERALD TABLET REACHED EUROPE. Four Latin channels out of one Arabic source, and they do not agree with one another: Hugo translates the *Book of the Secret of Creation* directly but is barely copied; the vulgate, which everyone later reads, arrives embedded in a compilation of commentaries translated from an Arabic original now lost; and the *Secret of Secrets* carries a different rendering into print forty years before the vulgate’s own *editio princeps*. Diagram drawn for this book from the transmission set out in this chapter.

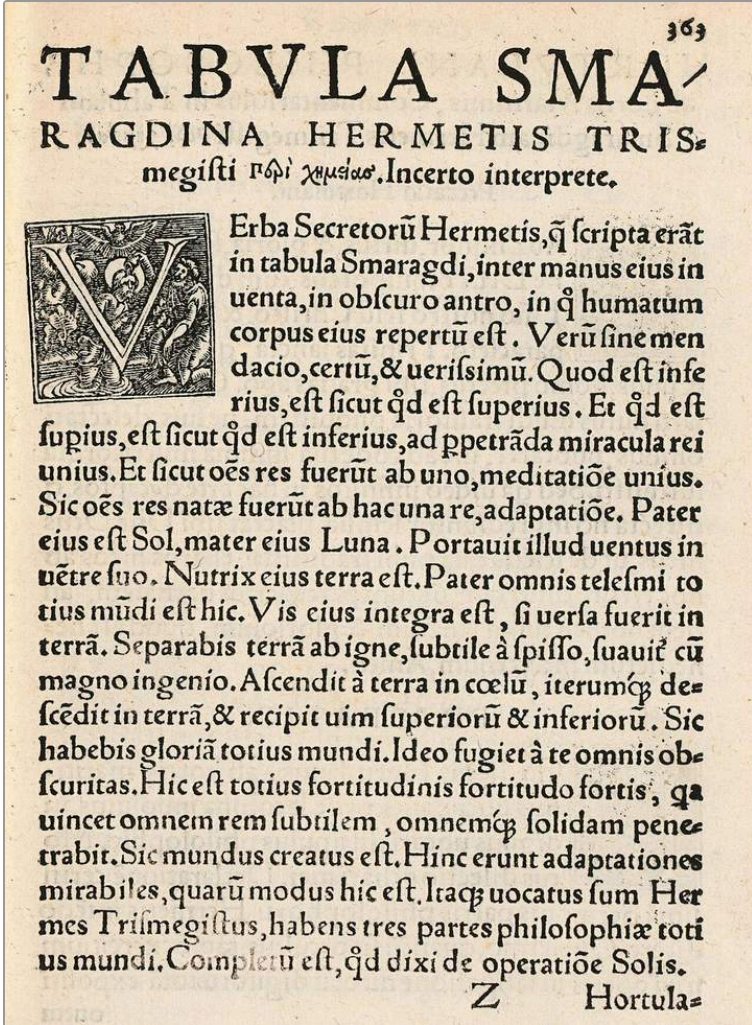


PLATE III — THE TABLET IN PRINT, 1541. The page from *De Alchemia* discussed above — the *editio princeps* of the Tablet as a free-standing text, and the printing that set it beside Hortulanus's commentary for the first time.

Petreius, its printer, is the same Nuremberg house that published Copernicus's *De revolutionibus* two years later. Reading the Latin here against the English on the preceding pages is the quickest way to see how much a translator decides.

Johannes Petreius, Nuremberg, 1541. Public domain; digitised by e-rara /
Zentralbibliothek Zürich, via Wikimedia Commons.

The commentary tradition

The Tablet’s history is largely a history of people disagreeing about what it means, and the disagreement divides along a fault line that runs through this entire book — laboratory or interior.

Hortulanus (Ortolanus), about whom almost nothing is known beyond what he says of himself, was probably active in the first half of the fourteenth century. His is the commentary that circulated most widely in print — published with the Tablet in 1541, reprinted in 1545, reissued in 1560 as the *Compendium alchimiae* under Johannes de Garlandia’s name, and again in 1571 — and he read the text as an operative one: a cryptic recipe describing laboratory processes under cover names, in which the Sun and Moon stand for alchemical gold and silver. He could not translate the obscure word *telesmus* either. He left it standing and glossed it; in the Elizabethan English of *The Mirror of Alchimy* (London, 1597) the gloss reads that the Philosopher “calleth the worke, the Father of all the Telesme: that is, of all secret, or of all treasure of the whole worlde.”

The word was obscure because it was not Latin. The vulgate’s translator met the Arabic *ṭilasm*, could not place it, and transliterated it as *telesmus* — the texts spell it variously (*telesmus*, *telesmum*, *telesmi*, *thelesmi*; the 1597 English *telesme*). Behind the Arabic is a Greek word built on the verb *teleō*, to complete or to perform a rite, though the witnesses differ over its form; the same Arabic word reaches English as “talisman.” The oldest Arabic recension calls the one thing *abū al-ṭilasmāt*, father of talismans.

Albertus Magnus commented on the vulgate in *On Minerals*, around 1250. **Roger Bacon** edited and annotated the Latin *Secret of Secrets* — Philip of Tripoli’s version, not a translation of his own — believing it a genuine work of Aristotle. Robert Steele, its 1920 editor, held that Bacon cited it throughout his career; Steven Williams has since argued that the edition belongs to the end of

Bacon's life, around 1280, and Bacon's heavy use of the text is documented from the 1260s rather than from his earliest writings. Either way it illustrates how much intellectual weight a misattribution can carry.

Johannes Trithemius, in the early sixteenth century, moved the reading decisively away from the laboratory and toward metaphysics, identifying the Tablet's "one thing" with the Pythagorean monad and the *anima mundi*, the soul of the world. That is an early and influential instance of the metaphysical reading; Debus records it being taken up by Dee, Agrippa and Gerhard Dorn. The move is visible on the page in a letter of his to Germain de Ganay, printed in 1613 among the epistles appended to the *Polygraphia*. Trithemius recites the Tablet with the arithmetic of unity written into it — *Quod est superius, est sicut quod est inferius ... quia solis unitatibus constat omnis numerus ad perpetranda miracula unius rei multa*: the miracles of the one thing are worked because every number is built of unities alone. The alchemists who take the text as furnace instruction are dismissed in the same letter as *simiarum discipuli, hostes naturae* — apes' pupils, enemies of nature — and the new reading is stated outright: *Nostra philosophia coelestis est non terrena* — our philosophy is celestial, not earthly. Whether the twentieth-century psychological readings descend from it or merely resemble it is not something the scholarship establishes.

Newton made his own interpretive choice at that same word. Where the Latin vulgate reads *pater omnis telesmi*, Newton's own Latin copy of the Tablet, on a later leaf of the same manuscript, reads *pater omnis perfectionis*, and his English follows it: "The father of all perfection in the whole world is here." The substitution therefore stands in the Latin rather than in an act of Englishing, and whether the reading was his own or one he inherited is not settled. It is worth adding that Newton's commentary in the same manuscript reads the text as chemistry, in terms of mercury and sulphur. The word did not make a cosmologist of him.

“AS ABOVE, SO BELOW” IS NOT IN THE EMERALD TABLET

The most quoted sentence in Western esotericism is a paraphrase, and a recent one. The vulgate’s second verse, in Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer’s translation, reads: “*That which is above is like to that which is below, and that which is below is like to that which is above.*” (Witnesses of the vulgate differ over which half comes first; the Latin behind Newton’s version above begins with the lower. The sense is unaffected — the verse is symmetrical.) The oldest Arabic recension runs differently again: its second line, *inna al-a’lā min al-asfal wa-l-asfal min al-a’lā*, says that the uppermost is *from* the lowermost and the lowermost *from* the uppermost. (Arabic as edited by Ursula Weisser; the English here is a literal gloss rather than a published translation, and is given without quotation marks for that reason.)

Note that the Arabic says the levels *derive from* each other, where the vulgate says they *resemble* each other. The Latin translators did not agree among themselves: Hugo of Santalla, working directly from the *Book of the Secret of Creation*, has *Superiora de inferioribus, inferiora de superioribus* — “from”, not “like” — and the *Secret of Secrets* version has the levels *respondent*, correspond. The vulgate was made from a different and now-lost Arabic compilation, so where the shift entered cannot be established.

The compressed form — “as above, so below” — was popularised by **Helena Blavatsky** in the late nineteenth century, and it was through her that it became the motto of modern occultism and later of the New Age. She does not present it as her own coinage: in *Isis Unveiled* (1877) she introduces it as something the reader already knows — “Remember the Hermetic axiom: ‘As above, so below; as in heaven, so on earth’” (vol. 1, p. 294) — and where she translates the verse itself (vol. 1, p. 507) she renders it “What is below is like that which is above,” not by the maxim. The wording is not the Tablet’s; whether it is hers is not established. This

is the same pattern as the Kybalion of Chapter 1: a modern formulation, elegant and genuinely useful, circulating as an ancient one. The maxim is a fair summary of what the verse says. It is simply not a quotation from it.

A third English rendering

This chapter has now printed Newton's version, and the note above gives Steele and Singer's. A third exists in this book's own period range and is worth setting beside them, because it shows how much the Tablet moves between translators. It appears inside *The Glory of the World*, one of the twenty-two alchemical treatises of *The Hermetic Museum*, Englished in 1893 — where the Tablet is quoted not as a curiosity but as an authority in an argument, numbered among forty other citations:

THE EMERALD TABLE: It is true, without any error, and it is the sum of truth; that which is above is also that which is below, for the performance of the wonders of a certain one thing, and as all things arise from one Stone, so also they were generated from one common Substance, which includes the four elements created by God. And among other miracles the said Stone is born of the First Matter. The Sun is its Father; the Moon its Mother; the wind bears it in its womb, and it is nursed by the earth. Itself is the Father of the whole earth, and the whole potency thereof. If it be transmuted into earth, then the earth separates from the fire that which is most subtle from that which is hard, operating gently and with great artifice. Then the Stone ascends from earth to heaven, and again descends from heaven to earth, and receives the choicest influences of both heaven and earth. If you can perform this you have the glory of the world.

Set that against Newton. Where Newton has *that which is below is like that which is above*, this has *that which is above is also that which is below* — likeness has become identity. Where Newton has the bare *one only thing*, this interpolates *one Stone* and *one common Substance, which includes the four*

elements, importing a doctrine the Tablet does not state. And the alchemical treatise it sits in takes its own title from the Tablet's closing promise: *you have the glory of the world*.

Three English versions, then, of a text that was already a translation of a translation. None is wrong; each is a reading. This is the ordinary condition of the material, and the reason this book gives the date and the translator every time it prints a sentence.

Reading it

Taken on its own terms, the Tablet describes a single process in a single substance. One thing is the origin of all things. It has a father and a mother, so its production requires a union. It must be separated — earth from fire, subtle from gross — and the separation must be done *sweetly, with great industry*, which is to say gradually and with attention rather than by force. It then ascends and descends, gathering the powers of what is above and what is below, and returns changed. The result penetrates everything.

Whether that is an account of a metallurgical operation, of the cosmos, or of a person is precisely the question the commentators have argued for eight hundred years, and the text is constructed so as not to settle it. That ambiguity is not a defect of the writing; on any reading of its purpose, it is the writing. The instruction that survives translation into every register is the one in the middle: separate patiently what has been confused, and expect to have to do it more than once.

Sources: *Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣanʿat al-Ṭabīʿa*, late 8th / early 9th c. (Ruska 1926, p. 166: 6th–8th c.; Kraus 1942, vol. II, pp. 274–75: c. 813–833; Weisser 1980, p. 54: c. 750–800); the vault frame story at Ruska, pp. 166–67. Pseudo-Jābir, *Kitāb Uṣṭuqus al-Uss al-Thānī*. Ibn Umayl, *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth*, 10th c. (Latin *Tabula Chemica*); the Tablet quoted and glossed there at Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, *Ambix* 3 (1949), 69–90, sect. XXI at p. 81. Pseudo-Aristotle, *Sirr al-Asrār*, 10th c. (long version); the Latin text of the Tablet in Robert Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1920), pp. 115–17. Robert of Chester (1144); vulgate version, 12th c., tentatively Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–45); Hugo of Santalla (c. 1145–51), ed. Françoise Hudry, *Chrysopoeia* 6 (1997–99), 1–154; Philip of Tripoli (13th c.). First printing as a free-standing alchemical text: *De Alchemia*, ed. “Chrysogonus Polydorus” (probably Andreas Osiander), Johann Petreius, Nuremberg, 1541, with Hortulanus’s commentary — but a different Latin version was already in print inside the *Secretum secretorum* by 1501 at the latest. Hortulanus, probably first half 14th c.; English of his commentary in *The Mirror of Alchimy* (London: printed by Thomas Creede for Richard Olive, 1597). Albertus Magnus, *On Minerals*, c. 1250; Roger Bacon, c. 1275–80, with Steven J. Williams, *Speculum* 69 (1994), 57–73, against Steele’s dating; Trithemius, early 16th c.: A. G. Debus, *Alchemy and Early Modern Chemistry* (2004), p. 415, for the reading’s later adoption; the letter to Germain de Ganay is quoted from *Libri Polygraphiae* (Strasbourg: Zetzner, 1613), pp. 31–32, read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan (identifier *bub_gb_E5TjGI-NIOsC*, leaves 716–717); the scan’s text layer is unusable for Latin and supplied no wording. In those quotations the long s is set as s and æ and æ are expanded to ae and oe; the ellipsis omits the clause’s mirrored second half, *et quod est inferius, est sicut quod est superius*, where the page has an ampersand; and the recipient is named in the French form — the letter’s own address is *ō Germane*. English of the vulgate’s second verse: Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer, “The Emerald Table,” *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine* 21 (1928), 485–501. Newton’s rendering: Keynes MS. 28, King’s College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v, in *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), ALCH00017 public domain. “As above, so below” — popularised by Blavatsky, who quotes it as a received “Hermetic axiom”: *Isis Unveiled* (1877), vol. 1, pp. 294, 306, 507.

Meditation Practices

Meditation is the foundation of everything else in this book. Every other practice here assumes an attention that can be directed and held, and that capacity is not native — it is trained. The ancient texts are explicit that the ascent they describe begins with stillness, and the practical writers of every later period agree. Skipping this chapter to reach the interesting ones is the most common mistake made with material like this, and it reliably produces practitioners who can recite correspondences and cannot sit still for ten minutes.

Basic technique

1. Find a quiet place to sit, upright but not rigid, where you will not be interrupted.
2. Close your eyes and bring your attention to the breath — not controlling it, simply following it.
3. When thoughts arise, notice them and return attention to the breath. *This is the practice; the returning is not an interruption of it.*
4. Begin with ten to fifteen minutes daily and increase gradually.
5. Be consistent rather than ambitious. Ten minutes every day will take you further in a year than an hour once a week.

Two things worth knowing at the outset. The first is that a session in which you notice fifty distractions is not a failed session — noticing is the skill being built, and fifty noticings is fifty repetitions. The second is that progress in this practice is almost invisible from inside it. What changes is not the quality of the sitting but the quality of the rest of the day.

Contemplation of a form

Once bare attention is reasonably stable, the tradition turns it toward an object. Take one of the forms from Chapter 3 — the circle, the triangle, a single sephirah — and hold it in mind, returning to it as you returned to the breath. The aim is not to think discursively about the symbol but to let it remain in attention until it begins to disclose relations you had not put there.

This is the technique the Hermetic texts assume when they describe knowledge arriving as vision rather than as argument. It is also where honest self-assessment becomes important: the felt sense of profound insight is not evidence of insight, and the practice includes writing down what you thought you saw and reading it again a week later when the atmosphere has worn off.

The discipline of the four elements

A widely used progression takes the elements of Chapter 5 as meditative subjects in turn: sitting with earth as solidity and weight, water as flow and receptivity, air as movement and mediation, fire as transformation. Each is held for a period of days or weeks before moving on. The value of the exercise is diagnostic as much as devotional — most people find one of the four significantly harder than the others, and that difficulty is generally informative.

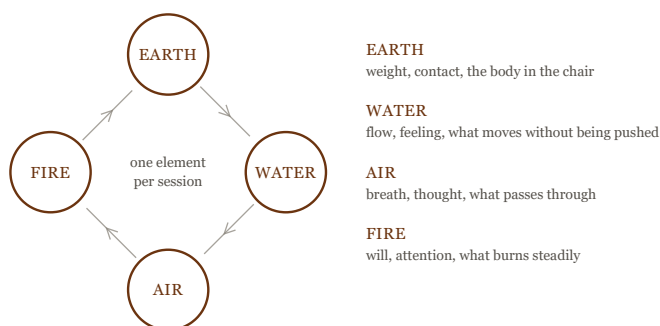


FIG. 1 — THE DISCIPLINE OF THE FOUR ELEMENTS. One element per sitting, in order, returning to earth. The sequence is not arbitrary: it runs from the most tangible to the least, so that attention is trained on something it can hold before being asked to hold something it cannot. Four sessions make one turn of the cycle; the tradition expects many turns. Drawn for this book.

Vibration

One technique deserves its own heading because everything ceremonial in this book depends on it, and because it is almost always taught badly. To *vibrate* a divine name is not to say it loudly. It is to sound it so that the body itself carries the sound — chest, throat, the bones of the face — and to hold the meaning of the name in attention while doing so.

The clearest published instruction is also one of the oldest available in English, from Crowley's *Liber O* of 1909, which prints it as a preliminary to assuming a godform:

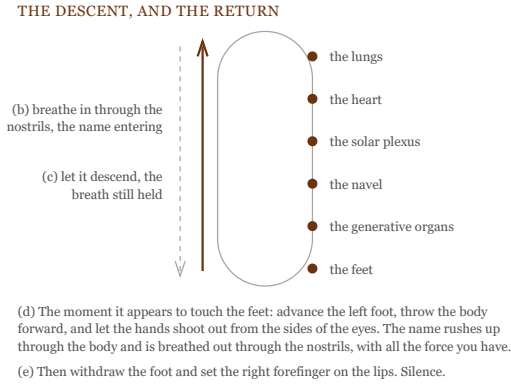


FIG. 2 — THE DESCENT, AND THE RETURN. *Liber O* names the stations exactly and in order — lungs, heart, solar plexus, navel, generative organs, feet — and the whole operation turns on the name reaching the feet before it is sent back up. The two attitudes it ends in are named for Horus, hands thrust out, and Harpocrates, finger to the lips. The text asks for the outbreath to be made with every bit of force the operator has, and treats being barely able to stand afterwards as the sign that a single vibration was done properly. Drawn for this book from *Liber O* (1909), section III; the wording in the panel is a compression of its steps (b) to (e), not a quotation.

VIBRATING A DIVINE NAME — LIBER O (1909)

1. Stand with arms outstretched.
2. Breathe in deeply through the nostrils, *imagining the name of the God desired entering with the breath.*
3. Let that name descend slowly from the lungs to the heart, the solar plexus, the navel, and so to the feet.
4. The moment it appears to touch the feet, advance the left foot, throw the body forward, and let the hands shoot out from beside the eyes, breathing the name out through the nostrils with all the force of which you are capable.
5. Withdraw the left foot and place the right forefinger upon the lips.

The text adds two tests, and they are worth quoting because they set an unusually concrete standard for a spiritual exercise. The first: it is a sign the student is doing it correctly “when a single ‘Vibration’ entirely exhausts his physical strength.” The second, a sign of success perceptible only to the practitioner, is when the name is heard “vehemently roared forth, as if by the concourse of ten thousand thunders,” and appears to proceed “from the Universe, and not from himself.”

That is the ceremonial maximum. For ordinary daily practice, a great deal less will do: sound the name on a single sustained out-breath, low in the chest, until the breath runs out, and feel where in the body it resonates. The rest of this book assumes you can do that much. The full form is worth attempting occasionally, if only because it makes the difference between vibrating a name and merely pronouncing one impossible to miss.

A daily sequence

The techniques above are given separately because the sources give them separately; a practice needs them in an order. The following twenty-minute sequence is this book's own arrangement of the chapter's contents and claims no other authority. Sit as directed and settle the breath into a slow, even count — the modern convention of equal fourths (in for four, hold for four, out for four, hold for four) is as good a regulator as any and is offered as convention, not doctrine. When the breath is steady, take up one contemplation only: a form from Chapter 3, one element of the four, or a single sentence of the Corpus held and turned without commentary. Close with a single vibrated name, as taught above, and write the record before standing up. One object per sitting, the same hour each day, and the journal kept honestly — the discipline is the practice; the contents of any one sitting matter far less than the unbroken series.

Recording the work

Keep a record. Date each session, note its length, and write a sentence or two on what happened without embellishing it. The reason is practical rather than ceremonial: memory is unreliable about interior states, and it edits in the direction of a good story. A written record is the only means you have of distinguishing genuine development from the impression of it, and it is the closest thing this tradition has to an experimental notebook.

MODERN PRACTICE

The technique above is essentially what the sources describe, and it needs little updating — but the surrounding context has changed in ways worth naming. Contemporary practitioners have access to a large body of clinical research on meditation that no historical author had, and it broadly supports the basic claims about attention, stress response and emotional regulation while saying nothing either way about the metaphysics. Many now use timers or apps for the practical business of sitting, which is a straightforward improvement over guessing. The one genuinely modern caution: intensive practice can destabilise people with certain psychiatric histories, a risk the historical literature does not discuss because it had no framework for it. If you have a history of dissociation, psychosis or severe trauma, extend the timelines and work with a professional rather than alone.

Sources: The vibration exercise is Aleister Crowley, *Liber O vel Manus et Sagittae sub figura VI*, section III, first printed in *The Equinox* I, no. 2 (1909) public domain; the quoted phrases are his. The remaining practices in this chapter are described rather than quoted, and are common to the contemplative literature of several traditions; no single historical source is claimed for them.

Ritual Foundations

Ritual is structured action undertaken to mark, focus and contain a piece of inner work. Its function is to establish a boundary in time and space: within these words and this hour, attention is on one thing only. That framing is what does the work, and it is why ritual structure is remarkably consistent across traditions that share no content at all.

The basic structure

1. **Preparation** — cleanse yourself and the space. Bathe; clear the room of clutter and interruption; put away anything not needed. Historically this stage was elaborate: the *Key of Solomon* devotes considerable attention to ablution, abstinence and prayer before any operation begins.
2. **Opening** — define the space and invoke protection. This is the circle of Chapter 3 made operational, and it is where a banishing such as the one in Chapter 15 is normally performed.
3. **Main work** — the central action: a meditation, a contemplation, a stated intention, a consecration.
4. **Closing** — give thanks, and close the circle deliberately. Closing matters as much as opening. A ritual left open is a working left unfinished, and in practical terms it means the frame that was meant to contain the work now has nothing to contain it.

Why the frame works

It is worth being clear about the mechanism, because the tradition is not, at its better moments, mystifying about it. A ritual makes an intention expensive. It requires preparation, time, specific words in a specific order, and the deliberate exclusion of everything else. Anything held to that standard is held with a seriousness that a passing wish cannot reach. The consistency of ritual structure across unconnected cultures is easier to explain by the reliability of that effect than by any shared descent.

This is also why the historical sources are so insistent on precision. Instructions about the hour, the direction faced, the material of an instrument, the exact form of words — these are not arbitrary hurdles. They are the means by which an action is made deliberate. Whether one takes the planetary hours of the Solomonite literature literally or as a discipline of timing, the effect on the operator is much the same.

The circle itself, as the Key builds it

This chapter has consecrated the water, the salt, the sword and the vestments, and has walked a circle in the opening rite — without ever giving the figure its own construction. The *Key of Solomon* devotes a chapter to it, and the thing it describes is not a chalk ring but a piece of surveying: three concentric circumferences, two squares set corner-on to the quarters, four small circles at the outer square's angles, and a divine name written in every space the construction opens. It is given below as the Key gives it, and the preparations that precede it — nine days' continence, the bath on the seventh, the white linen, the last three days fasting “without wind, and without clouds rushing hither and thither over the face of the sky” — belong to it as much as the geometry does.

THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE CIRCLE, FROM THE KEY OF SOLOMON

Who carries what. The Master distributes the instruments before anyone walks to the place: “The First Disciple will bear the Censer, the Perfumes and the Spices; the Second Disciple will bear the Book, Papers, Pens, Ink, and any stinking or impure materials; the Third will carry the Knife and the Sickle of Magical Art, the Lantern, and the Candles; the Fourth, the Psalms, and the rest of the Instruments; the Fifth, the Crucible or Chafing-dish, and the Charcoal or Fuel; but it is necessary for the Master himself to carry in his hand the Staff, and the Wand or Rod.”

The three circumferences. “Take thou the Knife, the Sickle, or the Sword of Magical Art consecrated after the manner and order which we shall deliver unto thee in the Second Book. With this Knife or with the Sickle of Art thou shalt describe, beyond the inner Circle which thou shalt have already formed, a Second Circle, encompassing the other at the distance of one foot therefrom and having the same centre.” Mathers’s note explains the count: two circles enclosed between three circumferential lines. In the foot of space between them, toward the four quarters, are traced “the Sacred and Venerable Symbols of the holy Letter Tau” — the cross, as the manuscripts draw it.

The four Names in the band. Between the first and second circles are made four hexagonal pentacles, and between those, four “terrible and tremendous Names of God”: the Supreme Name *IHVH* between East and South; the Essential Tetragrammatic Name *AHIH*, Eheieh, between South and West; the Name of Power *ALIVN*, Elion, between West and North; and the Great Name *ALH*, Eloah, between North and East.

The squares and the corner circles. “Furthermore, thou shalt circumscribe about these Circles two Squares, the Angles of which shall be turned towards the Four Quarters of the Earth; and the space

between the Lines of the Outer and Inner Square shall be half-a-foot. The extreme Angles of the Outer Square shall be made the Centres of four Circles, the measure or diameter of which shall be one foot.” In those four circles are written, at the East *AL* (El), at the West *IH* (Yah), at the South *AGLA*, and at the North *ADNI* (Adonai); between the two squares, Tetragrammaton.

What is said while drawing. “While constructing the Circle, the Master should recite the following Psalms: — Psalm II; Psalm LIV; Psalm CXIII; Psalm LXVII; Psalm XLVII; Psalm LXVIII. Or he may as well recite them before tracing the Circle.” The fumigations follow; then the Master “should reassemble his Disciples, encourage them, reassure them, fortify them,” place them at the four quarters, “and exhort them to fear nothing, and to keep in the places assigned to them.”

The simpler form. The Second Book gives a plainer way to strike the same figure, and it is the one a reader working alone will actually use: “take thou the Sickle or Scimitar of Art and stick it into the centre of the place where the Circle is to be made; then take a cord of nine feet in length, fasten one end thereof unto the Sickle and with the other end trace out the circumference of the Circle.” A nine-foot radius, struck with a cord from a blade set in the ground — which is why the circles of this tradition are eighteen feet across and why they were drawn out of doors.

Notice what the construction is doing. Every element is a boundary with a name on it: three lines, two squares, four corner circles, and in every interval a name of God, so that the operator stands at the centre of a nested set of enclosures each of which is signed. The instruction to the disciples — keep the places assigned to you, fear nothing — is the same doctrine in the register of stage-management, and it is worth setting beside the modern banishing of Chapter 15, which achieves the identical enclosure with no chalk at all, in a bedroom, in four minutes. The difference is not belief but real estate.

Tools

The traditional instruments — knife, wand, cup, disc, censer, lamp — correspond to the elements and to the functions of a working: to divide, to direct, to receive, to establish. The grimoire tradition specifies their making and consecration in great detail, often requiring specific materials, timings and inscriptions.

Two practical notes. First, tools are not required to begin; a clear space, an hour and a stated intention are sufficient, and every historical tradition contains practitioners who worked with almost nothing. Second, where the historical instructions call for animal sacrifice, blood, or materials obtained by harming anything, they should be read as history and not followed — the ethical position set out in Chapter 1 takes precedence over textual fidelity, and no serious modern practice depends on those elements.

Washing, and what it is for

HOW OLD THE PREPARATIONS ARE

Fasting, washing and continence before a working read, in the grimoires, like medieval Christian discipline borrowed for magical ends. They are very much older than that. The rubric to the sixty-fourth chapter of the Egyptian Book of the Dead attaches this condition to the recitation, in Budge's translation:

This chapter shall be recited by a man who is ceremonially clean and pure, who hath not eaten the flesh of animals or fish, and who hath not had intercourse with women.

Cleanness, abstention from flesh and fish, continence: the same three requirements, in the same order, that open the *Heptameron* and govern the whole first half of the *Key of Solomon's* second book. There is no line of transmission to point at here and this book does not assert one. What can be said is narrower and more interesting: the shape of ritual preparation in the Western grimoires is not a Christian innovation, and it was already conventional in Egypt long enough before them that a funerary text could state it in a single sentence and expect to be understood.

Nearly every operative text in this tradition begins with a bath. The *Key of Solomon* devotes a chapter to it: go to running water, or have warm water ready in a private room, and recite psalms while undressing — Psalm 27, *The Lord is my light and my salvation*, among them. The garments are then linen, or silk if you can afford it, and white; the book specifies that linen thread should have been spun by a young woman, which is the sort of detail that tells you the text is early modern rather than ancient.

What the washing is *for* is worth stating without mystification, because the tradition is not consistent about it and the modern practitioner has to decide. Read one way it is purification in a literal sense. Read another it is a boundary

marker: the point at which ordinary time stops. The second reading is the one that survives translation into a life with plumbing, and it is the reason the instruction is worth keeping even if you do not believe the first. Wash, deliberately, before you begin. Put on something you wear for nothing else.

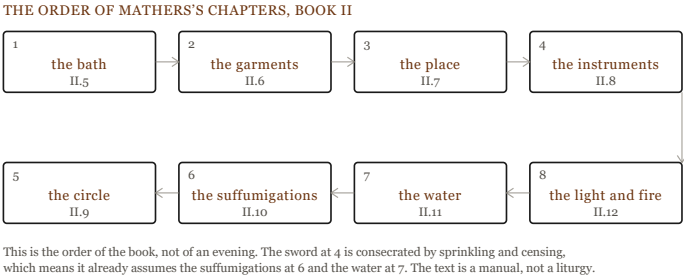


FIG. 1 — THE ORDER OF PREPARATION. Three of the rites printed below are consecrations, and this is where each sits in the *Key of Solomon*: the water for the bath at 1, the sword at 4, the water and salt at 7. Read serpentine — left to right along the top, then right to left along the bottom. What the figure shows is the order of Mathers’s chapters, which is worth knowing precisely because it is *not* a working sequence: the manual describes the instruments before it describes the water they are to be sprinkled with. Any operator has to reorder it, and the book never says how. Drawn for this book from the chapter list of the 1889 first edition.

THE EXORCISM OF THE WATER, FOR THE BATH

From the *Key of Solomon*, Book II, chapter 5. Undressing, the operator recites, in Mathers's printing, Psalms 14 or 53, 27, 54, 81 and 105. (Lists differ between manuscripts, and editions that record the variants give a different set again; the sequence above is the one Mathers actually prints.) Entering the water, they say:

I exorcise Thee, O Creature of Water, by Him Who hath created thee and gathered thee together into one place so that the dry land appeared, that thou uncover all the deceits of the Enemy, and that thou cast out from thee all the impurities and uncleannesses of the Spirits of the World of Phantasm, so they may harm me not, through the virtue of God Almighty who liveth and reigneth unto the Ages of the Ages. Amen.

That is the 1889 printing's wording. The Latin manuscripts run shorter — “cast out from me all impurity and uncleanness, so that no phantasm may enter therein” — and which reading a modern edition gives depends on which witnesses it follows.

Then dress in the consecrated garment and cense yourself before beginning.

Consecrating water and salt

This is the most useful single operation in the grimoire literature, because the result — a bowl of salted water — is what every subsequent purification uses. The *Key of Solomon* gives it in Book II, and what follows is that procedure, with the text as Mathers printed it in 1889.

THE CONSECRATION OF WATER AND SALT

1. Prepare the censer in the day and hour of Mercury, with the incense of the art (see Chapter 20 for reckoning the hour).
2. Take a vessel of tin or earthenware and fill it with clear spring water. Have salt ready.
3. Say over the salt:
*TZABAOTH, MESSIACH, EMANUEL, ELOHIM GIBOR,
 YOD HE VAU HE; O God, who art the Truth and the Life,
 deign to bless and sanctify this creature of salt, to serve unto
 us for help, protection and assistance in this art, experiment
 and operation, and may it be a succour unto us.*
4. Cast the salt into the water, and say Psalms 102, 54, 6 and 51.
5. Make a sprinkler of vervain, fennel, periwinkle, sage, valerian, mint, marjoram, basil and rosemary, gathered in the day and hour of Mercury with the Moon increasing, and bind it with thread spun for the purpose.

Two notes on the text. The divine names in step three vary considerably between manuscripts — Mathers's reading is given above; other witnesses have *Zeuaod, Messiah, Jehova, Nghimanuel, Nghelion, Gibor* and several further variants, which is characteristic of this literature and a reminder that no single wording is *the* wording. And the psalm numbers are given here in the English numbering; the manuscripts use the Vulgate numbering, which runs one lower through most of the Psalter.

If you keep nothing else from the operative tradition, keep this: consecrated water, made deliberately, sprinkled at the start of a working and used to close it. It costs a bowl and five minutes and it does the work that elaborate ceremony is usually reaching for.

THE CONJURATION OF THE SWORD

The instruments are consecrated as well as made. Having engraved the divine names on the blade — YOD HE VAU HE, ADONAI, EHEIEH, YAYAI on one side, ELOHIM GIBOR on the other — sprinkle it, cense it, and say:

I conjure thee, O sword, by these names, ABRAHACH, ABRACH, ABRACADABRA, YOD HE VAU HE, that thou serve me for a strength and defence in all magical operations, against all mine enemies, visible and invisible.

I conjure thee anew by the holy and indivisible name of EL strong and wonderful, by the name SHADDAI almighty; and by these names QADOSCH, QADOSCH, QADOSCH, ADONAI ELOHIM TZABAOTH, EMANUEL, the First and the Last, Wisdom, Way, Life, Truth, Chief, Speech, Word, Splendour, Light, Sun, Fountain, Glory, the Stone of the Wise, Virtue, Shepherd, Priest, Messiaich Immortal; by these names then, and by the other names, I conjure thee, O sword, that thou servest me for a protection in all adversities. Amen.

The same form serves for the knife and the other instruments, with the name of the instrument changed. Note the shape of the thing: it is a list of names, and the list is the operation.

The vestments, and the aspergillum

Two further pieces of the ceremonial apparatus can be given, and they come through a route worth naming. Several grimoires — the *Grimorium Verum*, the *Book of True Black Magic* — have no public-domain English text of their own. What exists is A. E. Waite's *Book of Ceremonial Magic*, which quotes

and summarises them. So what follows is at one remove: **Waite's rendering**, not those grimoires speaking directly, and the book says so rather than pretending otherwise.

THE SPRINKLER AND THE WATER

Sprinkling is performed with the *aspergillum*, which, according to the *Grimorium Verum*, should be composed of **mint, marjory and rosemary**, bound about with a thread woven by a virgin girl. It should be made on the day and in the hour of Mercury, the moon waxing.

The ewer should be a pot of glazed earth, filled with fresh spring water, in which some salt has been cast. Over it are recited the Psalms *Domine, ne in furore tuo arguas me* and *Domine, exaudi orationem meam* — Psalms 6 and 102 — with this prayer:

“O Thou most powerful Lord, my God, my rest, and my life! Do Thou help me, Most Holy Father! In Thee I place my hope, Who art the God of Abraham, God of Isaac, God of Jacob, God of the Angels and Archangels...”

Set that beside the consecration of water and salt given earlier in this chapter from the *Key of Solomon*. Same operation, same materials nearly, different psalms and a different prayer — and the herbs differ too, mint and marjoram and rosemary here against the nine-herb sprinkler Mathers prints. Two branches of one practice, neither derived from the other.

THE ASSUMPTION OF THE VESTMENTS

All garments, even to the shirt, must be of linen cloth, and when assuming them these words should be recited:

ANTON, AMATOR, EMITES, THEODONIEL, PONCOR, PAGOR, ANITOR — by the virtue of these most holy Angelic Names do I clothe myself, O Lord, in my Sabbath garments, that so I may fulfil, even unto their term, all things which I desire to effect.

SEVEN ANGELS, TWO LISTS

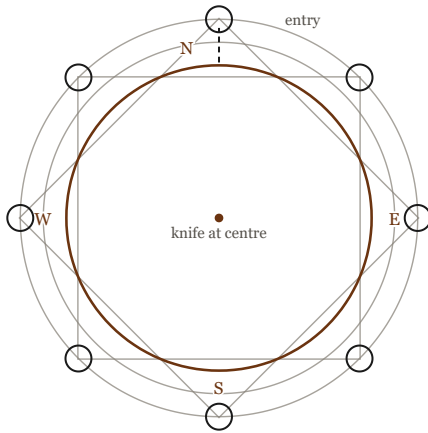
The *Key of Solomon* prescribes the same rite with a different set of names: **Amor, Amator, Amides, Ideodaniach, Pamor, Plaior, Anitor**, and calls the robes Vestments of Power rather than Sabbath garments.

Seven angels invoked at the same moment of the same operation, and the two lists agree on exactly two names — Amator and Anitor. Neither can be derived from the other by any plausible scribal slip; they are two traditions remembering the same seven differently. This book prints both because the disagreement is the finding: a reader who meets one list has met a branch, not the tradition.

The circle

The *Key of Solomon*'s circle is a construction of some complexity, and it is worth seeing in full before deciding what to do with it. Book II, chapter 9: drive the knife into the centre of the working place; take a cord of nine feet; describe the circumference. Mark four regions within it, east, west, south and north. Beyond that circle describe another, leaving an opening toward the north to enter and leave by; beyond that a third at a foot's distance, with the same opening; and beyond these, pentagrams with the names of the Creator,

surrounding the whole. Then a square outside the circles, and a second square set at forty-five degrees to the first so that its angles point to the four quarters, with a censer of lighted charcoal at each of the eight corners.



nine-foot cord
three concentric circles
two squares, offset 45°
eight censors at the corners
names of God between the rims
one opening, to the north

FIG. 2 — THE CIRCLE OF THE *KEY OF SOLOMON*. Book II, chapter 9, drawn to the text's own specification. The figure is included not because anyone is likely to build it but because it makes the logic visible: a marked centre, a bounded interior, a single controlled entrance, the quarters distinguished, and divine names at the perimeter. Every practical modern circle abbreviates this. Drawn for this book.

That is a nine-foot radius, an eighteen-foot circle, and eight burning censers. Almost nobody has ever done it. What the description does establish is the *logic* of a circle in this tradition: a marked centre, a definite boundary, a controlled point of entry, the quarters distinguished, and the names of God at the perimeter. Every practical modern circle is an abbreviation of that logic, and the abbreviation is legitimate as long as you know which parts you are abbreviating.

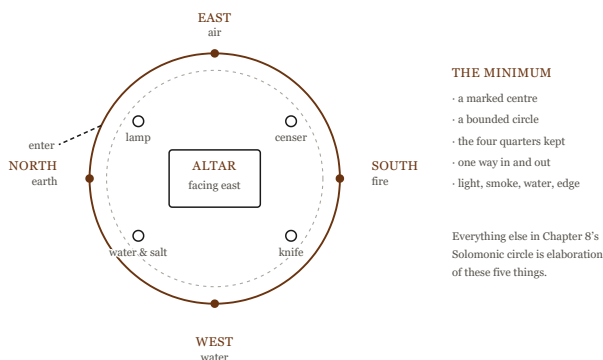


FIG. 3 — THE WORKING LAID OUT. A plan view of the short rite below: the circle, the four quarters marked, the altar at the centre facing east, and the four implements the opening actually uses. This is the practical reduction of the nine-foot Solomonic circle in Fig. 2 — same logic, one room. Drawn for this book.

A working rite you can actually perform

What follows is **this book's own synthesis**, not a historical text — assembled from the elements above and from the banishing of Chapter 15, and offered because a grimoire that describes procedures without ever putting one together is not much use. Every component is dated in the sources line; the arrangement is modern and is mine.

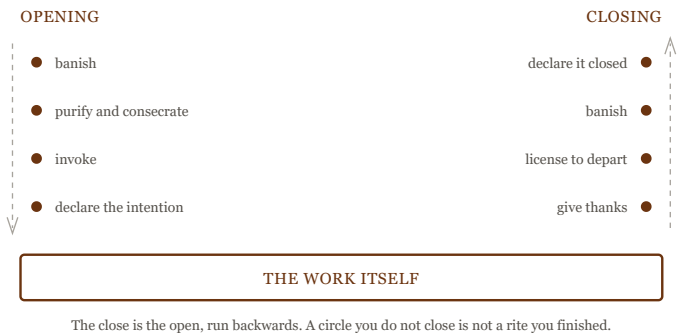


FIG. 4 — OPENING AND CLOSING. The two halves are deliberately symmetrical, and reading them side by side is the fastest way to learn either. Everything raised on the left is dismissed on the right, in reverse order, so that the last thing done is the undoing of the first. The arrangement below is this book’s own, assembled from dated components, and so is the diagram: the sources in this chapter all close what they open, but none of them sets it out as a symmetry, and none uses these four words for the four acts.

OPENING

1. **Prepare.** Wash. Put on the garment. Clear the space and set out what the working needs — no more than that.
2. **Set the centre.** Stand where the work will be done. Three slow breaths. Say, aloud, in your own words, what this hour is for. Aloud matters; the difference between a stated intention and a held one is most of what ritual is doing.
3. **Purify.** Sprinkle the consecrated water at the four quarters and over yourself, beginning in the east and moving sunwise.
4. **Mark the boundary.** Walk the circle sunwise, tracing it with the hand or the knife, returning to where you began. See it as a boundary of light, closed and complete.
5. **Banish.** Perform the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram (Chapter 15), or, if you do not use it, name the four quarters in turn and ask that the space be clear.
6. **Light and incense.** Kindle the lamp, then the censer. The *Key of Solomon* exorcises the fire before the incense goes on it; the practical residue is that you light the fire attentively rather than absently.

CLOSING

1. **Finish the work.** Stop before you are tired, not after.
2. **Give thanks,** in whatever terms you honestly hold — to the source of the work, and to anything you called on.
3. **Banish again.** The same rite as at the opening. The closing banishing is the one practitioners skip and the one that matters: it is what returns the space to ordinary use.
4. **Open the circle.** Walk it widdershins, or simply declare it open, and mean it.
5. **Extinguish** the lamp and the coals. Check them.
6. **Ground.** Eat something. Write down what happened before you interpret it. See Chapter 15.

Twenty minutes, and it is a complete ceremonial frame. Elaboration is available in every direction — a longer purification, a full Solomonic circle, planetary timing, consecrated instruments — and none of it is a substitute for having done the short form regularly.

⚠ Ritual Safety

Begin with simple rituals and work up gradually. Do not attempt advanced or evocatory rituals without proper preparation and grounding. Practical matters deserve equal attention: open flames and candles want a stable surface and a clear space above them, incense wants ventilation, and long periods kneeling or standing in one position want a realistic assessment of your own body. The commonest injuries in ceremonial practice are burns and falls, not spiritual ones.

MODERN PRACTICE

Where the historical sources assume a private room, a full night, and access to consecrated ground, most contemporary practitioners have a bedroom and forty minutes. The adaptations are sensible and near-universal: shortened forms of the longer rituals, electric light where open flame is unsafe or prohibited, substituted materials where the traditional ones are unobtainable, protected or endangered. Many practitioners now work seasonally rather than by planetary hour, simply because a calendar is easier to keep than an ephemeris. What has not changed — and what the modern shortcuts most often lose — is the deliberate closing. Practitioners who abbreviate a ritual almost always abbreviate the end of it, and that is the one part the sources treat as non-negotiable.

Sources: The construction of the circle: *Clavicula Salomonis* in Mathers's translation, *The Key of Solomon the King* (London: George Redway, 1889), Book I ch. 3, pp. 14–16, and the nine-foot cord from Book II ch. 9 — the Book I passages read on the page images of the Wellcome copy, identifier *b24884431*, and the cord sentence from that scan's text layer, which is stated because the two were verified differently. Mathers's footnotes supply the gloss on the three circumferential lines and on the Tau; the transliterations IHVH, AHIH, ALIVN, ALH, AL, IH, AGLA and ADNI are his. *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th; see Chapter 10), trans. S. L. MacGregor Mathers as *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) public domain — Verified for this edition against the first printing itself (London: George Redway, 1889, limited to 500 copies; Wellcome Collection copy *b24884431*), not from a later transcription. Book II, ch. 5 for the bath, its psalms and the exorcism of the water, ch. 6 for the garments, ch. 8 for the instruments and the conjuration of the sword, ch. 9 for the circle, ch. 10 for the incense and the exorcism of fire, ch. 11 for the consecration of water and salt and for the sprinkler. Manuscript variants of the divine names in the salt formula are recorded in Joseph H. Peterson's edition of Mathers's text. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book III, for ceremonial framing. The opening and closing rite given above is this book's own arrangement of those elements and is not a historical text. The aspergillum, the ewer and the vesting names: A. E. Waite, *The Book of Ceremonial Magic* (1913 printing) public domain in the US; Waite d. 1942 — quoting the *Grimorium Verum* and the *Book of True Black Magic*, neither of which has a public-domain English text of its own, so the wording is Waite's rendering at one remove. The variant list of seven vesting angels is from Waite's own footnote comparing the *Key of Solomon*. The purity condition quoted in the note on the age of the preparations is from the rubric to ch. LXIV of the Egyptian Book of the Dead in Budge's translation; the edition and page are given in full in Chapter 22, where the same rubric is printed and the caution about Budge as superseded scholarship is set out.

The Greek Magical Papyri

Everything else in this book is a reconstruction, an interpretation, or a tradition about a tradition. This chapter is different. The Greek Magical Papyri are the working papers of practising magicians of the Graeco-Roman world, written on papyrus in their own hands, surviving in museum cases in London, Paris, Berlin and Leiden. They are not a later account of what ancient magic might have been. They are ancient magic, in its own words, with the abbreviations and marginal notes still in place.

Scholars call the collection the *Papyri Graecae Magicae*, abbreviated PGM. The extant texts run from the late fourth century BCE — PGM XL, the curse of Artemisia, an isolated early outlier — and the first century BCE, down to the fifth century CE, with Christian magical texts extending into the sixth on a dating that should be treated as provisional. The bulk of the corpus, however, is **third to fifth century CE**, and it is worth holding that concentration in mind: this is predominantly the magic of late Roman Egypt, not of the Ptolemies. The texts are written mostly in ancient Greek, but also in Demotic Egyptian, in Old Coptic, and in passages of hieratic script and cipher. Individual texts are cited by volume and item number, so that PGM IV. 1266 refers to a specific line of a specific papyrus, the way one would cite any other classical text.

How they came to light

There was never an ancient library called “the Greek Magical Papyri.” The corpus is a modern scholarly assembly, and knowing how it was put together matters for reading it. The papyri surfaced through the antiquities trade from the eighteenth century onward. The largest single group — the so-called Anastasi collection — was assembled by Jean d’Anastasi, who was vice-

consul and from 1828 Consul-General of Sweden and Norway at Alexandria, as well as a grain merchant and antiquities dealer at the court of the Ottoman viceroy Muhammad Ali Pasha. He acquired the papyri through local agents at an unknown date before 1828; the first documented transfer is the purchase of the collection, consigned to Livorno in 1826, by the Dutch government in 1828 for the Rijksmuseum van Oudheden at Leiden. He said he had obtained them at Thebes, modern Luxor, and further material went to the British Museum, the Louvre, the Bibliothèque Nationale and the Staatliche Museen in Berlin.

Hans Dieter Betz, who edited the standard English translation, suggests — hedged, and as one of two possibilities alongside a temple library — that about half a dozen of the Anastasi papyri may have come from the collection of a single Theban scholar-bibliophile. The ownership of what is now called the Theban Magical Library remains disputed, and other scholars argue for multiple collectors rather than one. What is not disputed is that the same Theban material included Leyden papyrus X and the Stockholm papyrus, both of them alchemical — fourth-century codices written in the same hand, or very nearly, as PGM XIII. (Two Leiden papyri are easily confused and should not be: Leiden X, P. Leid. I 397, is the alchemical one; Leiden W, P. Leid. I 395, is PGM XIII. The Stockholm papyrus, P. Holm., is now in the Kungliga Biblioteket.) That detail is worth pausing on: the alchemy of Chapter 5 and the magic of this chapter came out of the same context. In late antique Egypt these were not separate disciplines.

Publication was slow, piecemeal and, in one instance, tragic. The first pieces of the corpus into print were PGM XL in 1826 (Petrettini) and PGM XIV in 1843 (Leemans). PGM XII and XIII — often wrongly said to have come first — were described in selections by C. J. C. Reuvens in his *Lettres à M. Letronne* (1830) and published in full, Greek text with Latin translation and commentary, by Conrad Leemans in 1885. The first scholarly publication in English is credited to Charles Wycliffe Goodwin, who translated PGM V with commentary for the Cambridge Antiquarian Society in **1852**. The critical edition is Karl Preisendanz's, published in two volumes in 1928 and 1931. A projected third volume, containing new texts and the indices, reached galley

proofs with a preface dated “Pentecost 1941”; Teubner’s Leipzig house was bombed on 4 December 1943. The proofs themselves survived and circulated as photocopies — most papyrological institutes hold the volume — and the 1941 preface was reprinted in the second edition. A revised edition, with Albert Henrichs, appeared in 1973–74, incorporating the lost third volume’s papyri but omitting the indices. Betz’s English translation, including the Demotic texts, was published by the University of Chicago Press in 1986. Preisendanz’s numbering runs to PGM LXXXI; later finds have been given further numbers by convention.

What is in them

Most of these fragments are pages from spell books. Broadly they fall into two kinds. Some are compilations assembled by collectors — scholarly gatherings of magical writing, made out of interest or for study. Others read like the working manuals of travelling practitioners: a repertoire, formulae for all occasions, the common phrases abbreviated because the owner already knew them by heart.

The range is much wider than the popular image of ancient magic allows. There are summonings of gods and daemons of real gravity, and there are parlour tricks. There are fatal curses and there are love charms. There are cures for impotence and remedies for minor medical complaints. There are folk recipes sitting on the same page as elaborate theurgy. The best known single text in the whole corpus is the invocation now generally called the Mithras Liturgy — a sustained ritual of ascent, and the piece most often anthologised.

Certain features recur throughout and are worth recognising on sight:

- *Voces magicæ* — strings of words with no meaning in Greek, Egyptian or Hebrew, to be spoken exactly as written. Their power was understood to lie in the sound and the precision, not in any sense they carried.

- **Charaktêres** — written signs resembling letters with small circles at their terminals, used as a script of their own.
- **Assumption of a divine identity** — rituals in which the practitioner takes on the identity of a deity, through invocation and visualisation, as part of an ascent or an operation.
- **Figurines** — repeatedly referenced, in judicial, erotic and curse workings alike, made of materials chosen to suit the spell. Surviving examples turn up across the Mediterranean, generally in places the Greeks associated with the underworld: graves, sanctuaries, bodies of water. Some were found inside lead coffins with the spell inscribed on the outside.
- **Prayers** alongside all of it, including the Prayer of Thanksgiving — a text that also turns up among the Nag Hammadi Hermetica.



letter-like forms, terminating in small rings

FIG. 1 — *CHARAKTÊRES*. The signs that recur through the papyri and on curse tablets: shapes built like letters but belonging to no alphabet, each stroke ending in a small ring. They are not a cipher for words and no one has read them. The forms drawn here are schematic — the point is the visual grammar, not any particular sign, and reproducing actual sequences from a working papyrus is outside what this chapter does. Drawn for this book.

The formulae are often strikingly close to those found on *defixiones* — curse tablets or binding spells, *katadesmoi* in Greek — inscribed on ostraka, amulets and sheets of lead. Some of those tablets date from as early as the late sixth and early fifth centuries BCE — the oldest are Sicilian, from Selinous and probably Himera — and they have been recovered from Sicily, Athens, Asia Minor, Rome and Egypt, in over a thousand texts. Some collections frame the

corpus more conservatively as fifth century BCE to fifth century CE. That continuity matters: it means the papyri are not an Egyptian curiosity but a window onto practice across the Graeco-Roman world.

The Headless Rite

Several texts from this corpus are printed here in full, and the rule that selects them needs stating before the first of them. It is not a judgement about which spells are safe. It is this: **an operation that acts on nobody but the operator is given entire; an operation aimed at another person is described and not printed.** The reasoning is set out at the end of the chapter, and the rule is applied there without exception. This is the first of the texts it admits, and the most consequential in the corpus for everything later in this book — the ancestor of the ceremonial tradition of Chapter 13 and Chapter 15 — and because it asks nothing of anybody but the operator.

It is PGM V. 96–172, an exorcism. The translation is Charles Wycliffe Goodwin's, made for the Cambridge Antiquarian Society in 1852 and long out of copyright — the first scholarly publication of any part of this corpus in English, and the same edition this chapter cites above.

AN ADDRESS TO THE GOD DRAWN UPON THE LETTER

I call thee, the headless one, that didst create earth and heaven, that didst create night and day, thee the creator of light and darkness. Thou art Osoronnophris, whom no man hath seen at any time; thou art Iabas, thou art Iapos, thou hast distinguished the just and the unjust, thou didst make female and male, thou didst produce seeds and fruits, thou didst make men to love one another and to hate one another. I am Moses thy prophet, to whom thou didst commit thy mysteries, the ceremonies of Israel; thou didst produce the moist and the dry and all manner of food. Listen to me: I am an angel of Phapro Osoronnophris; this is thy true name, handed down to the prophets of Israel. Listen to me, ... hear me and drive away this spirit.

I call thee the terrible and invisible god residing in the empty wind, ... thou headless one, deliver such an one from the spirit that possesses him. ... strong one, headless one, deliver such an one from the spirit that possesses him.

The gaps are in the printed translation, where the papyrus is damaged or Goodwin left the magical names untransliterated. The Greek continues with the passage the modern tradition took up: *egō eimi ho akephalos daimōn en tois posin echōn tēn horasin* — “I am the headless daemon, having sight in my feet.”

IT IS THE HEADLESS RITE, NOT THE BORNLESS RITE

Modern occultism knows this text as the *Bornless Ritual*, and under that name it has been one of the most widely performed pieces of ceremonial magic of the last century. The Greek word is *aképhalos*: *a-*, without, and *kephalē*, head. Goodwin translated it correctly in 1852 as “the headless one,” and the rite’s own imagery — a daemon with its sight in its feet — only makes sense of a figure that has no head.

“Bornless” is not what the word says. This book does not attempt to establish how the reading arose, because it could not verify the usual account; what can be shown is only that the earliest English translation says headless, that the Greek says headless, and that the popular name says something else. That is the pattern of Fig. 1 in miniature — a modern rendering circulating as the ancient one — and it is a fitting thing to find in the one chapter with the largest body of ancient primary material of this book.

Two more spells from the same papyrus

The Headless Rite is the papyrus’s most famous page, but it is not typical of the book it sits in. To show the texture of the working manual itself, here are two further operations from the same manuscript, in the same 1852 translation — both, like the exorcism, acting on nobody but the operator. The first is a consecration; the second is the classic dream-oracle of the corpus.

THE RING OF HERMES — THE CEREMONY OF THE BEETLE

Take a beetle, sculptured as described beneath, place it on a paper table, and under the table a pure linen cloth, and lay under it some olive sticks, and place on the middle of the table a small censer, and offer myrrh and kyphi, and have in readiness a small chrysolite vessel, into which put ointment of lilies, or myrrh, or cinnamon, and take the ring and put it into the ointment, first purifying it from every defilement, and offer in the censer the kyphi and myrrh. Leave it three days, and take it and put it in a pure place.

At the celebration let there lie near at hand some pure loaves, and such fruits as are in season, and having made another sacrifice upon vine sticks, during the sacrifice take the ring out of the ointment, and anoint yourself with the unction from it. Anoint yourself early in the morning, and turning towards the east pronounce the words underwritten.

The carving of the beetle. Carve a beetle upon a precious emerald, bore it and pass a gold wire through, and beneath the beetle carve the holy Isis, and having consecrated it as above written, use it.

Notice what the operation consists of: purification, a fixed waiting period, perfumes, a dawn orientation, and an anointing — the same grammar as the *Key of Solomon's* pentacle consecration in Chapter 20, fourteen centuries earlier. The grammar is the continuity; the gods change.

THE DREAM ORACLE OF HERMES

Take of the inner leaves of laurel twenty-eight, and virgin earth, and wormwood seeds, flour, and the herb cynocephalum — ground up together — and make an image of the cloaked Hermes, the moon's rising being in the Ram, the Lion, the Virgin, or the Archer. And let Hermes hold the herald's wand. And write the spell upon a sheet of hieratic paper, and having cut off a hair from your head, wrap it up in the paper, and tie it with a Phoenician knot, and place outside an olive branch.

And let the figure lie in a shrine of limewood; and when you wish for an oracular response, place the shrine with the god at your head and invoke, offering frankincense upon an altar. The address begins: *Hermes, ruler of the cosmos...* — and the answer is expected in the night's dream.

An incubation rite: the question is prepared by day and the god is expected to answer in sleep. The scrying protocol of Chapter 13 and the record-keeping of Chapter 7 are this operation's descendants, with the statue exchanged for a notebook. Both texts are given as Goodwin printed them, lightly normalised where the scan mangled a letter; his ellipses mark gaps in the papyrus itself.

An inquiry of the god, without a medium

One further operation from the wider corpus shows what a working manual looks like when it is describing a private rite rather than a public one. It is from the *Demotic Magical Papyrus of London and Leiden* — the PGM's bilingual sister, the same Theban material of this chapter, published by Griffith and Thompson in 1904. Most of the papyrus's divinations require a boy as medium; this one the operator performs alone, and sleeps.

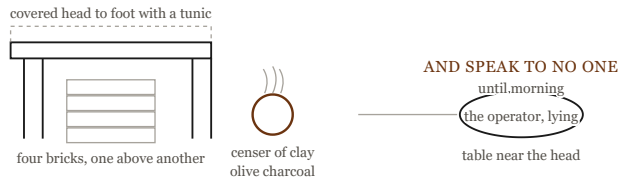


FIG. 2 — THE INCUBATION SETUP. The arrangement the papyrus specifies: a four-footed table nobody has sat on, draped, with four bricks stacked beneath it and a clay censer of olive charcoal before it, standing beside the sleeper's head. Every element is a condition rather than an instrument — the operation is the silence and the sleep. Drawn for this book from the description in the text.

INQUIRY OF THE GOD BY A TABLE AND A DREAM

Take a table of wood having four feet, upon which no man on earth has ever sat, and put it, it being clean, beside you. Put the table in a clean room in the midst of the place, it being near your head; cover it with a tunic from its head to its feet, and put four bricks under the table before it, one above another, there being a censer of clay before it. Put charcoal of olive-wood on the censer, and put wild-goose fat pounded with myrrh, and make them into balls, and put one on the brazier, and lay the remainder at your side, and pronounce the spell to it.

Then **spend the night without speaking to any one on earth**, and lie down. And you see the god in the likeness of a priest wearing fine linen.

The invocation begins: *I invoke thee who art seated in the invisible darkness and who art in the midst of the great gods...*

Griffith and Thompson's edition marks its uncertainties with question marks in the translation. They are the editors' honesty about a damaged text rather than hesitation about the sense, and they are *not* reproduced in the rite above: as this chapter's sources line records, they were dropped for readability and the uncertainty is described here instead. Note what the rite actually requires: a table nobody has sat on, a clean room, a specific smoke, and silence — the operator's own preparation doing most of the work, exactly as in the incubation rite of the Headless Rite's papyrus above.

The so-called Mithras Liturgy

This chapter called it, near the top, the best known single text in the corpus and the piece most often anthologised, and then printed not a line of it. That is the largest thing missing here, and it is fixed below: the text is given entire. It is PGM IV. 475–829, dug out of the great Paris magical papyrus, and it belongs in this chapter on the same rule as the rest — from its first word to its last it acts on nobody but the person performing it. There is no second party in it at all. What it asks for is the sight of the gods and a share in immortality, and the only equipment it names is two amulets and the light of the sun.

Before the text, its name, which is wrong twice over — and the demonstration comes from the translator himself, in the same volume that carries the English. **It is not a liturgy.** “A Liturgy is a service in which several take part, whereas it is plain that our Ritual was a secret and solemn inner rite for one person only.” And **whether it is Mithraic was contested before this translation was printed:** “though Cumont in his great work quotes several passages from the unrevised text, he does so only to reject it as a genuine Mithriac document.” Franz Cumont was the founder of the modern study of Mithraism, and he declined to admit this text to it. Read the rite below and the reason is plain enough: the name Mithras occurs in it exactly once, in the opening prayer, and everything after that is Egyptian, Greek and Hermetic. The title is Albrecht Dieterich's, from *Eine Mithrasliturgie* (Leipzig, 1903), and it stuck to the text

the way “Bornless” stuck to the headless daemon. That is twice in one chapter that the name a text travels under is not the name it gave itself, and in both cases the correction has been available in print for over a century.

Its date and its layers are worth having in the same breath. The Paris papyrus is placed “with every probability as the earliest years of the fourth century A.D.” — late, for a rite so often described as a survival of something much older. And the text is not of one piece: it “has, however, been plainly worked over by a school of Egyptian magicians, who inserted most of the now unintelligible words and names (*asēma onomata, nomina barbara, nomina arcana*), and vowel-combinations and permutations.” That the older layer was Mithraic and the insertions Egyptian is Dieterich’s argument and Mead’s, not this book’s; what is documented is a fourth-century Egyptian papyrus containing both.

THE DAGGERS ARE MISSING NAMES

A dagger — † — stands at sixteen places in the text below. It is not an editorial footnote and it is not damage to the papyrus. It is where the Greek has a magical name and the translator declined to set it: *Protect me!* †! is an invocation of a name, and *For † bids thee [remain]* makes no sense as anything else. Mead says as much obliquely when he comes to the one place he did print the barbarous syllables in full: “I have retained this specimen of magical chanting to give the reader some idea of one mode of theurgic language.” Retained — that is, out of a set he was otherwise suppressing. The daggers are reproduced here exactly where the 1907 printing puts them, and this book does not guess what stands behind them. A reader who wants the names themselves must go to Dieterich’s Greek.

THE RITE OF IMMORTALISATION, CALLED THE MITHRAS LITURGY

Prayers and utterances are in italic and rubrics in roman, which is the 1907 printing's own distinction, stated on its p. 17. The bracketed section headings and the bracketed words inside the text are the translator's.

I. [The Father's Prayer.] *O Providence, O Fortune, bestow on me Thy Grace — imparting these the Mysteries a Father only may hand on, and that, too, to a Son alone — his Immortality — [a Son] initiate, worthy of this our Craft, with which Sun Mithras, the Great God, commanded me to be endowed by His Archangel; so that I, Eagle [as I am, by mine own self] alone, may soar to Heaven, and contemplate all things.*

II. The Invocatory Utterance (Logos). *1. O Primal Origin of my origination; Thou Primal Substance of my substance; First Breath of breath, the breath that is in me; First Fire, God-given for the Blending of the blendings in me, [First Fire] of fire in me; First Water of [my] water, the water in me; Primal Earth-essence of the earthy essence in me; Thou Perfect Body of me — N. N., son of N. N. (fem.) — fashioned by Honoured Arm and Incorruptible Right Hand, in World that's lightless, yet radiant with Light, [in World] that's soulless, yet filled full of Soul!*

2. If, verily, it may seem good to you, translate me, now held by my lower nature, unto the Generation that is free from Death; in order that, beyond the insistent Need that presses on me, I may have Vision of the Deathless Source, by virtue of the Deathless Spirit, by virtue of the Deathless Water, by virtue of the [Deathless] Solid, and [by virtue of] the [Deathless] Air; in order that I may become re-born in Mind; in order that I may become initiate, and that the Holy Breath may breathe in me; in order that I may admire the Holy Fire; that I may see the

Deep of the [New] Dawn, the Water that doth cause [the Soul] to thrill; and that the Life-bestowing Æther which surrounds [all things] may give me Hearing.

3. For I am to behold to-day with Deathless Eyes — I, mortal, born of mortal womb, but [now] made better by the Might of Mighty Power; yea, by the Incorruptible Right Hand — [I am to see to-day] by virtue of the Deathless Spirit the Deathless Æon, the Master of the Diadems of Fire — I with pure purities [now] purified, the human soul-power of me subsisting for a little while in purity; which [power] I shall again receive transmitted unto me beyond the insistent Bitterness that presses on me, Necessity whose debts can never go unpaid — I, N. N., son of N. N. (fem.) — according to the Ordinance of God that naught can ever change.

4. For that it is beyond my reach that, born beneath the sway of Death, I should [unaided] soar into the Height, together with the golden sparklings of the Brilliancy that knows no Death.

5. Stay still, O nature doomed to perish, [nature] of men subject to Death! And straightway let me pass beyond the Need implacable that presses on me; for that I am His Son; I breathe; I am!

III. [The First Instruction.] 1. Take from the [Sun-]rays breath, inhaling thrice [as deeply] as thou canst; and thou shalt see thyself being raised aloft, and soaring towards the Height, so that thou seem'st to be in midst of Air. 2. Thou shalt hear naught, nor man nor beast; nor shalt thou see aught of the sights upon the earth, in that same hour; but all things thou shalt see will be immortal. 3. For thou shalt see, in that same day and hour, the Disposition of the Gods — the Ruling Gods ascending heavenwards, the other ones descending. And through his Disk — the God's, my Father's — there shall be seen the Way-of-going of the Gods accessible to sight.

4. And in like fashion also [shall be seen] the Pipe, as it is called, whence comes the Wind in service [for the day]. For thou shalt see as though it were a Pipe depending from His Disk; and toward the regions Westward, as though it were an infinite East Wind. But if the other Wind, toward the regions of the East, should be in service, in the like fashion shalt thou see, toward the regions of that [side,] the converse of the sight. 5. And thou shalt see the Gods gazing intently on thee and bearing down upon thee. Then straightway lay thy dexter finger on thy lips and say:

IV. [The First Utterance.] *O Silence! Silence! Silence! The Symbol of the Living God beyond Decay. Protect me, Silence! †!*

Next “hiss” forth long: *Š! Š!* Then “puff” saying: †! And thereon shalt thou see the Gods gazing benignly on thee, and no longer bearing down upon thee, but proceeding on the proper order of their doings.

V. [The Second Instruction.] When, then, thou see’st the Upper Cosmos clean and clear, with no one of the Gods (or Angels) bearing down on thee, expect to hear a mighty thunder-clap so as to startle thee. Then say again:

VI. The [Second] Utterance (Logos). *1. O Silence! Silence! I am a Star, whose Course is as your Course, shining anew from out the Depth †.*

Upon thy saying this, straightway His Disk will start expanding. 2. And after thou hast said the second utterance — to wit, twice *Silence* and the rest — “hiss” twice, and “puff” twice; and straightway shalt thou see a mighty host of stars, five-pointed, emerging from His Disk, and filling all the Air. 3. Then say again: *O Silence! Silence!* And when His Disk is opened [fully] out, thou shalt behold an infinite Encircling and Doors of Fire fast closed. Straightway set going then the utterance that follows, closing thy eyes:

VII. The Third Utterance (Logos). 1. *Hear me, give ear to me — N. N., son of N. N. (fem.) — O Lord, who with Thy Breath hast closed the Fiery Bars of Heaven; Twin-bodied; Ruler of the Fire; Creator of the Light; O Holder of the Keys; Inbreather of the Fire; Fire-hearted One, whose Breath gives Light; Thou who dost joy in Fire; Beauteous of Light; O Lord of Light, whose Body is of Fire; Light-giver [and] Fire-sower; Fire-loosener, whose Life is in the Light; Fire-whirler, who sett'st the Light in motion; Thou Thunder-rouser; O Thou Light-glory, Light-increaser; Controller of the Light Empyrean; O Thou Star-tamer!*

2. *Oh! Open unto me! For on account of this, the bitter and implacable Necessity that presses on me, I do invoke Thy Deathless Names, innate with Life, most worshipful, that have not yet descended unto mortal nature, nor have been made articulate by human tongue, or cry or tone of man:*

Ēēō · oēēō · iōō · oē · ēēō · ēēō · oēēō ·
iōō · oēēē · ōēē · ōōē · iē · ēō · oō · oē · ieō ·
oē · ōōē · ieōōē · ieeō · eē · iō · oē · ioē ·
ōēō · eoē · oeō · ōiē · ōiēēō · oi · iii · ēōē ·
ōuē · ēō · oēē · eōēia · aēaeēa · ēeeē · eeē ·
eeē · ieō · ēēō · oēēeoē · ēēō · euō · oē · eiō ·
ēō · ōē · ōē · ōē · ee · ooouiōē !

3. Utter all these with Fire and Spirit once unto the end; and then begin again a second time, until thou hast completed [all] the Seven Immortal Gods of Cosmos. When thou hast uttered them, thunders and crashings shalt thou hear in the Surround, and feel thyself a-shake with every crash. Then once more utter *Silence!* [and] the utterance [following it].
4. Thereon open thy eyes; and thou shalt see the Doors thrown open, and the Cosmos of the Gods that is within the Doors; so that for joy and

rapture of the sight thy Spirit runs to meet it, and soars up. Therefore, hold thyself steady, and, gazing steadily into thyself, draw breath from the Divine. When, then, thy Soul shall be restored, say:

VIII. [The Fourth Utterance.] *1. Draw nigh, O Lord!*

Upon this utterance His Rays shall be turned on thee, and thou shalt be in midst of them. 2. When, then, thou hast done this, thou shalt behold a God, in flower of age, of fairest beauty, [and] with Locks of Flame, in a white Tunic and a scarlet Mantle, wearing a Crown of Fire. Straightway salute Him with the Salutation of the Fire:

IX. [The Fifth Utterance.] *1. Hail Lord! O Thou of mighty Power; O King of mighty Sway; Greatest of Gods; O Sun; Thou Lord of Heaven and Earth; O God of Gods! Strong is Thy Breath; strong is Thy Might! O Lord, if it seem good to Thee, make Thou announcement of me unto God Most-high, who hath begotten and created Thee!*

2. For that a man — I, N.N., son of N.N. (fem.), born of the mortal womb of N.N. (fem.), and of spermatic ichōr, yea, of this [ichōr], which at Thy Hands to-day hath undergone the transmutation of re-birth —, one, from so many tens of thousands, transformed to immortality in this same hour, by God's good-pleasure, of God transcendent Good —, [a man, I say.] presumes to worship Thee, and supplicates with whatsoever power a mortal hath.

3. Upon this utterance He shall come to the Pole, and thou shalt see Him moving round as on a path. Then gaze intently, and send forth a prolonged “bellowing,” like to a horn-note, expelling the whole breath, with pressure on the ribs, and kiss the amulets, and say first to that upon the right:

X. [The Sixth Utterance.] *Protect me! †!*

When thou hast uttered this, thou shalt behold the Doors thrown open, and, issuing from the Depth, Seven Virgins, in byssus-robcs, with serpent-faces, and golden sceptres in their hands. These are they who

are the so-called Heaven's Fortunes (*Tychai*). When thou dost see these things, make salutation thus:

XI. [The Seventh Utterance.] *1. Hail Heaven's Seven Fortunes, Virgins august and good, ye sacred ones who live and eat with †! Ye holiest Protectors of the Four Supports! Hail thou, the First, †! Hail thou, the Second, †! Hail thou, the Third, †! Hail thou, the Fourth, †! Hail thou, the Fifth, †! Hail thou, the Sixth, †! Hail thou, the Seventh, †!*

2. There come forth others, too — Seven Gods, with faces of black bulls, in linen loin-cloths, with seven golden fillets on their heads. These are the so-called Heaven's Pole-lords. And in like fashion unto each of them thou must make salutation with his special name.

XII. [The Eighth Utterance.] *1. Hail Guardians of the Pivot, ye sacred sturdy Youths, who all, at once, revolve the spinning Axis of Heaven's Circle, ye who let loose the thunder and the lightning, and earthquake-shocks and thunder-bolts upon the hosts of impious folk, but [who bestow] on me, who pious am and worshipper of God, good-health, and soundness of my frame in every part, and proper stretch of hearing and of sight, and calm, in the now present good-hours of this day, O mighty Ruling Lords and Gods of me! Hail thou, the First, †! ... Hail thou, the Seventh, †!*

2. Now when they [all] are present in their order, here and there, gaze in the Air intently, and thou shalt see lightnings down-flashing, and lights a-quiver, and the earth a-shake; and [then] a God descending, [a God] transcending vast, of radiant Presence, with golden Locks, in flower of age, [clad] in a Robe of brightness, with Crown of gold [upon His Head], and Garments [on His Legs], holding in His Right Hand the golden Shoulder of the Calf. This latter is the Bear that moves the Heaven[-dome], and changes its direction, now up now down, according to the hour. Then shalt thou see lightnings leap from His Eyes

and from His Body stars. 3. Straightway send forth a “bellowing” prolonged, with belly-pressure, to start thy senses going all together — prolonged unto the very end, kissing again the amulets and saying:

XIII. [The Ninth Utterance.] †, *[O Lord] of me — N. N. — abide with me, within my Soul! Oh! leave me not! For † bids thee [remain].*

And gaze intently on the God, with “bellowing” prolonged, and thus salute Him:

XIV. [The Tenth Utterance.] *Hail Lord, Thou Master of the Water! Hail, Founder of the Earth! Hail, Prince of Breath! O Lord, being born again, I pass away in being made Great, and, having been made Great, I die. Being born from out the state of birth-and-death that giveth birth to [mortal] lives, I now, set free, pass to the state transcending birth, as Thou hast stablished it, according as Thou hast ordained and made the Mystery.*

The seven repetitions of the vowel-string are not decoration, and they answer a question this chapter raised in a bullet point and left hanging. *Voces magicæ* were listed above as one of the features to recognise on sight; that block is what one actually looks like, and the rubric beside it says what it is for — utter the whole string through, then begin again, “until thou hast completed [all] the Seven Immortal Gods of Cosmos.” Seven passes, one for each. The practice was neither secret nor peculiar to magicians. Demetrius, *On Interpretation*, reports that “in Egypt the priests hymn the Gods by means of the seven vowels, chanting them in order; instead of the pipe and lute the musical chanting of these letters is heard. So that if you were to take away this accompaniment you would simply remove the whole melody and music of the utterance (logos).” The seven Greek vowels — A E H I O Y Ω — answer to the seven spheres, and the string above is those seven sounds permuted, which is why it contains no consonant anywhere in it. Check the block: there is not one.

The hiss and the puff have the same standing. Nicomachus of Gerasa, in the second century, is quoted to the effect that the vowels are root-sounds combined with material elements as speech combines them with consonants, and that “whenever theurgists are awe-struck in any such operation, they make invocation symbolically by means of ‘hissings’ and ‘poppings’ and unarticulated and discordant sounds.” The Greek is *syrimos*, a shrill piping or hissing, and *poppysmos*, a clicking or clucking of lips and tongue — used of birds, of the smack of a kiss, and of the cry “hush.” Rendering them “hiss” and “puff” was the translator’s decision and he said plainly that he was unsure of the second: the precise meaning “escapes me.” So the reader has the rubric exactly, and an honest translator’s doubt about half of it.

What the rite is doing is not in doubt. It is a solitary ascent, worked in stages, each stage gated by a spoken formula and a breath: draw breath from the sun’s rays, rise, meet resistance, command silence, hear thunder, see the disk open, name the god, be received, salute what comes through the doors, and at the end die into the state that transcends birth. Strip the names and the sequence is the ascent of the *Poimandres* in Chapter 2, the graded vision of Chapter 19, and — in its insistence that the operator hold steady and keep looking while the body shakes — the scrying discipline of Chapter 13. It is also, on the evidence of the text itself, breathwork: three deep inhalations to begin, breath expelled long against the ribs, the whole thing timed to the lungs. That is the operative core, and it is the part no summary of this text ever reproduces.

Two things are honestly missing. The papyrus prescribes a preparation before any of this — a regimen, and the juice of a plant it calls *kentritis* — and it says how the two amulets are to be made; none of that is in the translation used here, which begins at the Father’s Prayer and ends at the tenth utterance. And every dagger is a name this book cannot supply. A reader who wants the rite whole needs the Greek. A reader who wants to know what the corpus’s most famous text actually says now has all of it that a century-old public translation contains.

A syncretism, not a survival

The religion of the papyri is a genuine blend rather than a pure inheritance. Greek, Egyptian, Jewish and later Christian elements sit together, sometimes in a single formula. Olympian gods take on the attributes of Egyptian counterparts, or Egyptian deities are addressed by Greek names — Aphrodite, associated with Hathor, is given the epithet *Neferihri*, from the Egyptian *nfr-iry.t*, “nice eyes” (PGM IV. 1266). Betz observes that the Greek gods here are frequently not the Hellenised aristocrats of contemporary literature but something closer to the figures of folklore: chthonic, demonic, dangerous.

Betz’s own summary is careful about what this mixture represents: in it, he writes, the indigenous Egyptian religion “has in part survived, in part been profoundly hellenized,” reduced and simplified to ease its assimilation — while Greek traditions were in turn Egyptianised. He is candid that the Jewish material resists explanation, calling its origin and nature “far from clear.” He concludes that what we have is specifically a Greco-Egyptian syncretism rather than a general Greco-Roman one. Janet H. Johnson made the complementary point in 1996: the texts cannot be fully understood from the Greek alone, because the Demotic passages carry part of the argument.

The papyri also sit at the centre of a live scholarly disagreement that any honest reader should know about. Betz treats them as a fraction of a much larger lost literature, a kind of “underground literature” subject to book-burning — citing Acts 19:19, Augustus’s order to burn magical books reported by Suetonius, and later Christian burnings. David Frankfurter reads them very differently: as the productions of innovative members of the Egyptian priesthood during the third- and fourth-century collapse of the temple infrastructure, and therefore far less “underground” than Betz allows. Alan F. Segal goes further still, using the hymns embedded in these supposedly magical texts to question whether the distinction between magic and religion holds up at all in the Hellenistic world. The people who copied these pages, on Segal’s reading, saw no such line.

WHY THIS CHAPTER IS NOT A SET OF INSTRUCTIONS

The operations printed above are given entire; the rest of the PGM are presented here descriptively. That division is deliberate, and it is not a squeamish one. These are historical documents whose interest lies in what they tell us about the people who wrote them — their cosmology, their anxieties, their remarkable willingness to file a summoning of a god next to a cure for a headache. The line this book draws is not between safe and unsafe texts but between operations that act on the operator and operations aimed at somebody else. Reproducing a binding spell against a named person would not make this book more authentic; it would only make it worse. Every rite printed in this chapter falls on the operator's side of that line — an exorcism the operator speaks over himself, a ring he consecrates, two dreams he goes to sleep to receive, and an ascent he undertakes alone — and every operation this chapter withholds falls on the other. Read them as what they are: the most direct access we have to the ancient practice that everything later in this tradition claims to descend from.

Sources: Preisendanz, *Papyri Graecae Magicae*, 2 vols (1928, 1931; vol. 3 reached galley proof, preface dated Pentecost 1941, Teubner's Leipzig house bombed 4 Dec 1943, proofs surviving in photocopy; 2nd ed. with Henrichs, 1973–74) — vol. 1 available at the Internet Archive. Betz (ed.), *The Greek Magical Papyri in Translation, Including the Demotic Spells* (University of Chicago Press, 1986; 2nd ed. 1992) — in copyright. Charles Wycliffe Goodwin, *Fragment of a Graeco-Egyptian Work upon Magic, from a Papyrus in the British Museum* (Cambridge Antiquarian Society, 1852) public domain — the first scholarly publication of any part of the corpus in English, and the source of the Headless Rite, the ring of Hermes and the dream oracle as printed above, all from PGM V. G. R. S. Mead, *A Mithriac Ritual*, Echoes from the Gnosis VI (London and Benares: Theosophical Publishing Society, 1907) public domain — the source of the rite of immortalisation printed above, pp. 18–33, and of the quotations from Mead's preamble (pp. 9–10, 15–17) and comments (p. 62). Every page of it was read on the images of the Internet Archive scan *amithriacritual00meadgoog*, leaves 14–38 and 67; the text layer of that scan corrupts the vowel-string past use — it gives *tê, toê, ðiiê, eôêta* and *e«ð* where the leaf reads *iê, ioê, ðuê, eôêia* and *euô* — so no character of it comes from the text layer. Mead translates Albrecht Dieterich's Greek text, *Eine Mithrasliturgie* (Leipzig, 1903), not the papyrus directly, and his title page says so; the underlying text is PGM IV. 475–829, in Paris, Bibliothèque nationale, suppl. gr. 574. Mead's macrons, accents, italics, brackets and daggers are reproduced as printed. The rite is given entire except that the seven salutations of the Eighth Utterance, which differ only in their ordinals, are elided after the first with a declared ellipsis; the Seventh Utterance prints all seven. The transliterations *asêma onomata*, *syrigmos* and *poppysmos* are this book's, of Greek Mead sets in Greek type. Demetrius and Nicomachus are quoted at second hand, from Mead's pp. 13–14, and neither original was consulted. F. Ll. Griffith and Herbert Thompson (eds), *The Demotic Magical Papyrus of London and Leiden*, vol. I (London: H. Grevel, 1904) public domain — the inquiry-of-god rite, col. IV; the editors' parenthetical question marks are omitted here for readability and their uncertainty is described instead. Earlier partial publication: Petrettini, PGM XL (1826); Reuvens, *Lettres à M. Letronne* (1830); Leemans, PGM XIV (1843) and PGM XII–XIII in full (1885). Frankfurter, "Ritual Expertise in Roman Egypt and the Problem of the Category 'Magician'" (1997). Segal, "Hellenistic Magic: Some Questions of Definition" (1981). Fowden, *The Egyptian Hermes* (1986). Christopher A. Faraone and Sofia Torallas Tovar (eds), *Greek and Egyptian Magical Formularies*, vol. I (California Classical Studies, 2022) — open access; rennumbers the formularies and supersedes Preisendanz. Jessica L. Lamont, "Orality, Written Literacy, and Early Sicilian Curse Tablets," *Greece & Rome* 69, no. 1 (2022), 27–51, for the dating and provenance of the earliest tablets.

CHAPTER X

The Solomonic Tradition

If the Greek Magical Papyri are ancient magic without a famous name attached, the Solomonic literature is the reverse: a large, influential and genuinely important body of texts attached to a name that did not write any of them. Every book in this tradition is pseudepigraphic — attributed to King Solomon, composed many centuries after him, by authors who are almost entirely anonymous. That is not a scandal to be exposed. It was a convention of the genre, and a claim about authority rather than a claim about history. But it does mean that the phrase “the magic of Solomon” describes a literary lineage, not a Judaeen one.

The oldest Solomonic book

This chapter has so far begun in the wrong millennium. Behind the medieval and early-modern books stands a much older text, and it is the one in which the whole idea of Solomon commanding demons is first worked out at length: the *Testament of Solomon*.

Its frame is worth telling because everything later descends from it. Solomon is building the Temple. A demon named **Ornias** is troubling one of the workmen, a boy, draining his strength. Solomon prays; the archangel **Michael** brings him a ring with a seal; the ring gives him authority over demons; and he uses it to conscript them into building the Temple. He then interrogates them one after another — Ornias, Beelzeboul, Onoskelis, Asmodeus and the rest — each stating its name, its activity, the harm it does, and, crucially, the angel or name by which it is thwarted.

That interrogation format is the ancestor of the demon catalogues of the *Ars Goetia*: name, office, appearance, and the means of control. What the later grimoires present as a list, the *Testament* presents as a series of encounters.

One section deserves particular notice because it shows what the text is actually made of. In chapter XVIII, Solomon summons the **thirty-six decans** — the decans being the divisions of the zodiac at ten degrees each, an Egyptian astronomical scheme — and each states which part of the body it afflicts and which name cures it. As McCown observes, the surviving decan lists do not agree with each other, but all agree on the underlying proposition, which Celsus had described as an Egyptian belief: that the decans rule diseases, each of a certain part of the body. This is astrological medicine, of the kind Chapter 16 describes, embedded in a demonological text.

HOW OLD, AND FROM WHERE

Chester Charlton McCown's critical edition of 1922 — assembled from manuscripts at Mount Athos, Bologna, Holkham Hall, Jerusalem, London, Milan, Paris and Vienna — remains the standard text, and his conclusions are carefully hedged in a way this book can only approve of.

On date: the *Testament* as we have it was written “early in the third century.” But its Jewish groundwork may be much older — Josephus shows that ideas of Solomon's dealings with demons “were common among the Jews already in the first century A.D.,” so the underlying material “may be as early as the first century of the Christian era.” McCown then stops: “At present our data allow no more precise date.”

On provenance he is blunter still. “So far as I am aware, no one has attempted to decide from what part of the ancient world the *Test.* came — perhaps wisely, for no certain conclusion can be reached.” He names three candidates — Palestine, Egypt, and the province of Asia — and leans, without insisting, toward Galilee, “where Judaism and Hellenism were in the closest contact.”

So: a text of the early third century, resting on first-century material, of uncertain origin, mixing Jewish, Egyptian, Greek and Christian elements. That is roughly a thousand years before the *Clavicula*, and it means the Solomonic tradition of this chapter has a genuinely ancient root — unlike the Rosicrucian brotherhood of Chapter 12, and like the papyri of Chapter 9.

The Key of Solomon

The *Clavicula Salomonis*, the *Key of Solomon*, is the central text. It probably dates to the sixteenth century, possibly the fifteenth — the older attribution to the fourteenth or fifteenth is Waite's rather than modern scholarship's — and it belongs to the Italian Renaissance. It is a model example of Renaissance

magic — heavily ceremonial, concerned with purification and consecrated instruments, framed throughout in devotional Christian language. Its introduction supplies the traditional legend: that Solomon wrote the book for his son Rehoboam. That is the document's backstory, not its provenance.

The manuscript tradition is rich and worth knowing, because “the *Key of Solomon*” is not one fixed book but a family of related texts that differ from copy to copy. The surviving manuscripts date mostly from the late sixteenth to the eighteenth century. Among the notable witnesses are a fifteenth-century Greek manuscript in the British Library (Harley MS 5596), an important Italian manuscript in the Bodleian (Michael MS 276) of around 1600, and an English translation, “The Clavicle of Solomon, revealed by Ptolomy the Grecian,” dated 1572. The Greek text is generally known separately as the *Magical Treatise of Solomon*; Armand Delatte transcribed one Athens manuscript of it in his *Anecdota Atheniensia* (1927) — not, it should be said, the Harley manuscript. Its contents closely resemble the *Clavicula*. Priority is not finally settled, but the specialist literature leans to the Greek as the ancestral form, and it is almost certain that the earliest Western version was translated from it.

The version most modern readers have met is S. L. MacGregor Mathers's English edition of **1889**, based on manuscripts in the British Museum — the British Library did not exist until 1973, and the anachronism is a common one. Mathers's edition is important for a reason beyond its scholarship: he was one of the three founders of the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, and it was largely through him that this medieval and early-modern material entered modern ceremonial practice. Nearly every twentieth-century magical order that uses circles, pentacles and consecrated tools is drawing, at some remove, on Mathers's reading of these manuscripts.

The practical content of the *Key* is broadly consistent across versions. It concerns the preparation of the operator through ablution, abstinence and prayer; the drawing of the circle as the defined space of the working; the making and consecration of instruments — knife, wand, censer, parchment —

each with its own procedure and timing; the planetary hours governing when a given operation may be attempted; and the pentacles, the engraved figures that give the tradition its visual signature.

The forty-four pentacles

The *Key*'s most-copied contents are its pentacles, and this chapter has described the procedure for making one — in Chapter 20 — without ever saying how many there are or what they are for. There are forty-four, grouped by planet, and Mathers's edition prints them as plates numbered straight through, Figures 11 to 54.

PLANET	PENTACLES	FIGURES	WHAT THE SET IS FOR
Saturn	7	11–17	terror and submission of spirits, adversity, ruin and destruction, defence at night, treasure-guarding spirits driven off
Jupiter	7	18–24	protection of the operator, riches and honour, treasure, visions
Mars	7	25–31	invoking martial spirits, disease and its cure, victory in war, resisting enemies
the Sun	7	32–38	the countenance of Shaddai, transport from place to place, invisibility, deliverance from prison
Venus	5	39–43	controlling the spirits of Venus, attracting love, gaining grace and honour
Mercury	5	44–48	spirits under the Firmament, opening what is shut, knowledge of hidden things
the Moon	6	49–54	opening doors, defence against sorcery and injury, answers in sleep, rain and safety on water

Two of the Saturn set are worth quoting, because between them they show what a pentacle in this literature actually is. The third is a piece of scheduling: “This should be made within the Magical Circle, and it is good for use at night when thou invokest the Spirits of the nature of Saturn,” and Mathers notes that the characters at the ends of its rays are the magical characters of Saturn, with the angels Omeliel, Anachiel, Arauchia and Anazachia named around it. The second is a small revelation:

Figure 12. — The Second Pentacle of Saturn. — This Pentacle is of great value against adversities; and of especial use in repressing the pride of the Spirits.

Editor’s Note. — This is the celebrated SATOR AREPO TENET OPERA ROTAS, the most perfect existing form of double acrostic, as far as the arrangement of the letters is concerned; it is repeatedly mentioned in the records of mediæval Magic; and, save to very few, its derivation from the present Pentacle has been unknown.

The famous word-square of Roman graffiti — found scratched at Pompeii, and argued over ever since — sits in the *Key* as a planetary talisman, and Mathers’s claim about its derivation is exactly the sort this book does not repeat unchecked: the square is centuries older than any manuscript of the *Key*, so the pentacle cannot be its origin, whatever a Victorian editor supposed. What is true and more interesting is the arithmetic he gives with it: twenty-five letters, plus the unity, making twenty-six, the numerical value of IHVH — and the Hebrew versicle around the rim, from Psalm lxxii, also of exactly twenty-five letters. The pentacle is a numerological argument in a circle, which is what the whole class of objects is.

The Lesser Key, or Lemegeton

The *Lesser Key of Solomon* is a separate and later compilation, assembled in the **mid-seventeenth century** from materials several centuries older. Despite the name it is not an abridgement of the *Key*; it is its own anthology, in five books:

1. *Ars Goetia* — the evocation of seventy-two spirits, each with a name, a rank and a sigil. This is the part of the *Lemegeton* that everyone has heard of, and the part that has done most to shape the popular idea of grimoire magic.
2. *Ars Theurgia Goetia* — spirit princes organised by the points of the compass.
3. *Ars Paulina* — angels assigned to the hours of the day and to the degrees of the zodiac.
4. *Ars Almadel* — angelic contact by means of a wax tablet and scrying.
5. *Ars Notoria* — prayers to strengthen memory, eloquence and understanding.

The layering here is instructive. The *Ars Notoria* is substantially older than the compilation that contains it: Véronèse's critical edition traces it from a thirteenth-century version A through a glossed version that appeared at the end of the thirteenth century and survives in three fourteenth-century manuscripts, with the core *Flores aurei* possibly redacted as early as the later twelfth. What survives as book five is a seventeenth-century composite of that older material. And the *Ars Goetia*, the most notorious section, has a traceable and rather deflating pedigree. Its ultimate ancestor is the list in Johann Weyer's *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum* — but not directly. The proximate source is the English translation printed in Reginald Scot's *Discoverie of Witchcraft*, which Peterson attributes to Abraham Fleming rather than to Scot, and whose exemplar he identifies as the expanded edition of 1665, established by the unique errors and spellings that edition introduced. As Peterson puts it, the *Goetia* “does, in fact, seem dependant on Scot, faithfully copying his frequent mistranslations, elaborations, and omissions.” The list is reordered, four spirits added and one dropped.

Weyer's own purpose is the sharpest irony in this chapter. Johann Weyer (1515–1588) was a Dutch physician — city physician of Arnhem, later court doctor to the Duke of Cleves — and he catalogued demons in the course of arguing *against* the witch trials. His *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563) criticised the *Malleus Maleficarum* and the witch-hunting of the civil and

ecclesiastical authorities, and he was among the first to publish systematic arguments against the persecutions. His position was narrower than it is usually reported to be, and the precision matters. Weyer *affirmed* the reality and power of demons — fallen angels who used supernatural powers against the kingdom of Heaven and who needed no human help — and concluded on that ground that the pact was pointless and legally void. What he voided was the pact and the *maleficia*, not the devil. He allowed that alleged acts might be fraud or poisoning, did not object to judicial enquiry of accused witches, and attributed apparently supernatural illness variously to melancholy, poisoning, malingering or unmediated demonic action. He also held learned magicians genuinely culpable, accusing popes, bishops, priests and monks of being magicians in league with the devil — he has been judged more concerned to inculcate magicians than to exculpate women. That judgement is not put in quotation marks here because the wording in circulation could not be traced to a named scholar for this edition, and an unattributed quotation is the one thing this book will not print.

He was also, from about the age of fifteen, a live-in student of Agrippa's in Antwerp — which is why his denunciation of the spurious *Fourth Book* carried weight. So the most notorious demon-catalogue in Western magic was compiled by a sceptical physician trying to stop people being burned, by a man who had studied under Agrippa and defended his teacher's actual work against forgery. It was then lifted, more or less wholesale, into the working grimoire that has carried it ever since.

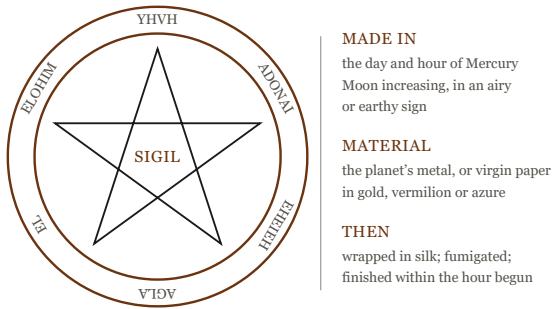


FIG. 1 — THE FORM OF A SOLOMONIC PENTACLE. Not a reproduction of any particular pentacle, but the shape they share: two concentric rings with divine names written in the space between them, and a figure or sigil at the centre. The names used here are the four of the banishing in Chapter 15 plus two more; the *Key of Solomon* tells the operator to choose names “which thou shalt think fit and proper” for the work in hand, so no fixed set exists. The conditions at the right are the text’s own, and are set out in full in Chapter 20. Drawn for this book.

The *Arbatel* and the seven governors

The last text in Turner’s 1655 volume is the *Arbatel of Magick*, first printed in Latin at Basel in 1575, and it is unlike everything else in this chapter. It contains no conjurations, no circles and no seals to draw. It is a book of *aphorisms* — and its system rests on seven governors called the Olympic spirits, each ruling the affairs of one planet.

GOVERNOR	GOVERNS	AS THE TEXT STATES IT
Aratron	Saturn	“those things which in Astronomy are ascribed to the power of Saturn”; teaches alchemy, magic and physic; makes the barren fruitful
Bethor	Jupiter	“governeth those things which are ascribed to Jupiter”; raises to dignities, reconciles the spirits of the air
Phaleg	Mars	“ruleth those things which are attributed to Mars, the Prince of peace”
Och	Sun	“governeth solar things”; gives perfect health, great wisdom, excellent spirits and perfect medicines
Hagith	Venus	“governeth Venereous things”; makes fair, and adorns with beauty
Ophiel	Mercury	“the governour of such things as are attributed to Mercury”; “he teacheth all Arts”
Phul	Moon	“governeth Lunary things”; healeth the dropsy; gives the spirits of the water

All seven attributions above are the 1655 text’s own words, not inferred from the order — though the order is itself the Chaldean sequence of Chapter 20, running from Saturn down to the Moon. Note the strangest line in the table: Mars, “the Prince of peace.” Whether that is Turner’s slip, the Latin’s irony, or a genuine doctrine that the planet of war governs the ending of wars, the text does not explain.

The *Arbatel*’s real distinction is its tone. Where the *Lemegeton* commands and constrains, the *Arbatel* advises: it warns that “a man that is a true Magician, is brought forth a Magician from his mothers womb,” that the governors “hear not the false Magicians, but expose them to the deceits of the devils,” and — quoting John the Baptist — that *no man can do any thing of himself, except it be given him from above*. It is the one book in this chapter that spends more effort on the operator’s character than on his equipment.

Agrippa and the Renaissance transmission

The channel through which all of this reached later practitioners is Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486–1535), whose *De occulta philosophia libri tres* is the single most important synthesis of Renaissance magical thought. Book I appeared in 1531, published at Paris and Antwerp (the Cologne imprint of that year is often listed alongside them but is unattested in the catalogues); the complete three books followed at Cologne in **1533**. The English translation by “J.F.” — probably John French, possibly James Freake — appeared in 1651 and is the version through which the work entered the English-speaking tradition.

The three books ascend deliberately through the levels of a magical cosmos. Book I treats natural or elemental magic: the properties of stones, herbs, animals and the human body, and the “occult virtues” Agrippa held to arise from hidden correspondences between the material world and higher principles. Book II treats celestial magic — stellar and planetary influence, and the construction of talismans to capture it. Book III treats intellectual or divine magic: theurgy, Kabbalah, ceremonial practice. Agrippa insists throughout that the true magus must also be a devout priest-philosopher, and he draws a firm line between holy magic and demonic sorcery, *goetia*.

That line is worth holding on to, because the *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* crosses it. Its earliest known imprint is Marburg, 1559 — twenty-four years after Agrippa’s death — and it was falsely attributed to him, and contains explicit spirit-summoning instructions of a kind entirely absent from the authentic three books. Weyer, Agrippa’s own former student, identified it as a forgery. Much of what circulates as “Agrippa” in later grimoire literature is in fact this spurious fourth book — which means readers have often taken a pseudonymous appendix for the thing it was attached to.

WHAT THE DATINGS ADD UP TO

Laid end to end, the Solomonic tradition runs: a legend of Solomon; a fourteenth- or fifteenth-century Italian text claiming him as author; a sixteenth-century sceptic's demon catalogue; a seventeenth-century compilation that absorbed it; a spurious fourth book attached to a genuine 1533 masterwork; and a nineteenth-century translation by a founder of the Golden Dawn, through which the whole assemblage reached the modern world. Not one link in that chain is ancient. Every link is real, documented, and has a date. That is a more interesting story than the legend, and it is a true one.

The *Heptameron*

One more text belongs in this chapter, because it is the cleanest working system in the whole Solomonic orbit: the *Heptameron, or Magical Elements*, attributed — falsely, like everything else here — to the medieval physician Peter de Abano (d. c. 1316). Its first attested appearance is in print in the sixteenth century, and it reached English in the same 1655 volume as the geomancy of Chapter 24, Robert Turner's translation of the *Fourth Book*.

Its organising idea is in its title: *hepta*, seven. One ritual frame, parameterised by the day of the week — each day with its own angel, its own perfume, and its own proper petitions, all riding on the planetary rulerships of Chapter 20. It is the day-side complement to the planetary hours: where the hours tell you *when*, the *Heptameron* supplies the *who*.

DAY	PLANET	ANGEL OF THE DAY
Sunday	Sun	Michael
Monday	Moon	Gabriel
Tuesday	Mars	Samael
Wednesday	Mercury	Raphael
Thursday	Jupiter	Sachiel
Friday	Venus	Anael
Saturday	Saturn	Cassiel

Note the crossing with Chapter 15: the *Heptameron*'s day-angels put Michael with the Sun and Samael with Mars, where the banishing ritual's quarter-angels put Michael at the fire quarter. The two systems assign the same names by different logics — day-rule against element — and both are “traditional.” This is the normal condition of the literature, and a practitioner who meets a contradiction between two tables has not found an error; they have found two sources.

The preparation of the working place is pure *Key of Solomon* discipline, and one passage is worth quoting for its rhythm alone. The operator, says the text, on the Lord's day in the new of the moon, is to enter the place “clothed with clean white garments,” exorcise and bless it, and make a circle “with a sanctified coal,” writing the names of the angels in the outer ring and the names of God within; then to enter “fasting, and washed,” praying toward the east — “and that let him do six days, continuing washed.”

The other family: the printed grimoires

Everything above belongs to one tradition, copied by hand and attributed to Solomon. Beside it runs a second, printed rather than copied, French rather than Latin or Italian, and cheaper in every sense: small duodecimo volumes sold through the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, promising treasure,

invisibility and command of spirits. They are the books most people picture when they hear the word *grimoire*, and their dates are worth setting out because almost every one of them lies about its own.

A. E. Waite catalogued the family in 1913 and had no patience with it, which makes him a useful guide to the dating even where he is contemptuous of the contents.

BOOK	WHAT IT CLAIMS	WHAT IT IS
Sworn Book of Honorius Liber Juratus	the work of a Honorius, master of magic	genuinely medieval — fourteenth century, in manuscript, not printed
Grimoire of Honorius	the same authority as the above	a different book: 1629, and routinely confused with the Sworn Book
Grimorium Verum	“Published by Alibeck the Egyptian” at Memphis, 1517	mid-eighteenth century, and Roman
Grand Grimoire later the <i>Red Dragon</i>	antiquity by association	eighteenth century, no older than the last
True Black Magic	a manuscript found at Jerusalem in the Sepulchre of Solomon	its own imprint says Rome, 1750
The Black Pullet and its offspring	very little, in the end	late eighteenth century, and barely pretending

Two men called Honorius

The confusion in the first two rows is old and still current. The **Sworn Book** is the serious one: a fourteenth-century manuscript work which Waite calls “one of the most historical and notable Rituals” of its kind, and which “has no title or other determinate name, but it appears from the text that it was understood to be the Sworn Book of Honorius.” Its prologue is a remarkable piece of

framing: the bishops, deceived by demons, have condemned magic, and in answer the masters of magic are convoked to defend it — eight hundred and eleven of them.

The **Grimoire of Honorius** is a printed book of **1629** trading on the same name, and Waite notes that it “has been sometimes referred erroneously to the same period of the previous century.” Three hundred years separate the two, one is a manuscript and one is a commercial print, and a modern edition of either is liable to carry a title implying it is the other.

Memphis is Rome

The *Grimorium Verum* is the clearest case in the genre of an imprint doing the work a text cannot. Its title page offers a translation from the Hebrew by a Dominican Jesuit — two orders which are not the same order — published by *Alibeck the Egyptian* at Memphis in **1517**. Waite’s verdict is one line and it is worth the whole paragraph:

The date specified in the title of the *Grimorium Verum* is undeniably fraudulent; the work belongs to the middle of the eighteenth century, and Memphis is Rome.

Not a mistaken date but a manufactured one, with a manufactured city and a manufactured translator attached. That is worth separating from the misdatings elsewhere in this book. Ficino believed the *Hermetica* ancient and was wrong; Mathers printed the argument against the *Zohar*’s antiquity in his own introduction. Here nobody is mistaken about anything. The false imprint is the first sentence of the sales pitch, and the buyer in 1750 was expected to enjoy it.

Of the last row Waite is blunter still, and the phrasing is exact enough to be worth quoting: the *Black Pullet* and its relatives are “quite unserious publications, which can scarcely be called spurious, as they are almost without pretence.” A book has to claim something before it can be accused of claiming falsely.

WHY THE IMPRINTS ARE EVIDENCE

Read the middle column of the table as a set of marketing decisions and a pattern appears. What sells a grimoire is age, foreignness and danger: Egypt, Jerusalem, a Hebrew original, a sepulchre, a date two centuries before the buyer. The same three ingredients recur from 1517-that-is-1750 to the tarot's Egyptian pedigree in Chapter 25, and they were still working in the nineteenth century.

The practical consequence for a reader is narrow and useful. In this family the title page is not evidence about the book; it is part of the book, and should be read with the same suspicion as anything else inside it.

Sources: The pentacles: Mathers's *Key of Solomon the King* (1889), read from the Wellcome copy, identifier *b24884431*. The Second and Third Pentacles of Saturn and the editor's note on the SATOR square are quoted from p. 59, read on the page image; the figure numbering was verified on Plate II itself, where Figures 11, 12 and 13 stand drawn under Saturn's glyph. The counts and figure ranges in the table were derived by enumerating the plate captions in the scan's text layer — seven each for Saturn, Jupiter, Mars and the Sun, five each for Venus and Mercury, six for the Moon, forty-four in all — and the “what the set is for” column summarises those captions rather than quoting them; neither is a leaf reading, and that is stated rather than glossed over. The observation that the SATOR square long predates any manuscript of the *Key*, and so cannot derive from the pentacle, is this book's. *Testament of Solomon*: Chester Charlton McCown (ed.), *The Testament of Solomon, edited from manuscripts at Mount Athos, Bologna, Holkham Hall, Jerusalem, London, Milan, Paris and Vienna*, Untersuchungen zum Neuen Testament 9 (Leipzig: Hinrichs, 1922), preface dated Berkeley, 24 December 1921 public domain — the standard critical text; quotations above from his sections on date and provenience, and on the decans. *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th; Mathiesen 2007) — MSS incl. Bodleian Michael 276 and BL Sloane 3847 (English, 1572); Mathers (trans.), *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) public domain. Delatte, *Anecdota Atheniensia* (1927), pp. 397–445, for one Athens manuscript of the Greek *Magical Treatise of Solomon*, whose sixteen or seventeen witnesses include BL Harley 5596; fuller editions in Torijano (2002) and Marathakis (2011). *Lemegeton / Lesser Key of Solomon*, mid-17th c.; Crowley's 1904 *Goetia* (Book One only, Mathers's translation uncredited) public domain; Peterson (ed.), *The Lesser Key of Solomon* (2001) for the whole five-book work. Weyer, *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum*, appended to *De praestigiis daemonum* from the fifth edition (Basel, 1577). Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia libri tres* (Book I 1531; complete Cologne 1533); trans. “J.F.” (1651) public domain. *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* — spurious. *Heptameron, or Magical Elements*, pseudo-Peter de Abano, in the same volume, trans. Robert Turner (London, 1655) public domain — the day-angel table and the consecration of the place; wording is the 1655 text, read in a modern facsimile whose typographic setting carries its own copyright. *Arbatel de magia veterum*, first printed in Latin at Basel in 1575; the English quoted here is that of Robert Turner, printed with the pseudo-Agrippan *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* (London, 1655) public domain — the seven governors and their attributions, and the aphorisms, are Turner's wording. On the *Ars Notoria*: Julien Véronèse, *L'Ars notoria au Moyen Âge et à l'époque moderne* (Florence: SISMEL, 2007) in copyright — the critical edition on which the version A dating and the manuscript sequence given above depend. Nothing of his wording is quoted. **The printed grimoires:** A. E. Waite, *The Book of Ceremonial Magic* (London: William Rider & Son, 1911; the 1913 printing is the one cited elsewhere in this book)

public domain in the US; Waite d. 1942 — read from the Internet Archive copy under [a.-e.-waite-the-book-of-ceremonial-magic](#). His is the authority for every date in the table above: the fourteenth century for the Sworn Book and his description of it as having no determinate title, 1629 for the Grimoire of Honorius and the error he notes about it, the mid-eighteenth century and Rome for the *Grimorium Verum*, the Grand Grimoire as no older, and the *Black Pullet* group as late eighteenth century. The title-page wording of the *Grimorium Verum* and of *True Black Magic*, including Alibeck the Egyptian, Memphis, 1517 and the Sepulchre of Solomon, is quoted from his catalogue of the imprints rather than from the books themselves; **this edition has seen none of these grimoires and quotes none of their contents**. Waite is a hostile witness to this literature and says so freely, which is worth knowing when reading his verdicts, though it bears on his opinions rather than on his dates. The observation that a false imprint is a claim rather than a mistake, and the reading of the middle column as marketing, are this book's own.

Demonology

Every tradition in this book keeps lists — of hours, of herbs, of names of God. Demonology is what happened when the same instinct was turned on the enemy. Its literature is not, for the most part, a literature of horror; it is a literature of filing. Spirits have names, ranks, offices, retinues counted in legions, and fixed hours at which they may be approached. The catalogue is the genre. This chapter reads the catalogue across fifteen hundred years — the oldest surviving interrogation of demons, the Renaissance list printed in order to be disbelieved, the English translation that carried it anyway, and the reply of a king who named both authors in print — and then the working itself, exactly as the sources give it: the conditions, the citation, the binding, and the licence to depart, printed from the same leaves as the catalogue, beside the confutation their own printer set two pages after them.

The ring, and the oldest catalogue

The ancestor of every list in this chapter is a Greek pseudepigraphon in which Solomon himself narrates how the demons were put to work on the Temple. F. C. Conybeare, who put the *Testament of Solomon* into English in 1898, placed the core of it around the first century of our era — his dating, argued from its debts to the Enoch literature and its nearness to the New Testament's world — and the text he translated begins not with a rite but with a labour dispute: a demon is taking half of a workman's pay and food, and the workman is wasting away. Solomon prays, and the help that arrives is an object:

And it came about through my prayer that grace was given to me from the Lord Sabaôth by Michael his archangel. [He brought me] a little ring, having a seal consisting of an engraved stone, and said to me: "Take, O Solomon, king, son of David, the gift which the Lord God has sent thee, the highest Sabaôth. With it thou shalt lock up all the demons of the earth, male and female; and with their help thou shalt build up Jerusalem. [But] thou [must] wear this seal of God. And this engraving of the seal of the ring sent thee is a Pentalpha."

The pentalfa is the five-pointed star — Conybeare's note glosses it as five interlaced A's — and the reader who has met the pentagram in Chapter 8 should notice where this one sits: not drawn in the air but engraved on a stone, worn on the hand, and delegated — Solomon lends the ring to the boy with instructions to throw it at the demon's chest and say, "In the name of God, King Solomon calls thee hither." What follows the ring is not an exorcism but an induction. Each spirit brought before Solomon is made to state its name, the star or sign it belongs to, what it does, and — the detail that organises the whole book — the name of the angel by which it is *thwarted*. Orniias, the pay-stealing demon of the opening, is set to hew stones. Asmodeus gives an account of himself that agrees with the Book of Tobit. Thirty-six spirits of the zodiac's divisions appear in a block, each with its ailment and its remedy-formula. Name, office, constraint: the entire later literature is already here, and it is a personnel file.

From office-book to print

The medieval heirs of the *Testament* were manuscript registers — books "of the offices of spirits" — circulating in the same world as the Solomonic handbooks of Chapter 10. What pulled the catalogue into print was, of all things, a book written against the witch trials. In 1577 Johann Weyer — the physician whose *De praestigiis daemonum* had argued since 1563 that the accused were deluded and ill rather than guilty — appended to his treatise a catalogue he titled *Pseudomonarchia daemonum*, the false monarchy of demons: sixty-nine spirits with their ranks, shapes, offices and legions, printed

as an exhibit of what the conjuring books actually contained. Seven years later Reginald Scot, an English gentleman writing the most radical attack on witch-belief of the century, carried the whole list into English inside *The discoverie of witchcraft* — and his margin names the source plainly: *J. Wierus in Pseudomonarchia daemonum*. Neither man believed a word of it. Both printed it. That is how a working conjuror’s register became the most accessible demon-list in Europe: through two authors who published it to be laughed at, and were read by people who did not laugh.

DATE	TEXT	WHAT IT IS
c. 100 CE	TESTAMENT OF SOLOMON	Greek; the ring, the interrogation, the thwarting angels
medieval	BOOKS OF OFFICES	manuscript registers of spirits and their duties
1570	THE T. R. PARCHMENT	English, in red and black; Scot’s copy-text for the forms
1577	PSEUDOMONARCHIA DAEMONUM	Weyer; sixty-nine spirits, inside a book against the trials
1584	DISCOVERIE, BOOK XV	Scot; the same list in English, printed to be disbelieved
mid-1600s	ARS GOETIA	the Lemegeton’s first book; seventy-two spirits, seals added
1904	GOETIA IN PRINT	the Mathers–Crowley edition; the catalogue reaches the revival

FIG. 1 — THE DESCENT OF THE CATALOGUE. Each stage is dated in this book’s bibliography; the counts are sixty-nine spirits in Weyer, sixty-eight in Scot — Prufas is lost in the English, as the text explains — and seventy-two in the *Goetia*. Drawn for this book from the sources cited below.

The inventarie itself

Scot introduces the list with open mockery — conjurors, unlike mere witches, “fetch diuels out of hell, and angels out of heaven” and undertake “to doo as much as God himselfe can doo” — and then promises that they “call up by name, and have at their commandement seventie and nine principall and princelie diuels, who have under them, as their ministers, a great multitude of legions of pettie diuels.” The chapter that follows is headed like a stock-take:

An inventarie of the names, shapes, powers, gouvernement, and effects of divels and spirits, of their severall segniories and degrees: a strange discourse woorth the reading.

Their first and principall king (which is of the power of the east) is called Baëll; who when he is conjured up, appeareth with three heads; the first, like a tode; the second, like a man; the third, like a cat. He speaketh with a hoarse voice, he maketh a man go invisible, he hath under his obedience and rule sixtie and six legions of divels.

Sixty-seven entries follow Baëll, each in the same form. Agares “commeth up mildlie in the likenes of a faire old man, riding upon a crocodile, and carrieng a hawke on his fist,” teaches languages “presentlie,” fetches back runaways, and causes earthquakes. Read as a set, the offices are a mirror held up to the customers: the spirits teach languages, logic, astronomy and “all handicrafts,” find treasure and things hidden, procure “the especiall love of women,” reconcile friends and enemies, confer dignities and overthrow them, and make a man invisible. Nothing in the list wants for the soul; everything in it wants tuition, money, love and standing. Here and there the bureaucratic surface cracks and something older shows through: Phoenix, a great marquess who sings “manie sweet notes” in a child’s voice before the conjuror, “hopeth to returne to the seventh throne after a thousand two hundreth yeares” — a demoted angel counting the years of his sentence.

The arithmetic is kept with the same solemnity. Baëll rules sixty-six legions, Agares thirty-one, Phoenix twenty; and the chapter closes with the driest sentence in the whole literature:

¶ *Note that a legion is 6666. and now by multiplication count how manie legions doo arise out of everie particular.*

The numbers in this chapter do not add up, and the failure is instructive at every step. Scot’s preface promises “seventie and nine” principal devils. The Latin list he was translating — Weyer’s — contains sixty-nine. And the inventarie Scot actually prints contains sixty-eight: reading the catalogue leaf

by leaf and counting the entries shows that *Prufilas*, Weyer's fourth spirit, is silently missing from the English, and no edition of Scot notices the loss. Seventy-nine promised, sixty-nine in the source, sixty-eight delivered — three numbers on adjacent pages, no two of them equal. The page teaches the lesson this book keeps meeting: the numbers in this literature are part of the rhetoric, and they should be counted rather than repeated.

The inventarie entire

Because the catalogue is the genre, it is given here whole: every spirit Scot prints, in his order and his spellings, with rank and legions as the inventarie states them. Each entry in the original runs a paragraph — shape, offices, conditions — and a selection is quoted at length below the table; the compressed columns here are an index to the sixty-eight, not a substitute for them. A dash means the entry states no number; Bifrons and Decarabia are given no rank; Haagenti's thirty-three is stated as "as manie legions as Zagan"; and Paimon's two hundred are "partlie of the order of angels, and partlie of potestates," with twenty-five more in the host of the two kings who attend him. Every figure was read on the page it stands on.

#	NAME (AND ALIASES)	RANK	LEGIONS
1	Baëll	king (of the east)	66
2	Agares	duke, first under the power of the east	31
3	Marbas (<i>Barbas</i>)	president	36
4	Amon (<i>Aamon</i>)	marquesse	40
5	Barbatos	countie or earle, and duke	30
6	Buer	president	50
7	Gusoin	duke	40
8	Botis (<i>Otis</i>)	president and earle	60
9	Bathin (<i>Mathim</i>)	duke	30
10	Purson (<i>Curson</i>)	king	22
11	Eligor (<i>Abigor</i>)	duke	60
12	Leraie (<i>Oray</i>)	marquesse	30
13	Valefar (<i>Malephar</i>)	duke	10
14	Morax (<i>Foraii</i>)	earle and president	36
15	Ipos (<i>Ayporos</i>)	earle and prince	36
16	Naberius (<i>Cerberus</i>)	marquesse	19
17	Glasya Labolas (<i>Caacrinolaas, Caassimolar</i>)	president	36

#	NAME (AND ALIASES)	RANK	LEGIONS
18	Zepar	duke	26
19	Bileth	king	85
20	Sitri (<i>Bitru</i>)	prince	60
21	Paimon	king	200
22	Beliall	king	80
23	Bune	duke	30
24	Forneus	marquesse	29
25	Ronove	marquesse and earle	19
26	Berith (<i>Beall, Bolfry</i>)	duke	26
27	Astaroth	duke	40
28	Foras (<i>Forcas</i>)	president	29
29	Furfur	earle	26
30	Marchosias	marquesse	30
31	Malphas	president	40
32	Vepar (<i>Separ</i>)	duke	29
33	Sabnacke (<i>Salmac</i>)	marquesse	50
34	Sidonay (<i>Asmoday</i>)	king	72

#	NAME (AND ALIASES)	RANK	LEGIONS
35	Gaap (<i>Tap</i>)	president and prince	66
36	Shax (<i>Scox</i>)	marquesse	30
37	Procell	duke	48
38	Furcas	knight	20
39	Murmur	duke and earle	30
40	Caim	president	30
41	Raum (<i>Raim</i>)	earle	30
42	Halphas	earle	26
43	Focalor	duke	3
44	Vine	king and earle	—
45	Bifrons	(no rank given)	26
46	Gamigin	marquesse	30
47	Zagan	king and president	33
48	Orias	marquesse	30
49	Valac	president	30
50	Gomory	duke	26
51	Decarabia (<i>Carabia</i>)	(no rank given)	30

#	NAME (AND ALIASES)	RANK	LEGIONS
52	Amduscias	duke	29
53	Andras	marquesse	30
54	Andrealphus	marquesse	30
55	Ose	president	—
56	Aym (<i>Haborim</i>)	duke	26
57	Orobas	prince	20
58	Vapula	duke	36
59	Cimeries	marquesse	20
60	Amy	president	36
61	Flauros	duke	20
62	Balam	king	40
63	Allocer	duke	36
64	Saleos	earle	—
65	Vuall	duke	37
66	Haagenti	president	33
67	Phoenix	marquesse	20
68	Stolas	prince	26

Nine entries at length

The compressed table loses what makes the inventarie worth reading — the operative conditions embedded in the entries, and the personalities. These are the entries a working conjuror needed most, quoted as Scot prints them.

Bileth, whose entry is a protocol in miniature: “When he is called up by an exorcist, he appeareth rough and furious, to deceive him. Then let the exorcist or conjuror take heed to himself, and to allay his courage, let him hold a hazell bat in his hand, wherewithall he must reach out toward the east and south, and make a triangle without besides the circle; but if he hold not out his hand unto him, and he bid him come in, and he still refuse the bond or chaine of spirits; let the conjuror proceed to reading, and by and by he will submit himselfe, and come in, and doo whatsoever the exorcist commandeth him, and he shalbe safe. ... Also, if he be cited by an exorcist, alwaies a silver ring of the middle finger of the left hand must be held against the exorcists face, as they doo for Amaimon.”

Paimon: “Note, that at the calling up of him, the exorcist must looke towards the northwest, bicause there is his house. When he is called up, let the exorcist receive him constantlie without feare, let him aske what questions or demands he list, and no doubt he shall obtaine the same of him. ... There follow him two hundred legions, partlie of the order of angels, and partlie of potestates. Note that if Paimon be cited alone by an offering or sacrifice, two kings followe him; to wit, Beball & Abalam, & other potentates: in his host are twentie five legions.”

Beliall, in whose entry the brazen vessel appears: “If he will not submit himselfe, let the bond of spirits be read: the spirits chaine is sent for him, wherewith wise Salomon gathered them together with their legions in a brasen vessell, where were inclosed among all the legions seventie two kings, of whome the cheefe was Bileth, the second was Beliall, the third Asmoday, and above a thousand thousand legions. Without doubt (I must confesse) I learned this of my maister Salomon; but he told me not why he gathered them together, and shut them up so: but I beleieve it was for the pride of this Beliall.”

Astaroth: “He talketh willinglie of the creator of spirits, and of their fall, and how they sinned and fell: he saith he fell not of his owne accord. ... Let everie exorcist take heed, that he admit him not too neere him,

bicause of his stinking breath. And therefore let the conjuror hold neere to his face a magicall ring, and that shall defend him."

Sidonay, alias Asmoday: *"When the conjuror exerciseth this office, let him be abroad, let him be warie and standing on his feete; if his cap be on his head, he will cause all his dooings to be bewraied, which if he doo not, the exorcist shalbe deceived by Amaymon in everie thing. But so soone as he seeth him in the forme aforesaid, he shall call him by his name, saieng; Thou art Asmoday: he will not denie it, and by and by he boweth downe to the ground; he giveth the ring of vertues ... he hath under his power seventie two legions."*

Gaap, *in whose entry the tradition dates itself: "There were certeine necromancers that offered sacrifices and burnt offerings unto him; and to call him up, they exercised an art, saieng that Salomon the wise made it. Which is false: for it was rather Cham, the sonne of Noah, who after the floud began first to invoke wicked spirits. ... It is to be noted, that if anie exorcist have the art of Bileth, and cannot make him stand before him, nor see him, I may not bewraie how and declare the meanes to containe him, bicause it is abomination, and for that I have learned nothing from Salomon of his dignitie and office."*

Focalor, *the smallest command in the list: "he killeth men, and drowneth them in the waters, and overturneth ships of warre, commanding and ruling both winds and seas. And let the conjuror note, that if he bid him hurt no man, he willinglie consenteth thereto: he hopeth after 1000. yeares to returne to the seventh throne, but he is deceived, he hath three legions."*

Andras, *the reason the books keep warning: "he is seene in an angels shape with a head like a blacke night raven, riding upon a blacke and a verie strong wolfe, flourishing with a sharpe sword in his hand, he can kill the maister, the servant, and all assistants, he is author of discords, and ruleth thirtie legions."*

Ose, the strangest office in the catalogue: “he maketh one cunning in the liberall sciences, he answereth truelie of divine and secret things, he transformeth a mans shape, and bringeth a man to that madnes, that he thinketh himselfe to be that which he is not; as that he is a king or a pope, or that he weareth a crowne on his head, Durátque id regnum ad horam” — and the delusion of kingship lasts an hour.

The rest of the catalogue keeps the same texture, and the one-line wonders deserve their line. Orobas “deceiveth none, nor suffereth anie to be tempted” — the one honest spirit in the list. Amduscias, a duke in the shape of a unicorn, gives concerts: “trumpets and all musicall instruments may be heard and not seene,” and trees bend to the conjuror’s will. Decarabia “commeth like a ✱” — the reprint sets a printer’s star where the Latin says he appears as a star in a pentacle — and makes birds fly before the exorcist, tame, drinking and singing. Gomory, the one spirit who appears “like a faire woman, with a duchesse crownet about hir middle, riding on a camell.” Shax steals money out of kings’ houses and “carrieth it backe after 1200. yeares, if he be commanded.” Marchosias “hopeth after 1200. yeares to returne to the seventh throne, but he is deceived in that hope” — the inventarie keeps actuarial tables on redemption, and they all read: denied.

The protocol of audiences

Collect the conditions scattered through the entries and a complete court etiquette emerges. Direction: face the northwest for Paimon, “bicause there is his house.” Posture: for Asmoday, be standing, in the open, and bare-headed — the cap on the head betrays the whole working. Address: call the spirit by name to its face, “Thou art Asmoday,” and it cannot deny itself. Courtesy: Bileth is received “courteouslie,” and glorified “in his pride,” “bicause he saith nothing without other princes.” Defence: the silver ring on the middle finger of the left hand, held against the exorcist’s face for Bileth and Amaymon, and the “magicall ring” held to the face against Astaroth’s breath. Verification: several spirits — Shax, Furfur, Flauros — lie at large and speak truth only inside a triangle. Escalation: the hazel bat and the triangle beyond

the circle for a furious Bileth, and the “bond or chaine of spirits” read aloud until submission. And schedule — for the hours are the frame the whole court runs on, the same logic that runs through the planetary hours of Chapter 20: power is real but scheduled, and the operator’s skill is knowing the timetable.

RANK	MAY BE BOUND
KINGS	third houre till noone; ninth houre till evening
DUKES	first houre till noone — and cleare wether is to be observed
MARQUESESSES	ninth houre till compline; compline till the end of the daie
COUNTIES OR EARLES	anie houre, so it be in woods or feelds where men resort not
PRELATES	anie houre of the daie
PRESIDENTS	in no houre, except the king whome he obeith be invocated
KNIGHTS	daie dawning till sunne rising; evensong till sunne set

FIG. 2 — THE PROTOCOL OF AUDIENCES. Compiled from the wording of Scot’s third chapter, which opens by naming the four kings — Maymon of the east, Gorson of the south, Zimimar of the north, Goap of the west. Rank determines access, exactly as at a court; the one figure who can never be approached directly is the President, who answers only if his king is called first.

At the end of this material Scot’s margin discloses, with the exactness of a man entering evidence, where it all came from: “This was the work of one T. R. written in faire letters of red & blacke upon parchment, and made by him, Ann. 1570. to the maintenance of his living, the edifieng of the poore, and the glorie of gods holie name: as he himselfe saith.” A jobbing conjuror’s working manuscript, copied out in red and black in 1570 to pay its author’s rent, quoted verbatim by the man who wanted the whole trade abolished — there is no better emblem of how this literature survives. The believers wrote it; the unbelievers published it; the readers decided for themselves.

The forme of adjuring

The fourth and fourteenth chapters of Scot’s fifteenth book print the working itself, from the same manuscript stratum as the hours — and the reprint’s margins collate it with Weyer’s Latin, noting where the parchment and the

Pseudomonarchia differ (“fast not in *Wier*”). It is given here as the sources give it. Read the conditions as a list before the words, because they are the operative doctrine in miniature: the operator must know the name and the office — the inventarie is the prerequisite, not an appendix — must fast and be clean, must never work alone, must offer no sacrifice, and must dismiss what he has called. On the leaf facing the licence, the reprint carries the woodcut of the conjuring knife, its blade graven *AGLA* — the same consecrated-instrument logic as the sword of Chapter 8.

THE FORME OF ADJURING OR CITING OF THE SPIRITS AFORESAID TO ARISE AND APPEARE

The conditions. “When you will have anie spirit, you must know his name and office; you must also fast, and be cleane from all pollution, three or foure daies before; so will the spirit be the more obedient unto you. Then make a circle, and call up the spirit with great intention, and holding a ring in your hand, rehearse in your owne name, and your companions (for one must alwaies be with you) this praier following, and so no spirit shall annoie you, and your purpose shall take effect.”

The praier. “In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ the ✠ father ✠ and the sonne ✠ and the Holie-ghost ✠ holie trinitie and unseparable unitie, I call upon thee, that thou maiest be my salvation and defense, and the protection of my bodie and soule, and of all my goods through the vertue of thy holie crosse, and through the vertue of thy passion, I beseech thee O Lord Jesus Christ, by the merits of thy blessed mother S. Marie, and of all thy saints, that thou give me grace and divine power over all the wicked spirits, so as which of them soever I doo call by name, they may come by and by from everie coast, and accomplish my will, that they neither be hurtfull nor fearefull unto me, but rather obedient and diligent about me. And through thy vertue streightlie commanding them, let them fulfill my commandements, Amen.” The prayer continues for two further pages in the same register — *Holie, holie, holie, Lord God of sabboth*, litanies of divine names, the life of Christ recited event by event, the petition for power to draw the spirits, to tie and bind them, and to loose them — and closes *Fiat ✠ fiat ✠ fiat, Amen*.

The binding. When the spirit is appeared, it is held with a second form. The manuscript gives it for the spirit Bealphares: “I charge thee *Bealphares*, that thou shalt not depart out of my sight, nor yet to alter thy bodilie shape, that thou art appeared in, nor anie power shalt thou have of our bodies or soules, earthlie or ghostlie, but to be obedient to

me, and to the words of my conjuration, that be written in this booke.” And then the terms of the audience: “When he is thus bound, aske him what thing thou wilt, and he will tell thee, and give thee all things that thou wilt request of him, without anie sacrifice dooing to him, and without forsaking thy God, that is, thy maker.”

A licence for the spirit to depart. “Go unto the place predestinated and appointed for thee, where thy Lord GOD hath appointed thee, untill I shall call thee againe. Be thou readie unto me and to my call, as often as I shall call thee, upon paine of everlasting damnation.” If he will not depart, the last conjuration is repeated, and the dismissal made absolute: “that thou depart from this place, without hurt or damage of anie bodie, or of anie deed to be doone; that all creatures may knowe, that our Lord is of all power, most mightiest.” Against outright refusal the manuscript keeps one last escalation, the malediction: “And the malediction of God the father omnipotent, the sonne and the holie ghost, descend upon thee, and dwell alwaies with thee, except thou doo depart without damage of us, or of any creature, or anie other evill deed to be doone: & thou to go to the place predestinated. And by our Lord Jesus Christ I doo else send thee to the great pit of hell.” Yet the forme ends in peace, not in power: “The peace of Jesus Christ bee betweene us and you; in the name of the father, and of the sonne, and of the Holie-ghost: Amen” — and then the opening of John’s Gospel, recited to the words *full of grace and truth*.

Notice what the sequence refuses as firmly as what it performs. No sacrifice — stated in the plainest terms the manuscript has. No working alone. No dismissal omitted: the licence is not a courtesy but a load-bearing part of the operation, and every later text in this lineage keeps it. The operator who binds and does not loose has, on the tradition’s own account, left the operation unfinished — which is the same doctrine the closing banishing of Chapter 15 carries in the modern curriculum.

The same working, four centuries on: the Goetia's apparatus

Everything Scot printed in fragments, the *Ars Goetia* — compiled in the mid-seventeenth century and printed in 1904 — systematises. The catalogue grows to seventy-two, the brazen vessel's own number: the spellings shift (Leraie to Leraje, Sidonay's alias Asmoday becomes the name), and spirits absent from Weyer and Scot appear — Vassago, Seere, Dantalion, Andromalius among them. Each spirit now has a seal, and the seal is the working instrument: after Samigina's entry the text says, "And his Seal is this, which is to be worn before the Magician when he is Invocator." The seals are graded by rank into metals — kings in gold, marquises in silver, dukes in copper, princes in tin, presidents in mercury, earls in copper and silver "alike equal," and one solitary knight, Furcas, in lead. The binding hours of Scot's third chapter return converted to clock time: "the Chief Kings may be bound from 9 till 12 o'clock at Noon, and from 3 till Sunset; Marquises may be bound from 3 in the afternoon till 9 at Night, and from 9 at Night till Sunrise ... and Counties or Earls any hour of the Day, so it be in Woods, or in any other places whither men resort not, or where no noise is."

The apparatus is a complete kit, and its continuities with everything above are exact. The Magic Ring or Disc, "to be made in gold or silver ... held before the face of the exorcist to preserve him from the stinking sulphurous fumes and flaming breath of the Evil Spirits" — Scot's silver ring against Bileth and the ring held to the face against Astaroth's breath, made standard equipment. The Hexagram of Solomon, drawn "on parchment of a calf's skin, and worn at the skirt of thy white vestment," shown to the spirits to compel human shape. The Triangle of Art, set outside the circle exactly as Bileth's entry demanded, now with directions: "this triangle is to be placed toward that quarter whereunto the Spirit belongeth. And the base of the triangle is to be nearest unto the Circle, the apex pointing in the direction of the quarter of the Spirit." The other requisites: "a sceptre, a sword, a mitre, a cap, a long white robe of linen ... also a girdle of lion's skin three inches broad, with all the names written about it which be round the outmost part of the Magical Circle," perfumes, a chafing-dish of charcoal, anointing oil, and "fair water to wash

thyself in” — with an Adoration at the Bath (“Thou shalt purge me with hyssop, O Lord!”) and another at the Induing of the Vestments, which is the bath-and-garments sequence of Chapter 8 in its goetic dress.

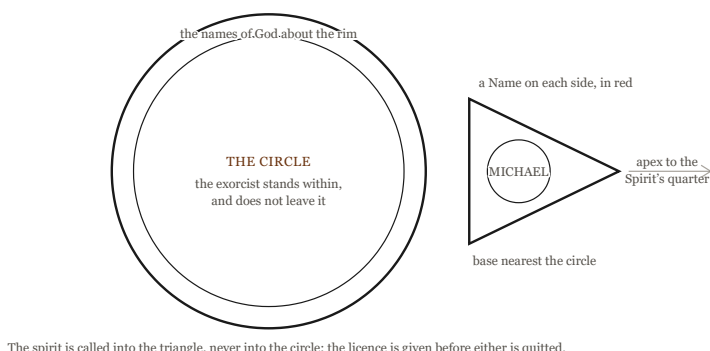


FIG. 3 — THE GROUND PLAN OF THE WORKING. Drawn from the directions in the 1904 *Goetia* as reprinted in 1916: the Triangle of Art stands outside the circle, base nearest it, apex toward the quarter the spirit belongs to, with Michael’s name in the centre and a Name on each side written in red. The plate itself is missing from the scan this book used, so nothing is drawn here that the text does not state; the curse names Tetragrammaton, Anaphaxeton and Primeumaton as its three names, and whether those are the triangle’s three the plate alone could show. The circle-and-triangle logic is Bileth’s entry from 1584, made standard.

The spoken sequence is likewise the 1570 forme grown formal, and its stations deserve quoting. The First Conjunction opens — in the spelling of the edition’s own archaic appendix — “I invoke and move thee, O thou, Spirit N.: and being exalted above ye in the power of the Most High, I say unto thee, Obey! in the name Beralensis, Baldachiensis, Paumachia, and Apologiae Sedes: and of the mighty ones who govern, spirits, Liachidae and ministers of the House of Death: and by the Chief Prince of the seat of Apologia in the Ninth Legion, I do invoke thee and by invoking conjure thee.” If the spirit refuses, the conjurations escalate to the Curse: the spirit’s name and seal, written and bound into a box, are “choken in sulphurous stinking substances, and burned in this material fire,” while the exorcist declares, “in the name

Iehovah and by the power and dignity of these three names, Tetragrammaton, Anaphaxeton, and Primeumaton, I do cast thee, O thou wicked and disobedient Spirit N., into the Lake of Fire” — and the box goes into the flame until the spirit comes, whereupon the fire is quenched and “a sweet perfume” made. Obedience arrived, the register changes completely: “Welcome Spirit N., O most noble king! I say thou art welcome unto me, because I have called thee through Him who has created Heaven, and Earth, and Hell, and all that is in them contained, and because also thou hast obeyed.” The demand is put with the lamen shown — “By the Pentacle of Solomon have I called thee! Give unto me a true answer” — and the working closes with the License to Depart:

O thou Spirit N., because thou hast diligently answered unto my demands, and hast been very ready and willing to come at my call, I do here license thee to depart unto thy proper place; without causing harm or danger unto man or beast. Depart, then, I say, and be thou very ready to come at my call, being duly exorcised and conjured by the sacred rites of magic. I charge thee to withdraw peaceably and quietly, and the peace of God be ever continued between thee and me! Amen!

“After thou hast given the Spirit license to depart, thou art not to go out of the circle until he or they be gone, and until thou shalt have made prayers and rendered thanks unto God.” The same doctrine as the 1570 parchment, the same doctrine as the closing banishing of Chapter 15: the dismissal is part of the operation, and the operator who skips it has not finished working — he has stopped in the middle.

The quarrel over the whole subject

The catalogue travelled inside an argument, and the argument was about killing people. Weyer’s *De praestigiis daemonum* held that the women being burned as witches were melancholic, deceived or ill — a physician’s verdict entered against a legal machine. Scot went further than Weyer — further than almost anyone in his century — and denied the crime outright: the confessions were extracted, the wonders were tricks and delusions, and the conjurors’

books were the vanity of “couseners.” The reply came from a head of state. James VI of Scotland — not yet James I of England — published his *Daemonologie* at Edinburgh in 1597, and its preface declares its targets by name:

...against the damnable opinions of two principally in our age, wherof the one called SCOT an Englishman, is not ashamed in publike print to deny, that ther can be such a thing as Witch-craft: and so mainteines the old error of the Sadducees, in denying of spirits. The other called WIERUS, a German Phisition, sets out a publick apologie for al these craftes-folkes, whereby, procuring for their impunitie, he plainly bewrayes himselfe to haue bene one of that profession.

The king’s logic deserves attention: Scot is wrong because denying witches denies spirits; Weyer, by defending the accused, proves he must be one of them. In 1603 James took the English throne, and a new and harsher Witchcraft Act followed in 1604. Behind all three books stands the manual this chapter describes and does not quote: the *Malleus Maleficarum*, first printed about 1486, the inquisitors’ handbook whose questions the confessions answered — Chapter 27 shows what happened when a twentieth-century reader mistook those confessions for ethnography. Weyer and Scot lost their argument for a century, and then won it completely; it is their books, not the king’s, that read as the modern position. A reader who wants the catalogue’s later career — the *Goetia*’s seventy-two spirits, seals and operative apparatus, compiled in the mid-seventeenth century and printed in 1904 — will find every stage of it dated in Chapter 10 and the bibliography.

⚠ What this chapter is and is not

The operation above is printed as its sources print it: a working text of 1570, carried into type by the century's great sceptic, with his confutation standing two pages after it on the same leaves — and this book prints both, because the reader is owed the pair. Its conditions are the sources' own and are not decoration: never alone, fasting before, no sacrifice ever, and the licence to depart always given. The *Goetia*'s later and more elaborate apparatus — seals, brass vessel, seventy-two spirits — is dated in Chapter 10 and left in its own editions, which are cited there. The tradition treats the approach to these powers as governed, conditional and dangerous from the *Testament*'s ring onward, and its protective frame — the banishing that opens and closes every working — is given in full in Chapter 15.

MODERN PRACTICE

What survives of demonology, for a modern reader, is mostly the debate. Weyer's move — to look for illness before crime, and to insist that a confession extracted is not a fact established — is one of the tradition's genuine gifts to the modern world, and it was made by a man who fully believed in the devil. The catalogue survives differently: as a mirror. Its offices — languages, knowledge, love, standing, hidden money — are a complete inventory of what its buyers lacked, and reading it that way tells more truth about the sixteenth century than any list of legions. The modern occult revival re-adopted the *Goetia* as a working text; this book's treatment of that adoption is in Chapter 10 and Chapter 27.

Sources: F. C. Conybeare, “The Testament of Solomon,” *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 11 (October 1898), 1–45 public domain — the ring passage from p. 16, read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *Cony1899JQRTestamentOfSolomon*; the square brackets in the quotation are Conybeare’s own supplied words, the pentalpha gloss is his footnote, and the first-century dating is his, reported from his introduction. Reginald Scot, *The discoverie of witchcraft* (London, 1584), quoted from the 1886 reprint of the first edition public domain — read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *discoverieofwitc00scot*: the “seventie and nine” passage and the *Wierus* margin note at p. 313 of the reprint, the inventarie heading and the Baëll entry at p. 314, the whole of the inventarie at pp. 314–326 — every leaf read, every rank and legion-count in the table above taken from its own page, and the entries quoted at length from pp. 316–326 — the hours of binding with the T. R. note at p. 327, the forme of adjuring and its prayer at pp. 327–329, and the binding of Bealphares with the licence to depart and the malediction at pp. 350–351, where the woodcut of the conjuring knife also stands; hyphens at line-ends are closed up, the benediction crosses of the page are set as ✠, and nothing else is altered. The ellipses in the quoted entries are declared by their marks and omit only matter within the same entry. The prayer’s two further pages and the *In throno* clause are described rather than quoted in full, and the descriptions were read on the same leaves. The *Goetia* is quoted from the printing of 1916 (Chicago: de Laurence), a page-for-page reprint of the 1904 Boleskine edition cited in the bibliography, read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *lesserkeysolomo00laurgoog*: the seal-as-lamen rule at p. 23, the clock hours and the classified list of the seventy-two with their metals at p. 47, the Triangle of Art directions at p. 50, the magical requisites and the adorations at p. 55, the Curse at p. 64, the Welcome and the Pentacle address at p. 65, the License to Depart at p. 66, and the First Conjunction in the archaic spelling of the edition’s appendix at p. 72. The seal drawings themselves are missing from that scan, and none is reproduced or invented here: the lamen rule is quoted instead, and Fig. 3 draws only what the directions state. The roster comparison with Weyer’s list was made name by name against the same scan. King James VI, *Daemonologie, in forme of a dialogue* (Edinburgh, 1597) public domain — the preface passage read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan of the 1597 printing (identifier beginning *bim_early-english-books*); the page’s double-V is set as W, its long s as s, and its spellings otherwise stand as printed. Johann Weyer, *Pseudomonarchia daemonum* (1577), is dated and described in the bibliography; his Latin was not read on page images for this chapter and is quoted here only through Scot’s English. The *Malleus Maleficarum* (c. 1486) is named and not quoted: the standard English translation of 1928 is in copyright, and no public-domain

rendering was consulted. The *Lemegeton* and its *Ars Goetia* are dated in Chapter 10 on Joseph H. Peterson's authority, and the 1904 Mathers–Crowley edition is cited there. Figs. 1 and 2 are this book's own arrangements of the sources named in their captions.

Rosicrucian Mysteries

The Rosicrucian tradition is the most influential body of Western esoteric thought whose founding organisation probably never existed. That sentence needs stating plainly at the outset, because almost everything written about the Rosicrucians for four hundred years has depended on which half of it the writer chose to emphasise. The manifestos are real, dated and enormously consequential. The Brotherhood they describe cannot be shown to have existed at all.

The three manifestos

Three anonymous texts appeared in Germany and then across Europe in quick succession:

- *Fama Fraternitatis Rosae Crucis* (The Fame of the Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross) — circulating in manuscript among German occultists from around 1610, and published at Cassel in **1614**. It announces the existence of a secret brotherhood and narrates the travels, education and death of a figure called “Father Brother C.R.C.”
- *Confessio Fraternitatis* (The Confession of the Brotherhood of R.C.) — printed at Cassel by Wilhelm Wessel in **1615**, in Latin, appended to Philippus a Gabella’s *Secretioris Philosophiae Consideratio brevis*, responding to the confusion and criticism the *Fama* had provoked and elaborating the programme further.
- *The Chymical Wedding of Christian Rosenkreutz* — published in **1616**: an allegorical romance in seven days, structurally quite unlike the two documents preceding it.

What they promised was a universal reformation of humanity, by means of a science built on esoteric truths of the ancient past — knowledge concealed from ordinary understanding that offered insight into nature, the physical universe and the spiritual realm, and which had supposedly been kept secret until the intellectual climate was ready for it. The programme was set out extensively but cryptically, in the languages of Qabalah, Hermeticism, alchemy and Christian mysticism — precisely the subjects the learned readership of the period was studying most avidly. The stated aims were the ones the earlier version of this chapter listed, and they are worth keeping: universal reformation, the advance of spiritual and scientific knowledge, the healing of the sick, and the teaching of divine wisdom.

The legend of C.R.C.

As the manifestos tell it, Christian Rosenkreuz was born in 1378 and lived 106 years. He studied in the Middle East under a succession of masters — a detail that has invited speculation about Sufi influence, which shaped a number of Western esoteric currents. During his lifetime the order was said to comprise no more than eight members, each of them a physician and all “bachelors of vowed virginity.” Each swore to heal the sick without accepting payment, to keep the fellowship secret, and to find a replacement for himself before he died. Three such generations were said to have passed between about 1500 and about 1600 — by which time, the *Fama* claims, scientific, philosophical and religious liberty had grown enough that the public might finally benefit, and the brotherhood was now seeking good men.

Read as literature this is superb: a lineage, a rediscovered tomb, a sealed vault of knowledge, and an open invitation the reader has no way to accept. Read as history it has no corroboration of any kind.

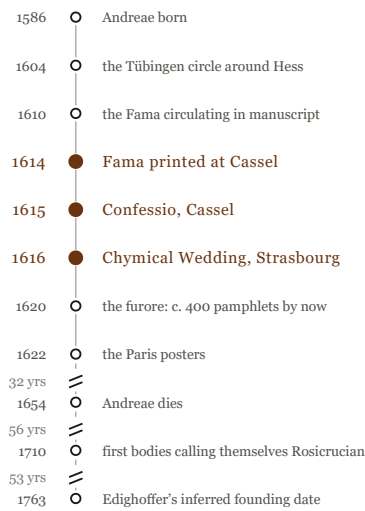


FIG. 1 — THE ROSICRUCIAN CHRONOLOGY. The three manifestos in filled circles; everything else in outline. The shape of the thing is visible at a glance: two years of publication, six years of uproar, and then nearly a century before any organisation calling itself Rosicrucian can be documented. The brotherhood the manifestos describe is placed by them in the fifteenth century, before this chart begins, and cannot be shown to have existed at all. Drawn for this book.

The vault, in the manifesto's own words

The tomb of Christian Rosenkreuz is the image the whole Rosicrucian episode turns on, and it is worth having exactly as the *Fama* tells it rather than as later writers summarise it. The discovery is an accident of building work. A brother, altering the house, lights on the memorial table of brass that carries the names of the Brethren, and means to move it to a better vault:

In this table stuck a great naile somewhat strong, so that when it was with force drawn out it took with it an indifferent big stone out of the thin wall or plaistering of the hidden door, and so unlooked for uncovered the door; whereat we did with joy and longing throw down the rest of the wall and cleared the door, upon which was written in great letters — Post CXX Annos Patebo, with the year of the Lord under it.

After a hundred and twenty years I shall open. They wait until morning — the text says they let it rest that night because they would first consult their Rota — and then:

In the morning following we opened the door, and there appeared to our sight a vault of seven sides and seven corners, every side five foot broad, and the height of eight foot. Although the sun never shined in this vault, nevertheless, it was enlightened with another sun, which had learned this from the sun, and was situated in the upper part in the center of the sieling. In the midst, instead of a tomb-stone, was a round altar, covered with a plate of brass, and thereon this engraven: — A. C. R. C. Hoc universi compendium unius mihi sepulchrum feci. Round about the first circle or brim stood, Jesus mihi omnia. In the middle were four figures, inclosed in circles, whose circumscription was, 1. Nequaquam Vacuum. 2. Legis Jugum. 3. Libertas Evangelii. 4. Dei Gloria Intacta.

This vault we parted in three parts, the upper part or sieling, the wall or side, the ground or floor. ... Every side or wall is parted into ten squares, every one with their several figures and sentences. ... The bottom again is parted in the triangle, but because therein is described the power and rule of the Inferior Governors, we leave to manifest the same, for fear of the abuse by the evil and ungodly world.

The Latin is worth translating rather than admiring: *A. C. R. C. — this compendium of the universe I made in my lifetime to be my tomb; Jesus is all things to me; and the four circumscriptions, By no means a vacuum, The yoke of the law, The liberty of the gospel, The untouched glory of God.* Every detail is a doctrine in miniature. The vault is **seven-sided**, on the planetary number

this book meets in every chapter. It is lit by an artificial sun “which had learned this from the sun” — a made thing that has taken instruction from a natural one, which is the whole Hermetic programme in a lamp. Its walls are divided into **ten squares** apiece, the sephirotic number of Chapter 4. And it withholds: the floor is left undescribed on the stated ground that the ungodly would abuse it — the withholding of Chapter 19, performed rather than discussed.

Whether any such vault existed is a question the rest of this chapter answers. What is certain is that the description worked: the seven-sided chamber was built, physically, more than two centuries later, by the Golden Dawn, as the Vault of the Adepti in which its Adeptus Minor grade was conferred. A room described in a pamphlet of 1614 by an author who called the whole thing a *ludibrium* became a room people stood in.

The furore

The reception is the part of this story that actually happened, and it was extraordinary. Europe in 1614 was sliding toward the Thirty Years’ War; the promise of a spiritual and intellectual transformation landed in a continent primed for it. Between 1614 and 1620 roughly **four hundred** books, pamphlets and manuscripts were published discussing the Rosicrucian documents, favourably and otherwise. Serious philosophers took up the worldview — Michael Maier, Robert Fludd, Thomas Vaughan, later Elias Ashmole. The manifestos drew on Heinrich Khunrath’s *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (first printed Hamburg, 1595), itself indebted to John Dee’s *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564); the invitation that opens the *Chymical Wedding* is marked with Dee’s Monas symbol.

The peak came in **1622**, when two mysterious posters appeared on walls in Paris within days of each other. The first began: “We, the Deputies of the Higher College of the Rose-Croix, do make our stay, visibly and invisibly, in this city.” The second closed: “The thoughts attached to the real desire of the seeker will lead us to him and him to us.” Nobody has ever established who put them up.

One consequence outlived all the others. The idea of an invisible college of natural philosophers, corresponding across borders and pooling discoveries, was taken up by the network around Kepler, Dee, Reticus and Tycho Brahe, and passed into the group that met weekly in London from about 1645 to conduct experiments. Robert Boyle wrote of “the cornerstones of the Invisible (or as they term themselves the Philosophical) College.” That body became the Royal Society in **1660**. The Rosicrucian manifestos are, by a genuinely traceable route, among the ancestors of the modern scientific academy.

Who wrote them

The attribution is not what the manifestos claim, though it is less settled than it is often made to sound. Roland Edighoffer, writing in the Brill *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (2005), traces the manifestos to the “Learned and Christian Society” that Johann Valentin Andreae established at Tübingen in 1610 — a small circle of close friends, notably Christoph Besold and Tobias Hess, who together conceived of and constructed the Rosicrucian myth. Recent scholarship refines this rather than overturning it: Andreae is widely accepted as the principal author, probably working with Tobias Hess, while Besold’s participation has been specifically doubted, and a minority of scholars exclude Andreae altogether. What is not seriously contested is that the manifestos came out of this Tübingen milieu rather than from an existing brotherhood.

Andreae (1586–1654) went further than being suspected. In his autobiography — the *Vita ab ipso conscripta*, unpublished in his lifetime and printed only much later — he acknowledged the *Nuptiae Chymicae* as his own work, listing it among juvenilia he assigns to 1602–1603. He gives no age; born 17 August 1586, he was then about sixteen or seventeen. And he was dismissive about it. Of that group of youthful writings he says the others perished, but this one survived:

... *Superfuerunt e contra Nuptiae Chymicae, cum monstrorum foecundo foetu, **ludibrium**, quod mireris a nonnullis aestimatum et subtili indagine explicatum, plane futile et quod inanitatem curiosorum prodat.*

Rendered as literally as the difficult clauses allow: *the Chymical Wedding survived by contrast, with its foetus fruitful of monsters — a **ludibrium**, which you may wonder was esteemed by some and expounded with subtle investigation, plainly futile, and disclosing the emptiness of the curious.* Waite, reading the phrase about monsters, took it to refer not to the book's contents but to its *progeny* — the ridiculous commentaries it spawned. Elsewhere Andreae is blunter still: in the *Vita*'s second book he speaks of his Invitations to the Fraternity of Christ as set in opposition to “that Rosicrucian *ludibrium*,” and in the *Menippus* of 1617 the Fraternity is “only a *ludibrium* for the curious,” in which those who followed an artificial path instead of the simple way of Christ were deceived.

WHAT *LUDIBRIUM* MEANS — AND WHAT IT DOES NOT

Everything in this chapter's reading of Andreae turns on one Latin word, and it is worth being careful with it. Lewis & Short give *ludibrium* (from *ludus*, play) as mockery, derision, wantonness; a laughing-stock, butt, jest or sport; and abuse done to a woman. Neither "hoax" — a fraud passed off as true — nor "lampoon" — a satire against a named target — is what the Latin says, and no authority cited here translates it either way: Waite renders it "jest" or "fantasy," Yates "a play, a comic fiction." Those two popular glosses are also incompatible with each other. A classical lexicon cannot by itself bound a word written in the seventeenth century, so the strongest form of the point is about the record rather than the dictionary: the harder English is read *back* into Andreae. (Waite 1924, p. 188, does at one point list the possibilities as "jest, hoax or fantasy," and the one study devoted to the word — Willard, 2010 — argues a Menippean-satire reading.)

The scholarship divides. Paul Arnold (1935) translated it "une farce" and concluded Andreae had told us the whole affair was a joke; Charles Webster (1970) calls the *ludibrium* phrases "derisive terms." Frances Yates argued at length for a different reading: *ludibrium* "could be a play, a comic fiction," and given Andreae's high regard for theatre as a moral and educative instrument, she read the Rosicrucian material as "not a hoax, but a dramatic presentation of a profoundly interesting religious and intellectual movement."

The defensible statement is therefore narrower than "Andreae called it a hoax." Andreae's later references to the Rosicrucian material are genuinely dismissive and at times derisive — *plane futile* is his own phrase. But he called it a jest or a fiction, not a fraud, and the stronger English glosses have been read back into him.

Two further cautions belong here, and both cut against the simple story. First, the text published at Strasbourg in 1616 cannot be the unrevised juvenile draft: it contains references to the manifestos of 1614 and 1615, so whatever Andreae wrote as a teenager was substantially reworked, and Yates doubted the two were the same work at all. Second, A. E. Waite is routinely miscited on this. His 1887 sentence that Andreae “considered the Rosicrucian manifestoes a reprehensible hoax” (*The Real History of the Rosicrucians*, p. 240) is a report of Andreae’s *contempt*, deployed as an argument *against* his authorship — and in the same book Waite rejects both the “frolicsome imposture” reading of the manifestos (p. 225) and the *ludibrium* reading of the *Chymical Marriage* (p. 234). In *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (1924) he argued at greater length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped (pp. 122 n., 207), while continuing to insist on Andreae’s disdain (p. 206). He was never the authority for the hoax reading he is quoted as supplying.

Some scholars have suggested Andreae distanced himself from the movement to protect a clerical career from the religious and political authorities of the day, and that reading cannot be ruled out. That reading is at least as old as Waite, who proposed a secret-society oath as the reason (1887, pp. 240–41); it remains a conjecture, and the evidence for it is thin.

WHEN DID REAL ROSICRUCIANS APPEAR?

Edighoffer is blunt on the central question: “there is no proof that the Brotherhood of the Rose Cross described in the *Fama Fraternitatis* ever existed, and it is only in the 18th century that actual organizations calling themselves ‘rosicrucian’ first come into existence.” He dates the first creation of a Rosicrucian order in Germany to 1763 — though that date deserves a footnote of its own. Edighoffer infers it from a later controversy between “Phoebron” (Bernhard Joseph Schleiss von Loewenfeld) and Baron von Ecker und Eckhofen, whose pamphlet *Der Rosenkreuzer in seiner Blösse* Edighoffer dates 1782 and the British Library 1781. It is an inference from a polemic, not a documented act of foundation, and Edighoffer does not name the body in the sentence itself; the surrounding discussion indicates the Gold- und Rosenkreuzer, the Order of the Golden and Rosy Cross. He offers three other candidate moments in the same entry — 1710, 1761 and 1777, of which he says only 1777 “signal[s] the ‘official’ foundation.” Renko Geffarth’s archive-based study of the order is summarised by its reviewer as covering circles that existed “from around 1760 until sometime after 1790” (Michael Driedger, *H-German*, Feb. 2010) — a statement about their duration, not a rival founding date. Every Rosicrucian order that has ever operated — the Order of the Golden and Rosy Cross, formally constituted in the 1760s–1770s out of a Rosicrucian literary milieu traceable to about 1750, the Societas Rosicruciana in Anglia from the 1860s, the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (1888), the Rosicrucian Fellowship (1909), AMORC (incorporated 1915) — postdates the manifestos by at least 140 years. They are its descendants, not its survivors.

What survives the correction

Almost everything of value, as it happens. A literary invention that produced four hundred books in six years, drew in Fludd, Maier and Ashmole, seeded the Invisible College, and still animates active orders four centuries later is not

diminished by being an invention — it is one of the most productive fictions in European intellectual history. Andreae's contempt for what he had started is a fact about Andreae, not a verdict on what his readers built.

A point often made about the alchemical writing of the Rosicrucian circle should be handled with care. It is true, so far as the surviving texts go, that neither Maier nor Khunrath announces a successful transmutation, and Maier does present the Brothers of the Rose Cross as existing to advance the inspired arts and sciences. The inference usually drawn from this — that their alchemy was therefore symbolic rather than operative — is not one the specialists draw; it circulates as an unsourced sentence in the Wikipedia article on Rosicrucianism, and the tracing that undoes it is set out in Chapter 5. Nor were Maier and Khunrath associates: Tilton records that Maier met Khunrath in Danzig and came to regard him as a fraud.

Sources: The vault is quoted from the *Fama Fraternitatis* in the English printed by A. E. Waite, *The Real History of the Rosicrucians* (London: George Redway, 1887), pp. 76–77, read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *realhistoryofros00waituoft*. Waite’s spelling stands as printed — *naile, sieling, plaistering, brasse* — and the two ellipses in the second passage omit the sentences on the ceiling and on the chests, which are described in the paragraph following rather than quoted. The English of the Latin inscriptions is this book’s. The Golden Dawn’s physical Vault of the Adepti is named here and described in Chapter 13 on the authority cited there. *Fama Fraternitatis* (Cassel, 1614); *Confessio Fraternitatis* (Cassel, 1615); *Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (1616). Gorceix, *La Bible des Rose-Croix* (1970) — translations of all three. Andreae, *Vita ab ipso conscripta*, Lib. I, p. 10, ed. F. H. Rheinwald (Berlin, 1849) — first published in German translation by D. C. Seybold (Winterthur, 1799). Roland Edighoffer, “Rosicrucianism I: First half of the 17th Century,” in Wouter J. Hanegraaff (ed.), in collaboration with Faivre, van den Broek and Brach, *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2005), 1009–1014, at 1009 and 1014; and Edighoffer, “Rosicrucianism II: 18th Century,” *ibid.*, 1014–1017, at 1015, for the 1763 date. Waite, *The Real History of the Rosicrucians* (London: George Redway, 1887), p. 240 for “a reprehensible hoax” and p. 232 for “before he was sixteen” public domain — but see *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (London: William Rider & Son, 1924), pp. 122 n., 207, where Waite argues at length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped — a position already implicit in 1887 (pp. 225, 234), so this is a restatement rather than a retraction. Yates, *The Rosicrucian Enlightenment* (1972; Routledge Classics ed., pp. 43, 68, 182–85, the edition to which those page numbers belong) — in copyright; see also Brian Vickers, “Frances Yates and the Writing of History,” *Journal of Modern History* 51, no. 2 (1979), 287–316, not consulted for this book. Arnold, *Histoire des Rose-Croix* (1935), p. 50; Webster, *Acta Comeniana* 26 (1970), p. 149. *Ludibrium* lexicography: Lewis & Short, s.v. *ludibrium*; and cf. Thomas Willard, “Andreae’s *ludibrium*: Menippean Satire in the *Chymische Hochzeit*,” in Classen (ed.), *Laughter in the Middle Ages and Early Modern Times* (De Gruyter, 2010), 767–90 — not consulted for this book. Andreae defends his own method at *Vita* Lib. II, pp. 46–47: not from a mocking spirit, but by the art many pious men have used, “ut per lusum et ingeniosa allectamenta seria agerem” — that through play he might treat serious matters. Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* (Hamburg 1595; Hanau 1609). Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564). Maier, *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617). **Three quotations in this chapter are printed without an established source, and are flagged rather than dressed up.** The English of the two Paris placards of 1622 is in wide circulation and no edition or translator for it could be traced for this edition; the French originals do not survive in a form this book was able to consult, and even the placards’ existence rests on

contemporary report rather than on a surviving copy. Robert Boyle's phrase about the cornerstones of the Invisible College comes from his correspondence of the later 1640s; the letter was not consulted directly and the wording is given as it circulates. A reader building an argument on any of the three should go behind this book.

Advanced Practices

Advanced practice in this tradition means sustained work with techniques that assume the foundations are already in place — a stable attention, a reliable ritual frame, and enough self-knowledge to notice when you are deceiving yourself. What follows is descriptive: these are the practices the sources contain, with their actual provenance, so that a reader can tell what they are looking at and decide what is worth pursuing under proper guidance.

One general observation belongs first, and it reorganises this whole chapter. Most of what circulates as “advanced Hermetic practice” is not ancient. It was systematised by the **Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn**, founded in 1887–88 by three Freemasons — William Robert Woodman, William Wynn Westcott and Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers — with the Isis-Urania Temple formally established in London in 1888. The order’s foundational documents, the CIPHER Manuscripts, were written in English in Trithemius cipher; Westcott decoded them in 1887 after receiving them from A. F. A. Woodford the previous year. Those manuscripts outline the grade rituals and set out a graduated curriculum covering Hermetic Qabalah, astrology, divinatory tarot, geomancy and alchemy — outlines rather than full texts, from which the rituals as performed were elaborated. That curriculum is, in substance, the modern Western magical syllabus.

The grade structure

The Golden Dawn organised its teaching into ten numbered grades across three tiers, each mapped to a sephirah of the Tree of Life and running downward from 10 to 1, preceded by a preliminary Neophyte grade (0=0) that stands outside the series:

- **First Order:** Neophyte (0=0), Zelator (1=10), Theoricus (2=9), Practicus (3=8), Philosophus (4=7)
- **Second Order:** Adeptus Minor (5=6), Adeptus Major (6=5), Adeptus Exemptus (7=4)
- **Third Order:** Magister Templi (8=3), Magus (9=2), Ipsissimus (10=1)

The First Order taught theory — correspondence, symbolism, divinatory systems — and the Second Order taught magic proper, including scrying, astral travel and alchemy. The Third Order was, in practice, understood as belonging to those beyond ordinary membership. The graduated structure is itself the point: material was withheld until earlier material had been demonstrated, which is a pedagogical judgement this book endorses even where it declines to reproduce the content.

The practices

Scrying. Sustained soft-focus attention on a reflective or featureless surface — black mirror, bowl of water, crystal — until imagery arises. The *Ars Almadel* of the *Lemegeton* uses a wax tablet for a related purpose, and scrying is among the techniques the Golden Dawn's Second Order explicitly taught. What the technique actually reliably produces is the mind's own imagery under conditions of reduced sensory input; whether it produces more than that is the question the tradition exists to ask, and it is not answerable by assertion in either direction. The discipline is to record what arises before interpreting it.

Assumption of godforms. Building the image of a deity around oneself in visualisation and speaking or acting from within it. This has a genuine ancient parallel — the Greek Magical Papyri contain rituals in which the practitioner assumes the identity of a deity through invocation and visualisation, as part of an ascent or operation (see Chapter 9) — which makes it one of the few advanced techniques here with attested antiquity behind it, even if its modern form is a Golden Dawn reconstruction rather than a continuous inheritance.

The Middle Pillar and pathworking. The Middle Pillar exercise circulates energy through the central sephiroth of the Tree; pathworking traverses the twenty-two paths in structured visualisation, using the correspondences described in Chapter 3. Both belong to the modern Qabalistic system rather than to any ancient source. Their fullest published form comes through Israel Regardie, whose *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order* appeared in four volumes between **1937 and 1940** — the publication that broke the order’s secrecy and made this entire body of technique publicly available. It remains in print.

The Enochian material. The system of angelic communication and language recorded by John Dee and Edward Kelley in the 1580s, subsequently reworked by the Golden Dawn into something considerably more systematic than Dee left it. Anyone working with Enochian material should know which layer they are handling — Dee’s diaries and the Golden Dawn’s redaction are different objects.

Working the practices

Descriptions are of limited use without procedure, so three of the above are given here as procedures. All three are modern — that is the finding of this chapter, not a caveat bolted onto it.

THE MIDDLE PILLAR

1. Stand or sit upright. Perform the banishing of Chapter 15.
Breathe evenly until the breath is regular.
2. **Above the head**, formulate a sphere of brilliant white light, and vibrate *Eheieh* (eh-heh-YEH) — the name of Kether. Hold it until it is steady.
3. **At the throat**, a sphere of soft grey. Vibrate *YHVH Elohim* (ye-ho-WAU e-loh-HEEM) — the name of Daath.
4. **At the heart**, a sphere of gold. Vibrate *YHVH Eloah ve-Daath* (ye-ho-WAU e-LOH-ah ve-DAH-ath) — Tiphareth.
5. **At the groin**, a sphere of violet. Vibrate *Shaddai El Chai* (shah-DYE el KHYE) — Yesod.
6. **At the feet**, a sphere of olive, russet, citrine and black. Vibrate *Adonai ha-Aretz* (ah-doh-NYE ha-AH-retz) — Malkuth.
7. When all five stand, circulate: bring the light down the left side of the body on the out-breath, up the right on the in-breath, several times; then up the front and down the back; then draw it from the feet up the central column and let it fountain from the crown to fall around you.
8. Let the images go. Ground as in Chapter 15.

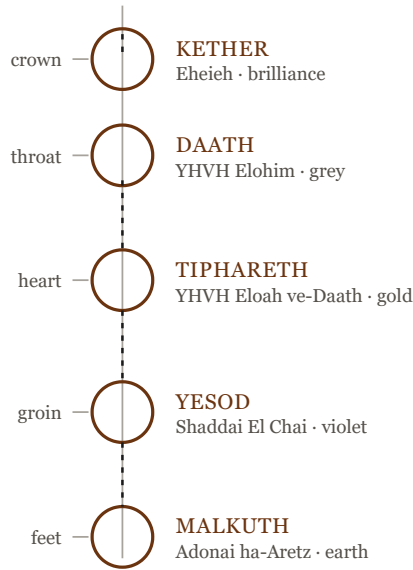


FIG. 1 — THE MIDDLE PILLAR. Five centres on the body’s central axis, each with the divine name vibrated at it. Daath, at the throat, is not one of the ten sephiroth but the “non-sephirah” of the Tree; it appears here because the exercise uses the central column of the Tree (Chapter 3, Fig. 2) rather than the sephiroth as such. Drawn for this book.

A word on provenance, since this book insists on it. The Middle Pillar in this form was published by Israel Regardie in *The Middle Pillar* (1938) and his text is in copyright; what is given above is a description of the procedure rather than his wording. The divine names are the standard Qabalistic names of the sephiroth concerned and are much older than the exercise that arranges them.

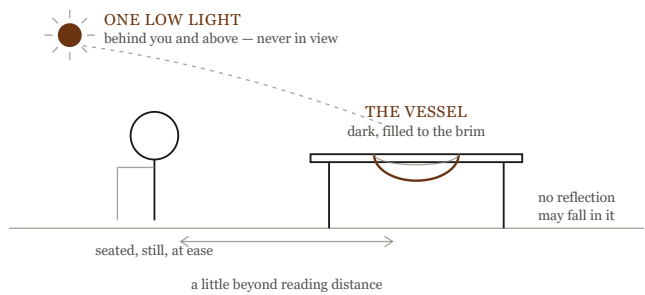


FIG. 2 — THE SCRYING ARRANGEMENT. Almost every practical difficulty beginners report with this exercise is a lighting problem, and the geometry above solves it: a single dim source set behind and above the operator lights the room without appearing anywhere in the dark surface. Put the lamp in front and you spend the session looking at a lamp. The distance is set so the eyes cannot comfortably focus on the surface, which is the point. Drawn for this book.

SCRYING

1. Work at night or in low, even light, with the speculum — black mirror, dark bowl of water, crystal — at a comfortable distance, angled so that it reflects nothing in particular. A reflection of your own face defeats the exercise.
2. Banish. State what you are seeking, once, aloud, and then set the question down.
3. Rest the eyes on the surface with the focus slightly soft. Blink normally. Do not stare: staring produces eye strain and afterimages, which are the commonest thing mistaken for a vision.
4. Wait. Twenty minutes is a session. Cloudiness, dimming or a sense of depth usually precede imagery, and often nothing else follows, which is normal.
5. When imagery arises, **do not interpret it in the moment.** Note it. If it is a figure, it is legitimate to ask it to name itself and to test whether it remains consistent; inconsistency under questioning is information.
6. Close deliberately: cover the speculum, banish, write the record, then eat something.

The reason for the discipline in step five is not superstition about spirits. It is that the material is generated at least partly by you, and interpretation offered while the imagery is still arriving contaminates what arrives next. Record first, interpret later — days later, for preference.

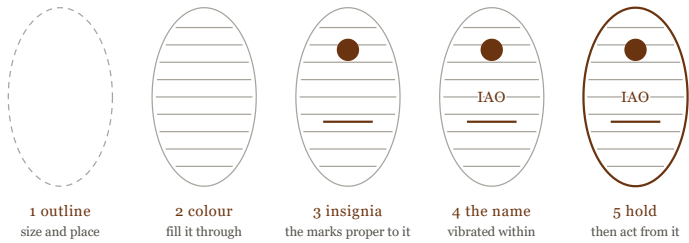


FIG. 3 — BUILDING A GODFORM. The figure is not imagined all at once. It is assembled in a fixed order, each stage held until it is steady, and the name is not given until there is something to give it to. The outline is deliberately abstract here: what shape you build depends entirely on which form you are assuming, and the sources describe the procedure rather than supply the picture. The letters shown are a placeholder for whatever name the operation names. Drawn for this book.

ASSUMPTION OF A GODFORM

1. Choose the form before you begin, and know its attributes, its posture and its name. Do not improvise this.
2. Banish. Stand in the posture of the form.
3. Build the image around you, not in front of you: the size, the headdress, the colours, the weight of it. Take the time this needs — it is the whole exercise.
4. Vibrate the name as set out in Chapter 7, feeling it fill the form rather than the body.
5. Speak or act from within it, briefly. Brevity is a safety measure, not modesty.
6. **Take it off.** Let the image dissolve deliberately; state your own name aloud; banish; ground. This step is not optional and is the one that gets skipped.

The ancient parallel noted above is real — the papyri contain rituals of exactly this shape — but the modern form is a Golden Dawn reconstruction, and the Egyptian godforms it uses are the Egypt of the nineteenth-century imagination as much as of the monuments.

A NOTE ON WHAT IS AND IS NOT ATTRIBUTED

The Golden Dawn's founding, dates, grade structure, Cipher Manuscripts and curriculum are well documented, as is Regardie's publication. What is *not* settled — and this book will not pretend otherwise — is exactly which of these techniques the order invented outright and which it inherited or adapted from earlier sources. The scholarly record establishes that the Second Order taught scrying, astral travel and alchemy; it does not cleanly establish the origin of each individual exercise. Where this chapter says “Golden Dawn,” read it as “systematised and transmitted by the Golden Dawn,” which is defensible, rather than “invented there,” which in several cases is not yet demonstrated.

⚠ Advanced Practice Warning

These practices assume extensive preparation and, in their original setting, years of graded work under supervision. The graded structure existed for a reason and its removal by publication was not an unmixed improvement. Two specific cautions. Sustained visualisation and evocatory work can be genuinely destabilising, and the tradition's own literature contains ample evidence of practitioners who came apart; if you have a history of psychosis, dissociation or mania, this material is not for solitary work. And the commonest failure here is not dramatic — it is the slow inflation of the practitioner's sense of their own significance, which the grade systems were partly designed to check.

MODERN PRACTICE

Regardie's publication changed this material permanently: what was once transmitted in a temple over years is now available in a single volume, and every modern practitioner is in some sense working from a leaked syllabus. Contemporary orders descended from the Golden Dawn still use graded curricula, while a large majority of practitioners now work solo from published sources. The honest assessment is that solitary work loses the two things the original structure supplied — pacing, and someone else's eyes on your conclusions — and that practitioners who compensate deliberately, through written records and a peer or teacher who will disagree with them, do markedly better than those who do not.

Sources: Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, founded 1887–88 (Woodman, Westcott, Mathers); Isis-Urania Temple, London, 1888; the original order fractured in 1903. Cipher Manuscripts (Trithemius cipher; decoded by Westcott 1887). Ellic Howe, *The Magicians of the Golden Dawn* (1972), for the grade numbering — the descending 10–1 series maps the ten sephiroth, with a preliminary 0=0 outside it. Regardie, *The Golden Dawn*, 4 vols (1937–40) — in copyright; note that Regardie was not first into print, Crowley having published order material in *The Equinox* (1909–13). Dee and Kelley's Enochian diaries (1580s) — BL Sloane MS 3188 runs 22 December 1581 to 23 May 1583 and opens with Barnabas Saul, not Kelley, as scryer. PGM for the ancient parallel to godform assumption (Betz, 1986). The Middle Pillar exercise as given here follows the procedure published by Israel Regardie, *The Middle Pillar* (1938) in copyright — described, not quoted; the sephirotic divine names are older than the exercise. The scrying and godform procedures are this book's own arrangement of practices the order's published papers describe.

Enochian

Enochian is not one thing. It is three, laid down two and a half centuries apart: the diaries John Dee kept in the 1580s, the folio in which those diaries were first printed in 1659, and the working system the Golden Dawn built out of them after 1888. Only the first is a primary source, and almost everything a modern practitioner would recognise belongs to the third. Knowing which layer a given piece of Enochian comes from is the whole of the difficulty, and the rest of this chapter is the evidence for telling them apart.

What Dee and Kelley actually did

Between 1581 and 1587 **John Dee** — mathematician, astrologer to Elizabeth I, owner of the largest private library in England — held several hundred sessions in which a scryer looked into a crystal and reported what appeared there, and Dee wrote it down. Out of those sessions came a corpus: an angelic alphabet, a set of long texts in a language its recipients called Angelical, a great many tables of letters, and instructions for their use.

The critical fact about the arrangement is one Dee states himself, and it governs everything downstream. **He did not see anything.** Casaubon, editing the diaries in 1659, puts it plainly — Dee “himself saw nothing (for so himself acknowledgeth in some places) but by Kelley’s eyes, and heard nothing but with his ears.” The scryer for most of the corpus was **Edward Kelley**, and everything in it reached the page through him.

Even the beginning of the record is not Kelley’s. The manuscript of the earliest sessions, British Library Sloane MS 3188, runs from 22 December 1581 to 23 May 1583 and opens with a different scryer altogether, Barnabas Saul. Kelley arrives after him and stays.

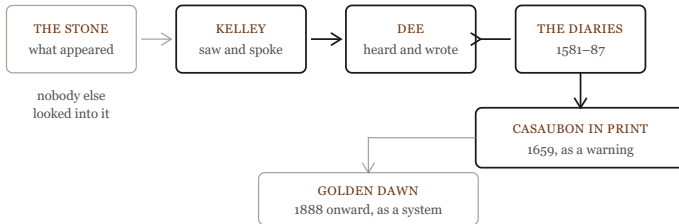


FIG. 1 — EVERYTHING CAME THROUGH ONE PAIR OF EYES. Dee recorded what Kelley reported seeing; he says himself that he saw nothing directly. The corpus is therefore a record of one man’s testimony, taken down faithfully by another — which is a different kind of document from a thing observed. The two faint boxes are the ends nobody can check: what was in the stone, and what the Golden Dawn added. Drawn for this book.

How it got into print, and who wanted it there

The diaries sat in manuscript for seventy years. They were printed in 1659 by **Merick Casaubon** — a Doctor of Divinity, and the son of the Isaac Casaubon who in 1614 demolished the ancient dating of the *Hermetica* in Chapter 2. The family has a claim to have twice redirected the history of Western esotericism, both times by publishing something.

The title page states the contents and the intent together, and it is worth reading as the editorial document it is:

A True & Faithful Relation of What passed for many Yeers Between D^r. John Dee (A Mathematician of Great Fame in Q. Eliz. and King James their Reignes) and Some Spirits: Tending (had it Succeeded) To a General Alteration of most States and Kingdomes in the World... Out of The Original Copy, written with D^r. Dees own Hand: Kept in the Library of Sir Tho. Cotton, Kt. Baronet. With a Preface Confirming the Reality (as to the Point of Spirits) of This Relation: and shewing the several good Uses that a Sober Christian may make of All.

Read the last sentence again. Casaubon is not publishing a magical handbook. He is publishing an exhibit. The preface exists to confirm that the spirits were *real* and to show what a sober Christian should conclude from that — which, in his view, is that Dee was destroyed by them.

THE FRAUD HYPOTHESIS IS OLDER THAN YOU THINK

The modern explanation of Enochian is that Kelley invented it and imposed on a credulous old man. That explanation is not modern. Casaubon states it in 1659, in the preface, as an objection he has to deal with: is it not possible, he asks, “that Kelley being a cunning man, and well practised in these things might impose upon the credulity of Dr. Dee (a good innocent man) and the rather, because by this office under the Doctor he got 50*l.* by the year” — fifty pounds a year being Kelley’s salary as scribe.

Casaubon calls the suggestion “plausible as it is proposed” and then rejects it, on the ground that a careful reader of the whole record will “find it far otherwise.” He rejects it because he has a third explanation available that the modern reader does not: that the spirits were there, and were evil. The point worth keeping is not who was right. It is that the argument was joined at the first printing, by the editor, in public, and that the corpus has never at any time been free of it.

What Casaubon concluded about the spirits he states without hedging. Of the suggestion that good angels were involved:

such as appear in form of Angels of Light, such as deluded Dr. Dee, and daily doth those that hunt after Revelations, and Prophecies, and unlawful Curiosities, I grant it. But that any good Angels did ever meddle in a practice commonly attended with so much imposture, impiety, cousenage as this commonly is, I shall not easily grant.

And of Dee himself he is generous, which is what makes the verdict land. Dee was, he writes, “so good, so innocent, yea, so pious a man, and so sincere a Christian” — and the question that troubles Casaubon is why God would permit such a man “to be so deluded and abused... by evil Spirits, even to his dying day, for ought we know.” The first printed Enochian is a book published by a churchman who thought its author sincere, its contents genuine, and its source damnable.

The third layer, and why this chapter stops

What most modern practitioners mean by Enochian is not the diaries. It is the system the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn assembled from them in the late nineteenth century: the four Watchtowers worked as a coherent scheme, the elemental and Tarot attributions laid across the tables, the pronunciation conventions, the grade structure the material was fitted into. That work is a genuine construction and a considerable one. It is also a *construction*, and it is not in Dee.

This book gives no Enochian operation, and the reason is specific rather than squeamish. **The workable system is in copyright and the public-domain source is not a workable system.** The Golden Dawn material reached print chiefly through Regardie between 1937 and 1940 and remains in copyright; this book’s practice, set out in the bibliography, is to describe such material and not reproduce it. What is free of copyright is Casaubon’s 1659 folio, and that is a transcript of conversations, not a set of instructions — the tables are there, and so are the angelic names, but the method for using them as the orders use them is the orders’ own.

An honest chapter can therefore give you the history, the provenance, the layers and the caution, and it cannot hand you a rite without either infringing a copyright or inventing one and calling it Dee’s. It does the first and declines the second.

What the free source does contain: a Call, entire

The section above is right that the folio is a transcript rather than a manual, and it has been understating what the transcript holds. The tables are in it, and the angelic names — and so are the *Calls*: the long invocations in the Angelical tongue, set down word by word as Kelley reported them from the stone, with Dee's English against each word and a syllabified pronunciation in the margin. A chapter that says the language exists and never lets the reader see a line of it is hiding the most concrete thing the public-domain source has. Here, therefore, is one entire, exactly as the 1659 folio prints it across pp. 207–208: the Call of the Thirty Aethyrs, the one Call that is used with each of the thirty in turn, its name inserted — and the one the later tradition worked hardest.

Read the middle column downward and Dee's own English runs: *one while let her be known, and another while a stranger, because she is the bed of an harlot and the dwelling place of him that is fallen. O you heavens arise, the lower heavens underneath you let them serve you. Govern those that govern, cast down such as fall, bring forth with those that encrease, and destroy the rotten. No place let it remain in one number. Adde and diminish until the stars be numbred. Arise, move, and appear before the covenant of his mouth, which he hath sworn unto us in his justice. Open the mysteries of your creation, and make us partakers of undefiled knowledge.*

AS DICTATED	DEE'S ENGLISH	AS THE FOLIO SYLLABIFIES IT
LCAPIMAO	one while	L ca pi ma o.
IXOMAXIP	let her be known,	Ix o máx ip.
ODCACOCASB	and another while	Od ca có casb.
GOSAA	a stranger,	Go sa a.
BAGLEN	because	Baglen.
PII	she is	Pi i.
TIANTA	the bed	Ti án ta.
ABABALOND	of an harlot	A bá ba lond.
ODFAORGT	and the dwelling place	Od fa orgt.
TELOCVOVIM	of him that is fallen.	Te lóc vo v im.
MADRIIAX	O you heavens	Má dri iax.
TORZU	arise,	Tor zu.
OADRIAX	The lower heavens	O ádriax.
OROCHA	underneath you	O ró cha.
ABOAPRI	let them serve you,	A bó a pri.
TABAORI	Govern	Tabá o ri.
PRIAZ	those	Priáz.
ARTABAS	that govern,	Ar ta bas.

AS DICTATED	DEE’S ENGLISH	AS THE FOLIO SYLLABIFIES IT
ADRPAN	Cast down	A dr pan.
CORSTA	such as	Cor sta.
DOBIX	fall,	Dobix.
YOLCAM	bring forth	Yol cam.
PRIAZI	with those	Pri á zi.
ARCOAZIOR	that encrease,	Ar co a zior.
ODQUASB	and destroy	Od quasb.
QTING	the rotten	Q ting.
RIPIR	No place,	Ri pí.
PAAOXT	let it remain	Pa a oxt.
SAGACOR	in one number.	Sa gá cor.
VML	Adde	Vml.
OD	and	—
PRDZAR	Diminish	Prd zar.
CACRG	until	Ca crg.
AOIVEAE	the Stars	A oi vé ae.
CORMPT	be numbred;	Cormpt.
TORZU	arise,	Tor zu.

AS DICTATED	DEE'S ENGLISH	AS THE FOLIO SYLLABIFIES IT
ZACAR	Move	Zacar.
ODZAMRAN	and appear	Od zamran.
ASPT	before	Aspt.
SIBSI	the Covenant	Sib si.
BUTMONA	of his mouth,	But mo na.
DS	which	Ds.
SURZAS	he hath sworn	Sur zas.
TIA	unto us	Tia.
BALTAN	in his Justice.	Baltan.
ODO	Open	Odo.
CICLE	the mysteries	Cicle.
QAA	of your Creation,	Q áa.
OD	and	Od.
OZAZMA	make us	Ozazma.
PLAPLI	partakers	Pla pli.
IADNAMAD	of undefiled knowledge.	Iad na mad.

Three things in that table are worth more than any modern commentary on it. The first is that the language behaves like a language: *od* is “and” and recurs as “and”; *torzu* is “arise” both times it appears; *madrii*ax and *oadri*ax are “heavens” and “lower heavens.” Whatever produced it was consistent with itself across a long text dictated letter by letter. The second is the interruptions, which the folio prints and this book keeps in its note below: the curtain drawn and undrawn mid-Call, and Gabriel breaking in with “Move not, for the place is holy.” The record is of a

séance, and it never stops looking like one. The third is what the Call is *for*: it asks for the mysteries of creation to be opened and for the speaker to be made a partaker of undefiled knowledge. It is a request for knowledge, in the same register as the *Poimandres* of Chapter 2, four hundred years and one invented language later.

What is still not here is the operation, and the distinction is exact. The folio gives the words and their meaning; it does not give which Aethyr to call for what, what a sryer should expect, how the Call is to be voiced, or what follows from it — the apparatus that turns a text into a practice. That apparatus is the third layer, it is the orders' own, and the fullest modern account of it is in copyright. A reader who wants to know what the Angelical language *is* now has fifty-two words of it with the recipient's own translation. A reader who wants to know what to *do* with them is looking at the gap this chapter exists to describe.

Which layer are you holding?

Three questions settle it, and they are worth asking of any Enochian source you meet. **Is it in Casaubon 1659 or in the manuscripts?** Then it is Dee and Kelley, and it is a record of what one man said he saw. **Is it a Watchtower worked as an elemental temple, with Tarot and colour attributions?** Then it is Golden Dawn, and it is Victorian. **Is it a pronunciation guide?** Then it is later still, and largely conjectural: the diaries record spellings, not sounds.

None of that makes the later layers worthless. It makes them *later*, and a practitioner who cannot say which century a technique comes from cannot say what it is evidence of.

Sources: The Call of the Thirty Aethyrs is quoted from Meric Casaubon (ed.), *A True & Faithful Relation* (London, 1659), pp. 207–208, read on the page images of the Wellcome copy on the Internet Archive, identifier *b30324282_0001* (leaves 301–302). Reading the leaves was the only possible course: the scan’s text layer renders this passage as unusable rubble, and no word of the table above comes from it. The three columns are the folio’s own — the dictated word in capitals, Dee’s English, and the syllabified pronunciation set to the right — and the accents in the third column are the printing’s. The folio adds marginal alternatives for four readings (*gt* or *dgt* for the ending of ODFAGORT; *lotch* or *loch* in TELOCVOVIM; *yax* for the ending of MADRIAX; *ka* in OROCHA), and two more (*Kor*, *Pur*, *cirg*, *dg*) sit above their words on p. 208; none is reproduced in the table and all are recorded here. Kelley’s two interruptions and Gabriel’s “Move not, for the place is holy” fall where the text says they do and are omitted from the table because they are not part of the Call. The running English in the paragraph above is the middle column read continuously, with the folio’s punctuation and nothing added. Meric Casaubon (ed.), *A True & Faithful Relation of What passed for many Yeers Between D^r. John Dee... and Some Spirits* (London: printed by D. Maxwell for T. Garthwait, 1659) public domain — the title page, the preface on Kelley and the fifty pounds a year, the passage on Angels of Light, and the passage on Dee’s piety. **Two scans of the same edition were used, and which one each passage comes from is worth stating, because neither is legible throughout.** The title page is quoted from the Getty Research Institute copy, identifier *truefaithfulrela00deej*, whose title leaf is clean; the preface is quoted from the Wellcome copy, *b30324282_0001*, whose preface is clean where the Getty’s is not — the Getty text layer gives *DuLthdLany good Angels* for *But that any good Angels* and *prA<5tice* for *practice*, and the Wellcome renders both correctly. Long *s* is set as round *s* and the scans’ broken word-spacing is closed up throughout; period spellings — *cousenage*, *Reignes*, *Kingdomes*, *shewing* — stand. Beyond spacing and the long *s*, one reading is repaired: the Wellcome scan gives *Revelatsons* for *Revelations*. The ellipses are marked. British Library Sloane MS 3188, for the dates of the earliest sessions and for Barnabas Saul as the first scribe, is cited here on the authority of the same manuscript record used in Chapter 13; the manuscript itself was not consulted for this book. **The Golden Dawn redaction is described and not quoted.** Regardie, *The Golden Dawn*, 4 vols (1937–40), is in copyright, and no Enochian operation from it, or from any other modern order source, is reproduced here. The three questions in the box above are this book’s own.

Protection & Banishing

Protection and banishing are the practical hygiene of this tradition. Their function is to clear a space before work and to close it afterwards, and in ordinary use they have less to do with repelling hostile forces than with establishing a definite beginning and end. A practitioner who banishes reliably is a practitioner who does not carry the residue of one working into the next, or into the rest of their life.

Basic techniques

1. **Visualisation** — establish an image of light surrounding you, bounded and complete. Simple, portable, and requires nothing.
2. **Prayer** — call upon whatever you understand the divine to be, in your own words or a traditional form. The overwhelming majority of historical protective practice is prayer.
3. **Salt** — used across many traditions for purification and boundary-marking, whether scattered, dissolved in water, or laid at a threshold.
4. **Herbs** — sage and rosemary are the most commonly used in this tradition, burned or hung. Ventilate if burning, and note that white sage in particular is both ecologically pressured and culturally specific to practices this book does not claim; garden sage and rosemary do the same work in a Hermetic frame.

These four are genuinely sufficient for ordinary purposes, and a practitioner who does them consistently is better protected than one who performs an elaborate ceremony occasionally.

The Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram

The most widely used banishing in Western ceremonial practice is the LBRP, and it comes from the original Golden Dawn — which places it in the late nineteenth century, not antiquity. It belonged to the **First**, or Outer, Order: apart from the grade ceremonies it was the only ritual revealed at that level, disclosed to neophytes immediately after initiation, and on R. A. Gilbert's assessment the nearest thing to a purely magical ritual in the outer curriculum. Its skeleton is genuinely in the Cipher Manuscripts — the banishing-pentagram concept appears on page 14, in what looks like a different hand, and the archangel, element and cardinal-point correspondences are already there — though the Cipher MS nowhere sets the ritual out in full. Its structure has four movements:

1. **The Qabalistic Cross.** The practitioner traces a cross on the body, touching forehead, breast and each shoulder while vibrating Hebrew words drawn from the doxology of the Lord's Prayer, each position corresponding to a location on the Tree of Life.
2. **Formulation of the pentagrams.** Beginning in the east and proceeding around the quarters, a pentagram is drawn at each cardinal point while a divine name is vibrated: YHVH in the east, Adonai in the south, Eheieh in the west, AGLA in the north.
3. **Evocation of the archangels.** Standing with arms outstretched in the form of a cross — the posture the Golden Dawn called the Calvary Cross, and the position of the godform "Osiris Slain" — four archangels are named at the quarters: Raphael before (east), Gabriel behind (west), Michael at the right hand (south), Auriel at the left (north). The declaration continues in the same breath: "Before me flames the pentagram, behind me shines the six-rayed star," locating the magician between the pentagram of the microcosm and the hexagram of the macrocosm.
4. **The Qabalistic Cross repeated**, closing the ritual as it opened.

Set out in full, and in a form you can work from, it runs as follows. The Hebrew is given unpointed, the pronunciation as the earliest printed version gives it.

THE LESSER BANISHING RITUAL OF THE PENTAGRAM

1. **The Qabalistic Cross.** Face east. Touch the forehead, then the breast, then the right shoulder, then the left, then clasp the hands at the breast, vibrating at each:

אתה *Ateh* ah-TAH — “unto Thee”

מלכות *Malkuth* mal-KOOTH — “the Kingdom”

וגבורה *ve-Geburah* ve-ge-boo-RAH — “and the Power”

וגדולה *ve-Gedulah* ve-ge-doo-LAH — “and the Glory”

לעולם אמן *le-Olahm, Amen* le-oh-LAHM, ah-MEN — “to the ages, amen”

2. **The pentagram in the east.** Trace a banishing earth pentagram in the air — beginning at the lower left point, up to the top, and round — with the extended fingers or the wand. Bring the point of the wand to the centre and vibrate:

יהוה *YHVH* ye-ho-WAU

3. **South.** Turn sunwise, carrying a line of light at shoulder height from the centre of the eastern pentagram. Trace the same figure and vibrate:

אדני *Adonai* ah-doh-NYE

4. **West.** The same, and vibrate:

אהיה *Eheieh* eh-heh-YEH

5. **North.** The same, and vibrate:

אגלא *AGLA* ah-goo-LAH

6. **Close the circle.** Complete the line back to the east, so that the four pentagrams stand joined in a ring of light at shoulder height.

7. **The archangels.** Return to face east. Extend the arms sideways in the form of a cross — the posture the order called the Calvary Cross, and the godform of Osiris Slain — and say:

Before me Raphael. Behind me Gabriel. On my right hand Michael. On my left hand Auriel. For before me flames the pentagram, and behind me shines the six-rayed star.

8. **The Qabalistic Cross repeated,** exactly as at the opening.

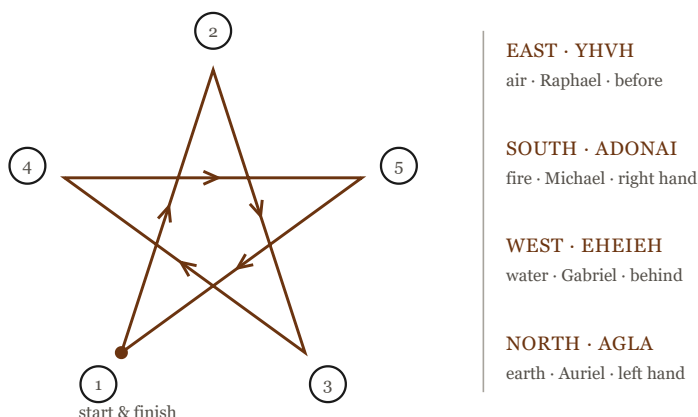


FIG. 1 — THE BANISHING PENTAGRAM OF EARTH, AND THE FOUR QUARTERS. The tracing order is the whole point of the figure: begin at the lower left, go up to the apex, and continue in one unbroken line, closing the angle where you began. The same figure is drawn at each of the four quarters with a different divine name. The requirement that the angles be closed is, on Graham Wheeler's reconstruction, the one element of the ritual borrowed from a work of fiction — Mephistopheles is held in Faust's study by a pentagram whose angle was left open. Drawn for this book.

TWO TEXTUAL POINTS, SINCE THIS BOOK IS ABOUT TEXTS

The wording of the archangel declaration is not stable. The Golden Dawn form is the one given above, and Graham Wheeler notes that “behind me shines the six-rayed star” is regularly altered in modern versions to “in the column shines the six-rayed star” — the column being the middle pillar of the Tree, with which the magician is identifying. Wheeler dates that variant to Crowley’s “Star Ruby” of 1913. The text of *Liber O* as it now circulates online in fact reads “*For about me flames the Pentagram, and in the Column stands the six-rayed Star;*” which would push the variant back to 1909 — but this book has not checked that text against the 1909 printing of *The Equinox*, and an online transcription may carry a later editor’s emendation. The point is recorded here unresolved rather than smoothed over.

The pronunciations are those printed in *Liber O*: “Ye-ho-wau, Adonai, Eheieh, Agla.” They represent one nineteenth-century English convention, not Hebrew as spoken anywhere. YHVH is not pronounced at all in Jewish practice, and a reader who finds the convention uncomfortable is in good company; substituting *Adonai* or a silent intention is a recognised solution and the ritual does not stop working.

The ritual’s stated purpose is to banish chaotic or impure forms of the elements from the working space. Its components are plainly Christian and Qabalistic: the Lord’s Prayer doxology, Hebrew divine names, the four archangels, and an association of the quarters with the classical elements by way of the biblical four living creatures.

WHAT IS DOCUMENTED AND WHAT IS NOT

The LBRP is attributed to the original order of the Golden Dawn, and its structure and content are well attested. Two questions remain genuinely open: who first assembled the formula, and exactly when. Mathers is credited as the principal hand by convention rather than by demonstration — R. A. Gilbert has argued for a larger role for Westcott — and the composition process, in Graham John Wheeler’s words, “remains obscure: the evidence simply does not survive” (*Correspondences* 8, no. 1, 2020, p. 8). Nothing resembling the ritual existed before the 1880s, and the earliest located manuscript text is datable to the 1890s.

The third question — which earlier materials shaped it — is no longer open, and an earlier version of this book conceded more ground here than it needed to. Wheeler’s 2020 source-analysis — by his own account the first anyone has attempted — identifies the ingredients in detail. **Eliphas Lévi** above all: he first noticed the resemblance between the doxology of the Lord’s Prayer and the sephiroth, and he gives the Qabalistic Cross gesture in recognisable form — the order’s replication of his Hebrew solecisms makes the dependence close to certain. Behind Lévi stand Matthew 6:13 and 1 Chronicles 29:11, by way of a Zohar passage *Mathers himself translated in 1887*. **Agrippa**, reaching the order through Barrett’s *Magus*, supplies the archangel–element correspondences; **Ptolemy’s Tetrabiblos** supplies the element–direction correspondences onto which Agrippa’s were mapped. Solomonian grimoire practice supplies the divine names at the quarters and the ritual dagger; Freemasonry the circumambulation; medieval rabbinic material the four archangels surrounding the divine throne. The rule about closing the angles of the pentagram appears to come from Goethe’s *Faust* — the one element borrowed from a work of fiction.

One derivation often repeated should be resisted: the archangel invocation does not descend from the bedtime Shema. What the two share is an earlier ancestor — the Jewish motif of four archangels surrounding God’s throne, the throne being the detail that discriminates — and the

before/behind/right/left formula itself runs back through the *Seder Rav Amram Gaon* to a second-millennium-BCE Mesopotamian exorcism. Claims that the ritual descends from ancient Egyptian or Solomonic practice remain unsupported; the ritual is modern. But its ingredients are now traceable, and the tracing is more interesting than the agnosticism it replaces.

The Lesser Ritual of the Hexagram

The banishing of the pentagram has a companion, and this book has referred to it twice without printing it — the six-rayed star named in the fourth movement above. *Liber O* gives it immediately after the pentagram ritual, with the instruction that it “is to be performed after the *Lesser Ritual of the Pentagram*.” It opens with the passage known as the Analysis of the Keyword, which is the most theatrical thing in Western ceremonial practice and also the most compressed: a Latin inscription, read as Hebrew letters, read as a sequence of Egyptian gods, resolving into a single word of light.

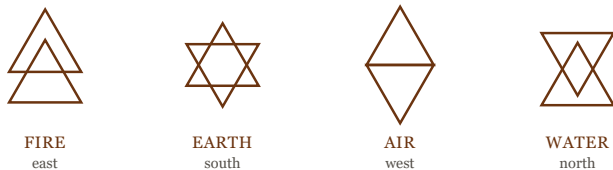


FIG. 2 — THE FOUR HEXAGRAMS. Two interlocked triangles, arranged differently at each quarter, as *Liber O* describes them. Where the pentagram of Fig. 1 is the sign of the microcosm, the hexagram is the sign of the macrocosm — which is what the two rituals together are for: the pentagram sets the practitioner’s own boundary, the hexagram addresses what is outside it. Drawn for this book from the descriptions in the text.

THE LESSER RITUAL OF THE HEXAGRAM

1. **Stand upright**, feet together, left arm at the side, right across the body, holding the wand upright in the median line. Face east.

2. **The Analysis of the Keyword.** Say:

I.N.R.I. Yod. Nun. Resh. Yod.

Virgo, Isis, Mighty Mother.

Scorpio, Apophis, Destroyer.

Sol, Osiris, Slain and Risen.

Isis, Apophis, Osiris, IAO.

3. **The signs.** Extend the arms in the form of a cross: *the Sign of Osiris Slain*. Raise the right arm to point upwards and lower the left to point downwards, elbows square, head turned over the left shoulder so the eyes follow the left forearm: *the Sign of the Mourning of Isis*. Raise the arms at sixty degrees to each other above the head, head thrown back: *the Sign of Apophis and Typhon*. Cross the arms on the breast and bow the head: *the Sign of Osiris Risen*.

4. **Extend the arms again** as in the first sign, then cross them again as in the last, saying:

L.V.X., Lux, the Light of the Cross.

5. **The four hexagrams.** Trace the hexagram of Fire in the east, of Earth in the south, of Air in the west, of Water in the north, as drawn above, vibrating at each:

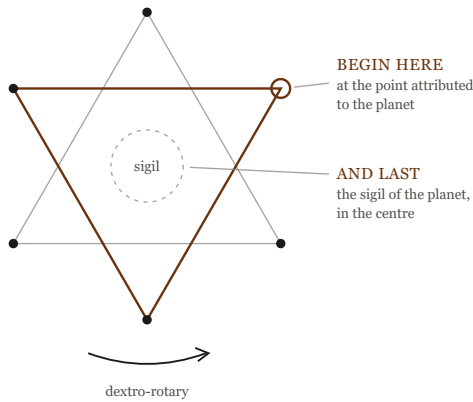
אראריטא *ARARITA* ah-rah-REE-tah

The name is an acrostic: “One is His Beginning: One is His Individuality: His Permutation is One.”

6. **Repeat** the Analysis of the Keyword and the signs, exactly as at the opening.

To banish rather than invoke, the ritual is identical except that the direction in which each hexagram is traced is reversed.

THE HEXAGRAM OF EARTH



Begin at the point attributed to the planet. Which of the two triangles that falls on depends on the planet, so the figure has no fixed starting corner. *Liber O* sends the reader to a table of attributions for it. Trace that triangle dextro-rotary and complete it; then trace the other from its own attributed point. The sigil of the planet goes in the centre, drawn last. To banish, the hexagram is reversed.

FIG. 3 — THE HEXAGRAM OF EARTH. The Greater ritual differs from the Lesser chiefly in being worked for one force at a time, and the mechanical consequence is this: there is no fixed order in which the figure is drawn. You begin wherever the planet's point falls, complete that triangle, then take the other. *Liber O* gives one worked example — Jupiter, from the right-hand point of the lower triangle, which is the corner ringed above — and refers the reader elsewhere for the rest of the attributions. This book does not reproduce that table, so the figure marks the position and not the planet.

THE GREATER RITUAL OF THE HEXAGRAM

1. Used to invoke or banish a **planet** or a sign of the zodiac rather than an element. Only the hexagram of Earth is used.
2. Begin tracing from the point of the figure attributed to the planet in question, sunwise, and complete that triangle; then trace the other triangle from its own attributed point and complete it. *Liber O* gives the rule in the form of a single worked example — to invoke Jupiter, begin from the right-hand point of the lower triangle — which is why some later printings state it as though the lower triangle always came first. It does not; the starting point moves with the planet.
3. Trace the astrological sigil of the planet in the centre of the hexagram.
4. For a sign of the zodiac, use the hexagram of the planet that rules the sign, but draw the sigil of the *sign* in the centre rather than the planet's.

The point attributions are those of Crowley's table 777. For which planet governs what, and for choosing the hour, see Chapter 20.

A pentacle of defence

The Solomonic answer to the same problem is an object rather than a rite. Of the forty-four pentacles Mathers prints, one is the exemplary defensive figure, and his description of it is given here exactly as the 1889 first edition has it:

THE FOURTH PENTACLE OF THE MOON

Figure 52. This defendeth thee from all evil sorceries, and from all injury unto soul or body. Its Angel, Sophiel, giveth the knowledge of the virtue of all herbs and stones; and unto whomsoever shall name him, he will procure the knowledge of all.

Editor's Note. The Divine Name Eheieh Asher Eheieh, and the Names of the Angels Yahel and Sophiel. The versicle is: “Let them be confounded who persecute me, and let me not be confounded; let them fear, and not I.”

Two things are worth drawing out. The versicle names persecutors, but every clause of it asks for the bearer’s own preservation — the operation is defensive throughout, which is why it is printed here and most of its neighbours are not. And the angel’s side-gift is characteristic of the whole literature: a figure worn against harm also confers the knowledge of the virtues of herbs and stones, which is to say it opens onto Chapter 20. Nothing in this tradition does only one thing.

For how such a figure is made — the metal, the hour, the colours, the silk — see Chapter 20; for the logic of its rings and names, Chapter 22.

Grounding

The most useful protective skill is also the least ceremonial: the ability to return deliberately to ordinary awareness. Eat something. Wash your hands and face. Put your attention on physical sensation — feet on the floor, weight in the chair. Write down what happened and then stop. Speak to someone about something unrelated.

Practitioners who neglect this are the ones who get into difficulty, and the difficulty is nearly always the same: not an external attack but a failure to fully come back, accumulating over weeks into distraction, poor sleep, and a steadily thinner grip on ordinary priorities. If that is happening, the correct response is to stop practising for a while. That option is always available and using it is not a failure.

MODERN PRACTICE

Most contemporary practitioners use the LBRP or an abbreviated version of it as a daily practice rather than reserving it for ceremonial occasions, which is a departure from its original place in a graded curriculum and generally a productive one — done daily it becomes a reliable frame rather than a special event. Practitioners uncomfortable with the ritual's explicitly Judaeo-Christian content have developed numerous adaptations substituting other divine names or dispensing with them; these work, and their existence is worth knowing about, though the version above is the documented one. The broader modern shift is a demystified reading of what banishing accomplishes: many practitioners now describe it frankly as a psychological boundary-setting technique, and find that describing it that way does not reduce its usefulness in the least.

Sources: Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram — attributed to the original Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (founded 1887–88); a First Order ritual; first printed in Crowley, *Liber O* (1909), then Regardie, *The Tree of Life* (1932) and *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40). The Lesser and Greater Rituals of the Hexagram, the Analysis of the Keyword and the four hexagram forms: Crowley, *Liber O* (1909), section V public domain; the wording of the Analysis and of the hexagram instructions is his. For the sources of the pentagram ritual's components: Graham John Wheeler, "A Microcosm of the Esoteric Revival: The Histories of the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram," *Correspondences: Journal for the Study of Esotericism* 8, no. 1 (2020), 5–44 — open access under CC BY-NC 4.0, which is not the same as public domain. R. A. Gilbert for the argument that Westcott's hand was larger than convention allows. Who assembled the formula, and when, remains unresolved; see the note above.

Healing & Wellness

Healing occupies a central and honourable place in this tradition. It is worth remembering that the Rosicrucian manifestos made it the first practical commitment of the brotherhood they described: each member was sworn to heal the sick *without accepting payment*. Of everything those documents promised, this is the part that has aged best, and it sets the tone for the chapter.

Principles of Hermetic healing

- All healing is understood to come from the divine source; the practitioner does not generate it
- The healer functions as a channel rather than an originator — which is also a safeguard against self-importance
- Healing addresses the whole person: body, mind and spirit, none of them treated in isolation
- Prevention is better than cure, and regimen matters more than intervention

The fourth of these is worth dwelling on, because it is where the historical tradition and modern medicine agree most completely. The Hermetic and Paracelsian writers took sleep, diet, air, exercise, work and companionship to be the substance of health rather than its background. That is an unglamorous position and it was correct.

The historical practice

Historically, healing in this tradition drew on several strands. Herbalism, systematised through the doctrine of correspondences that assigned plants to planets and planets to organs — the material of Agrippa's first book. Astrological medicine, timing treatment by the heavens and reading the chart for constitutional tendency. Amulets and charms, ubiquitous in the ancient evidence: a substantial portion of the Greek Magical Papyri consists of remedies and phylacteries for entirely ordinary complaints, alongside the grander material. Prayer and laying on of hands, the oldest and most widespread element. And Paracelsian iatrochemistry, which took the alchemical tradition into medicine and, for all its errors, moved European practice toward specific remedies for specific conditions.

The physicians of the Rosicrucian legend were, in the setting of the manifestos, ordinary doctors — the healing described was practical care given freely, not miracle-working. That framing is a useful corrective to how the subject is often presented now.

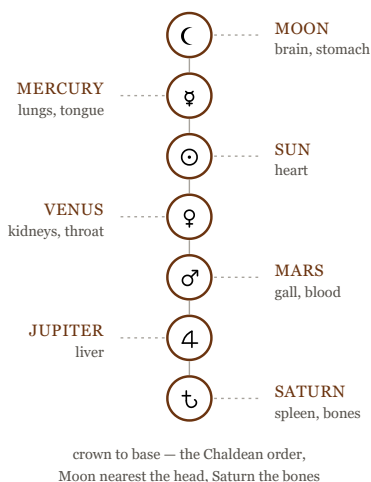


FIG. 1 — THE PLANETARY BODY. The scheme underlying Renaissance astrological medicine: each planet governs organs and functions, so the choice of herb, the timing of treatment and the reading of a chart all belong to one system. The particular assignments vary between authorities — these are the commonest — and the whole framework is a historical one. It is given here because the herbal correspondences of Chapter 20 are unintelligible without it, not as a guide to treating anything. Drawn for this book.

Paracelsus and the signature of things

The figure who did most to shape this material is **Paracelsus** (1493 or 1494–1541), and his contribution was to insist that disease comes from outside and is specific — against the humoral orthodoxy, which held it came from inside and was a matter of balance. From that follows the search for specific remedies, which is the ancestor of pharmacology, and much of the strangeness of the tradition besides.

The strangeness is the *doctrine of signatures*: the belief that a plant's form advertises its use, so that the walnut resembling a brain is good for the head and the lungwort with its spotted leaf is good for the lung. It is an inference from the correspondence principle of Chapter 1 — if the above and the below answer to each other, a thing's appearance should disclose its virtue. As a

research method it is unreliable; as a mnemonic in a world without pharmacopoeias it did real work; and as an illustration of how a metaphysical principle turns into a practice it is the clearest example in this book.

Culpeper, whose planetary herbs are tabulated in Chapter 20, is working inside this system. When he assigns a herb to Mars and an inflammation to Mars, the assignment is the diagnosis and the prescription at once. The system is coherent. It is also, in a great many particular cases, wrong, and the chapter's warning below is not a modern imposition on it — several of its own practitioners said as much.

The vow, and what it was for

Return to the detail this chapter opened with, because it repays attention. The *Fama* requires each brother “to profess nothing but to cure the sick, and that gratis” — and it is worth seeing what that commits them to. A physician who may not charge cannot select patients by their means. The vow is not primarily about generosity; it is a constraint on *whom* the healer may serve, and it removes the mechanism by which medicine sorts itself by wealth.

Of everything the manifestos promised — the invisible college, the universal reformation, the secret tomb — this is the commitment that has aged best, and it is the one that would still be difficult to keep.

Energetic work

Contemporary practice in this area centres on directing attention and intention toward another person, whether by laying on of hands, at a distance, or through visualisation of light. If you do this work, a few things follow from the tradition's own commitments. Ask permission — working on someone without their knowledge violates the ethical position of Chapter 1 whatever the intention behind it. Ground afterwards, as in Chapter 15. Make no diagnostic or prognostic claims. And attend to your own state: practitioners who do this work while depleted tend to make it about themselves.

The still-room: how the medicines were actually made

“Potions” is the storybook word; the historical word is *preparations*, and the tradition wrote them down in exact and practical detail. Culpeper, whose planetary herbs are tabulated in Chapter 20, closes his herbal with a section headed “Directions for making Syrups, Conserves, &c.” — the working end of astrological medicine, addressed “for your instruction-sake, kind countrymen and women.” His three ways of making a syrup are a fair sample of the whole craft:

Syrups made by infusion are usually made of flowers, and of such flowers as soon lose their colour and strength by boiling, as roses, violets, peach flowers, &c. They are thus made: Having picked your flowers clean, to every pound of them add three pounds or three pints, which you will (for it is all one) of spring water, made boiling hot; first put your flowers into a pewter pot, with a cover, and pour the water on them; then shutting the pot, let it stand by the fire, to keep hot twelve hours, and strain it out.

Then syrups by decoction, for roots and barks that can stand the boiling; and syrups by juice, for herbs pressed fresh. Behind those stand the rest of the still-room’s repertoire — conserves, distilled waters, oils, ointments and poultices — each with its own directions in the same plain voice. Two things are worth seeing in this. First, the *method is the timing*: the herb is gathered in its planet’s day and hour, exactly as Chapter 20 prescribes, and the preparation is where that timing was supposed to be captured and kept. Second, there is nothing arcane in the procedure itself — it is kitchen technique, and deliberately so; Culpeper’s whole polemical project was to put medicine into the hands of people who could not pay a physician.

The warning below applies with full force: these are seventeenth-century medical directions reproduced as history. The *form* — infusion, decoction, expression — is simply good extraction technique and is used in every

kitchen; the *uses* Culpeper assigns to the results are pre-modern medicine and are not to be followed against illness.

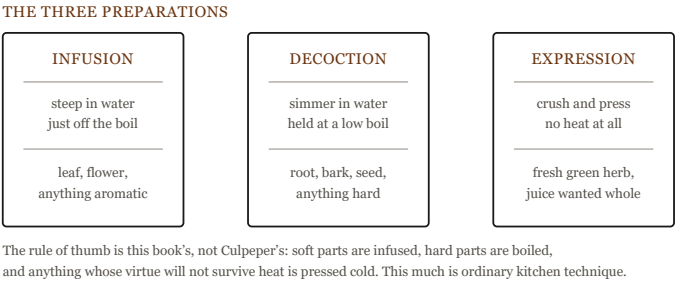


FIG. 2 — THE THREE PREPARATIONS. Culpeper’s regimen below turns on this distinction and assumes the reader already has it. The *method* is sound extraction practice and has not changed; what has changed, entirely, is the seventeenth-century account of what the resulting liquid then does, which is not medicine and is not to be followed as such. Drawn for this book from the distinctions the 1653 text uses throughout.

THE REGIMEN

The oldest and least glamorous practice in the chapter, and the one its sources agree on. It is given as a discipline rather than as medicine.

1. **Sleep, first.** The tradition ranks it before all interventions, and so does the modern evidence.
2. **Air and movement daily**, outdoors where possible. Both are in the classical list of the non-naturals — the things not intrinsic to the body that nonetheless determine its state.
3. **Food as regimen, not event.** The Hermetic and Paracelsian writers treat diet as the substance of health rather than its background.
4. **Work that is yours**, and rest that is genuinely rest.
5. **Company.** Isolation is treated in this literature as a condition to be corrected, not a neutral circumstance.
6. **Review the six weekly**, in writing, and change one thing at a time. The tradition's claim is that the six together are the treatment.

Nothing here is occult, and that is the finding rather than a disappointment. When the sources of this book are read for what they actually recommend most often, this is what comes back.

⚠ On Health and Medicine

Nothing in this chapter is a substitute for medical care. Do not delay diagnosis or treatment, and do not discontinue prescribed medication, in favour of any practice in this book. Do not offer prognoses, discourage anyone from seeing a doctor, or represent spiritual practice as treatment for a serious condition — the historical record of harm here is extensive and it falls hardest on the frightened and the desperate.

Herbal preparations are not exempt from this: plants contain active pharmacology, several traditional remedies are outright toxic, and interactions with prescribed drugs are common and sometimes severe. Consult a physician or pharmacist before combining them with medication, and treat historical herbals as history rather than as dosing guidance.

Used as a complement to proper care — for calm, for meaning, for the considerable value of attentive presence — this material has a real contribution to make. Used as a replacement, it kills people.

MODERN PRACTICE

Responsible contemporary practitioners position this work explicitly as complementary, and many now work alongside conventional care rather than in competition with it — in hospice and chaplaincy settings, in pain management, in support of patients under active treatment. That represents a genuine and fairly recent maturation of the field. Practitioners also now have research literature on placebo effects, therapeutic presence and the measurable value of unhurried attention, which offers a plausible and unembarrassing account of why sitting with a frightened person helps. Where the historical tradition claimed to cure, the honest modern claim is narrower and more defensible: this work can reliably reduce suffering, and it does not treat disease.

Sources: *Fama Fraternitatis* (1614) on healing the sick without payment. Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book I, on herbal and planetary correspondence. PGM for ancient remedies, amulets and phylacteries (Betz, 1986). Paracelsus (1493 or 1494–1541) for iatrochemistry. Nicholas Culpeper, *The Complete Herbal* (1653), “Directions for making Syrups, Conserves, &c.”, quoted verbatim public domain.

Prosperity & Abundance

Prosperity in the Hermetic tradition is not merely material wealth but the sufficiency of all good things — health, wisdom, love, competence, and spiritual growth. That definition is not a euphemism for having less money; it is a claim that money is one good among several and behaves badly when treated as the only one.

Principles of prosperity

- Prosperity follows from alignment with the order of things rather than from force applied against it
- Service to others creates abundance — a claim about how goods actually circulate, not only a moral instruction
- Gratitude reorients attention toward what is present rather than what is absent
- Generosity multiplies prosperity, and hoarding reliably impoverishes the hoarder in the ways that matter

Where this chapter has to be careful

This is the subject on which the tradition has been most thoroughly commercialised, and the dating work of this book bears directly on it. The modern “law of attraction” — the doctrine that thought directly produces material circumstance — is not ancient Hermeticism. It comes from the same New Thought movement of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries that produced *The Kybalion* in 1908, and its lineage runs from there through

twentieth-century positive-thinking literature to the contemporary prosperity-teaching industry. Recognising that lineage is useful, because it explains why the doctrine feels Hermetic while sitting awkwardly with the actual texts.

The ancient Hermetica are not about acquisition. Their concern is the ascent of the soul and the shedding of what binds it — and among the things to be shed, in the *Poimandres*'s account, is greed. A tradition whose foundational vision treats acquisitiveness as an impediment cannot straightforwardly be made into a wealth technique, and the attempt requires quietly dropping most of what the source says.

The practical harm is specific and worth naming. Doctrines that make prosperity a direct product of correct thinking imply, unavoidably, that poverty is a product of incorrect thinking — which blames the poor for structural conditions and lands hardest on people already in difficulty. It is also the mechanism by which a great deal of money is extracted from desperate people by teachers selling the technique. Where a practice in this area asks for significant payment on the promise of return, that is the point to stop.

Where the modern doctrine comes from

The lineage can be dated precisely, which is the most useful thing this chapter can offer. It does not begin in Egypt.

DATE	STEP
1840s–60s	Phineas Quimby’s mental healing in New England — the root of New Thought, and a healing doctrine before it is a wealth doctrine.
1908	<i>The Kybalion</i> , Chicago. Mentalism as the first principle: “The All is Mind; the Universe is Mental.” See Chapter 1.
1910	Wallace D. Wattles, <i>The Science of Getting Rich</i> — the doctrine in its bare form, and the direct ancestor of everything after it.
1937	Napoleon Hill, <i>Think and Grow Rich</i> — the same claim, mass-market.
2006	<i>The Secret</i> , which cites Wattles as its origin and sells the doctrine to a global audience as ancient wisdom.

Wattles is worth reading in his own words rather than paraphrased, because he is admirably unhedged. His first chapter opens: “There is a Science of getting rich, and it is an exact science, like algebra or arithmetic. There are certain laws which govern the process of acquiring riches; once these laws are learned and obeyed by any man, he will get rich with mathematical certainty.”

That is not a claim about attitude or diligence. It is a claim about physical law. And Wattles saw clearly what follows from it, and accepted it. His third chapter is titled “Is Opportunity Monopolized?” and answers itself in its first sentence: “No man is kept poor because opportunity has been taken away from him; because other people have monopolized the wealth, and have put a fence around it.”

Whatever else that is, it is a falsifiable claim about the world, made in 1910, and the twentieth century has not been kind to it. It is also the exact point at which the doctrine becomes cruel: if no one is kept poor by circumstance, then everyone poor is poor by their own thinking. The prosperity industry has never resolved this, because it cannot — the promise and the blame are the same sentence read from two ends.

What the older sources actually say

Set that beside the *Hermetica*. The *Poimandres* describes the soul's ascent through the spheres, and at each sphere it surrenders something: at one, the appetite for increase; at another, the desire to rule; at another, deceit. Acquisitiveness appears in that account as a weight to be put down, not a power to be exercised. The *Asclepius* is bleaker still about a world given over to gain.

This does not make the tradition hostile to competence or to having enough. What it does mean is that a wealth technique cannot be derived from these texts without inverting them. The modern doctrine did not grow out of ancient Hermeticism; it borrowed its vocabulary. That is a specific, checkable claim, and it is the reason this chapter exists.

Practice

What the tradition genuinely supports here is modest and useful. A gratitude practice — the deliberate daily enumeration of what is actually present — reliably shifts attention, and attention shapes judgement. Clarity of intention: writing plainly what you are working toward and what you are prepared to do for it, which is more often revealing than motivating. Regular generosity, fixed in advance rather than decided by mood. And the discipline of examining what you actually want, since a good deal of what presents itself as a desire for money is a desire for security, or standing, or the freedom to stop doing something — all of which have more direct routes.

None of this is a technique for obtaining money without working, and the tradition never claimed otherwise. What it offers is a defensible relationship to material things: enough is a real quantity, it is generally nearer than it appears, and the pursuit of more than enough has a documented history of costing people the other goods on the list.

A PROSPERITY DISCIPLINE, OFFERED AS WHAT IT IS

This is modern, it is this book's own arrangement, and it makes no claim to alter circumstance by thought. It is a discipline of attention, which is the part of the older material that survives translation.

1. **Keep the ledger honestly.** Once a week, write down what came in and what went out. Not a budget — a record. Most of what people believe about their own finances does not survive contact with a written record.
2. **Name sufficiency.** Write the figure that would be *enough*, and the date you last had less than it. The tradition's claim is that prosperity is sufficiency of several goods rather than maximisation of one; that claim is testable against your own ledger.
3. **Give something away weekly** — money, work or time, in an amount fixed in advance rather than by feeling. The tradition holds that goods circulate; whether or not that is metaphysics, it is a check on hoarding.
4. **Note one thing already present.** Aloud, at the same point in the week. Gratitude here is not a technique for acquiring more; it is a correction to the habit of registering only what is absent.
5. **Do the work in front of you.** Wattles's one durable observation, stripped of the metaphysics, is that people who act on present opportunity do better than people who wait for a better one.

Sources: *Corpus Hermeticum* I (*Poimandres*) on the shedding of greed in the soul's ascent. *The Kybalion* (1908) and the New Thought movement as the origin of modern attraction doctrine — cf. Ch. 1.

Seasonal Celebrations

Seasonal observance connects practice to something outside the practitioner's own schedule. The solstices and equinoxes are astronomical facts — the actual turning points of the year, determined by the tilt of the planet — and marking them anchors a practice to a cycle that does not care whether you are enthusiastic this month. That is precisely their value: they arrive on time regardless.

The four solar stations

- **Spring Equinox** (around 20 March in the northern hemisphere) — renewal and new beginnings. Light and dark in balance, with light increasing. Traditionally a point for starting work and for setting intentions that will be tested over the growing season.
- **Summer Solstice** (around 21 June) — the peak of solar energy, the longest day. A point of fullness, and, in most traditional readings, of recognition that fullness is also a turning: the light begins to withdraw from here.
- **Autumn Equinox** (around 22 September) — harvest and gratitude. Balance again, with dark increasing. A point for assessment: what actually came of the year's work, honestly counted.
- **Winter Solstice** (around 21 December) — inner light and contemplation, the longest night. Traditionally the most inward of the four, and the one most widely marked across cultures, since the return of the light after the longest night is the most reliably consoling fact available to people without calendars.

Practitioners in the southern hemisphere should reverse these: the astronomical events are shared but the seasons are not, and observing a “spring” equinox in March in Australia inverts the meaning of the whole cycle. A surprising amount of published material silently assumes the northern hemisphere. Phineas Quimby (1802–66) for the New Thought root; Wallace D. Wattles, *The Science of Getting Rich* (1910) public domain — quoted here from chapters 1 and 3, and the direct ancestor of the modern prosperity literature; Napoleon Hill (1937) and *The Secret* (2006) in copyright, named but not quoted. The weekly discipline above is this book’s own and is not historical.

The cross-quarters

Many practitioners also mark the four traditional British and Irish season-opening quarter days, at the beginning of February, May, August and November: Imbolc (1–2 February), Beltane (1 May), Lughnasadh or Lammas (1 August) and Samhain (1 November). These are conventionally called cross-quarter days, but they are not true midpoints — as Hutton notes, the eight dates form “two equal-armed crosses, imposed on each other in a slightly crooked pattern, some five weeks apart and some seven weeks apart.” Together with the four solar stations they make up the eightfold “Wheel of the Year.”

It should be said plainly that the Wheel as a unified system is a **mid-twentieth-century construction**, and that it was assembled by stages rather than designed in one act. In Wicca the quarter days came first, standing alone in the earliest surviving liturgy of the 1940s; the solstices were added around 1953; the equinoxes only after *Witchcraft Today* went to press in 1954; and the eight reached equal status in early 1958, when Gardner’s coven objected collectively and Gardner gave way — a sequence Ronald Hutton reconstructs from the testimony of four surviving members. Ross Nichols’s Order of Bards, Ovates and Druids is a recipient rather than a co-originator: on Hutton’s account Nichols seceded in 1964 and promptly instituted “the new Wiccan pattern of eight festivals” as one of his Druidic innovations. The often-repeated story that Gardner and Nichols harmonised the calendar together

during a naturist retreat is unsourced, and the reverse claim — that Nichols conceived it first — comes from a rival Druid order rather than from scholarship. The phrase “Wheel of the Year” was in use for the cycle of eight observances by the mid-1960s.

Three of the eight names are later still, and not British. **Yule** is a genuinely old midwinter name, but **Ostara**, **Litha** and **Mabon** were applied to the spring equinox, summer solstice and autumn equinox by the Californian Wiccan Aidan Kelly — by his own account for a “Pagan-Craft” calendar of 1974 — and spread through the magazine *Green Egg*, only entering British Pagan usage in the 1980s. The words themselves are older: Litha and Ostara are Bede’s month-names (Ostara reaching modern usage via Jacob Grimm), and Mabon is Mabon ap Modron of Welsh myth, a derivation Hutton notes British scholars might find “preposterously inappropriate.” What Kelly did was apply existing words, not coin them.

The individual festivals have genuine historical antecedents of varying strength — the Gaelic quarter days are attested, the solstices are astronomical — but the eightfold wheel as a single system is recent, and it is not Hermetic in origin at all. This is worth stating because the Wheel is frequently presented as an unbroken ancient inheritance. It is a good framework, genuinely useful, well balanced, and now the practice of a great many people. It is also about seventy years old. Both things are true and neither needs hiding.

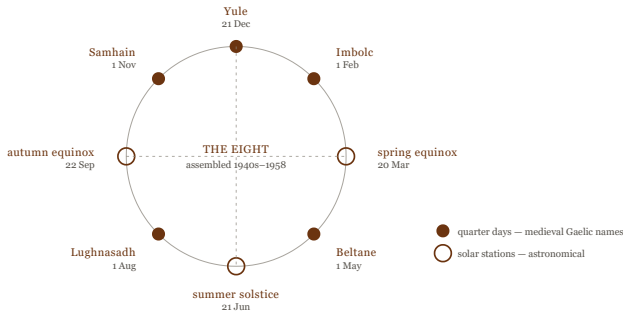


FIG. 1 — THE WHEEL OF THE YEAR. Four solar stations and four quarter days. The geometry is the point: as Ronald Hutton observes, the eight are not evenly spaced but form “two equal-armed crosses, imposed on each other in a slightly crooked pattern, some five weeks apart and some seven weeks apart.” The quarter-day names are medieval Gaelic and genuinely old; the solar stations are astronomical facts. What is modern is the *wheel* — the decision to observe all eight as one cycle, reached by stages between the 1940s and 1958. The names Ostara, Litha and Mabon are not shown, because they were applied to the equinoxes and midsummer in California around 1974. Drawn for this book.

Observance

What to actually do is simple, and the tradition’s own emphasis falls on regularity rather than elaboration. Mark the day. Note where the sun rises and sets, which is the observation the whole system rests on and which almost nobody makes. Review the season that is ending and name what you are carrying into the next. Eat something appropriate to the time of year. If you keep the record recommended in Chapter 7, read back to the previous station — four entries a year, read in sequence, will tell you more about your own development than any amount of daily introspection.

A single structure serves all eight stations, which is the practical advantage of an eightfold wheel over eight unrelated festivals. What changes between them is the question asked, not the form.

AN OBSERVANCE FOR ANY OF THE EIGHT

1. **Observe first.** Go outside near sunrise or sunset and note where on the horizon the sun stands. Write it down. Over a year these notes become the only part of this that is not interpretation.
2. **Open** as in Chapter 8 — the short form is sufficient and appropriate here.
3. **Light** one candle for the season closing and one for the season opening. At the winter solstice, light the second from the first.
4. **Read back** to your record from the previous station. Read it aloud. This is the heart of the practice and it takes five minutes.
5. **Name**, aloud, one thing the closing season completed and one thing it did not. Neither needs to be significant.
6. **Ask the question of the station** (below), and write the answer without editing it.
7. **Eat** something of the season, deliberately, as part of the rite rather than after it.
8. **Close** as in Chapter 8. Extinguish the first candle; let the second burn down safely.

STATION	APPROX. DATE	THE QUESTION
Winter solstice (Yule)	21 Dec	What is worth carrying through the dark?
Imbolc	1–2 Feb	What has begun that is not yet visible?
Spring equinox	20 Mar	Where am I out of balance, and in which direction?
Beltane	1 May	What am I willing to commit to in public?
Summer solstice	21 Jun	What is at its height, and what does that cost?
Lughnasadh (Lammas)	1 Aug	What is ready to be harvested, and what am I refusing to cut?
Autumn equinox	22 Sep	What is finished? Say it plainly.
Samhain	1 Nov	Who and what am I carrying that is no longer here?

The questions are this book's own, not traditional. The dates are for the northern hemisphere; in the southern, the solar stations shift by six months and the quarter days conventionally follow them.

The names *Ostara*, *Litha* and *Mabon* are deliberately absent from that table: as the dating above establishes, they were applied to the solar stations in California in the 1970s. Use them if you like them — many practitioners do, and nothing depends on it — but the solstices and equinoxes had no such names before then, and the table above says only what can be dated.

The deeper purpose of seasonal practice is the correspondence of Chapter 1 put to use: the cycles of the year, of a life, and of the alchemical work of Chapter 5 are held to be the same pattern at different scales. Winter is *nigredo*. Whether one takes that as metaphysics or as metaphor, it is a genuinely steadying thing to have available in February.

Sources: Solstices and equinoxes — astronomical. Ronald Hutton, “Modern Pagan Festivals: A Study in the Nature of Tradition,” *Folklore* 119, no. 3 (2008), 251–74 — for the staged assembly of the cycle (quarter days 1940s, solstices c. 1953, equinoxes after 1954, equal status early 1958), the “two equal-armed crosses” geometry, Nichols’s 1964 adoption, and Aidan Kelly’s application of Ostara, Litha and Mabon in the 1970s. Kelly’s own account dates his calendar to 1974. Ethan Doyle White, *Wicca: History, Belief, and Community in Modern Pagan Witchcraft* (Sussex Academic, 2015), ch. 13. Individual festivals have antecedents of varying documentation; the unified eightfold system does not.

Greater Mysteries

Every tradition in this book claims a summit — a body of knowledge reserved for those who have prepared for it, spoken of in the sources with deliberate reticence. This chapter is about what that reticence has actually meant historically, and what it means for a reader holding a book that claims to contain the whole thing.

The Path of Initiation

The path to the Greater Mysteries, as the tradition describes it, involves:

1. Mastery of the foundational practices
2. Purification of body, mind and spirit
3. Development of the spiritual faculties
4. Service to humanity
5. Direct experience of the divine

Two features of that list deserve notice. It is sequential, and the sequence is not decorative: nothing in the tradition suggests the later items are available to someone who has skipped the earlier. And service sits fourth — before the culmination, not after it. Whatever else the Greater Mysteries were held to be, they were not understood as a private attainment.

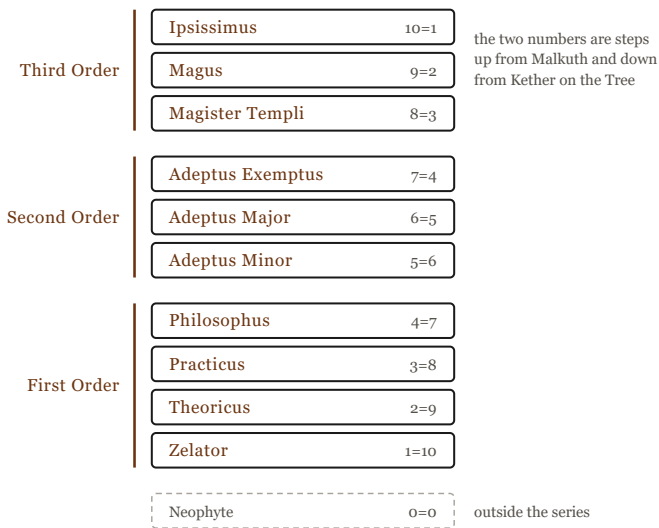


FIG. 1 — THE GRADE LADDER. Ten numbered grades in three tiers, each mapped to a sephirah of the Tree in Chapter 3, with a preliminary Neophyte standing outside the series. The paired numbers are the two ways of counting the same position: steps up from Malkuth, and steps down from Kether — so 5=6 is the sixth sephirah counted either way, Tiphareth. The structure is late nineteenth century, not ancient, and the withholding it encodes is the subject of this chapter. Drawn for this book.

What “mystery” meant

The word carries a specific historical sense that has largely been lost. In the ancient mystery cults — Eleusis, Samothrace, the Mithraic grades — a *mystery* was not a puzzle or a secret doctrine but something *undergone*. The initiate at Eleusis was not told a fact; they were put through an experience, and the prohibition on disclosure concerned that experience rather than any proposition about it. This is why ancient sources can be simultaneously insistent about secrecy and unembarrassed about publishing their philosophy: the philosophy was never the secret.

The Hermetic texts inherit this structure. The *Poimandres* reports a vision rather than arguing a case, and its claim that knowledge of the divine comes through direct experience and not through belief is a statement about method. What cannot be transmitted in writing is not information being withheld; it is an experience that writing cannot contain. Michael Maier, defending the Rosicrucians in 1617, placed their origins in exactly this lineage — “the mysteries of Eleusis and Samothrace, the Magi of Persia, the Pythagoreans” — a genealogy that says more about how the seventeenth century understood itself than about actual descent, but which locates the aspiration accurately.

Lesser and Greater

The distinction in this chapter’s title is not decorative, and it is older than the orders of Chapter 13. In the ancient mystery traditions the Lesser Mysteries and the Greater were separate stages with separate subjects, and G. R. S. Mead, editing the Hermetic sermons in 1906, states the division plainly: the subject of the Lesser Mysteries was *genesis*, birth — and “Rebirth was that of the Greater.”

That single sentence organises the whole subject. The Lesser Mysteries concern how a thing comes to be: cosmology, the descent of the soul, the structure of the world. Those are the subjects of Chapter 2 and Chapter 3, and they can be taught. The Greater concern *palingenesis*, being born again — and the tradition’s consistent claim is that this cannot be taught, only undergone.

Whether one accepts the claim or not, it explains the shape of every institution in this book. A curriculum can deliver the Lesser. The Greater is why the curricula all end in a grade that no examination can confer, and why the literature turns, at exactly that point, from instruction to report.

The rebirth sermon

The Hermetic corpus contains one text devoted to the Greater subject: the thirteenth treatise, on rebirth, addressed by Hermes to his son Tat. It is worth knowing how it proceeds, because it is the tradition’s own account of what

initiation is.

Tat asks to be taught the rebirth. Hermes tells him it cannot be taught in the ordinary way — that it comes when it will, that the one reborn is not the person who asked, and that he himself cannot describe it except by pointing. Then, rather than explain, he leads Tat through the expulsion of a series of tormentors — ignorance, grief, incontinence, greed and the rest — each displaced by an answering power. The instruction is not information. It is a sequence performed until something changes.

The pattern recurs everywhere in this book: the graded curriculum that withholds, the alchemical stages that cannot be hurried, the banishing repeated daily until it becomes a frame rather than an event. This is the same claim in different vocabularies — that certain changes are structural, take time, and cannot be arrived at by being told about them.

The corpus contains one initiation text, and this chapter has named it without letting it speak. *The Secret Sermon on the Mountain* — the thirteenth treatise — is a dialogue in which Hermes brings his son Tat through rebirth, and it is the nearest thing the philosophical Hermetica has to a rite. Its mechanism is worth following exactly, because it is the ancestor of every graded working in this book. Tat is not given a doctrine; he is emptied and refilled. Twelve torments hold the ordinary self — ignorance, sorrow, intemperance, desire, unrighteousness, avarice, error and the rest — and against them Hermes calls in ten Powers, one at a time, each driving out its opposite as it arrives:

Gnosis of God hath come to us, and when this comes, my son, Not-knowing is cast out.

Gnosis of Joy hath come to us, and on its coming, son, Sorrow will flee away to them who give it room. The Power that follows Joy do I invoke, thy Self-control. O Power most sweet! Let us most gladly bid it welcome, son! How with its coming doth it chase Intemperance away!

Now fourth, on Continnence I call, the Power against Desire. ... This step, my son, is Righteousness' firm seat. ... We are made righteous, son, by the departure of Unrighteousness. Power sixth I call to us, — that against Avarice, Sharing-with-all. And now that Avarice is gone, I call on Truth. And Error flees, and Truth is with us.

When the tenth Power has come the arithmetic completes itself — “when the Ten is come, my son, that driveth out the Twelve, the Birth in understanding is complete” — and what has been born is not an opinion but a new subject: “This is, my son, Rebirth — no more to look on things from body’s viewpoint.” Tat asks the obvious question, whether this new body can dissolve as the old one will, and the answer is the sermon’s hinge:

Tat. Tell me, O father: This Body which is made up of the Powers, is it at any time dissolved?

Her. Hush, [son]! Speak not of things impossible, else wilt thou sin and thy Mind’s eye be quenched. The natural body which our sense perceives is far removed from this essential birth. The first must be dissolved, the last can never be; the first must die, the last death cannot touch. Dost thou not know thou hast been born a God, Son of the One, even as I myself?

Three features of this rite deserve carrying into the rest of the book. It is **graded**: the Powers arrive in order and the order is not negotiable, which is the logic every grade system in Chapter 13 inherits. It is **silent**: “be still and solemn silence keep,” Hermes says at the turning point, and the treatise closes

by binding Tat not to broadcast it, “in order that we may not be calumniators of the All unto the multitude” — the withholding this chapter describes, stated by the text itself rather than reported of it. And it is **a death**: the language throughout is of striking a tent and leaving it, and the initiate is told he has already been born a god, in the perfect tense, before he feels any different. Every mystery-grade in this tradition is a rehearsal of that grammar.

Grades and the structure of withholding

The organisational expression of all this is the graded system: the ten Golden Dawn grades of Chapter 13, the Rosicrucian degrees, the Masonic rites. Their logic is pedagogical before it is dramatic. Material is withheld until earlier material has been demonstrated, because the earlier work is what makes the later work legible — and because a technique reached too early tends to be absorbed into whatever the practitioner already wanted to believe.

The systems also functioned, less admirably, as instruments of authority. Grades create hierarchy, hierarchy creates deference, and the history of esoteric orders is substantially a history of schism over who held which grade legitimately. The original Golden Dawn fractured in exactly this manner in 1903, fifteen years after its founding, when Waite and Blackden took possession of Isis-Urania at that spring’s annual meeting. Nothing was dissolved: Waite ran his branch until he closed it in 1914, and the Stella Matutina and Alpha et Omega continued for decades, mostly moribund by the Second World War. A reader encountering claims of high initiatory rank is entitled to notice that such claims have a poor historical record and are unfalsifiable by design.

THE HONEST POSITION OF THIS CHAPTER

A book cannot confer initiation, and this one does not claim to. What has actually happened over the last century is that nearly all of the material formerly reserved to the grades has been published — Regardie's four volumes of Golden Dawn ritual between 1937 and 1940, Mathers's editions of the Solomonic texts, Betz's translation of the Papyri, critical editions of the Hermetica. The secrets are in print. Anyone can read them today.

And the result is instructive: the availability of the material turned out not to be the thing that mattered. What the grade systems supplied was not information but sequence, supervision, and other people who would tell you when you were wrong. Those remain scarce, and they were never in the books to begin with. The genuine Greater Mystery, on the evidence of the century since publication, is that reading the syllabus and doing the work are entirely different activities.

Greater Mysteries Warning

This material is not to be taken lightly. It assumes dedication, preparation and — in every historical setting — guidance. Approach it with respect, and with a working suspicion of your own conclusions. The characteristic failure at this level is not danger but self-deception: the practitioner who has read everything, experienced something, and concluded that they have arrived. The tradition's own remedy is the fourth item on the list above, which is difficult to fake and tends to correct the rest.

Sources: *The Secret Sermon on the Mountain (Corpus Hermeticum XIII)*, quoted from G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes*, vol. II (1906): the calling of the Powers at p. 225 and the exchange on the two bodies at p. 228, both read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *thricegreatesthe02hermuoft*; the Ten driving out the Twelve and “no more to look on things from body’s view-point” are at pp. 226–227 of the same treatise in the scan’s text layer, and are the only words here not read on an image. The square brackets are Mead’s. The first ellipsis marks a lacuna Mead himself flags in a footnote — “something has here evidently fallen out in the text” — and the second omits his fifth Power; both are declared rather than passed over. Ancient mystery cults — Eleusis, Samothrace, Mithraic grades. *Corpus Hermeticum* I on direct experience over belief. Maier, *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617) for the claimed genealogy. Golden Dawn grade structure (1888–1903); Regardie, *The Golden Dawn* (1937–40) for the publication of the reserved material.

Correspondences, Timing & Materials

Everything operative in this book eventually needs three things the earlier chapters have only gestured at: *when* to work, *what to work with*, and *how to make the object*. This chapter supplies them. It draws almost entirely on one source — the *Key of Solomon* in Mathers’s 1889 translation, out of copyright and freely available — because a single coherent system used consistently is worth more than a synthesis assembled from six systems that disagree.

One caution before the tables. Correspondence tables have a way of acquiring an authority they have not earned. As Chapter 3 notes, the elaborate tables in modern handbooks are largely Golden Dawn constructions of the late nineteenth century, and even the older material below varies between manuscripts. These are the attributions of a tradition, recorded and dated. They are not laws of nature, and a practitioner who cannot say where a correspondence comes from is not using a tradition but repeating one.

The planetary hours

This is the oldest and most useful piece of magical timekeeping, and it is genuinely simple once the one counter-intuitive part is understood: **a planetary hour is not sixty minutes.**

The *Key of Solomon* sets out the doctrine directly. The hours of day and night together are twenty-four, and each is governed by one of the seven planets “in regular order, commencing at the highest and descending to the lowest.” The order it gives is the Chaldean order, by apparent speed, slowest first — and it gives the Hebrew names with them:

ORDER	HEBREW	PLANET	METAL	DAY RULED
1	Shabbathai	Saturn	Lead	Saturday
2	Tzedeq	Jupiter	Tin	Thursday
3	Madim	Mars	Iron	Tuesday
4	Shemesh	Sun	Gold	Sunday
5	Nogah	Venus	Copper	Friday
6	Kokav	Mercury	Mixed metal	Wednesday
7	Levanah	Moon	Silver	Monday

The rule of the planets “begins from the dawn at the rising of the Sun on the day which takes its name from such planet,” and each following hour goes to the next planet in the order, returning to the top of the list after the seventh. So on Saturday, Saturn rules the first hour, Jupiter the second, Mars the third, the Sun the fourth, Venus the fifth, Mercury the sixth, the Moon the seventh — and Saturn the eighth, and so on round.

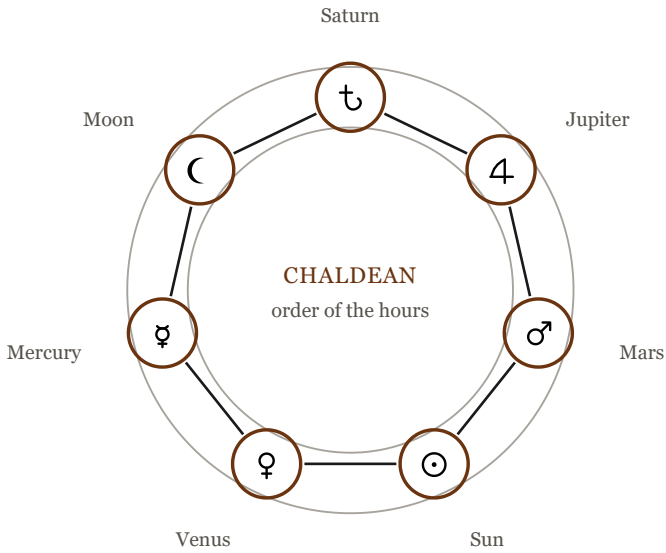


FIG. 1 — THE CHALDEAN ORDER. The seven planets by apparent speed, slowest first, as the *Key of Solomon* gives them. Each hour hands to the next planet clockwise; after the Moon it returns to Saturn. Because 24 is not a multiple of 7, counting twenty-four hours forward lands three places on — which is exactly how the days of the week are ordered. The week and this wheel generate each other. Drawn for this book.

RECKONING THE HOUR

1. Find today's **sunrise and sunset** for your location, and tomorrow's sunrise.
2. **Daylight length** $\div$ **12** = the length of one hour of the day.
Night length $\div$ **12** = one hour of the night. In London in June the day-hour runs to about eighty-two minutes and the night-hour to about thirty-eight; at the equinoxes both are sixty. This is what "unequal hours" means and it is why the reckoning has to be done afresh each time.
3. The **first hour of the day begins at sunrise** and is ruled by the planet of the weekday.
4. Count forward through the Chaldean order, one planet per hour, wrapping round after the Moon.
5. The **first hour of the night begins at sunset** and simply continues the count — hour 13 of the day-and-night sequence.

Worked example. A Wednesday on which the sun rises at 06:00 and sets at 18:00. Daylight is twelve hours, so each day-hour is sixty minutes. Wednesday is Mercury's, so 06:00–07:00 is Mercury; 07:00–08:00 the Moon; 08:00–09:00 Saturn; 09:00–10:00 Jupiter; 10:00–11:00 Mars; 11:00–12:00 the Sun; 12:00–13:00 Venus; and 13:00–14:00 Mercury again. The eighth hour of any day returns to the day's own planet, which is a useful check on your arithmetic.

A consequence worth noticing, because it is the elegant part of the system: count twenty-four hours forward from sunrise on any day and you land on the planet that rules the *next* day of the week, in exactly the order the week actually runs. The seven-day week and the Chaldean order generate each other.

The same rulers, at the scale of ages

The system did not stop at hours and days. In a short tract dedicated to the Emperor Maximilian — *De Septem Secundeis*, “of the seven secondaries, that is, the intelligences or spirits moving the orbs after God” — Johannes Trithemius runs the same seven rulers across history itself. The proem states the scheme in one sentence: the lower world is governed under God by seven spirits set over the seven planets from the beginning of heaven and earth, *quorum unusquisque mundum annis gubernat trecentis quinquaginta quatuor mensibusque ex ordine quaternis* — each of whom in his turn governs the world for three hundred and fifty-four years and four months. The tract then walks the reigns from creation, dated to the day: Orifiel, the spirit of Saturn, rules first; Anael of Venus takes over on the 24th of June in the year of the world 354; Zachariel of Jupiter arrives on the 26th of October in 780; and the rotation continues toward the author’s own century. Two clauses are worth carrying away. *Orifiel autem nomen est officij, non naturae* — Orifiel is the name of an office, not of a nature: even at the scale of world-ages the planetary ruler is a function, exactly as the hour-tables above treat theirs. And the dedication closes with a scruple worth imitating: the doctrine is laid before the Emperor *non asserendo, sed referendo* — not by asserting, but only by reporting. The boldest extension of planetary rulership in the literature arrives marked as a report, not a claim, and that is the spirit in which this chapter passes it on.

What each planet is held to govern

The *Key of Solomon*’s own list, condensed. It is given here as the text gives it, including the parts a modern practitioner will decline to use — the book’s position on those is set out below the table.

PLANET	PROPER TO
Saturn	Summoning the souls of those who died naturally; fortune good or ill to buildings; familiar spirits in sleep; success or failure in business, possessions, goods, seeds and fruits; acquiring learning; and — the text is candid — destruction, death, hatred and discord.
Jupiter	Obtaining honours; acquiring riches; contracting friendships; preserving health; “arriving at all that thou canst desire.”
Mars	War; military honour; courage; overthrowing enemies; and ruin, slaughter, cruelty and discord.
Sun	Temporal wealth, hope, gain, fortune, divination, the favour of princes; dissolving hostility and making friends.
Venus	Forming friendships; kindness and love; “joyous and pleasant undertakings”; travelling.
Mercury	Eloquence and intelligence; promptitude in business; science and divination; apparitions; answers about the future; also thefts, writings, deceit and merchandise.
Moon	Embassies, voyages, envoys, messages, navigation; reconciliation; love; acquiring merchandise by water.

Roughly a fifth of that list is for harming people. The book prints it because a source should be reported as it stands rather than tidied, and because pretending the grimoire tradition was uniformly benign is its own kind of falsification — this is a literature that contains cursing, and Chapter 9 has already shown the same range in the ancient material. The ethical position of Chapter 1 is not suspended for interesting sources. Read those entries; do not work them.

Planetary herbs

The standard English source for this is Nicholas Culpeper’s *The Complete Herbal* of 1653, which assigns nearly every plant it treats to a planet in the opening line of its “Government and virtues” section — “It is an herb of

Mercury,” “under the dominion of the Moon.” Culpeper is worth using rather than a modern table for three reasons: he is out of copyright, he states the attribution for each plant individually so it can be checked, and he is arguing a case rather than reciting one. He was a radical who translated the College of Physicians’ Latin pharmacopoeia into English against their wishes, and the astrology is load-bearing in his medicine, not decorative.

The table below was compiled by reading his attributions directly, plant by plant, and is a selection rather than the whole herbal.

PLANET	HERBS, AS CULPEPER ASSIGNS THEM
Saturn	Comfrey, crosswort, mullein, black hellebore, amaranthus, wintergreen, polypody of the oak, mosses
Jupiter	Agrimony, houseleek (sengreen), liverwort, scurvygrass, samphire, dandelion, costmary, clove gilliflowers, roses, chicory, henbane
Mars	Anemone, masterwort, mustard, hyssop, barberry, sweet basil, carduus benedictus, gentian, madder, all-heal, crowfoot, horseradish, savine
Sun	Angelica, marigold, celandine, saffron, garden rue, peony, centaury, lovage, tormentil, mistletoe, butterbur, holly
Venus	Alkanet, mugwort, daisy, coltsfoot, ground ivy (alehoof), columbine, foxglove, herb Robert, catmint, pennyroyal, parsnip, wood sage, dwarf elder, filipendula
Mercury	Fennel, parsley, horehound, liquorice, sweet marjoram, wild marjoram, calamint, elecampane, eyebright, germander, lily of the valley, wall rue, smallage, pellitory of the wall, honeysuckle
Moon	Chickweed, cleavers, watercress, white lily, water lily, purslane, cucumber, clary, wild clary, coralwort, lady’s smock, water caltrops, rattle grass

Three cautions, and they matter more than the table does.

Culpeper is not always consistent with himself. Plantain, for instance, is assigned to different planets in different places in the herbal, and where his own text disagrees it has been left out above rather than resolved by picking a

favourite. Where other writers disagree with Culpeper — and they frequently do — there is no adjudicating authority. That is a fact about the tradition, not a defect in this table.

These attributions are for ritual correspondence, not for medicine. That distinction is not one Culpeper drew, and it matters here. Several plants in the table are seriously poisonous: black hellebore, henbane, foxglove and savine are all capable of killing an adult, and savine was used as an abortifacient at doses close to lethal ones. Others interact dangerously with prescribed drugs. Use them as symbols, as things to have on the altar or in the incense, and treat any suggestion in a seventeenth-century herbal about taking a plant internally as a historical statement rather than a dosage.

A herb chosen for correspondence is a mnemonic and a focus. It ties a working to a planet, a day, an hour and a metal in a coherent set, and coherence is most of what a correspondence system is for. Nothing in this book claims the plant acts on the working by an occult virtue of its own; the tradition does claim that, and the reader is at liberty to. What is not at liberty is the pharmacology.

Making a talisman

A talisman — the grimoires say *pentacle* or *medal* — is a physical object carrying names, figures or characters, made under specific conditions. The *Key of Solomon* is unambiguous about how much weight it puts on these: “the whole science and understanding of our Key dependeth upon the operation, knowledge, and use of pentacles.”

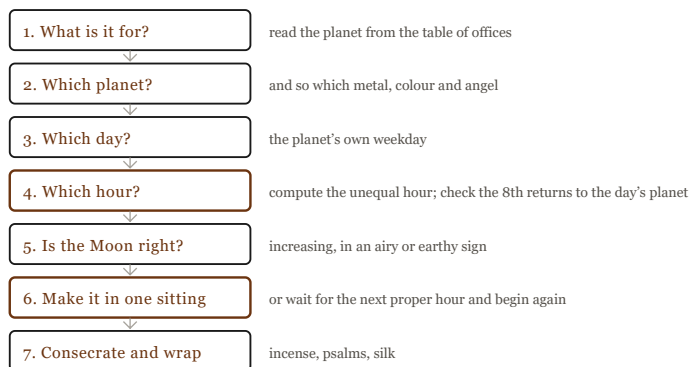


FIG. 2 — MAKING A TALISMAN: THE ORDER OF DECISIONS. Each step is fixed by the one above it, which is why the system feels rigid and is in fact simply arithmetic plus a table. The two highlighted rows are where operations most often fail: the hour is computed wrongly, or the work is broken off and resumed out of hour, which the text says means beginning again. Drawn for this book from the procedure below.

THE PROCEDURE, FROM THE KEY OF SOLOMON

1. **Timing.** Make them “in the days and hours of Mercury, when the Moon is in an aerial or terrestrial sign” — Gemini, Libra or Aquarius; Taurus, Virgo or Capricorn — “she should also be in her increase.”
2. **Place.** A room set apart and newly cleaned, where you will not be interrupted, incensed beforehand. The text asks for a clear sky.
3. **Material.** Either the metal proper to the planet (see the table above), or virgin paper — paper used for nothing else and handled by nobody else.
4. **Colours.** “Gold, cinnabar or vermilion red, and celestial or brilliant azure blue.” Where the metal itself is used, the text says the colour rule need not be observed.
5. **Completion.** Finish within the hour you began in if you possibly can. If you must break off, wait for the proper day and hour to resume — do not simply carry on.
6. **Consecration.** Wrap the finished pentacle in fine silk. Set a censer of charcoal with frankincense, mastic and aloes. Standing in a circle with the names of God written between its two rims, face east and hold the pentacle in the smoke, reciting Psalms 8, 19, 27, 22, 32, 51, 29, 72, 54 and 134.
7. **Keeping.** Keep it in the silk. The tradition treats a consecrated object as spent if it is handled carelessly, which is a practice worth keeping whatever one thinks of the metaphysics.

Two remarks. First, the psalm numbers above are the English numbering; Mathers gives eight of them and the manuscripts give ten, which is a fair illustration of how much a “standard” grimoire text can vary. Second, notice what the procedure actually consists of: a defined material, a defined window, a requirement of unbroken attention, and a rule that a lapse means starting again at the proper time. Whatever else it is doing, it is an unusually well-designed instrument for making a person concentrate.

Incense

The *Key of Solomon* divides perfumes simply — “those which are of sweet odour are for the good, those which are of evil savour are for the evil” — and for the good gives incense, aloes, nutmeg, gum benjamin and musk, with the manuscripts adding saffron, myrrh, costus and nard. Frankincense, mastic and aloes are named for consecrating pentacles.

The fire is kindled fresh, with flint and steel, in a newly glazed earthen vessel, and both fire and spices are blessed before use. For a modern practitioner the durable elements are: charcoal in a heatproof vessel on a stable surface, resins rather than perfumed sticks if you want the historical thing, and a window open. See the safety note in Chapter 8; incense in an unventilated room is a genuine respiratory hazard and the tradition, which worked in larger and draughtier rooms than yours, is no guide here.

Why incense is supposed to work

Every grimoire in this book gives lists of perfumes. Almost none of them says *why* a particular fume should do anything, and the modern literature inherits the lists without the reasoning. One text does explain, and it is worth the detour to reach it.

Sepher Raziel, also called *Liber Salomonis*, survives in an English manuscript of 1564 that ends with the sort of colophon a historian dreams about — it names the scribe, his lodgings, his birthplace, his patron, his patron’s county, and the day:

The booke, entituled Cephar Raziel, contain’g seuen treatises, was written by William Parry of Clyffords Inne by Temple barre in London borne at Northof in the County of Flynt & at the charges of John Gwyne of Llandlos in the county of Mountgomericke Esquire in the year of our lord god a thousand five hunderd threscore & four... Londinij 2^o Nouembris 1564. William Parry.

A London law-clerk copying a book of magic to order for a Welsh gentleman, on the second of November 1564, in the sixth year of Elizabeth. There is no better single illustration in this book of who actually owned these manuscripts. Not hermits: propertied men, who paid someone by the hour.

⚠ Two different books with one name

This is **not** the Hebrew *Sefer Raziel ha-Malakh* first printed at Amsterdam in 1701. That is a separate work. Sloane 3846 belongs to the Latin *Liber Razielis* tradition compiled at the court of Alfonso X in the thirteenth century, and reached English by a different route entirely. The two share a title and an angel and very little else, and conflating them is the single commonest error made about this text. When a modern source cites “the Book of Raziel,” it is worth establishing which one it means before believing anything that follows.

Its third book is a treatise on suffumigation, and rather than opening with a table it opens with a mechanism. Two of them, in fact, and they do not agree with each other:

And euermore consider thou the nature of the spirit & of the fumigacion & the spirits be constrayned by their contrary & be comforted by like things. Wherefore it is to witt that as a wise leche in giueing a medicine to a sick man remoueth the sickenes & in ledeth health. So fumigacion remoueth the contrary from the place if it be good. And with euill fumigacion be remoued good spirits & euill spirits also dreadeth for eich thing more loueth health then sicknes. And therefore it is said that Sulphur remoueth both good spirits & euill. And this is probation & prof [profit] after one way. And there [is] another way for lignum aloes gathereth together the spirits of ligni aloes & none other. And Sulphur chaseth them away & this is very reason.

Unpack that and there are two separate theories sitting side by side. The first is **medical**, and the text says so outright: a fume works as a physician's medicine works, by removing the contrary and leading in health. Spirits are *constrained by their contrary* and *comforted by their like*. On this account incense is a treatment applied to a place.

The second is **selective**, and it is a different claim: *lignum aloes gathereth together the spirits of ligni aloes and none other*. Here a fume does not treat anything. It calls its own and is inert towards everything else, the way a name calls one person out of a crowd. Sulphur is the text's worked example of the difference — it drives off good and evil alike under the first theory, and under the second it summons its own proper spirits, which the text adds are *full stronge & penetrate & thicke* and slow to leave a room.

That is a far more interesting statement than any correspondence table, and it explains something the tables never do: why the sources disagree about whether a given incense is protective or attractive. They are not disagreeing about the substance. They are working from two different accounts of what a fume is, and the manuscript that preserves them both has the honesty to set them down consecutively and call the second *another way*.

WHAT WAS LEFT OUT, AND BY WHOM

Between the two halves of this treatise stand the weekday incense lists and a passage on Hermes' seven manners of sacrifice. The latter is not printed here: two of the seven are blood sacrifice, which this book does not reproduce as procedure. The omission is stated rather than concealed, because a quotation that closes over a gap reads as complete when it is not.

The bracketed words [*profit*] and [*is*] above are the modern transcriber's insertions, not the 1564 scribe's, and are left visible for that reason. The abbreviation *w^{ch}* and spellings like *leche*, *witt* and *eich* are the manuscript's own.

MODERN PRACTICE

Most contemporary practitioners keep the planetary hours and drop nearly everything else in this chapter, and that is a defensible reading of what the system is for. The hours cost nothing but arithmetic — there are calculators everywhere, though doing it by hand once is worth the twenty minutes — and they supply the thing the tradition is really offering: a reason to begin at a particular moment rather than whenever you get round to it. Talismans are made now in paper and ink far more often than in engraved metal, which the text itself permits. And the requirement to finish within the hour, or else wait for the next proper one, turns out to be the single most useful instruction in the chapter for anyone whose difficulty is not belief but consistency.

Sources: *Clavicula Salomonis* (16th c., possibly 15th), trans. S. L. MacGregor Mathers, *The Key of Solomon the King* (London: George Redway, 1889) public domain. Verified against the 1889 first printing (Wellcome b24884431), whose wording for the planetary order is reproduced here exactly. Book I, ch. 2 for the hours, the Chaldean order with its Hebrew names, the day rulerships and the operations proper to each planet; Book I, ch. 8 for the construction of pentacles, their timing, colours, consecration and psalms; Book I, ch. 18 for the planetary metals; Book II, ch. 10 for the incense and the exorcism of fire. Quotations are Mathers's wording. Manuscript variants throughout are recorded in Joseph H. Peterson's edition of that translation. Nicholas Culpeper, *The Complete Herbal* (London, 1653) public domain — the planetary herbs, compiled by reading his "Government and virtues" attributions plant by plant rather than from a secondary table; the selection is this book's, the assignments are his. Johannes Trithemius, *De Septem Secundeis, id est, intelligentiis, sive Spiritibus orbes post Deum moventibus* (Strasbourg: Lazarus Zetzner, 1613, appended to the *Libri Polygraphiae* with its own title page, which describes the text as *ex Archetypo anno 1545 conscriptus*) public domain — read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan [bub_gb_E5TjGI-NlOsC](#): the title page at leaf 684, the proem at leaf 685, and the opening reigns at leaf 686. In the quotations the long s is set as s and æ is expanded to æ; nothing else is altered and no printer's abbreviation is silently expanded. The unequal-hour arithmetic, the worked example and the seasonal questions of Chapter 18 are this book's own; the remaining tables are the sources'. *Sepher Raziel*, called *Liber Salomonis*: British Library, Sloane MS 3846, an English manuscript of 1564 the manuscript text is public domain — the colophon at fol. 128r and the suffumigation doctrine at fols. 142r—143r. Read in Joseph H. Peterson's diplomatic transcription at Esoteric Archives, which is how the text is practically reachable; his introduction, footnotes and bracketed glosses are his own and in copyright, and the two bracketed insertions quoted above are marked as his. This is a witness to the Latin *Liber Razielis* compiled for Alfonso X in the thirteenth century, and is not the Hebrew *Sefer Raziel ha-Malakh* printed at Amsterdam in 1701. Steve Savedow's translation, and the Skinner and Rankine and Don Karr editions of the related Sloane MS 3826, are in copyright and were not used.

Astrology

A horoscope is a map of the sky as it stood over one place at one moment. Planetary hours, planetary metals, planetary herbs and the zodiac are all read off it, and none of them means very much until the map exists: they are the furniture, and the chart is the house they go in. That image belongs to William Lilly, whose *Christian Astrology* of 1647 is the fullest account of the traditional art in English, and it is the argument of this chapter in one sentence.

Two things called a house

First a confusion to clear, because the word does two jobs. Chapter 22 gives the traditional rulerships and says that the Sun and Moon “take one house each” while the other planets take two. That is *house* in the older sense of **domicile** — the sign a planet governs, its home in the zodiac. It is not the sense in which an astrologer says “the seventh house.”

The twelve houses are something else entirely: divisions not of the zodiac but of the sky as seen from one place at one moment, fixed to the horizon rather than to the stars. The signs turn; the houses do not. A planet is in a sign because of where it is in its orbit, and in a house because of where the observer was standing and what time it was. Confusing the two is the commonest error in popular astrology, and the two senses of the word are most of the reason for it.

Lilly, and the book that made English astrology

William Lilly’s *Christian Astrology* of 1647 is the first substantial treatment of the art in English, and it is still the standard reference for the traditional practice because it is exhaustive and because Lilly was working, not

compiling. Its title page divides it into the three things astrology actually does:

The first containing the use of an Ephemeris; the erecting of a Scheam of Heaven; nature of the twelve Signs of the Zodiack, of the Planets; with a most easie Introduction to the whole Art of Astrology. The second, by a most Methodicall way, Instructeth the Student how to Judge or Resolve all manner of Questions contingent unto Man... The third, contains an exact Method, whereby to Judge upon Nativities.

Erect the chart; answer a question; read a life. Those are horary and natal astrology with their common groundwork in front of them, and the division has not changed since.

On the houses Lilly is emphatic, and the sentence is worth having whole:

As before we have said there are twelve Signs, and also twelve Houses of Heaven, so now we are come to relate the nature of these twelve Houses; the exact knowledge whereof is so requisite, that he who shall learne the nature of the Planets and Signes without exact judgment of the Houses, is like an improvident man, that furnisheth himselfe with variety of Household-stuffe, having no place wherein to bestow them.

A man who buys furniture and has no house to put it in. That is precisely the condition of a reader who has this book's tables of planetary correspondence and no chart, and Lilly diagnosed it in 1647.

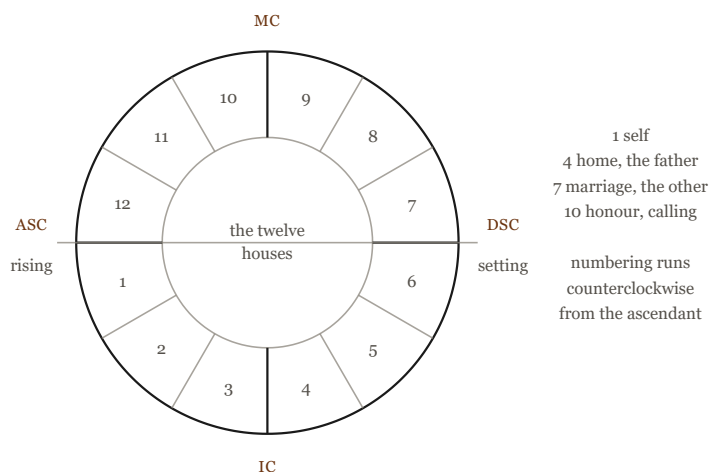


FIG. 1 — THE TWELVE HOUSES. The wheel is the sky from one place at one moment, not the zodiac. The horizon is the line across it: the ASCENDANT is the degree rising in the east, the MIDHEAVEN the highest point, and the numbering runs counterclockwise from the ascendant, beginning below the horizon because that is where the eastern sky has just come from. The four heavier spokes are the angles, and a planet on one of them is at its most consequential. Lilly’s significations for the four are given at the side. Drawn for this book.

Lilly’s claim for the scheme is total, and traditional astrology stands or falls on it: “There is nothing appertaining to the life of man in this world, which in one way or other hath not relation to one of the twelve Houses of Heaven.” Twelve compartments, and everything a life contains goes in one of them.

The twelve houses of heaven

The horary art of Lilly’s era assigns every affair of life to one of twelve houses, and no question can be judged until it has been put in its house. The significations below are the traditional ones of that literature, stated generally rather than quoted — Lilly devotes a chapter to each house, and a reader working horary should read his chapters entire.

HOUSE	TRADITIONAL SIGNIFICATION
1	the querent: body, life, appearance
2	moveable goods, money, what is owned
3	siblings, neighbours, short journeys, letters
4	the father, land and houses, endings, things hidden in the earth
5	children, pleasure, play, ambassadors
6	sickness, servants, small animals, the conditions of labour
7	the other party: marriage, partners, open enemies, the thief
8	death, the partner's goods, legacies, fear
9	long journeys, religion, learning, dreams
10	honour, office, the mother, authority, the outcome of ambition
11	friends, hopes, the resources of the powerful
12	secret enemies, imprisonment, large animals, self-undoing

The aspects

The aspect is the other half of the machinery: the angular distance between two planets, which decides whether they are held to co-operate. Lilly gives them as simple arithmetic on the circle — “When Planets are one hundred and twenty degrees distant, we say they are in a Trine Aspect... When two Planets are one hundred and eighty degrees distant, we call that Aspect an Opposition.”

ASPECT	DEGREES	TRADITIONAL READING
Conjunction	0°	the two act as one, for good or ill according to the planets
Sextile	60°	opportunity, requiring something of the native
Square	90°	obstruction; the classic hard aspect
Trine	120°	ease, and the ease is not always a favour
Opposition	180°	confrontation, or a matter brought to a head

The divisions are the circle cut by two, three, four and six — the same arithmetic as the polygons of Chapter 3, applied to the sky. That is not a coincidence anybody hid; it is why the aspects are the ones they are.

Horary: the question as the moment

The second of Lilly's three books is given to **horary**, and it is the branch least familiar to a modern reader. A horary chart is not cast for a birth. It is cast for *the moment the question was asked*, and read as an answer to that question. Lilly's second book is a long catalogue of worked examples — whether the querent will live long, where a lost thing is, whether a marriage will hold — with the chart for each and his judgment of it.

Whatever one makes of the premise, the method has a property worth noticing: it is **falsifiable in a way natal astrology is not**. A nativity is read against a whole life and can absorb almost any outcome. A horary question has an answer, usually soon, and Lilly published his charts and his judgments together so that a reader could check them. That is a more exposed position than most of the tradition takes.

HOW OLD IS THIS, ACTUALLY

The parts of astrology have very different ages, and the tradition tends to present them as one thing. What can be said briefly: **omen astrology** — celestial events read as signs for a king or a kingdom — is Mesopotamian and ancient. The **horoscope** as this chapter describes it, cast for an individual with an ascendant and twelve houses, is Hellenistic and much later; the machinery in Fig. 1 belongs to the Greek-speaking Mediterranean, not to Babylon. **Ptolemy**, writing in the second century, systematised what he received rather than inventing it. The material then passed through Arabic astronomy and returned to Latin Europe in the twelfth century, and **Lilly** is the end of that line in English, printing in 1647.

Of those stages this edition has consulted Ptolemy and Lilly directly and takes the rest from general reference. The dates are given because the shape matters, and they are flagged here rather than asserted with a citation this book cannot supply.

Seven planets, and why this book keeps it that way

Chapter 22 notes that modern astrology reassigns three of the traditional rulerships to planets Ptolemy could not see, and that the older scheme is used here because everything else in this book predates the telescope. The same holds for the whole chapter. The system described above is the one Lilly practised: seven planets, the traditional rulerships, whole aspects rather than the finer modern set. It is internally consistent, it is what every source in this book means when it says *Mars*, and it has the advantage of being a system somebody actually used rather than a compromise between two.

Sources: William Lilly, *Christian Astrology, modestly treated of in three Books* (London, 1647) public domain — read from the Wellcome Collection copy on the Internet Archive, identifier b30338724. The title page for the threefold division; Book I, ch. VII, “Of the twelve Houses, their Nature and signification,” for the passage on the houses, for the improvident man and his furniture, and for the claim that nothing in a life falls outside the twelve; and Book I for the aspects and their degrees. Long *s* is set as round *s* and the scan’s broken word-spacing is closed up; period spellings — *Household-stuffe*, *Signes*, *Scheam*, *Zodiack* — stand. **Three readings are repaired and declared:** the scan gives *Houles* for *Houses* where the long *s* defeats it, *exa&* for *exact*, and *variety ol* *HoLifholdstuffe* for *variety of Household-stuffe*. The aspect passage is quoted from the same book with *Afped* read as *Aspect* and *Offofition* as *Opposition*. Ptolemy, *Tetrabiblos*, is cited in Chapter 22 for the domiciles and is not requoted here. **The table of aspects, its third column, and the whole of the dating note are this book’s own;** the readings given for each aspect are the common traditional ones and are not any single author’s wording. The observation that horary is more exposed to falsification than natal astrology is this book’s, and is offered as an observation about method and not as a defence of the premise.

Sigils, Seals & Symbols

A sigil is a name or an intention compressed into a line. That is the whole of the idea, and everything else in this chapter is a method for doing the compressing. The tradition has several, of different ages and very different standing, and they are worth keeping apart: some are ancient scripts nobody can read, some are Renaissance number-work, and one is a twentieth-century invention that most people now assume is old.

A caution belongs at the head of this chapter rather than buried in it. The meanings given below are the meanings the tradition assigns. They are conventions — widely shared, long-lived, internally coherent conventions, but conventions. A symbol does not carry its sense the way a stone carries its weight.

How the planetary glyphs are built

The seven planetary signs are not arbitrary marks. They are assembled from three elements, and once that is visible they stop needing to be memorised.

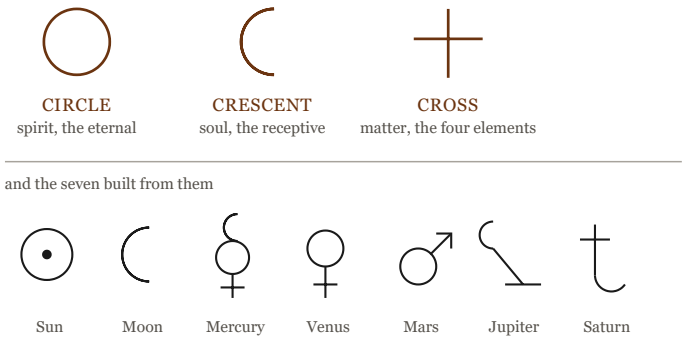


FIG. 1 — THE PARTS, AND THE SEVEN. Circle for spirit, crescent for soul, cross for matter. The Sun is spirit alone with its centre marked; the Moon is soul alone. Mercury is all three — crescent above circle above cross — which is why it is the mediating principle of Chapter 5. Venus is spirit over matter; Mars the same pair with the cross drawn as an arrow. Jupiter and Saturn are crescent and cross in the two possible orders: soul rising from matter, and matter weighing on soul. Drawn for this book; the reading of the parts is the traditional one.

The planets and what they signify

GLYPH	PLANET	SIGNIFIES	METAL	DAY
☉	Sun	the centre, vitality, the self that does not change	gold	Sunday
☾	Moon	reflection, cycle, memory, the tidal part of a life	silver	Monday
☿	Mercury	speech, exchange, crossing between states	mixed metal	Wednesday
♀	Venus	attraction, harmony, what draws things together	copper	Friday
♂	Mars	severance, force, the cut that separates	iron	Tuesday
♃	Jupiter	expansion, mercy, increase and its dangers	tin	Thursday
♄	Saturn	limit, time, structure, the boundary of a thing	lead	Saturday

The metals and the days are the *Key of Solomon*'s, set out with the hours in Chapter 20. The significations are the common stock of the astrological and magical literature and cannot be traced to a single author.

The twelve signs

The zodiac glyphs complete the symbolic alphabet this chapter has been assembling, and they matter operatively: the talisman timing of Chapter 20 is stated in signs (“the Moon in an aerial or terrestrial sign”), and the geomantic figures of Chapter 24 each carry one. Each sign is an element in one of three modes — cardinal beginning, fixed sustaining, mutable dissolving — so the twelve are the four elements of this book run through three phases.

GLYPH	SIGN	ELEMENT	MODE	TRADITIONAL RULER
♈	Aries	fire	cardinal	Mars
♉	Taurus	earth	fixed	Venus
♊	Gemini	air	mutable	Mercury
♋	Cancer	water	cardinal	Moon
♌	Leo	fire	fixed	Sun
♍	Virgo	earth	mutable	Mercury
♎	Libra	air	cardinal	Venus
♏	Scorpio	water	fixed	Mars
♐	Sagittarius	fire	mutable	Jupiter
♑	Capricorn	earth	cardinal	Saturn
♒	Aquarius	air	fixed	Saturn
♓	Pisces	water	mutable	Jupiter

The rulerships are the traditional scheme, from Ptolemy's *Tetrabiblos*: the two luminaries take one house each — the Sun Leo, the Moon Cancer — and each planet takes two, arranged symmetrically outward from the luminaries in Chaldean order. Modern astrology reassigns three of them to planets Ptolemy could not see; the older scheme is used here because everything else in this book predates the telescope.

The elements, the principles and the metals

The alchemical symbols of Chapter 5 work on the same logic of assembly. The four elements are one triangle with one modification:

SIGN	ELEMENT	THE RULE
	Fire	triangle, apex up — ascending, hot and dry
	Water	triangle, apex down — descending, cold and moist
	Air	fire's triangle with a bar — ascending, but bounded
	Earth	water's triangle with a bar — descending, bounded

Two triangles and two bars encode four things and their relations to each other, which is an efficient piece of design and the reason the scheme lasted. Superimpose the fire and water triangles and you have the hexagram of Chapter 3: everything above and everything below, in one figure.

The oldest inscribed amulet

Every seal in this chapter joins a figure to a written name. That marriage is far older than the kameas, and the oldest documented instance is Egyptian: the **heart scarab**, a beetle of green stone carved with a formula and laid on the body of the dead. It is attested from the Twelfth Dynasty to the Roman period — some two thousand years of continuous use for a single amulet type, which no object in the rest of this book approaches.

What makes it belong here rather than in a museum catalogue is that the Egyptian texts state the specification: the material, the finish, the placement, the anointing, and the words to be recited over it. Budge summarises the rubrical direction belonging to the sixty-fourth chapter at page 152 of his first volume, where it stands as a note to a different chapter altogether:

Behold, make a scarab of green stone, wash it with gold and place it in the heart of a man (i.e., the deceased), and it will perform for him the “opening of the mouth”; anoint it with āntu unguent, and recite over it as a charm the following words:— “My heart, my mother; my heart, my mother!” etc.

TWO RUBRICS, ONE SCARAB, AND AN ERROR THE WHOLE LITERATURE REPEATS

Budge prints a second rubric for what is manifestly the same amulet, and the two do not agree. Attached to Chapter XXXB at page 151, from the Papyrus of Amen-ḥetep:

These words are to be said over a scarab of green stone encircled with a band of refined copper and [having] a ring of silver; which shall be placed on the neck of the khu.

And the rubric to Chapter LXIV, translated in full at page 222 — the last page of that volume:

And behold, thou shalt make a scarab of green stone, with a rim plated (?) with gold, which shall be placed in the heart of a man, and it shall perform for him the “opening of the mouth.” And thou shalt anoint it with ānti unguent, and thou shalt recite over it [these] enchantments:—

Same stone, same charm, same opening of the mouth — and then **copper and silver, worn at the neck** against **gold, set in the heart**. Two incompatible specifications for one amulet, in one volume, on facing subjects. This book prints both and adjudicates neither: the disagreement is older than any modern editor and is not resolved by preferring the famous one.

And the famous one is habitually miscited. The wording everybody quotes — *wash it with gold and place it in the heart* — belongs to the rubric of Chapter LXIV, not to Chapter XXXB, which is where secondary writing routinely attaches it. The copper-and-silver rubric is the one that actually stands with the XXXB text.

One smaller thing, recorded because harmonising it would be a small dishonesty: the unguent is *āntu* at page 152 and *ānti* at page 222, in the same printing, for the same word in the same rubric. That is the book

disagreeing with itself, not a transcription slip, and both spellings are given above where they occur.

The formula it introduces — the thirtieth chapter, the one actually inscribed on the amulets — opens as the dead man’s own speech at the weighing of the heart:

My heart my mother, my heart my mother, my heart my coming into being. May there be nothing to resist me at my judgment; may there be no opposition to me from the Tchatcha; may there be no parting of thee from me in the presence of him that keepeth the scales. Thou art my Ka within my body, which knitteth together and strengtheneth my limbs.

Read as a piece of amulet design it is remarkable. The object is addressed to a court — the heart is being asked not to testify against its owner — and the inscription is written in the *first person of the wearer*, to be spoken by someone who cannot speak. That is a solution to a problem no other amulet in this book has to solve, and it is why the scarab carries text at all rather than only a figure.

ON BUDGE, HONESTLY

E. A. Wallis Budge’s translations are the reason most English readers have met this material at all, and they are also, by common consent among Egyptologists, superseded — his grammar predates the decisive advances in the field and his renderings are freely archaizing. They are used here because they are the only versions out of copyright, and the same rule this book applies to Mead applies to Budge: an old translation honestly labelled is better than a modern one paraphrased. Where a word matters, the reader should check a current edition.

Tchatcha, left untranslated above, is Budge’s transliteration of the divine assessors at the judgment — he glosses it elsewhere as the “Chiefs.”

Two more, and what they have in common

The scarab is not the only amulet in this literature that comes with a specification. Two others do, and printing them together shows something neither shows alone.

The first is the **buckle of Isis**, the *tjet*. Its chapter is four lines long, and its rubric is longer than its text:

THE CHAPTER OF A BUCKLE OF CARNELIAN

Saith Osiris Ani, triumphant: “The blood of Isis, the charms of Isis, the power of Isis, are a protection unto me, the chief, and they crush that which I abhor.”

Rubric. This chapter shall be said over a buckle of red jasper (or carnelian) which hath been dipped in water of *ānkham* flowers and inlaid in sycamore wood, and hath been placed on the neck of the shining one. If this chapter be inscribed upon it, it shall become the power of Isis, and it shall protect him; and Horus, the son of Isis, shall rejoice when he seeth it. No way shall be impassable to him, and one hand shall extend unto heaven, and the other unto earth.

The second is the **ṬeṬ of gold**, the pillar. Budge prints its rubric twice, from two different manuscripts, and the versions differ. The one attached to the Nebseni papyrus reads, in his word-for-word rendering:

Shall be said chapter this over a ṬeṬ of gold laid upon a body of sycamore wood, washed in water of ānkham flowers, and placed on the neck of shining one this.

The later recension gives the same object without the flower-water, and adds something no other amulet in the book receives — **a date**: it shall set him in his place *on the day of the new year*. Everywhere else in this literature the amulet is timeless; here alone there is a calendar.

THREE AMULETS WITH A FULL SPECIFICATION			
THE SCARAB		THE BUCKLE	THE TET
the stone	green stone	red jasper	gold
the figure	a beetle	a knot	a pillar
prepared with	ānti unguent (anoined)	water of ānkham flowers	water of ānkham flowers
set in	a rim of gold	sycamore	sycamore
worn	in the heart	on the neck	on the neck
its chapter	XXX ⁹	CLVI	CLV

Two objects with nothing in common as figures are prepared identically. That makes the flower-water a general consecration for amulets, not a detail of one chapter. The scarab is the outlier: it is anoined, not washed.

FIG. 2 — THREE SPECIFICATIONS, COMPARED. These are the only amulets in Budge’s volumes that come with the material, the preparation, the placement and the words all stated together. Reading them in isolation, as the popular literature does, hides the thing the comparison makes obvious: the buckle and the TēT share a consecration — washed in water of ānkham flowers, set in sycamore, worn at the neck — although one is a red stone knot and the other a gold pillar. Compiled for this book from the rubrics quoted above; the rubrics themselves are Budge’s.

THE CONSECRATION IS GENERAL, NOT PARTICULAR

Set the two rubrics side by side and the same three operations appear in both, for two entirely different objects made of two different materials:

- washed or dipped in **water of ānkham flowers**;
- set in **sycamore wood**;
- placed **on the neck** of the shining one.

A red stone knot and a gold pillar have nothing in common as figures, and yet they are prepared identically. That makes the flower-water lustration a *general consecration for amulets* rather than a quirk of one chapter — the Egyptian counterpart of the water and salt of Chapter 8, applied to the object rather than to the room. No popular treatment of either amulet mentions it, because the rubrics are almost never printed with the texts they belong to.

It also explains an error this book made and has corrected. The heart scarab above was said in earlier printings to be anointed with *ankham* unguent. It is not — the scarab takes *āntu* or *ānti* unguent — but *ānkham* is a real ingredient of amulet consecration in exactly this literature, two chapters away, in water rather than in oil. The mistake was not an invention. It was a transplant, which is the harder kind to catch, and it is recorded here rather than quietly fixed because the same slip is available to anyone reading these rubrics out of order.

One further condition in the buckle rubric is worth pausing on, because it is the hinge of this whole chapter: *if this chapter be inscribed upon it*. The stone dipped in flower-water and set in sycamore is not yet the power of Isis. It becomes so when the words are cut into it. Object, preparation and text are three separate requirements, and the third is the one that does the work — which is the same claim the seals below make in a different idiom two and a half thousand years later.

Agrippa's own words

The method of drawing a seal out of a square is usually described from the general literature; it does not need to be. The 1651 English translation is on the Internet Archive in full, as a scan of the Early English Books microfilm — it does not surface on a title search because the identifiers in that collection are machine-generated. What follows is Agrippa's own account, from that printing.

He begins by saying what the tables are, and the answer is not that they are lucky numbers:

It is affirmed by Magicians, that there are certain tables of numbers distributed to the seven planets, which they call the sacred tables of the planets, endowed with many, and very great vertues of the Heavens, in as much as they represent that divine order of Celestiall numbers, impressed upon Celestials by the Idea's of the divine mind, by means of the soul of the world, and the sweet harmony of those Celestiall rayes, signifying according to the proportion of effigies, supercelestiall Intelligencies, which can no other way be expressed, then by the marks of numbers, and Characters.

For materiall numbers, and figures can do nothing in the mysteries of hid things, but representatively by formall numbers, and figures, as they are governed, and informed by intelligencies, and divine numerations, which unite the extreame of the matter, and spirit to the will of the elevated soul, receiving through great affection, by the Celestiall power of the operator, a power from God, applied through the soul of the universe, and observations of Celestiall constellations, to a matter fit for a form, the mediums being disposed by the skill, and industry of Magicians.

Read that second paragraph slowly, because it is the operative theory of this entire chapter in one sentence. **Material numbers and figures can do nothing.** The engraved square is not the agent. What acts is a chain: God,

through the soul of the universe, through the constellations, through the skill of the operator, into a matter made fit to receive a form. The seal is the last link and the least of them. Nothing in the later literature of talismans improves on this as a statement of what a talisman is supposed to be doing, and a great deal of it forgets the sentence entirely.

Then the rule of derivation, given once, for Saturn, and assumed thereafter:

The first of them is assigned to Saturn, and consists of a square of three, containing the particular numbers of nine, and in every line three every way, and through each Diameter making fifteen. Now the whole sum of numbers is forty five. Over this are of Divine names set such names as fill up the numbers with an Intelligency to what is good, with a spirit to what is bad, and out of the same numbers is drawn the seal, or Character of Saturn, and of the spirits thereof, such as we shall beneath ascribe to its table.

Three things follow from those four lines, and together they are the whole system. The names are not chosen for their meaning: they are chosen because their letters *fill up the numbers* of the square. Each planet gets exactly two such names, an Intelligence answering to what is good and a spirit answering to what is bad, and the tradition never explains the pairing further. And the seal is drawn *out of the same numbers*, which is why the tracing method given earlier in this chapter works at all: the figure and the name are two expressions of one arithmetic.

The table Agrippa prints on the facing pages sets the numbers against the names. Here are the first two exactly as page 243 has them, with the numerals in his margin:

PAGE 243, IN AGRIPPA'S OWN SETTING

Divine names answering to the numbers of Saturn.

3. Ab · 9. Hod. · 15. Iah. · 15. Hod. · 45. Jehovah extended.

45. Agiel. The Intelligence of *Saturn*.

45. Zazel. The spirit of *Saturn*.

Divine names answering to the numbers of Jupiter.

4. Abab. · 16. · 16. · 34. El Ab.

136. Johphiel. The Intelligence of *Jupiter*.

136. Hismael. The spirit of *Jupiter*.

Forty-five is the sum of every number in the three-by-three square. Agiel and Zazel are both marked 45, and so is *Jehovah extended* — the divine name, the Intelligence and the spirit all answer to the same total. That is the mechanism, visible on one page.

The remaining five planets are set out in the same form, all on page 243, with the squares and seals following from page 244: **Graphiel** and **Barzabel** for Mars, **Nachiel** and **Sorath** for the Sun, **Hagiel** and **Kedemel** for Venus (with *Bne Seraphim* as “The Intelligencies of *Venus*,” plural, for Venus alone), **Tiriel** and **Taphthartharath** for Mercury, and for the Moon a fuller hierarchy than any other planet receives: **Hasmodai** “the spirit of the *Moon*,” *Schedbarschemoth Schartathan* “the spirit of the spirits of the *Moon*,” and *Malcha betharsisim hed beruah schehalim* “The Intelligency of the Intelligence of the *Moon*” — the 1651 page’s own descriptors, singular and plural exactly as set there.

⚠ How much of this was actually read

Pages 239, 243 and 244 of the 1651 printing were opened as page images and read directly: the two blockquotes, the Saturn and Jupiter panel, and every name-form above come from the leaves themselves, down to the page's "Iupiter" and its singular "Intelligency." The scan's text layer is no help here and was not relied on: the long *s* defeats it constantly, and it renders *tables* as "caoles," *Idea's* as "1des's," *divine order* as "Tine order," *Agiel* as "Agicl" and *Graphiel* as "Grzphicl." The 3×3 square of Saturn in Fig. 3 stands in the same orientation the 1651 page prints, rows 4·9·2, 3·5·7, 8·1·6.

Paracelsus disagrees, and first attacks the field

Agrippa indexes everything to the planets. That is so nearly universal in the later literature that it is easy to take for the only system there is. It was not, and the dissent comes from the most famous physician of the century.

Before Paracelsus will give a character at all, he clears the ground, and the passage could serve as an epigraph for this book. He is describing the characters other practitioners draw:

There are many such-kinde of words found amongst them, which have no affinity at all with the Idioms of the Latine, Greek, or Hebrew Tongues, neither with any other; which cannot possibly be interpreted by any man, nor rendred into any other Tongue. Therefore I speak not without cause, and say, That we are not to credit all Letters, Characters or Words, but to keep to those onely which are true, and have been often proved, and taken out of the Foundation of Truth.

A sixteenth-century magical writer applying source-criticism to magical signs, on the ground that a word belonging to no known language and interpretable by nobody is not thereby profound. He is even unimpressed by novelty as a

selling point, noting drily that such characters are said to be *found out and devised by themselves*. Set that beside the *voces magicæ* of Chapter 9, where the untranslatable name is precisely the point, and you have two coherent and irreconcilable views of what an unintelligible word is for.

Having cleared the field he prints two, and only two:

Two Triangular Figures, cutting one another thorow with a cross, are so painted or engraven, that they do include and divide themselves into seven spaces within, and do make six corners outwardly, wherein are written six wonderful Letters of the great Name of God, to wit, Adonaj, according to their true order.

There is another which excelleth the former in power and virtue, and this hath three Hooks cutting one another through by a cross, and are so delineated, that by their mutual intersection they include six spaces, and outwardly five angles, wherein are written five syllables of the supream name of God; to wit, Tetragrammaton, also according to their true order.

I would have put down the Figures themselves; but because you may happily finde them in many other places and Books, I have the rather omitted them.

The first is a hexagram, described by construction rather than named: two triangles crossed, seven interior spaces, six outward points, one letter of ADONAY to each point. The second is a five-angled figure carrying the five syllables of *Te-tra-gram-ma-ton*. In both, the geometry comes first and the Name is then distributed into the compartments *according to their true order* — the figure is a container with a fixed number of places, and the name has to fit it.

And then the sentence that has frustrated readers for four centuries: he does not draw them, because you can find them elsewhere. It is worth noticing that this is the same instinct that produced the passage above. He will not print a figure to pad a book.

TWO AUTHORITIES, TWO INDEXES, ONE OPERATION

This is where Paracelsus and Agrippa come apart, and the difference is not cosmetic.

Agrippa indexes to the *planets*. Seven squares, and from each square an Intelligence and a spirit whose letters fill the same numbers — Agiel and Zazel at forty-five, and so on. The arithmetic of the square generates the names and the seal alike.

Paracelsus indexes to the *divine name*. His two chief characters are not planetary at all; they are geometric vessels sized to hold ADONAY and Tetragrammaton, and the count that matters is the count of syllables and points, not a magic sum. Where he does give a set of seals in series, in his treatise on the signs of the zodiac, they are keyed to the *parts of the body* each sign rules, and the planets enter only as election and metal.

So the two great sixteenth-century authorities on talismans disagree about what a seal is filed under. This book prints the divergence instead of merging them, because merging them is what produced the modern impression of a single unified “system of planetary seals” that no source actually states.

What the two men do agree on is the thing that matters most, and Paracelsus states it as a rule of concurrence:

Characters, Letters, and Signes, &c. have several virtues and operations; wherewith also the nature of Metals, the condition of Heaven, and the influence of the Planets, with their operations, and the significations and proprieties of Characters, Signes, and Letters, and the observation of the times, do concur and agree together... but every one is to be prepared in his own proper time, and helpeth such and such infirmities, and no other; as drink is to be taken within the body, and not otherwise.

Four things must concur: the metal, the state of the heavens, the planetary influence, and the election of the time. Miss one and you have an ornament. That is Agrippa's chain of causes restated by a physician, and it is the reason Chapter 20 spends as long as it does on the hour. The analogy at the end is characteristically blunt: a seal made in the wrong hour fails the way medicine fails when it is not swallowed.

What became of that book

Agrippa's Book II is the source of nearly every planetary square, intelligence and spirit-name in circulation, and it reached most later readers through an intermediary rather than directly. The intermediary is worth meeting, because the way it handled its source is a lesson in exactly what this book is for.

In 1801 Francis Barrett published *The Magus, or Celestial Intelligencer* in London, for Lackington, Allen and Co. of the Temple of the Muses. Its title page describes the contents and then makes a claim:

Forming a complete system of delightful knowledge and abstruse science; such as is warranted never before to have been published in the English Language.

Here is how Barrett's Part II opens, in his chapter on the four elements:

Therefore, there are four elements, the original grounds of all corporeal things, viz. fire, earth, water, and air, of which elements all inferior bodies are compounded; not by way of being heaped up together, but by transmutation and union; and when they are destroyed, they are resolved into elements.

And here is Agrippa, in the English of 1651 — a hundred and fifty years before Barrett went to press:

There are four Elements, and originall grounds of all corporeall things, Fire, Earth, Water, Aire, of which all elementated inferiour bodies are compounded; not by way of heaping them up together, but by transmutation, and union; and when they are destroyed, they are resolved into Elements.

It is the same sentence. It continues being the same sentence: earth dissolved becomes water, made thick becomes earth again, evaporated passes into air, kindled into fire, cooled after burning becomes earth or stone or sulphur, and this is shown by lightning. Fire hot and dry, earth cold and dry, water cold and moist, air hot and moist. The Stoics called the heavy elements passives and the light ones actives. Plato distinguished them another way and assigned three qualities to each. Barrett follows Agrippa clause for clause, in order, with the spelling modernised and the occasional word turned round — Agrippa's earth *becoming dirty* becomes Barrett's earth *being moistened* — and no acknowledgement anywhere on the page.

WHY THIS IS IN THE BOOK AND NOT IN A FOOTNOTE

Barrett is not a villain and *The Magus* is not worthless. It is handsomely engraved, it gathered scattered material into one place, and it is the channel through which the nineteenth-century revival — and therefore the Golden Dawn, and therefore most of Chapter 13 — received this tradition at all. A great deal of what a modern practitioner takes for ancient magic arrives by way of a compilation printed in the year Nelson took Copenhagen.

But set the title page against the text. *Never before published in the English Language*, printed over a chapter that had been available in English since 1651. That is the mechanism this whole book exists to make visible, caught in one volume: material is transmitted, the transmitter's name replaces the source's, and within a generation the compilation *is* the tradition. It is the same movement that turned a New Thought pamphlet of 1908 into the Seven Hermetic Principles (Chapter 1), and a 1610 Tübingen jeu d'esprit into an ancient brotherhood (Chapter 12).

The reader can check this one personally, which is the point of printing both passages. Both editions are free, both are scanned, and the parallel runs for pages.

Seals from the squares

The most systematic sigil method in the Western tradition is Renaissance, and it is arithmetic. Each planet is assigned a *kamea* — a magic square whose rows, columns and diagonals all sum alike — of a size matching the planet's order in the Chaldean sequence: Saturn 3×3, Jupiter 4×4, Mars 5×5, Sun 6×6, Venus 7×7, Mercury 8×8, Moon 9×9. The scheme is set out in Agrippa's *De occulta philosophia*, Book II, in the chapter titled “Of the tables of the Planets, their virtues, forms, and what Divine names, Intelligencies, and Spirits are set over them.”

THE SQUARE OF SATURN			READING IT
4	9	2	Every row, column and diagonal sums to 15 ; the whole square sums to 45. This is the only 3×3 magic square that exists, up to rotation and reflection — a mathematical fact, not a magical claim, and one reason the figure impressed people who met it.
3	5	7	
8	1	6	

TRACING A SEAL ON A KAMEA

1. **Choose the planet** whose nature suits the work, from the table above.
2. **Write the name** — of the intelligence, the spirit, or the intention — in Hebrew letters, and take each letter's numerical value.
3. **Reduce each value** to fall within the square: for the 3×3 of Saturn, values run 1 to 9, so 300 becomes 3 and 40 becomes 4. The conventions for reducing differ between authorities, and this is where two practitioners working “the same” method get different figures.
4. **Mark the first number** on the square with a small circle, then draw a line to the cell of the next number, and so on to the last, ending with a short bar.
5. **The resulting figure is the seal.** It is drawn on the metal or the paper of Chapter 20, in the planet's hour.

What the method actually does is turn a word into a path. Nothing about the line is arbitrary once the name and the square are fixed — but nothing about it is inevitable either, since the reduction rules are conventions.

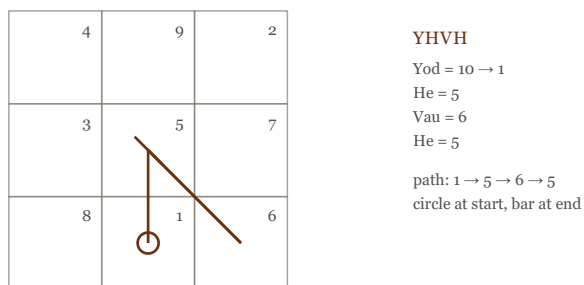


FIG. 3 — A SEAL TRACED ON THE SQUARE OF SATURN. The worked example the method above describes: the name YHVH, letter values 10, 5, 6, 5, the 10 reduced to 1 to fall within a square of nine cells. A circle marks the first number, the line visits each in turn, a bar closes the last — the doubled He simply returns the line to the cell it left. A different reduction convention would give a different figure from the same name, which is the point made above: the seal is determined by the name, the square *and* the convention. Drawn for this book; the arithmetic is checkable against the square.

Signs nobody can read

Against all that stands the oldest layer, the *charaktères* of Chapter 9: letter-like shapes with small rings at their terminals, thick through the magical papyri and the curse tablets, and not decipherable. They are not a cipher for words, they encode no name, and no key has ever been found — which makes them the honest limit of a chapter about meanings. Some signs in this tradition mean something. Some are older than the traditions that explain them, and the explanations came later.

Between the two sits **John Dee's *Monas Hieroglyphica*** (Antwerp, 1564), a single composed glyph — Moon, Sun, cross and the sign of Aries stacked into one figure — about which Dee wrote a whole book of theorems. It is the most ambitious sigil in the tradition: an attempt to compress the entire cosmos into one mark, made by a man who thought the compression would be legible to anyone who understood it. Almost nobody has.

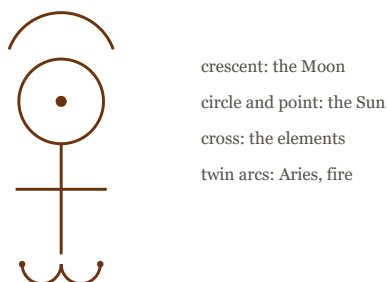


FIG. 4 — THE MONAS, REDRAWN. Dee’s glyph assembled from the parts this chapter has already given: the Moon’s crescent, the Sun’s circle and point, the elemental cross, and the sign of Aries — fire — as its base. Dee’s claim, argued through twenty-four theorems, was that the whole cosmos could be read out of this one construction. Redrawn for this book from the elements of the figure; the 1564 engraving sets it in an egg-shaped frame not reproduced here.

MODERN PRACTICE

The method most people now mean by “sigil magic” is none of the above. It was set out by the artist **Austin Osman Spare** in the early twentieth century: write the intention as a sentence, strike out repeated letters, and combine what remains into a single abstract figure, which is then charged and deliberately forgotten. It is elegant, it works on its own terms, and it is about a hundred years old — not medieval, not Solomonic, and owing nothing to the kameas. It is included here because it is what a reader is most likely to encounter, and because a book that dates the Kybalion ought to date this too. Spare died in 1956, so his own writings remain in copyright; the method is described here rather than quoted.

Sources: The construction of the planetary glyphs from circle, crescent and cross is the traditional reading, and is not attributable to a single author. Planetary metals and days: *Clavicula Salomonis*, trans. Mathers (1889), Book I, chs. 2 and 18 public domain. The kameas and the seal-tracing method: Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia* (1533), Book II, chs. XXII—XXIII, in the English of “J.F.” (probably John French), *Three Books of Occult Philosophy* (London: printed by R.W. for Gregory Moule, 1651), pp. 239 and 243 public domain — from the Early English Books scan on the Internet Archive. Francis Barrett, *The Magus, or Celestial Intelligencer* (London: printed for Lackington, Allen and Co., 1801) public domain — the title page and Part II, ch. I, from the Wellcome Collection copy b22006795. The parallel with Agrippa Book I, ch. III was made by setting the two texts side by side for this edition, not taken from a secondary account; the reader can repeat it, since both scans are free. Paracelsus: *Paracelsus Of the Supreme Mysteries of Nature*, Englished by R. Turner (London: printed by J. C. for N. Brooks and J. Harison, 1656) public domain — the polemic on false characters and the two true characters in “Of Occult Philosophy” at pp. 40—42, and the rule of concurrence in the Prologue to “Of the Mysteries of the Signes of the Zodiack” at pp. 94—95. The title *Archidoxes of Magic*, under which this text usually circulates, is not on the 1656 sheets: it belongs to the twentieth-century reprints, which are in copyright. Note that the 1975 and 1998 reprints of Barrett carry their own editorial matter and are not public domain; the 1801 sheets are. The 3×3 square and its uniqueness are mathematical. The zodiacal rulerships: Ptolemy, *Tetrabiblos* I.17 (domiciles), in the traditional pre-telescopic scheme; the element and mode assignments are the standard ones and predate no single author. The seal-trace worked example and the reduction of 10 to 1 follow the method stated above; other reduction conventions exist and give other figures. *Charaktères*: see Chapter 9. Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (Antwerp: Willem Silvius, 31 March 1564) public domain. The heart scarab: E. A. Wallis Budge, *The Book of the Dead: An English Translation of the Chapters, Hymns, etc., of the Theban Recension*, vol. I (Chicago: Open Court / London: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trübner, 1901) public domain — the rubrical direction to ch. LXIV as Budge summarises it at p. 152, the rubric to ch. XXXB at p. 151, and the rubric to ch. LXIV translated in full at p. 222. Budge’s chapter numbering follows Lepsius and Naville and does not map onto modern spell numbers, so “Chapter LXIV” here is a reference to him and not to the Egyptian. The buckle and the ȚȚ: E. A. Wallis Budge, *The Book of the Dead. The Papyrus of Ani in the British Museum* (London: printed by order of the Trustees, 1895) public domain — chapters CLV and CLVI with their rubrics in the Appendix to Plate XXXIII, and the Nebseni rubric for the ȚȚ in the interlinear at p. 226 n. 1. Budge renders the same rubric differently in his interlinear and his running translation within this one volume, and the wording above is the running translation except where the Nebseni rubric is quoted — the rubric to ch. LXIV and the

opening of ch. XXX as printed there; Budge's translations are superseded scholarship and are used because they are the only ones out of copyright. Austin Osman Spare (1886–1956) in copyright — method described, not quoted.

Talismanic & Astral-Image Magic

A talisman is two things joined: **an image, and a moment**. The figure comes from the seals and sigils of Chapter 22, the timing from the planetary days and hours of Chapter 20, and the tradition's claim is that together they do what neither does alone: a figure cut at the right moment takes an impression from the sky, the way wax takes one from a seal. This chapter sets out the machinery that claim needs — and the large hole in the middle of its literature.

Three ways to cut the same circle

Astral-image magic needs the sky divided, and it inherited three divisions that do not agree. The twelve **signs** of thirty degrees are familiar. The thirty-six **faces** or decans of ten degrees each divide the signs evenly, three to a sign, and govern the demon-lists of Chapter 10. The twenty-eight **mansions of the Moon** do not divide the signs at all, and that is the interesting part.

Agrippa gives the reason and the arithmetic together. The Moon “measureth the whole Zodiack in the space of twenty eight dayes,” so the circle is cut into twenty-eight, and each mansion “containeth twelve degrees, and one and fifty minutes, and almost twenty six seconds.”

That figure is worth checking, because it is exact. Twelve degrees fifty-one minutes and about twenty-six seconds is 360 divided by 28, to the second. Agrippa is not approximating a tradition; he is reporting a division of the circle, and the boundaries he then lists confirm it — the second mansion begins at twelve degrees fifty-one minutes twenty-two seconds of Aries, the third at twenty-five degrees forty-two minutes fifty-one seconds, the fourth at eight degrees thirty-four minutes seventeen seconds of *Taurus*. The mansions walk straight through the signs without stopping at them.

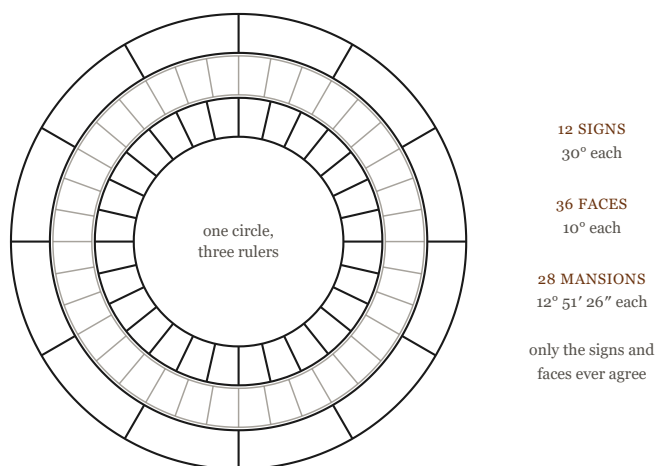


FIG. 1 — THREE RULERS LAID ON ONE CIRCLE. Twelve signs, thirty-six faces and twenty-eight mansions, drawn to scale. The faces nest inside the signs exactly, three to each. The mansions do not nest inside anything: at twelve degrees fifty-one minutes and twenty-six seconds apiece they cross every boundary the other two rulers make, which is why a mansion is always given as a degree within a sign and never as a part of one. Drawn for this book.

The twenty-eight, entire

A chapter that names the mansions and does not list them is no use to anybody, so here they are: all twenty-eight as the 1651 English gives them, with the alternative names it records, what each name means, and the virtues attributed to each. Agrippa opens the chapter with the arithmetic and its authorities — the Moon measures the whole zodiac in twenty-eight days, so “the wise-men of the *Indians* and ancientest Astrologians have granted twenty eight Mansions to the Moon, which being fixed in the eight sphere, do enjoy (as *Alpharus* saith) diverse names and proprieties from the diverse Signs and Stars which are contained in them” — and gives each mansion a span of “twelve degrees, and one and fifty minutes, and almost twenty six seconds” on the authority of *Abraham*. He states the exact beginning for the first seven and

then says the rest follow “in the like order and number of degrees, minutes and seconds”; the Begins column therefore carries a figure only where he prints one, and a dash where the reader is to continue the count.

#	NAME, AS AGRIPPA GIVES IT	MEANING	BEGINS	VIRTUES
1	Alnath	the horns of Aries	0° Aries	causeth discords, and journies
2	Allothaim <i>or</i> Albochan	the belly of Aries	12° 51' 22" Aries	conduceth to the finding of treasures, and to the retaining of captives
3	Achaomazon <i>or</i> Athoray	showring, or Pleiades	25° 42' 51" Aries	profitable to Saylers, Huntsmen, and Alchymists
4	Aldebaram <i>or</i> Aldelamen	the eye or head of Taurus	8° 34' 17" Taurus	causeth the destruction and hindrances of buildings, fountains, wels, of gold-mines, the flight of creeping things, and begetteth discord
5	Alchatay <i>or</i> Albachay	—	21° 25' 40" Taurus	helpeth to the return from a journey, to the instruction of scholars, it confirmeth edifices, it giveth health and good will
6	Alhanna <i>or</i> Alchaya	the little Star of great light	4° 17' 9" Gemini	conduceth to Hunting, and besieging of Towns, and revenge of princes; it destroyeth Harvests and fruits, and hindreth the operation of the Physitian
7	Aldimiach <i>or</i> Alarzach	the Arm of Gemini	17° 8' 34" Gemini	conferreth gain and friendship, its profitable to Lovers, it scareth flies, destroyeth Magisteries

#	NAME, AS AGRIPPA GIVES IT	MEANING	BEGINS	VIRTUES
8	Alnaza <i>or</i> Anatrachya	misty or cloudy	0° Cancer	causeth love, friendship, and society of fellow travellers; it driveth away mice and afflicteth Captives, confirming their imprisonment
9	Archaam <i>or</i> Arcaph	the eye of the Lyon	—	hindreth Harvests and travellers, and putteth discord between men
10	Algelioche <i>or</i> Albgebh	the neck or forehead of Leo	—	strengtheneth buildings, yeeldeth love, benevolence and help against enemies
11	Azobra <i>or</i> Ardaf	the hair of the Lyons head	—	good for voyages, and gain by merchandize, and for redemption of Captives
12	Alzarpha <i>or</i> Azarpha	the tayle of Leo	—	giveth prosperity to Harvests and Plantations, but hindreth Seamen; good for the bettering of servants, Captives and companions
13	Alhaire	Dogstars, or the wings of Virgo	—	pravalent for Benevolence, gain, voyages, Harvests, and freedom of captives
14	Achureth <i>or</i> Arimet, Azimeth, Alhumech, Alcheymech	the spike of Virgo, or flying spike	—	causeth the love of married folk, it cureth the sick, its profitable to Saylor, but it hindreth journies by land

#	NAME, AS AGRIPPA GIVES IT	MEANING	BEGINS	VIRTUES
15	Agrapha <i>or</i> Algarpha	covered, or covered flying	0° Libra	profitable for the extracting of treasures, for digging of pits; it helpeth forward divorce, discord, and the destruction of houses and enemies, and hindreth travellers
16	Azubene <i>or</i> Ahubene	the Horns of Scorpio	—	hindereth journeyes and Wedlock, Harvests and Merchandize; it prevaieth for redemption of captives
17	Alchil	the Crown of Scorpio	—	bettereth a bad fortune, maketh love durable, strengtheneth buildings, and helpeth Seamen
18	Alchas <i>or</i> Altob	the Heart of Scorpio	—	causeth discord, sedition, conspiracy against princes and mighty ones, and revenge from enemies; but it freeth captives and helpeth edifices
19	Allatha <i>or</i> Achala, Hycula, Axala	the tayle of Scorpio	—	helpeth in the besieging of Cities and taking of Towns, and in the driving of men from their places, and for the destruction of Seamen, and perdition of captives
20	Abnahaya	a beam	—	helpeth for the taming of wild beasts, for the strengthening of prisons; it destroyeth the wealth of societies, it compelleth a man to come to a certain place
21	Abeda <i>or</i> Albeldach	a desert	—	good for Harvests, gain, buildings and travellers, and causeth divorce

#	NAME, AS AGRIPPA GIVES IT	MEANING	BEGINS	VIRTUES
22	Sadahacha <i>or</i> Zodeboluch, Zandeldena	a pastour	0° Capricorn	promoteth the flight of servants and captives, that they may escape, and helpeth the curing of diseases
23	Zabadola <i>or</i> Zobrach	swallowing	—	maketh for divorce, liberty of captives, and the health of the sick
24	Sadabath <i>or</i> Chadezoad	the Star of fortune	—	prevalent for the Benevolence of married folk, for the victory of souldiers; it hurteth the execution of Government, and hindreth that it may not be exercised
25	Sadalabra <i>or</i> Sadalachia	a Butterfly, or a spreading forth	—	helpeth besieging and revenge, it destroyeth enemies, maketh divorce, confirmeth prisons and buildings, hasteneth messengers; it conduceth to spels against copulation, and so bindeth every member of man, that it cannot perform his duty
26	Alpharg <i>or</i> Phragh Mocaden	the first drawing	—	maketh for the Union and love of men, for the health of captives; it destroyeth prisons and buildings
27	Alcharya <i>or</i> Alhalgalmoad	the second drawing	—	encreaseth Harvests, Revenues, Gain; it healeth infirmities, but hindreth buildings, prolongeth prisons, causeth danger to Seamen, and helpeth to infer mischiefs on whom you shall please

Read the virtues column as a whole and the character of the system shows: these are not blessings and curses but *windows*, each opening on a mixed set of affairs — the same mansion that frees captives strengthens prisons, the one that helps harvests hinders seamen. Captives, buildings, journeys, harvests, marriage and merchandise recur through all twenty-eight, which is a fair portrait of what the people consulting this system actually worried about. Agrippa closes the chapter by pointing beyond it: “in these twenty eight Mansions do lye hid many secrets of the wisdom of the Ancients, by the which they wrought wonders on all things which are under the circle of the Moon; and they attributed to every Mansion his resemblances, Images, and seals, and his president intelligences.” The images he means are the ones this chapter gives above.

What the mansions were for

The virtues Agrippa assigns are startlingly concrete, and reading a few in a row tells you more about the practice than any description of it. The first mansion, *Alnath*, the horns of Aries, “causeth discords, and journies.” The second “conduceth to the finding of treasures, and to the redeeming of captives.” The third, the Pleiades, is “profitable to Saylers, Huntsmen, and Alchymists.” The fourth, Aldebaran, causes “the destruction and hindrances of buildings, fountains, wels, of gold mines, the flight of creeping things,” and begets discord. The fifth “helpeth to the return from a journey, to the instruction of scholars, it confirmeth edifices, it giveth health and good will.”

Sailors, scholars, builders, wells, prisoners. This is not a contemplative system. It is a calendar for deciding when to do a specific job, and the mansion names are the giveaway about where it came from: *Alnath*, *Allothaim*, *Athoray*, *Aldebaran*, *Alchatay*, *Alhanna*. They are Arabic, transliterated through Latin, and Agrippa says as much — he credits “the wise men of the Indians and ancientest Astrologians,” cites one authority as *Alphares* and another as *Abraham*, and is transmitting a system he did not invent.

The images, and whose they are

For the faces, Agrippa gives images: a figure to be seen, and cut. He is explicit about his source and it is not the one most readers assume — “there are besides in the Zodiack thirty six images, according to the number of the faces, of the which (as Porphyry saith) Teucer the Babylonian long since wrote, who was a most ancient Mathematician, after whom the Arabians also wrote of these things.” The first face of Aries then ascends as

the image of a black man, standing and clothed in a white garment, girdled about, of a great body, with reddish eyes, and great strength, and like one that is angry; and this image signifieth and causeth boldness, fortitude, loftiness, and shamelessness.

Seven further chapters give the images of the planets, Saturn through the Moon. All of it is in print, in English, from 1651, and out of copyright.

These are Agrippa's images, and not the ones you were looking for

The decan images most readers come to this subject for are the *Picatrix*'s, and the bibliography of this book records why they are not here: no public-domain edition of the *Picatrix* exists in any language, and the images “are **not obtainable from any public-domain source.**” That note also anticipates exactly the move this chapter might have made, and forbids it — substituting Agrippa's images for the *Picatrix*'s “which is what circulates — would be the same error in a different direction.”

So the images above are given as what they are: Agrippa's, from a line he traces to Porphyry and Teucer. They overlap the *Picatrix* tradition and they are not identical to it, and a reader who needs the *Picatrix* decans specifically still has to go to an edition this book cannot reproduce. The gap is stated rather than filled with something that would pass for it.

The moment, and why the whole thing is an argument about time

An image alone is a picture. What the tradition claims is that an image cut *while the relevant part of the sky is doing the relevant thing* becomes something else. That is why this material sits in astrological literature rather than in books of drawing: an election is a chart, and a talismanic election is a chart chosen rather than observed — see Chapter 21.

The practical machinery is distributed across three chapters, and it is worth naming in one place. The **hour** and the **day** come from Chapter 20. The **metal or stone** comes from the same place, and the reason a Saturn talisman is lead is that the correspondence is supposed to be a real affinity and not a mnemonic. The **figure** comes from Chapter 22 if it is a seal or a kamea, and

from Agrippa's image chapters if it is an astral image. The **consecration** comes from Chapter 8. The fourth coordinate is the one the mansions supply: **where the Moon is.**

Sources: The twenty-eight mansions with their names, meanings, degrees and virtues: Agrippa, *De occulta philosophia*, Book II ch. 33, in the English of 1651, pp. 286–289 — every name and every virtue read on the page images of the Early English Books scan (leaves 0314–0317), which was necessary rather than fastidious: the scan's text layer gives the tenth mansion as “Alpe/ioche” where the page reads *Algelioche*, and mangles several others the same way. The chapter opening and closing are quoted from pp. 285 and 289. Spelling, capitalisation and the alternative names are the printing's own; the long s is set as s. Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa, *Three Books of Occult Philosophy*, trans. “J.F.” (London, 1651) public domain — Book II, ch. XXXIII, “Of the twenty eight Mansions of the Moon, and their vertues,” for the twenty-eight-fold division, the figure of twelve degrees fifty-one minutes and almost twenty-six seconds, the mansion names and beginnings, and the virtues quoted; Book II, ch. XXXVII, “Of the Images of the Faces,” for the thirty-six images, the ascription to Porphyry and Teucer the Babylonian, and the first face of Aries; Book II, chs. XXXVIII–XLIV for the planetary images, which are described here and not reproduced. Read from the Early English Books scan on the Internet Archive, identifier `bim_early-english-books-1641-1700_three-books-of-occult-ph_agrippa-henricus-cornel_1651`, which is the same copy Chapter 22 uses and which the bibliography notes is reachable only by wildcarding the collection prefix. This scan sets the long s properly, so the quotations need less repair than most in this book; word-spacing is closed up, and period spellings — *Saylers*, *Alchymists*, *wels*, *Zodiack* — stand. **Two readings are repaired and declared:** the scan gives *wife-* at a line break for *wise men*, and *wandveth,ic ob=aneth* for *wandreth, it obtaineth*; that second phrase is therefore not quoted here, only summarised. **The arithmetic is this book's own check**, not Agrippa's claim: he states the interval and lists the boundaries, and the observation that the interval is 360 divided by 28 to the second, and that the listed boundaries confirm it, is verification done for this edition. The *Picatrix* position is quoted from this book's own bibliography and is unchanged by this chapter.

Geomancy

Geomancy is the divination system this tradition actually used. It is not the best known — tarot has long since taken that place — but it is older in Europe, it was in the Golden Dawn curriculum listed in Chapter 13, and unlike almost everything else in this book it is completely specified. Sixteen figures, a fixed procedure for generating and combining them, and a single figure at the end that answers the question. Nothing is left to the reader's intuition until the very last step.

The name means divination by earth, and the Arabic name it translates — *'ilm al-raml*, the science of the sand — describes the original method: marks made at random in sand or dust. It entered Latin Europe in the twelfth century with the same wave of translation from Arabic that carried the Emerald Tablet — the movement Chapter 6 traces, and the collection this chapter follows also contains a treatise on astronomical geomancy under the name of Gerard of Cremona.

The sixteen figures

Every figure is four rows, and each row holds either one dot or two. Four binary rows give exactly sixteen possibilities, and the tradition uses all sixteen — which is why the system is closed in a way that tarot is not. The rows correspond, from the top, to fire, air, water and earth.

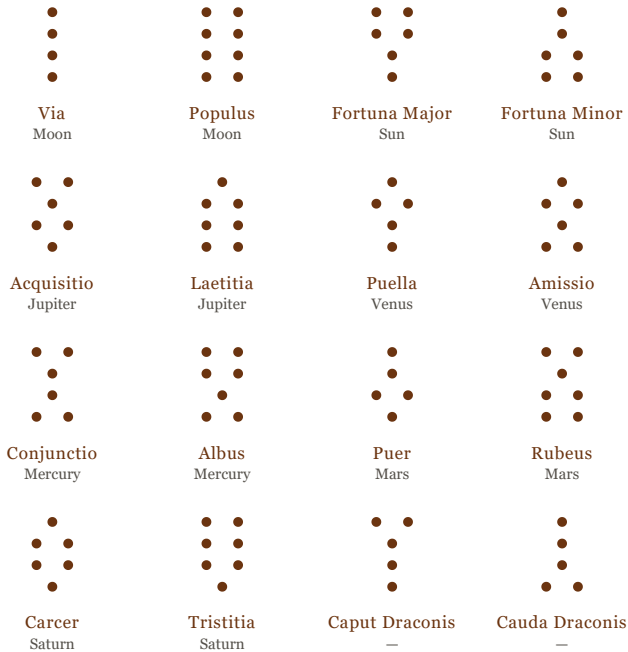


FIG. 1 — THE SIXTEEN FIGURES. One dot in a row is active, two is passive; the four rows are fire, air, water and earth from the top. The planet under each name is Agrippa's attribution. Note that the planets come in pairs, one benign and one less so — Fortuna Major and Minor for the Sun, Puella and Amissio for Venus, Puer and Rubeus for Mars — with the two Dragon figures, as Turner's translation puts it, following "their owne natures." Drawn for this book.

FIGURE	PLANET	SIGN	SIGNIFIES
Via	Moon	Cancer	the way; movement, change of place
Populus	Moon	Cancer	the crowd; multitude, whatever is common
Fortuna Major	Sun	Leo	the greater fortune; success held by one's own strength
Fortuna Minor	Sun	Leo	the lesser fortune; success held by another's help
Acquisitio	Jupiter	Pisces	gain, profit, what is taken in
Laetitia	Jupiter	Sagittarius	joy, gladness, health
Puella	Venus	Taurus	the girl; beauty, harmony, the fortunate
Amissio	Venus	Libra	loss; what goes out and does not return
Conjunctio	Mercury	Virgo	joining; meeting, recovery of what was lost
Albus	Mercury	Gemini	white; wisdom, clarity, peace
Puer	Mars	Scorpio	the boy; rashness, violence, the beardless
Rubeus	Mars	Scorpio	red; passion, vice, the malevolent
Carcer	Saturn	Capricorn	the prison; delay, binding, confinement
Tristitia	Saturn	Aquarius	sorrow; damnation, what is cast down
Caput Draconis	—	Capricorn	the dragon's head; the threshold entering, good with good
Cauda Draconis	—	Scorpio	the dragon's tail; the threshold leaving, ill with ill

The two ways of laying the figures

The tradition lays the generated figures out in two forms. The shield, worked in full below, is the self-contained form: sixteen lines of marks yield four Mothers, and everything else is derived from them until a single Judge

answers the question. The second form borrows the frame of astrology: the first twelve figures — Mothers, Daughters and Nieces — are set into the twelve houses of heaven, and the chart is judged like a horary figure, the question assigned to its house and the figure falling there examined, with the significations the astrology of Chapter 21 gives. Agrippa's treatise on geomancy sets out the house method, and it is described here rather than quoted; the shield is older, simpler, and complete in itself, which is why this chapter works it in full.

Casting a chart

THE SHIELD

1. **Frame one question.** Geomancy answers the question asked, and an unclear question produces an unclear judge. Write it down before casting.
2. **Make sixteen lines of marks** — dots in sand, or on paper, made rapidly and without counting. Then count each line: an odd number gives one dot, an even number gives two.
3. **The four Mothers.** Take the sixteen results four at a time; each group of four is one figure. These are the Mothers, set down right to left.
4. **The four Daughters** are read out of the Mothers: the first row of each Mother, taken in order, forms the first Daughter; the second rows form the second Daughter; and so on.
5. **The four Nieces.** Add each adjacent pair — Mothers one and two, then three and four, then the Daughters likewise — row by row. Two dots plus one dot gives one; two of the same gives two. This is addition modulo two, and the whole engine of the method is that operation.
6. **Two Witnesses** from the Nieces the same way, then **the Judge** from the two Witnesses.
7. **Read the Judge** as the answer, the Witnesses as how it comes about — the right Witness for the querent's side, the left for the matter's. A Judge that cannot be reached by an even number of dots indicates the chart is void; recast.

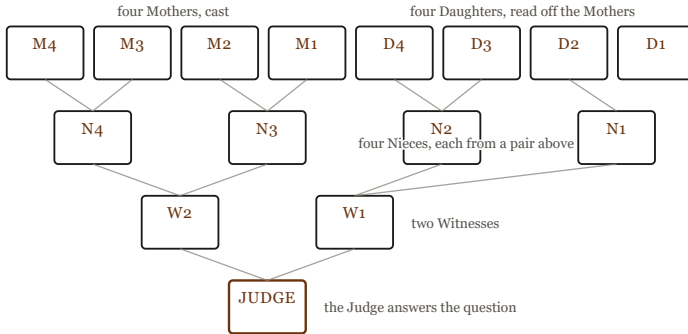


FIG. 2 — THE SHIELD. Sixteen random marks become four Mothers; the Mothers are transposed into four Daughters; and the eight are folded downward in pairs to two Witnesses and one Judge. Every step below the Mothers is determined — there is no judgement in the arithmetic, only in the question and the reading. Drawn for this book.

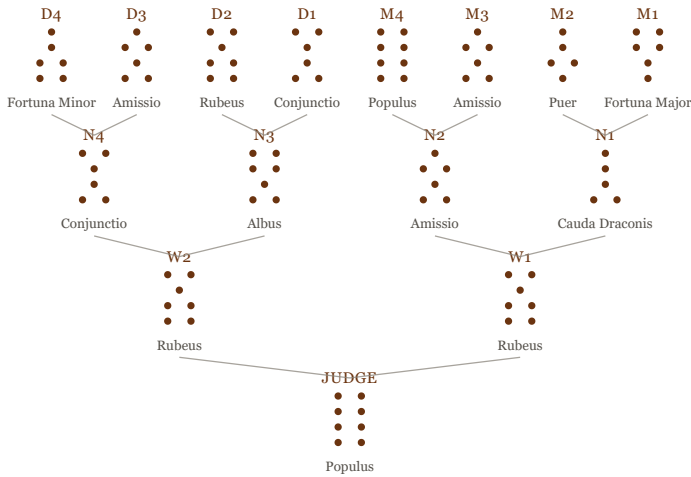


FIG. 3 — A SHIELD, WORKED. Four Mothers cast for illustration — Fortuna Major, Puer, Amissio, Populus — and everything below them computed by the rules above. The Daughters transpose the Mothers' rows; each Niece adds a pair; the Witnesses and Judge fold the rest down. The Judge here is Populus, the crowd: an answer of "as things commonly go," with the right Witness Rubeus warning where the querent's own conduct sits in it. Every figure below the top row is forced — redo the arithmetic and you must get the same chart. The generating code for this diagram computed it the same way, so the figure is correct by construction.

WHY THIS ONE IS WORTH LEARNING

Every other divinatory method in this book asks the practitioner to see something. Geomancy asks them to *compute* something and then interpret the result, and the computation is checkable by anybody. That makes it the honest place to start: the arithmetic either works or it does not, and a reading that goes wrong cannot be blamed on a failure of vision.

It also makes the system falsifiable in a way the rest of the tradition is not, which a reader may take either as a recommendation or as a warning.

Sources: The figures, their planetary and zodiacal attributions and their significations: *Of Geomancy*, attributed to Agrippa, in *Henry Cornelius Agrippa his Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy*, trans. Robert Turner (London, 1655) public domain. Turner's text was read in a modern facsimile whose typographic setting carries its own copyright; the wording quoted here is the 1655 text, which does not. The same volume contains *Of Astronomical Geomancy* under the name of Gerard of Cremona, and the *Heptameron* of pseudo-Peter de Abano quoted in Chapter 10. The four-row binary structure, the derivation of Daughters, Nieces, Witnesses and Judge, and the modulo-two addition are the system's own and are not in copyright to anyone. Arabic origin: *'ilm al-raml*; the Latin transmission belongs to the twelfth-century translation movement of Chapter 6.

Tarot

Twenty-two trumps; twenty-two letters in the Hebrew alphabet; twenty-two paths on the Tree of Life. That arithmetic is the whole reason tarot belongs in a book of ceremonial magic rather than in a history of card games, and somebody had to notice it first. Éliphas Lévi did, in 1856. Forty years later the Golden Dawn changed his answer, and the version in every modern handbook is the second one. Both are set out below, because they disagree about twenty-one cards out of twenty-two and a reader who has only seen the winner would never guess there had been a contest.

Where the cards came from, and where they did not

Playing cards reach Europe in the later fourteenth century. The tarot pack — four suits plus a fifth sequence of picture cards used as permanent trumps — appears in fifteenth-century Italy, and for something like three hundred years it is a **card game**. That is not a debunking; trick-taking with a trump suit is what the pack was made for, and it is still played.

Divination by tarot is an eighteenth-century development, and the moment it acquires an ancient pedigree can be dated. In **1781** Antoine Court de Gébelin published an essay on the *Jeu des Tarots* arguing that the pack was a survival of Egyptian priestly wisdom. Waite, who had no reason to be generous about it, gives the citation exactly — *Monde Primitif, analysé et comparé avec le Monde Moderne*, volume 8, Paris, 1781, the articles “at pp. 365 to 410” — and the citation is good: the essay opens at p. 365 under the title *Du Jeu des Tarots*, with a subtitle promising its origin, its allegories, and the proof that it is the source of the modern playing pack. Its second section states the whole claim in a sentence: *Le fait est cependant très-vrai: ce Livre Egyptien, seul reste de leurs superbes Bibliothèques, existe de nos jours* — the fact is

nonetheless quite true: this Egyptian Book, sole remnant of their superb Libraries, survives to our day. The pack he describes he also counts: *LXXVII feuillets ou tableaux, même de LXXVIII* — seventy-seven cards, or even seventy-eight.

The Egyptian claim has no evidence behind it and never had. It was made before the hieroglyphs could be read, on the strength of the pictures looking old, and it survived because it was useful. This is the same shape as the *Hermetica* in Chapter 2 and the *Zohar* in Chapter 4: a misdating that made the material matter, and that the material then outlived.

The attribution, and the man who changed it

The step that made tarot part of ceremonial magic rather than a fortune-telling pack was **Éliphas Lévi's**, in 1856: twenty-two trumps, twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet, therefore twenty-two paths on the Tree of Life of Chapter 4. Lévi's own assignment is unambiguous and he states it through the figure rather than in a table — of the first trump he writes that “his body and arms form the letter aleph.” The Juggler is Aleph, the numbered trumps take the letters in order, and the Fool falls near the end.

The Golden Dawn moved the Fool to the front. Under its scheme the Fool is Aleph, the Magician is Beth, and every numbered trump from one to twenty shifts one letter along. That single decision is the difference between the two systems in the table below, and its effect is total: **the two schemes agree about exactly one card.**

CARD	NAME	LÉVI, 1856	GOLDEN DAWN
0	The Fool	Shin	Aleph
I	The Magician	Aleph	Beth
II	The High Priestess	Beth	Gimel
III	The Empress	Gimel	Daleth
IV	The Emperor	Daleth	He
V	The Hierophant	He	Vau
VI	The Lovers	Vau	Zayin
VII	The Chariot	Zayin	Cheth
VIII	Strength	Cheth	Teth
IX	The Hermit	Teth	Yod
X	Wheel of Fortune	Yod	Kaph
XI	Justice	Kaph	Lamed
XII	The Hanged Man	Lamed	Mem
XIII	Death	Mem	Nun
XIV	Temperance	Nun	Samekh
XV	The Devil	Samekh	Ayin
XVI	The Tower	Ayin	Pe
XVII	The Star	Pe	Tzaddi
XVIII	The Moon	Tzaddi	Qoph
XIX	The Sun	Qoph	Resh
XX	Judgement	Resh	Shin
XXI	The World	Tau	Tau

The World is the only row where the columns match, and it matches for an uninteresting reason: it is last in both. Every other card in the pack has been given a different Hebrew letter, a different path on the Tree, and therefore a different meaning by anybody reading meaning off the Tree.

AND A SECOND CHANGE, WHICH WAITE REFUSED TO EXPLAIN

Traditionally Justice is the eighth trump and Strength the eleventh. In the Waite–Smith pack of 1909 they are the other way round, and Waite says so in the *Pictorial Key* two years later, in one of the more remarkable sentences in the literature: “For reasons which satisfy myself, this card has been interchanged with that of Justice, which is usually numbered eight. As the variation carries nothing with it which will signify to the reader, there is no cause for explanation.”

A four-hundred-year-old sequence altered, and the reason withheld on the ground that the reader would not understand it. Every deck descended from Waite–Smith — which is most of them — carries the change, and most of their users have never heard that it is one.

Waite against Waite

The sharpest thing in this chapter is that both attributions above are Waite’s doing, and he knew it. The English translation of Lévi quoted throughout this chapter is *his* — he translated *Dogme et Rituel* as *Transcendental Magic*, and it is in his English that an English reader meets the sentence about the Juggler’s body forming the aleph. Then, having put Lévi’s attribution into the language, he issued a pack built on the one that contradicts it.

He does not hide this either. Of the traditional placement of the Fool he writes that the zero card “is allocated, as it always is, to the place which makes it equivalent to the number twenty-one. The arrangement is ridiculous on the surface, which does not much signify, but it is also wrong on the symbolism.”

That is a man rejecting, in print, the scheme he had himself translated — not quietly, and not without argument, but also without ever setting the two side by side for a reader to compare. The table above is that comparison; Waite appears never to have printed one.

The other fifty-six

The trumps monopolise the theory, but the pack Court de Gébelin counted has seventy-eight cards, and the other fifty-six deserve their paragraph. They are the four suits of the ordinary mediaeval pack — wands, cups, swords, and coins or pentacles — each running ace to ten with four court cards. The ceremonial systematisation is the Golden Dawn's: the four suits to the four elements — wands to fire, cups to water, swords to air, pentacles to earth — and to the four letters of the divine Name in order, so that the whole pack becomes a diagram of the Name working through the elements, ace to ten mapping the ten sephiroth of Chapter 4 in each element in turn. That scheme is a construction of the 1890s, exactly like the path-attributions above. Divinatory meanings for the small cards are older than the Golden Dawn but not ancient — they descend from eighteenth-century cartomancy — and the familiar pictorial minors, with a scene on every numbered card, begin with the Waite-Smith pack of 1909: before it, the small cards of a tarot pack look like playing cards, pips and nothing else. A reader who finds the fifty-six “meanings” less stable than the trumps' has noticed something real: they are younger, they were never argued over by the theorists, and no two manuals agree.

What this means if you use a modern deck

Any correspondence table in a modern handbook — this trump to that path, that path to this colour, planet or angel — is downstream of the Golden Dawn column above and not of anything older. It is coherent and it is usable. It is also about a hundred and thirty years old, it disagrees with the nineteenth-century French system on every card but one, and neither of them is attested in a fifteenth-century Italian card game.

None of that stops the system working as a system. It does mean that a claim of the form *the Tower has always meant this* is a claim about the 1890s.

Sources: Éliphas Lévi, *Dogme et Rituel de la Haute Magie* (Paris, 1854–56), quoted in the English of A. E. Waite, *Transcendental Magic: Its Doctrine and Ritual* public domain — read from the De Laurence printing of Waite’s translation on the Internet Archive, identifier [transcendentalma00levi_0](#); the attribution of the first trump to aleph is at his description of the Juggler, and the Fool is placed in his table of lunar days at the twenty-ninth. A. E. Waite, *The Pictorial Key to the Tarot* (London: William Rider & Son, 1911) public domain — read from the Internet Archive copy under [a.-e.-waite-the-pictorial-key-to-the-tarot](#); the interchange of Strength and Justice and the refusal to explain it, the judgment on the placing of the Fool, and the bibliographical citation of Court de Gébelin. Court de Gébelin, *Monde Primitif, analysé et comparé avec le Monde Moderne*, vol. 8, huitième livraison (Paris, 1781), *Du Jeu des Tarots* opening at p. 365, with the *Recherches* signed “M. le C. de M.” following under the same running head — read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan [mondeprimitifana08cour](#), the opening at leaf 473; in the quotations the long s is set as s and nothing else is altered. Waite’s page range is confirmed against the volume. Word-spacing in both scans is closed up and nothing else is altered; no reading required repair. **The table is this book’s own construction** and is the point at which it should be checked hardest. The Golden Dawn column is the standard modern attribution, a construction of the 1890s; it is set out here from that standard scheme and not from an order document, because the order’s own papers reached print through Regardie and are in copyright. The Lévi column is derived: he gives the first trump and the sequence, and the rest follows from taking the letters in order, which is what he describes rather than tabulates. A reader who needs either column for scholarly purposes should go behind this book to the sources. The dating of playing cards and of the tarot pack is given in outline from general reference and no primary source for it was consulted for this edition.

Folk Magic

Everything so far in this book belongs to a learned tradition. It is written by men with libraries, in Latin and Greek and Hebrew, for readers who can afford instruments and virgin parchment and a room set apart. There is another stream entirely, and leaving it out would misrepresent what magic in the West has mostly actually *been*: charms, said aloud, by people with no equipment, for the ordinary catastrophes of a working life — a burn, a bleeding cut, a house in a storm, a fire in the barn.

The book this chapter follows is the best-documented example in English: *The Long Lost Friend*, published in German at Reading, Pennsylvania in 1820 by **John George Hohman** and in English from the 1840s. It is the handbook of Pennsylvania Dutch *Braucherei* or powwowing, a folk practice still alive, and it is a genuinely different object from the grimoires of Chapter 10: cheap, small, in the vernacular, and organised by complaint rather than by planet.

Three features mark *this* book, and the third of them marks the whole tradition. The charms are **Christian in idiom**, not Solomonic — the names invoked are the Trinity and the saints, not Hebrew godnames. They are **spoken, not written**, and Hohman requires no instrument at all. And most are built on **epic precedent**: a holy event is narrated, and the narration is expected to make its outcome recur here. That form is very old — the same shape appears in Anglo-Saxon and Old High German charms centuries earlier — and it is entirely absent from the ceremonial chapters of this book.

Hold the first two of those loosely. They are true of Hohman, and it is tempting to read them as the definition of folk magic against ceremonial magic. The Anglo-Saxon material later in this chapter will not support that

reading: it has instruments, timed hours, a silence taboo and a consecration, and it is folk practice throughout. The chapter states the neat division here because it is the one most readers arrive with, and then takes it apart.

THE RULE THAT GOVERNS EVERYTHING IN THIS CHAPTER

Hohman states one instruction that applies across the whole book, and it should be read before any charm in it:

“Every thing prescribed in this book must be used three times, even if the three crosses should not be affixed. Words are always to have an interval of half an hour, and between the second and third time should pass a whole night, except where it is otherwise directed.”

Three repetitions, half an hour apart, with a night between the second and the third. That timing rule is to this tradition what the planetary hour is to Chapter 20: the thing that makes an utterance an operation.

Four charms

These are printed exactly as the 1850 English edition has them, misspellings and all — “firy oven,” the mangled names of the three men in the furnace, “Thus they shalt abate.” The errors are part of the record: this is a cheap book, set by a jobbing printer, for readers who were not going to check it against a Bible.

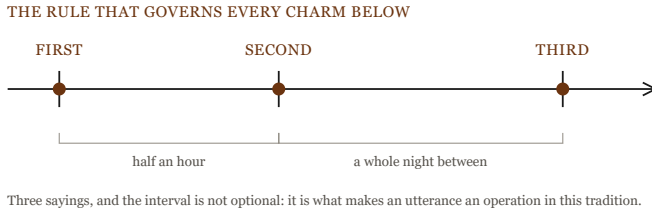


FIG. 1 — THE THREEFOLD TIMING. Hohman states this once, near the front of his book, and then assumes it for everything that follows — which means a reader who meets one of his charms out of context will almost certainly perform it wrongly. It is the exact counterpart of the planetary hour in the ceremonial chapters: the element that turns saying words into working. Drawn for this book from the 1850 English edition.

HOW TO CURE A BURN

Three holy men went out walking,
 They did bless the heat and the burning;
 They blessed that it might not increase;
 They blessed that it might quickly cease!

Four lines, no apparatus, and the epic-precedent form in its purest state: three men walk out of scripture, bless a fire, and the blessing is expected to carry into this burn. Nothing is asked of any spirit; the charm works, on its own account, by re-narration.

A CERTAIN REMEDY TO STOP BLEEDING

Which cures, no matter how far a person be away, if only his first name is rightly pronounced while using it.

Jesus Christ, dearest blood!

That stoppeth the pain, and stoppeth the blood.

In this help you, [first name] God the Father, God the Son, God the Holy Ghost. Amen.

A BENEDICTION TO PREVENT FIRE

The bitter sorrows and the death of our dear Lord Jesus Christ shall prevail. Fire, and wind, and great heat, and all that is within the power of these elements, I command thee through the Lord Jesus Christ, who has spoken to the winds and the waters, and they obeyed him. By these powerful words spoken by Jesus, I command, threaten, and inform thee, fire, flame, and heat, and your powers as elements, to flee forthwith.

The holy, rosy blood of our dear Lord Jesus Christ, may rule it. Thou, fire and wind, and great heat, I command thee, as the Lord did by his holy angels command the great heat in the fiery oven when those three holy men, Sadrach and his companions, Mesach and Obed Rego, to leave them untouched, as was done accordingly.

Thus they shalt abate, thou fire, flame, and great heat, the Almighty God having spoken in creating the four elements, together with heaven and earth: **Fiat, Fiat, Fiat!** that is: It shall be, in the name of God, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost. Amen.

Note what the operator does here: *commands an element*, and does so on a precedent — the furnace of Daniel 3, whose three men Hohman’s printer garbles into “Sadrach and his companions, Mesach and Obed Rego.” The threefold *Fiat* at the close is the folk register reaching for ceremonial speech, and it is the one place in the chapter where this tradition and Chapter 8 sound alike.

PROTECTION OF ONE’S HOUSE AND HEARTH

Beneath thy guardianship, I am safe against all tempests and all enemies, **J. J. J.**

These three J’s signify Jesus three times.

A complete operation in one sentence — and the three initials are the whole system in miniature: a name said three times, compressed so far that only its first letter survives, with the book’s own gloss appended in case the reader has forgotten.

Where the form comes from

The three-part shape described above — a holy event narrated, then the outcome expected to recur — is not a Pennsylvania Dutch invention, and it is not a vague family resemblance either. It has a name, a documented mechanism, and a scholarly statement of both that is old enough to be quoted here. Felix Grendon set it out in 1909, working from the Old High German and Vedic material rather than the American:

The exorcist, desiring to cure a disease or to invoke favors from the deity, recounts a mythological incident presenting circumstances analogous to the situation in which the patient is found. The procedure of the supernatural beings in the narrative is to serve as a precedent in the case with which the conjurer is dealing.

In the two Old High German and in many of the Hindu incantations, it will be observed that the recitation of the mythological precedent frequently concludes with a precise formula, supposedly uttered by the deity or hero who appears in the incident. The potency of a phrase having been proved by its use under supernatural auspices, the conjurer believes that a recital of the same formula will insure the attainment of his end.

Read that as a piece of legal machinery, because that is what it is. The narrative is not decoration and it is not scene-setting. It is a **cited precedent**: a case in which the desired outcome already occurred, chosen because its circumstances are analogous to the present ones, and adduced so that the present case must be decided the same way. The words that closed the precedent then carry the authority of having worked once under conditions no human can reproduce. Almost every popular account of these charms treats the opening story as poetry. It is the argument.

The same charm, twice, four centuries apart

What makes this more than a theory is that one charm survives in both its heathen and its Christian form, and Grendon prints them within two pages of each other. The older is the second of the two Merseburg incantations, from a tenth-century manuscript, for a dislocation. Grendon gives the opening in English:

*Phol and Woden rode to forest
Where sprained was the foot of Balder's foal.*

He describes the rest rather than printing it: three goddesses attempt the cure and fail; then Woden, who in Grendon’s paraphrase knew well how, effects it; and the charm closes on the formula Woden himself is supposed to have spoken, which is the part the human operator repeats. That formula is the bone-to-bone, blood-to-blood binding that every reader of folk charms has met somewhere.

And here is the same charm as it was still being used after the conversion:

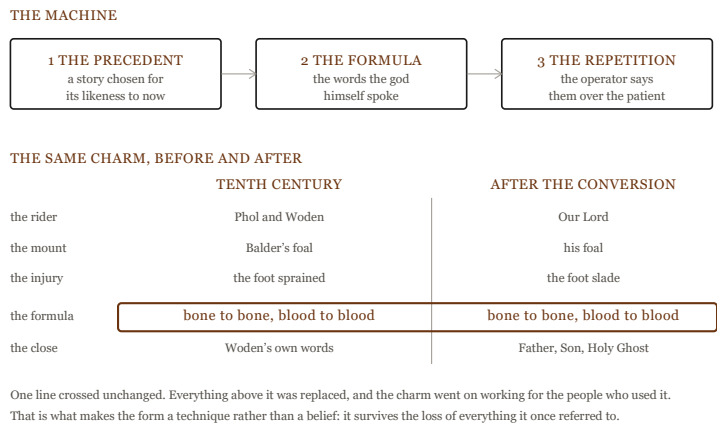


FIG. 2 — THE MACHINE, AND ONE CHARM THROUGH IT. Grendon prints the heathen and the Christian versions of this dislocation charm two pages apart, and setting them out in columns shows what changed: the rider, the horse and the god, and nothing else. The operative line — the bone-to-bone binding — crossed the conversion intact, which is why it can still be found in Pennsylvania nine centuries later. The upper band is the structure Grendon describes at p. 111 and is this book’s arrangement of his three terms; the columns are his two texts.

OUR LORD RADE

Our Lord rade, his foal's foot slade;
Down he lighted, his foal's foot righted.
Bone to bone, sinew to sinew,
Blood to blood, flesh to flesh:
Heal in the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost.

The rider has changed and nothing else has. The horse still stumbles, the rider still dismounts, the joint is still set, and the operative formula — bone to bone, blood to blood — survives word for word into a charm that ends on the Trinity. Grendon states the substitution flatly: the Christian versions are “plainly related to the Old High German charm, the principal modern changes being the invariable substitution of the words “Jesus,” “Lord,” or “God” for the names “Woden,” “Phol,” “Sindgund,” “Frija,” and “Volla.””

WHAT THIS DOES TO THE CHARMS ABOVE

Go back to Hohman's cure for a burn. *Three holy men went out walking, they did bless the heat and the burning.* Four lines, no apparatus, an unnamed trio walking out of scripture, and a blessing expected to carry into the present injury. It is the identical machine: precedent narrated, formula applied. Hohman is publishing in Reading, Pennsylvania in 1820, in German, for farmers. The manuscript Grendon is reading was written in the tenth century. Nothing connects them but the form, and the form survived the entire Christianisation of northern Europe by the simple expedient of changing who is riding the horse.

This also explains something the ceremonial chapters of this book cannot: why the folk register needs no instruments, no hour, no circle and no consecration. A ceremonial operation builds a situation in which a thing may be commanded. A charm of this kind does not command at all. It *argues*, and the whole of its apparatus is one remembered story.

The English charms, and what they undo

This chapter has so far set an 1820 book printed in Pennsylvania beside a German manuscript of the tenth century. Between them lies a large English corpus, and it is worth reaching because it complicates the neat division this chapter opened with. Anglo-Saxon charms are not simple. Several are more elaborately staged than anything in Chapter 8, and they achieve it without a single instrument.

Start with the smallest complete operation in the book:

FOR MUCH TRAVELLING

For much travelling on land, lest a person tire: let him take mugwort in his hand or put it in his shoe, lest he grow weary; and if he would pluck it before sunrise let him first say these words:

Tollam te artemesia, ne lassus sim in via.

Sign it with the sign of the cross when you pull it up.

Two lines of instruction, one line of Latin — *I shall take you, mugwort, that I be not weary on the road* — and a gesture. There is a herb, a time, a formula and a sign, and nothing else. Put it in your shoe. It is the whole of the tradition compressed into something a person could actually do on a Tuesday, and it is worth holding in mind against the nine-foot circle.

A rite in the folk register

And then this, which is the reason the English material belongs in this book. It is a remedy, and it is also a staged ceremonial operation running over two days:

FOR ELF-DISEASE

On Thursday evening when the sun is set, go where you know that elecampane stands; then sing the Benedicite and a Paternoster and a litany, and stick your knife into the herb; let it stick fast therein and go away.

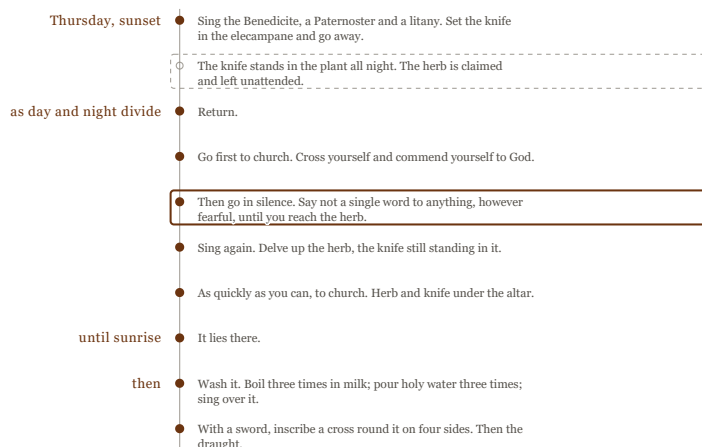
Go again thither, just as day and night divide. During this same daybreak go first to church and cross yourself and commend yourself to God.

Then go in silence, and, though something of a fearful kind or a man should come upon you, say not a single word to it until you reach the herb you marked the night before.

Then sing the Benedicite and a Paternoster and a litany, delve up the herb, letting the knife stick fast in it. As quickly as you can, go to church and place it with the knife under the altar; let it lie until the sun has risen.

Afterwards wash it and make it and bishop's-wort and lichen off a crucifix into a drink; boil the drink three times in milk, pour holy water into it three times, sing over it a Paternoster and a Credo and a Gloria in excelsis deo, and sing a litany over it; and also, with a sword, inscribe a cross round it on four sides, and after that let the patient drink the draught.

ONE REMEDY, TWO DAYS



Election of the hour, a marked boundary, a silence, a triple repetition, a consecration, a cross cut on four sides. Every element of a ceremonial working, and not one instrument the operator did not already own.

FIG. 3 — ONE REMEDY, TWO DAYS. Laid out in sequence, the folk remedy stops looking like a charm and starts looking like a liturgy. The two timed moments are thresholds — sunset, and the exact division of day and night — which is the same interest that produces the planetary hours. The marked step is the silence, and the text takes the trouble to cover the case where something frightening speaks to you. Compiled for this book from the wording of the rite above; the rite is Grendon's English.

Count what is in there. A **fixed day and a fixed hour**, twice over — Thursday at sunset, and again at the exact division of day and night, which is the same interest in the threshold moment that drives the planetary hours of Chapter 20. A **knife left standing in the plant overnight**, marking it as claimed and returned to. A **silence taboo** with an explicit clause covering the case where something frightening addresses you, which is one of the strongest injunctions of its kind anywhere in this book. A **consecration under an altar until sunrise**. **Threefold repetition**, twice: three boilings, three pourings. And a **cross inscribed on four sides with a sword**, which is a circle-casting by another name.

Every structural element of a ceremonial working is present — election of time, purification, a marked boundary, a triple repetition, a spoken formula, a consecrated instrument. What is absent is the entire apparatus: no circle drawn on the ground, no wand or pentacle, no Hebrew, no spirit named, no hierarchy. The instruments are a knife and a sword the operator already owns, and the words are the ones any parish knew by heart.

WHAT THIS DOES TO THE DIVISION THIS CHAPTER BEGAN WITH

The opening of this chapter drew a clean line: ceremonial magic has libraries, instruments and Hebrew godnames; folk magic has a spoken charm and nothing else. On the evidence of the English material that line is too clean. The elf-disease rite is not a charm; it is a liturgy, performed by a layman, using the parish church as its temple and the parish's own prayers as its words.

The honest description is not two traditions but **one grammar with two vocabularies**. Where the grimoires say *in the day and hour of Mercury*, this says *on Thursday evening when the sun is set*. Where they consecrate on an altar of their own construction, this walks to the one down the road. The difference between the registers turns out to be a difference of *access* — to Latin, to materials, to a private room — far more than a difference of method.

Herbs addressed as persons

One habit in this corpus is worth setting against the ceremonial chapters, because it is the same move made on a different object: the plant is spoken to, in the second person, and reminded of its own history. The *Key of Solomon* does this to water — *I exorcise Thee, O Creature of Water, by Him Who hath created thee and gathered thee together into one place* — reciting the material's own past as the ground of the demand. What differs is not the

grammar but the warrant: the ceremonial text addresses the water through the God who made it, and the charm addresses the plant directly, on its own record. The Nine Herbs Charm opens:

*Remember, Mugwort, what you revealed,
What you prepared at Regenmeld.
Una, you are called, eldest of herbs.
You avail against three and against thirty,
You avail against poison and against infectious sickness,
You avail against the loathsome fiend that wanders through the land.*

*And you, Plantain, mother of herbs.
Open from the east, mighty from within.
Over you carts creaked, over you queens rode.
Brides exclaimed over you, over you bulls gnashed their teeth.
Yet all these you withstood and fought against...*

That is not a correspondence table. The herb is not being *used*; it is being *reminded* — of what it once did, of what has been driven over it, of what it withstood — and the reminding is the operation, in exactly the way the narrated precedent was the operation in the charms above. Plantain grows in cart-ruts and doorways and is walked on by everything, and the charm makes that its qualification. Something trodden by carts and queens and bulls alike, and still there, is precisely what you want against a sickness.

Grendon, describing how the older layer of this material was handled once the Church took an interest, gives the mechanism its best short formulation. Of a line in the field-blessing appealing to Earth to be fruitful *in God's embracing arm*, he writes that it shows admirably “the method of toning down the Paganism of the spell”. Not deletion. Adjustment — which is why so much of it survived.

⚠ What this chapter is and is not

These are historical charms, printed as evidence of what people did. That applies to the Anglo-Saxon remedies above exactly as it applies to Hohman: *for elf-disease* is a treatment for a condition no modern reader has, made of a plant no modern reader should be boiling into a draught on the strength of a tenth-century manuscript. It is given for its structure, not its pharmacy. Several of Hohman's remedies are dangerous, some are unpleasant, and a great many address serious illness in place of medicine. The four above are given because they are harmless in themselves; the bleeding charm in particular is **not** a treatment for bleeding, and *The Long Lost Friend* was written in a world where the alternative to a charm was frequently nothing at all.

The living tradition should also be named rather than mined. Braucherei is practised today in Pennsylvania and elsewhere, ordinarily within a Christian frame and often transmitted only across the sexes and within families. A reader who wants to learn it should go to it, not to a book.

MODERN PRACTICE

The folk register never went away, and it is where most people actually meet magic: a charm said over a child's scraped knee, a horseshoe over a door, salt thrown over a shoulder, a phrase repeated three times. The ceremonial tradition of this book has libraries and vocabulary and a documented history. This one has survived four centuries in the mouths of people who left no records at all, which is a different and not obviously lesser achievement.

Sources: John George Hohman, *The Long Lost Friend, or, Faithful & Christian Instructions Containing Wondrous and Well-Tried Arts & Remedies* (Harrisburg, Pa., 1850), translated from *Der lange verborgene Freund* (Reading, Pa., 1820) public domain — the three-times rule at p. 22 and the four charms as printed, spellings and all; read from the Wellcome Collection copy on the Internet Archive, identifier *b33030467*, and verified against its page images. The witness matters more than usual here: another 1850 printing (the National Library of Medicine copy) is a different English rendering whose rule reads “an interval of several hours” where this one has “half an hour,” so the wording quoted above belongs to this copy and not to “the 1850 edition” at large. Modern editions of this text carry their own editorial apparatus and are not the source used here. The English charms — *For much travelling* (B 2), *For elf-disease* (B 3) and the opening of the *Nigon Wyrta Galdor* or Nine Herbs Charm (B 4) — are quoted in Grendon’s facing English at pp. 191 and 194; his Old English is printed opposite and is not reproduced here. In the Latin tag of B 2 the scan reads *ne bssus sim in via*; *lassus* is printed above as an expansion of an obvious corruption, the sense being fixed by Grendon’s own instruction *lest he grow weary*, and the expansion is declared here rather than made silently. The remark on toning down is his, from the discussion of the field-blessing at p. 156. Felix Grendon, *The Anglo-Saxon Charms* (reprinted from the *Journal of American Folk-Lore*, vol. XXII, 1909) public domain — the statement of the doctrine at p. 111, the English of the second Merseburg charm at p. 148 n. 9, and *Our Lord rade* with the account of the substituted names at p. 149. Unlike the Agrippa material in Chapter 22, these were read in the scan’s text layer and not on page images. The OCR is clean in these paragraphs and was checked against the surrounding argument, but the distinction is stated because this book has made it a standard elsewhere: no Old High German is quoted here, and the goddess-name *Sindgund* rests on that single witness — Grendon’s own footnote elsewhere records that the form was already contested in his day.

The Modern Occult Revival

Nearly everything a modern reader will meet as *the tradition* was made between 1875 and 1978, and each stage of it believed it was continuing something much older. Theosophy, the Golden Dawn, Thelema, the witch-cult thesis, Wicca and chaos magic follow one another within a single century, and each inherited the previous one's invention as an antiquity. Setting them in a row is the only way to see the shape of it.

DATE	MOVEMENT	PRINCIPALLY	CLAIMED TO BE CONTINUING
1875–88	THEOSOPHY	Blavatsky	Egyptian and Indian antiquity
1888	GOLDEN DAWN	Mathers, Westcott	a German adept and a cipher manuscript
1904	THELEMA	Crowley	a discarnate intelligence at Cairo
1921	THE WITCH-CULT	Murray	the pre-Christian religion of Europe
1954	WICCA	Gardner	Murray's surviving covens
1978	CHAOS MAGIC	Carroll and others	nothing, deliberately

FIG. 1 — A HUNDRED YEARS OF INHERITANCE. Six stages, the people mainly responsible, and what each understood itself to be carrying on. Only the last column is contentious, and only the last row is honest about it. Drawn for this book.

Lévi, 1854, the stage before the curtain

One name belongs before the figure's first row, and Fig. 1 should be read with him standing ahead of it. Éliphas Lévi — Alphonse Louis Constant, a Parisian ex-seminarian — published *Dogme et Rituel de la Haute Magie* in 1854–56, and nearly every structural idea the revival ran on is in it: magic presented as a single coherent tradition rather than a heap of curiosities, the tarot joined to

the Hebrew alphabet (Chapter 25 gives his attribution and what the Golden Dawn did to it), and the astral light as the medium of the whole art. He wrote in the wake of the spiritualist wave that began at Hydesville in 1848 — the séance room is the unacknowledged background of the entire period — and he reached English occultism in Waite’s translation, cited in Chapter 25. Every movement in the figure below inherited him, usually without saying so.

Theosophy, and the reason so much of this is Indian

Helena Blavatsky and the Theosophical Society, from 1875, are why a Western esoteric handbook of the twentieth century talks about karma, reincarnation, chakras and root races. Before Theosophy those are not part of this tradition; after it they are inseparable from popular versions of it. One of her importations is now so thoroughly naturalised that its source is rarely named: “as above, so below” is not in the Emerald Tablet, and it circulates because Blavatsky quoted it as a received Hermetic axiom — see Chapter 6.

Theosophy also supplied the *form* of the modern claim: a hidden brotherhood of masters, a secret doctrine older than the religions, a text received rather than composed. Every movement below borrows that shape, whatever it fills it with.

Thelema, 1904

Aleister Crowley is the hinge between the Golden Dawn and everything after it, and the founding document is *Liber AL vel Legis*, the Book of the Law, which he held to have been dictated to him at Cairo in April 1904. Two of its verses have entered general use far beyond anybody who would call themselves a Thelemite:

Every man and every woman is a star.

Do what thou wilt shall be the whole of the Law.

The second is routinely quoted as a licence and was not meant as one; the *Law* pairs it immediately with “Love is the law, love under will,” and Crowley’s *thou wilt* means a true will discovered rather than a preference indulged. Whether that is a meaningful distinction is not this book’s question. That it is the text’s own reading is checkable, and the misquotation is one of the most common in the subject.

Murray, 1921, and the claim that made Wicca possible

Margaret Murray was an Egyptologist who argued, in *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe*, that the people tried as witches in early modern Europe had been practising a real religion — an organised pre-Christian survival, which she named the Dianic cult. Her statement of it is admirably plain, and the first four words are the trouble:

The evidence proves that underlying the Christian religion was a cult practised by many classes of the community... It can be traced back to pre-Christian times, and appears to be the ancient religion of Western Europe.

The evidence does not prove that, and the thesis is no longer held by historians of the subject. Murray built it by reading confessions extracted under torture as ethnographic reports and by treating what the interrogators supplied as what the accused described. The book was influential for forty years — it was in the *Encyclopædia Britannica* — and it is the indispensable link in the chain, because the next stage depended on it being true.

Wicca, 1954, and chaos magic, 1978

Gerald Gardner published *Witchcraft Today* in 1954, presenting the practice he taught as a surviving remnant of exactly the religion Murray had described — and Murray wrote the introduction. Chapter 18 already dates one piece of that practice in detail, and the finding there is representative: the eightfold Wheel of the Year, presented as immemorial, was assembled between the

1940s and 1958, with the equinoxes added after *Witchcraft Today* had gone to press. This book's treatment of Gardner is deliberately thin because his work is in copyright and this edition describes rather than quotes it; the dating is Ronald Hutton's, and it is cited there.

Chaos magic, from the late 1970s and associated in print with Peter Carroll and Ray Sherwin, closes the sequence by breaking the pattern. Its founding move is to drop the lineage entirely: no ancient tradition, no received text, no masters — technique treated as technique, belief treated as a tool to be adopted for a working and dropped afterwards. Whatever one makes of it, it is the only stage in Fig. 1 that never claimed to be old, and it arrived after a century in which every previous stage had. That is also in copyright and is described here and not quoted.

WHY THE PATTERN IS WORTH NAMING

Read down the last column of Fig. 1 and the shape is unmistakable: each generation received the previous generation's invention as an inheritance. The Golden Dawn took a cipher manuscript for a German lineage. Gardner took Murray's thesis for a surviving religion. Modern handbooks take the Golden Dawn's correspondence tables for immemorial doctrine. In every case the material outlived the claim, and in every case it is still in use.

That is the argument of this whole book, arriving in the century that made it: **the dating being wrong is not the same as the practice being worthless.** It is only the same if the practice was being recommended *because* it was old — which is exactly why the dates belong on the page.

Sources: Aleister Crowley, *Liber AL vel Legis* (received 1904; first published in *The Equinox*, 1909) public domain in the US — read from the Internet Archive copy under CrowleyTheBookOfTheLaw. The two lines quoted are verses I:3 and I:40 of the 1904 text. **Crowley’s own Introduction, printed with the text in that scan, is a later composition and is not quoted here;** the phrase “Love is the law, love under will” is quoted from the text proper and not from that introduction. Margaret Murray, *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe: A Study in Anthropology* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1921) public domain — read from the Internet Archive copy witchculturweste00murr; the passage quoted is from her Introduction, where she also names the Dianic cult. Two readings repaired there: the scan gives *ot* for *oft* twice in the quoted sentence. The ellipsis is marked. H. P. Blavatsky is cited in Chapter 6 for the circulation of “as above, so below” and is not requoted here. **Gerald Gardner, *Witchcraft Today* (1954), and Peter Carroll, *Liber Null* (1978), are in copyright and are described and not quoted,** which is this book’s standing practice for modern order and movement material. The dating of the Wheel of the Year is Ronald Hutton’s and is cited in full in Chapter 18. The judgment that Murray’s thesis is no longer held is reported from the general state of the field; no historiographical survey was consulted for this edition, and a reader who wants the case against her in detail should go to Hutton. **Fig. 1, its last column, and the observation that only the final stage declined to claim antiquity are this book’s own.**

Materials

This chapter exists because the rest of the book does not answer an obvious question. The sources specify their materials scrupulously and in scattered places, and a reader who wants to actually perform something has to reconstruct the list by hunting back through five chapters. Here it is in one place, built from the rites themselves rather than from a general impression of what magic requires.

It covers all thirty-nine rites this book gives outside the laboratory. The six laboratory operations of Chapter XXIX are deliberately not in the table: what they require is a working laboratory with a fume hood, and that chapter states the requirement for each operation where it belongs, alongside the hazard it exists to control.

The first thing the table shows is worth stating before the table: **eleven of the thirty-nine rites in this book need no equipment at all.** Not improvised equipment — none. That includes all four of Hohman's charms, the Merseburg charm beside them, the vibration of a divine name, the assumption of a godform, and the reckoning of the planetary hour. If the apparatus is what has been putting you off, better than a quarter of the book is already open to you. (Not every folk charm qualifies: the Anglo-Saxon rites in the same chapter are among the most demanding in the book.)

The minimum, and what it unlocks

Ten ordinary things cover **twenty-three of the thirty-nine rites** between them. None is specialist and none is expensive:

ITEM	WHAT IT IS	rites
Paper and a pen	Ordinary paper. The <i>Key of Solomon</i> asks for virgin parchment and permits paper; every modern practitioner uses paper.	13
A herb or two	Dried culinary herbs are fine for most. Specific plants are named where a rite needs one.	7
A table	Any table you can clear. The altar of Fig. 2 in Chapter VIII is a table facing east.	4
Water	Fresh, in a clean vessel. Spring water where a text specifies it.	8
Charcoal and a resin	Self-lighting charcoal discs and frankincense or myrrh, from any incense supplier. With a window open.	9
A light	A single candle or an oil lamp.	4
Clean clothes kept for the purpose	The sources say linen, and say white. What they are describing is <i>clothes you wear for nothing else</i> .	6
A vessel	Earthenware or glass. The <i>Key</i> specifies tin or glazed earth for the water.	5
Salt	Any salt.	2
A knife	A knife you own. Chapter VIII gives the consecration; the text cares about the consecration, not the price.	4

Add a wand — which in the sources is a cut rod, not a purchase — and a dark bowl for scrying, and the rest is the odd particular the rite itself names: a metal blank, a length of cord, a sword, a flask of strong spirit, a compass.

Every rite, and what it asks for

A dash means the rite requires nothing but the operator. Where a rite names a specific plant, stone or metal, the requirement is listed generically here and the particulars are in the rite itself.

RITE	CH.	WHAT IT NEEDS
The construction, as a contemplation	III	compass & straightedge, paper or parchment
The separation of the three principles in a plant	V	a fire outdoors, herbs, strong drinkable spirit, vessel or bowl
Vibrating a divine name — Liber O (1909)	VII	—
The exorcism of the water, for the bath	VIII	censer & charcoal, linen or clean clothes, water
The consecration of water and salt	VIII	censer & charcoal, cord, herbs, salt, vessel or bowl, water
The conjuration of the sword	VIII	censer & charcoal, knife, sword, water
The sprinkler and the water	VIII	cord, herbs, salt, vessel or bowl, water
The assumption of the vestments	VIII	linen or clean clothes
The Construction of the Circle, from the Key of Solomon	VIII	a light, censer & charcoal, cord, knife, linen or clean clothes, sword
Opening	VIII	a light, censer & charcoal, knife, linen or clean clothes, water
Closing	VIII	a light, paper or parchment
An address to the god drawn upon the letter	IX	—
The ring of Hermes — the ceremony of the beetle	IX	a table or altar, censer & charcoal, herbs, linen or clean clothes, metal or stone, oil unguent, paper or parchment, vessel or bowl
The dream oracle of Hermes	IX	a table or altar, censer & charcoal, herbs, paper or parchment

Substitutions the sources themselves allow

This matters more than it might seem, because the impression that these operations require rare materials is largely an artefact of reading the most demanding text and assuming it speaks for the rest. The traditions are more accommodating than their reputation:

- **Paper for parchment.** The *Key of Solomon* prefers virgin parchment and allows paper. Talismans are now made in paper and ink far more often than in engraved metal, and the text permits it.
- **Any knife, once consecrated.** The consecration in Chapter VIII is what makes the instrument, and the rite is given in full. Nothing in it depends on what the blade cost.
- **A cut rod for a wand.** Where a wand is specified the sources describe cutting one, not buying one.
- **Resins over sticks.** If you want the historical thing, the sources name gums and resins — frankincense, myrrh, mastic, aloes — burned on charcoal. Perfumed sticks are a modern convenience and no source knows them.
- **Kitchen technique for herbs.** Infusion, decoction and expression (Chapter XVI, Fig. 1) need a pan and a sieve.

⚠ **What not to buy, and what not to do**

Nothing in *this chapter* requires a toxic material, and nothing in it should send you looking for one. The historical alchemical literature is full of mercury, antimony, lead and corrosive acids, and this chapter treats that material historically and gives no procedure for handling any of it. Chapter 29 does give the procedures, hazard before method every time, for a reader who already has a fume hood and a waste-disposal route. If a source hands you one of those operations without the hazard attached, the source is being reckless with you.

Incense needs ventilation. This is the one genuinely common hazard in the book. Burning resins in a small unventilated room is a real respiratory risk, and the tradition — which worked in larger, draughtier rooms than yours — is no guide at all here. Open a window. Every time.

Open flame, unattended, near cloth. Robes, hangings, paper and a candle on a table is how a working becomes a house fire. The historical texts do not warn you about this because their rooms were built of stone and their attention was undivided.

No animal materials requiring harm. Several sources call for them. None is reproduced here, and where a passage was cut for that reason the cut is stated on the page.

Fasting. Several rites prescribe it. Do not, if you have any condition that makes it unwise, and note that the sources prescribe it for people whose ordinary diet and medical expectations were nothing like yours.

MODERN PRACTICE

The honest summary of this chapter is that the barrier to practising almost anything in this book is not equipment. It is the two things the sources ask for that cannot be bought: **a time you have decided on in advance**, and **an hour when you will not be interrupted**. Chapter XX is about the first, and no chapter is about the second — though the sources are not quite silent on it: the *Key of Solomon* asks for a room set apart where you will not be interrupted, and then says no more about how one is to be had.

Practitioners who assemble a full kit before beginning almost always assemble it instead of beginning. The kit above is ten items, most of them already in your kitchen, and a quarter of this book needs none of them.

Sources: This chapter is derived, not sourced: every entry in the table was taken from the text of the rite it names, in the chapter where that rite is printed and under that rite's own citation. The permissions listed under substitutions are the sources' own — the *Clavicula Salomonis* in Mathers's 1889 translation for parchment and paper, for the vessel of tin or glazed earth, and for the consecration of the instruments. The safety notes are this book's: they are modern, and they are in no historical text. The sources are uniformly silent about ventilation, and one of them recommends shutting the room up.

CHAPTER XXIX

The Laboratory

Chapter 5 stops at the third of John French's four degrees of fire and says so plainly: everything it gives is done with warm water, a water bath or a sand bath, and everything it refuses is on the far side of the naked fire, where the metals and minerals are. This chapter crosses that line. It is written for a reader with a working laboratory, and it assumes that reader would rather have the real operations, properly hazarded, than a gap.

What follows is history and chemistry together. Each operation is given as its source gives it, then as it would actually be run now, then as what was chemically happening — which is very often the most interesting part, because it explains why intelligent, careful people concluded they had witnessed a transmutation. They had witnessed something. It was not nothing.

⚠ Read this section before any other in the chapter

The operations below injured the people who invented them. That is not a figure of speech and it is not a moral: it is the documented occupational history of the trade, and it is set out at the end of this chapter. The controls that make these operations survivable did not exist until the twentieth century. You have them. Use them.

The four things that actually cause harm here:

- **Metal fume and dust.** Antimony trioxide and lead oxide are produced as fine fume the moment these charges are hot and open to air. Both are inhalation hazards; antimony trioxide is classed as a suspected human carcinogen. Fume does not smell and does not warn you. The corrosive sublimate belongs under this head too and is the worst of the three: a metal dust that is acutely lethal rather than slowly cumulative, produced by an operation that ends with opening a vessel coated in it.
- **Mercury vapour.** Mercury evaporates appreciably at room temperature and copiously when warmed. It is a cumulative neurotoxin, it is absorbed efficiently through the lungs, and a spill in a warm room is a chronic exposure that persists for months in floor cracks.
- **Corrosive and oxidising acids.** Nitric acid distillation liberates nitrogen dioxide, which is the classic delayed-onset lung injury: you feel fine, and hours later you do not. Aqua regia is worse and cannot be stored.
- **Deflagration.** Several historical charges are nitre-based. A mixture of saltpetre with a sulphide and an organic reducing agent is, chemically, a low-order pyrotechnic composition. Some of these procedures do not melt quietly. They go off.

The controls, none of which are optional: a fume hood with verified face velocity, or genuine outdoor work with the wind at your back and nobody downwind. Nitrile under leather for hot work, splash goggles and a face shield for acids, and a lab coat that stays in the lab. A mercury spill kit within reach *before* mercury is opened, never a domestic vacuum cleaner. Proper waste routes for heavy-metal residues, which are regulated waste and not drain waste. No food, no drink, no phone in the room. Never alone.

One thing this book does not give you. The fulminates are primary explosives. They detonate on friction and impact rather than burning, they are what an initiator is made of, and they are not alchemy at all — mercury fulminate was first prepared by Edward Howard in 1800, long after every source in this book. It is excluded because it does not belong here and not because the chemistry is secret. Everything that *is* alchemy is below, including the poisons.

Calcination and roasting

The first operation of the tradition and the simplest to state: heat a substance in air until it changes. Applied to a metal it produces the *calx*, the powdery oxide, and the observation that a calx weighs *more* than the metal that made it is one of the loose threads that eventually unravels the whole theory. The alchemists recorded the gain and could not explain it. Oxygen explains it.

Applied to stibnite — antimony trisulphide, the grey striated ore that is the raw material of every antimony operation — roasting in air drives off sulphur as sulphur dioxide and leaves antimony trioxide.

ROASTING STIBNITE TO THE WHITE OXIDE

Hazard first. Both products are the hazard. Sulphur dioxide is an acute respiratory irritant. Antimony trioxide is a fine white fume, a suspected carcinogen, and the reason this is a fume-hood or genuinely-outdoors operation and nothing else.

Procedure. Grind the ore coarsely. Spread it thin in a shallow refractory dish — thin matters, because a deep bed sinters and stops reacting. Bring it to a dull red under a fume hood with the sash low, and rake it occasionally to turn fresh surface up. Sulphur dioxide comes off first and is obvious. The charge lightens toward grey, then toward white as the trioxide forms. Do not chase the last of it: overheating volatilises the trioxide, which then condenses everywhere in your hood as the fine dust you least want.

What is happening. $\text{Sb}_2\text{S}_3 + \text{O}_2$ gives $\text{Sb}_2\text{O}_3 + \text{SO}_2$. The white powder the texts call the *calx* or *flowers* of antimony is the oxide, and the sublimate that forms on cool surfaces above the charge is the same thing recondensed — which is why *flowers* is a good name for it.

The regulus of antimony, and its star

This is the central operation of early modern chemistry and the one that most persuaded people that metals could be made. Basil Valentine gives it in three lines:

Take equal parts of best Hungarian Antimony and crude tartar, and half the quantity of saltpetre; pound together, melt over wind fire, pour into copper dish, allow to cool, and you will find the Regulus. The Regulus is thrice, or oftener, purified with tartar and saltpetre till it becomes of a brilliant silvery white.

⚠ What that recipe actually is

Read the charge as a chemist rather than as a reader of alchemy. **Saltpetre is an oxidiser. Tartar is an organic fuel. Antimony sulphide is a sulphide.** Potassium nitrate, carbon and sulphur, in one pot, in a hot dish. That is a description of a deflagrating mixture, and the historical accounts of this operation are full of it going off, throwing the charge, and burning operators.

It does work, and it worked for four centuries. But it is the single most energetic thing in this chapter, and if you run it you run it in small charges, behind a shield, in a heavy crucible with room to spare, outdoors or in a hood with the sash between you and it, with nothing flammable in the vicinity and a route away from the bench. Never scale it up because a small one went well. **The iron-reduction route below does the same job without the oxidiser and is what a modern reconstruction should use unless the nitre route is specifically the object of study.**

And that recommendation turns out to have a precedent of three hundred and forty years. Theodore Kerckring, whose commentary accompanies the text above, appends a footnote to this very charge telling the reader to use salt of tartar in place of crude tartar and adding that “the *sal nitri* is useless in this operation.” He gives no reason and says nothing about the charge going off; he is correcting a recipe, not warning anybody. But the commentator printed on the same page as the recipe had already reached the conclusion this chapter reaches — that the oxidiser earns nothing — and the recipe went on being copied with the saltpetre in it anyway.

THE REGULUS BY IRON REDUCTION — THE CONTROLLED ROUTE

Hazard. Antimony fume; a melt near 700 °C; a crucible that will destroy anything it is dropped on. Fume hood, face shield, leather over nitrile, dry tools — any moisture in a tool put into a melt throws the melt.

Charge. Stibnite with iron — clean iron filings or cut nails, roughly a third the mass of the ore — and a flux of sodium carbonate with a little sodium sulphate.

Procedure. Preheat a clay-graphite crucible empty; a cold crucible charged and heated hard will spall. Charge it no more than two-thirds full and bring it to a full melt, dull orange and quiet. Hold it there until the surface is still and mirror-like rather than boiling — this is the part everyone rushes and should not. Pour into a preheated iron mould, greased and truly dry, and let it cool undisturbed.

You will find two layers, cleanly separated: a brittle grey-white button of metal beneath, and a dark glassy slag above that lifts off. That button is the *regulus*, and it is antimony metal.

What is happening. Iron has the greater affinity for sulphur; it takes it, forming iron sulphide which goes into the slag, and the antimony is left as metal and sinks. The alchemists described this as the iron *seizing* the sulphur, and about the mechanism they were not wrong — only about what it meant.

The star. Cooled slowly and under the right conditions, the surface of the button crystallises in a radiating pattern that looks unmistakably like a star. This is the famous *star regulus* or *regulus stellatus*, and it was taken as a sign that the operation had succeeded and that the antimony had drawn down a celestial influence, the star of the metal made visible. It is dendritic crystallisation, and it depends on purity and cooling rate.

Knowing that does not make it less impressive to see, and it is worth understanding why a careful person looking at it in 1650 concluded what they concluded.

Cupellation: the assay that actually works

If any operation in this literature deserves to be called a genuine analytical technique, it is this one. It is old, it is exact, it is still done, and Agricola describes it in 1556 in terms a modern assayer would recognise. It is also the origin of a good deal of transmutation belief, for a reason that becomes obvious once you see it.

CUPELLATION

Hazard. Lead. The whole operation is a hot open lead melt producing lead oxide fume, which is a cumulative neurotoxin and by far the most under-respected hazard in this chapter because it is so undramatic. Hood, always. Litharge-soaked cupels and the spent lead are regulated waste. Wash before you touch anything.

The cupel. A shallow porous dish of **bone ash**, pressed damp and thoroughly dried. Bone ash is not decorative: it is calcium phosphate, and its porosity and its chemistry are what make the operation work.

Procedure. Bring the cupel to a bright heat in a muffle and let it come to temperature — a cold cupel cracks and takes your assay with it. Add the lead button containing the sample and let it melt and *drive*, which is the assayer's word for the moment the surface goes bright and mobile and begins to fume. Hold it there with air reaching the surface. The melt shrinks steadily. Toward the end the button becomes a small bright bead which suddenly flashes brilliantly and goes still — the *brightening* or *fulguration*, the moment the last of the lead leaves.

What is happening. The lead oxidises to litharge; the litharge dissolves the oxides of the base metals, copper and iron and the rest; and the whole of it soaks into the porous bone ash, which does not absorb gold or silver. What is left standing on the cupel is the noble metal that was in the sample, and nothing else.

Why it convinced people. Watch that without knowing the chemistry. A large dull button of lead is put in. It smokes, shrinks, and vanishes into the dish. Left behind, sitting alone and unmistakable, is a bead of bright silver or gold that was not visible before. Every appearance is of

a base metal being consumed and a noble metal being *born*. It is in fact a separation, not a creation — but the person who insisted otherwise was not being stupid, and could point at the bead.

The mineral acids

The isolation of the strong acids somewhere around the thirteenth century is the single most consequential thing this tradition did. Nothing else it produced changed the world remotely as much. They dissolve what nothing else dissolves, and the whole later chemistry of separation depends on them.

Agricola gives the charges for *aqua valens* — the strong water, nitric acid — plainly enough. One of his is three parts vitriol to one of saltpetre with asbestos and baked brick; another is saltpetre with alum and sal ammoniac. He then describes the furnace: brick, about two feet square, plated over with iron, with a hole in the top for the earthen vessel that holds the glass *ampulla*, and air holes beside it.

DISTILLING THE STRONG WATER

Hazard, and this one is different in kind. The gas that comes off is **nitrogen dioxide**, red-brown, and it is a *delayed* lung injury: exposure can feel minor and develop into pulmonary oedema many hours later. There is no version of this that is safe outside a working fume hood, and anyone who has taken a real breath of it needs medical attention even if they feel well. Nitric acid also attacks skin instantly and stains it yellow, which is your protein.

Procedure, in modern glass. Charge a retort or a distillation flask with the nitrate and the sulphuric acid — this is the modern equivalent of vitriol and saltpetre, and it is the same reaction. Ground-glass joints, no grease that the acid will attack, and a receiver cooled in ice. Heat gently in a sand bath or mantle. The acid distils over; the red fume in the neck is the nitrogen dioxide and tells you it is running. Take it slowly. Stop before the flask goes dry.

Aqua regia is made by combining the strong water with spirit of salt — nitric with hydrochloric, classically one part to three. It dissolves gold, which nothing else in the historical laboratory would do, and the alchemists named it *royal water* for exactly that reason. **Make it in the quantity you are about to use and no more.** It decomposes as it stands, it evolves gas, and a stoppered bottle of aqua regia left on a shelf is a bottle that will eventually burst.

Amalgamation

Mercury dissolves gold and silver at room temperature into a soft amalgam, and the amalgam gives the metal back when heated. That single property made mercury the most important reagent in the tradition, and it is also the property that has poisoned more people than everything else in this chapter combined.

⚠ Before you open mercury

This is the operation on which this book is least relaxed, and the reason is not historical. Gold amalgamation is *currently* the largest source of mercury pollution on earth and the direct cause of chronic mercury poisoning in artisanal mining communities today. The mechanism is precisely the step below: heating the amalgam in the open to drive off the mercury, and breathing what comes off.

Mercury vapour is invisible, odourless, and neurotoxic; a droplet lost in a floor seam evaporates for months. If mercury is opened at all it is opened **in a hood, over a tray that will catch a spill, with a spill kit already open**, never over a drain, never near a warm surface, and never in a room anyone sleeps in. **The mercury is never driven off in the open.** It is done in a closed retort that condenses and recovers it, which is both the safe way and, as it happens, exactly what the better historical sources already tell you to do.

AMALGAMATION AND RECOVERY, IN A CLOSED RETORT

Procedure. Bring finely divided gold into contact with clean mercury and work them together until the gold is taken up; the amalgam is a soft grey paste. Press the excess mercury out through fine leather or a close-woven cloth, which is the historical method and still a good one; what remains is a stiff amalgam holding perhaps two parts gold to one of mercury.

Charge that into an **iron retort** with its neck led into a water-cooled condenser discharging under water. Heat the body of the retort. The mercury distils off, condenses, and is recovered under the water; the gold stays behind as a porous sponge. Let the whole apparatus cool before opening it, and open it in the hood.

What is happening, and what is not. No transmutation and no compound: an amalgam is a solution of a metal in mercury, and the operation is dissolution and recovery. But watch it from outside. Gold vanishes into a silver liquid and is gone. Heat is applied, the liquid departs, and the gold reappears. A substance is destroyed and restored — which is *solve et coagula* performed in front of you in an afternoon, and it is not hard to see why mercury got the philosophical career it did.

Sublimation, and the corrosive sublimate

Sublimation — a solid vaporised and recondensed without ever being liquid — is one of the tradition's favourite operations, because it looks like purification made visible: the substance leaves its dross behind and re-forms above, glittering, in needles. Sal ammoniac sublimes beautifully and harmlessly and is the one to learn on.

The important sublimate of the corpus, though, is *mercurius sublimatus corrosivus* — corrosive sublimate, mercuric chloride. It appears constantly from the Arabic writers onward, it is a reagent in a great many operations, and it is one of the most lethal substances handled routinely in a historical laboratory.

⚠ What this substance is

Mercuric chloride is acutely and severely toxic by ingestion, by inhalation of its dust, and through the skin. A gram is around a lethal dose for an adult. It was for centuries the standard agent of both suicide and homicide in Europe, and it remains the reason old chemistry cupboards are treated as hazardous sites. It is also, in many jurisdictions, subject to poisons regulation; check what applies where you are before acquiring or preparing it.

It is described here because it is genuinely and unavoidably part of the subject — the texts are full of it — and because the chemistry has been in every history of chemistry for two hundred years. Handle it, if at all, as an experienced worker handles a serious poison: weighed in a hood, on a tared paper, never as loose dust, with dedicated glassware that does not return to general use.

The chemistry, in outline, is a partner-exchange followed by a separation by volatility: a mercury salt and common salt are heated together, and the mercuric chloride leaves as vapour where the by-product does not, recondensing cool as a hard translucent crust. It is an elegant piece of work and the alchemists arrived at it by experiment.

The clearest account this edition could reach is Nicolas Lémery's. His *Cours de chymie* of 1675 was reprinted for decades: the London printing of 1720 calls itself on its title page "The Fourth Edition" and "Translated from the Eleventh Edition in the French, which has been revised, corrected, and much

enlarged beyond any of the former.” Walter Harris put it into English as *A Course of Chymistry* in 1677. Lémery gives the preparation in Chapter VIII, *Of Mercury*, under the head *Sublimate Corrosive*, and gives it in four movements: dissolve the mercury in spirit of nitre; evaporate that solution down to a white mass; grind the mass together with calcined vitriol and decrepitated salt; sublime the mixture in a long-necked flask.

Put a pound of Mercury revived from Cinnabar into a Matrass, pour upon it Eighteen or Twenty ounces of Spirit of Niter: Set your Matrass upon Sand a little warm, and leave it there until it be all dissolved; pour your dissolution, which will be clear as water; into a glass-vessel or earthen pot, and evaporate the Liquor gently over a Sand-fire, until there remains a white Mass, which you must powder in a glass mortar, and mix with a pound of Vitriol Calcined white, and so much Salt decrepitated: put this mixture into a Matrass, whose two thirds at least remain empty, place your Matrass on Sand, and begin with giving a small fire, which you must continue so for three hours, then encrease it with coals to a pretty good violence, there will arise a Sublimate to the top of the Matrass; the Operation must be ended in six or seven hours, let the Matrass cool, then break it, avoiding a kind of Farine, or light powder that flies up into the air when the matter is stirred...

Harris’s English of 1677, p. 93, read from the Wellcome copy. The text layer reads every long *s* as an *f*, and it is set here as *s*; the scan’s broken word-spacing is closed up; *encrease* is his spelling and stands. **Five readings are repaired, and are declared here rather than passed off as the scan’s.** The italic fount defeats the capital M, so the text layer gives *Aercury* and *AZercury* throughout for *Mercury* — the chapter is headed *Of Mercury* in roman and comes through clean, which settles it. Then (*inna bar* for *Cinnabar*; *4 slafts-veffel* for *a glass-vessel*; *mortat* for *mortar*; and *Farine-or* for *Farine, or*. Those four are legible in the English edition of 1686, which was consulted to settle characters and supplied no wording. **The ellipsis is a refusal and not a trim.** Lémery closes the paragraph by stating the yield, and both editions are corrupt at exactly that point — 1677 reads *you’l. have a pound aa very good Sublimate Corrofive* — so the figure is not printed here. He ends by directing

that the red scoriae at the bottom be thrown away as useless. The two short quotations in the paragraph below are from p. 95 of the same edition and are set the same way; the second of them also has a line break, the scan reading *very inconve-nient and unwholfom*.

Read the last clause of that quotation again, because it is the nearest thing in this chapter to a historical source protecting its reader. There is one other, and it is worth naming so that the claim stays honest: Kerckring warns twice, in so many words, about vessels bursting — he sets out an apparatus “in order to avoid bursting your vessels, during the distillation of the spirits of metals,” and cautions that too much mercury poured in at once “may burst and overturn the retort and the furnace as well.” Both are mechanical hazards, and both are about protecting the operation as much as the operator. Nobody in this literature writes about what the operation does to the body of the person running it, which is the distinction that matters. Lémery tells you to avoid the *farine* — the flour, the light powder — that flies up when the cold flask is broken open, and he is right: that is the single most dangerous moment of the operation. But he does not connect the dust to the poison he says two pages later will kill a man taken inwardly “in a very little time,” and of the dry route he rejects he says only that it raises a dust to the nose that is “very inconvenient and unwholsom.” A nuisance, in his account, rather than the thing itself made airborne.

THE CORROSIVE SUBLIMATE — HOW IT WOULD BE RUN NOW

Hazard, before anything else. This is the most acutely poisonous product in the chapter, and the procedure stacks three separate hazards on one bench. Dissolving mercury in nitric acid evolves **nitrogen dioxide** in quantity — Lémery's red clouds — which is the delayed lung injury set out under the strong waters above; it is evolved from an open flask of warm mercury, so **mercury vapour** is coming off the same flask at the same time. The product is **mercuric chloride**, of which about a gram is a lethal dose and which is taken up through skin, and the operation finishes by breaking a vessel whose entire inner surface is coated in it as a friable crust. All of this is fume-hood work with the sash low. The last part is fume-hood work with the sash low and a respirator you have been fit-tested for.

The controlled route. The nitric stage exists only to get the mercury into a salt that will exchange partners in the heat, and it can be dropped. Mercuric sulphate ground with dry sodium chloride sublimes to mercuric chloride directly: the same reaction with the worst stage of the preparation removed, and the route to use unless Lémery's own procedure is specifically the object of study. Sublime in an all-glass apparatus, cooled above, that can be opened wet — flood the condensed crust and take it into solution rather than scraping it dry, which is the whole of what Lémery could not do, because his sublimation vessel had to be broken to be emptied. And if the compound rather than the operation is what is wanted, do not sublime at all: mercuric oxide dissolves in hydrochloric acid, and the chloride crystallises out of the cooling solution in the same white needles, with no dust stage anywhere in it.

Waste. Every residue here is a mercury residue — the wash water, the spent glassware, and the red scoriae Lémery tells you to throw away. None of it is drain waste. Dedicated glassware that does not return to

general use; the bench wiped down afterwards and the wipes bagged with the rest.

What is happening. Nitric acid takes the mercury up as mercuric nitrate, and that is the white mass left behind when the solution is evaporated. *Vitriol calcined white* is green vitriol — iron sulphate — dried by heat until it loses its colour; that it is the iron vitriol and not the copper or the zinc one is confirmed by the residue, because iron oxide is what makes the scoriae at the bottom of the flask red. In the fire the sulphate passes to the mercury. The mercuric sulphate so formed exchanges partners with the common salt: sodium takes the sulphate, mercury takes the chloride, and of the two products only mercuric chloride is volatile at that temperature. It leaves the mass, travels up the cold neck, and recondenses there as the crust. The separation is by volatility and by nothing else, and the reason the product comes out pure is that nothing else in the pot will follow it.

The 1686 edition is not a reprint, and two of its changes are worth having.

The first is a correction, and Lémery leads his remarks with it: a pound of mercury does not need anything like the spirit of nitre he had allowed it, and less than half will do. The recipe above is the earlier and wasteful one, and he found that out by running it. The second is an argument. Readers had objected that a sublimate made with spirit of nitre was unfit for making *mercurius dulcis* — the calomel that went into patients — because the nitre would leave its saline and sulphureous parts behind in the product. Lémery answers from the bench rather than from doctrine: red vapours pour out through the neck of the flask for three hours at the least, those vapours can be nothing but the spirits of nitre, and a fire that small cannot raise the spirits of salt and vitriol to follow them. The volatile thing leaves first, and by the end of the operation it has left. He is right, and the form of the argument — an observation of the process answering an objection from theory — is why this book takes him as the clearest account it could reach. **Nothing is quoted from the 1686 here.**

The phrase this paragraph most wanted, the objectors' *saline sulphureous parts*, is corrupt in the scan at both of the places it occurs, and the argument is therefore given in this book's words from a reading of it.

What this book advises, having given the operation. Buy it. Mercuric chloride is a stocked laboratory reagent; it is subject to poisons regulation in many jurisdictions, and that paperwork is itself part of the control; and nothing in this chapter needs it made rather than bought. The preparation is set out because it is a real and central operation of the corpus and a book that gives the regulus and the strong waters and then goes quiet here is not being careful, it is being squeamish about one thing and not another. It is also the one operation in this chapter where the historical route and the modern one part company so far that the honest modern route is not to run it.

What the sublimate is *for* in the corpus is worth knowing regardless. It is a chloride donor and a powerful oxidant, and it is the route by which mercury enters dozens of other preparations — including the various *mercurius vitae* and *mercurius dulcis* of the medical writers, the latter being the calomel that European medicine then administered to patients for three centuries with results that do not bear thinking about.

What it did to them

The occupational toll of this work is documented, and it belongs in the chapter rather than in a footnote, because it is the strongest argument for the controls at the top of it.

Paracelsus wrote what is generally reckoned the first monograph on occupational disease, on the illnesses of miners and smelter workers — *Von der Bergsucht*, the mountain sickness. He was describing the people who prepared the materials this chapter uses, and he was describing metal poisoning, from the inside of the trade, in the sixteenth century. The knowledge was available. What was not available was any means of avoiding it.

Isaac Newton spent decades at this bench, and the analyses performed on surviving samples of his hair have been widely reported as showing greatly elevated mercury. His biographers have connected that to the episode of insomnia, paranoia and derangement he suffered in 1693 and recovered from. Causation is not established and this book does not assert it. What is certain is that a man of extraordinary carefulness worked mercury for years in a small room and that his hair carried the record.

Set that beside the tradition's own language and something uncomfortable comes into focus. The literature is full of warnings that the work destroys the unworthy, ruins the greedy, drives men mad. This book has generally read that as moral instruction dressed as chemistry. It is worth allowing that some of it was straightforwardly a description of what was happening in the room.

MODERN PRACTICE

Historical chemistry is a live and respectable field, and reconstruction is how a good deal of it is now done: the operations are run, the products characterised, and the texts read against what actually comes out of the crucible. That work has repeatedly shown the sources to be more competent and more literal than a century of commentary assumed. Recipes that read like nonsense turn out to describe real products, once you know that *Hungarian antimony* means a particular ore and *crude tartar* a particular grade of potassium bitartrate.

If you are going to do this, do it that way: run the operation, keep a real notebook, weigh everything, and record what actually happened rather than what the text said would. That is what the better alchemists were already doing, and it is the part of their practice worth inheriting.

Sources: Georgius Agricola, *De re metallica* (Basel, 1556), trans. Herbert Clark Hoover and Lou Henry Hoover (London: The Mining Magazine, 1912) public domain — the cupel of bone ash, the conduct of the assay, the charges for *aqua valens* and the furnace built to hold the glass ampulla, in Books VII and X. Basil Valentine, *The Triumphal Chariot of Antimony*, with the commentary of Theodore Kerckringius (London: James Elliott, 1893) public domain — the regulus charge quoted above, p. 142, verified there against the page; Kerckring’s note on the *sal nitri* is the footnote to that page, and his two warnings about bursting vessels are the footnotes to pp. 136 and 137. **Three things about this volume are worth stating, because the chapter leans on it.** Its title page describes it as “being the Latin version published at Amsterdam in the year 1685 translated into English” — so what is printed above is English out of Kerckring’s Latin, and not out of whatever German stands behind Valentine: a translation of a translation, and the wording quoted is the 1893 translator’s. That translator is **not named on the title page**; catalogue records give A. E. Waite, and the publisher is the house that issued Waite’s *Hermetic Museum* in the same year, which is suggestive and is not proof. This edition does not treat the attribution as settled. And “Basil Valentine” is a persona rather than a documented person; the authorship question is real, this book did not investigate it, and no position is taken here. John French, *The Art of Distillation* (1653), for the degrees of fire, cited in full in Chapter 5. Nicolas Lémery, *Cours de chymie* (Paris, 1675), in the English of Walter Harris, *A Course of Chymistry* (London: printed for Walter Kettilby, 1677) public domain — the corrosive sublimate in the First Part, *Of Minerals*, ch. VIII, *Of Mercury*, pp. 93–96 — the long quotation above from p. 93 and the two short ones from p. 95; read from the Wellcome Collection copy on the Internet Archive, identifier b3033696x, with characters checked against the English edition of 1686 (Wellcome b30326618), which supplied no wording. The five readings repaired in the long quotation, and the normalisations applied to all three, are declared beneath it. The edition statement quoted above is from the title page of the London printing of 1720, read from the Eighteenth Century Collections scan on the Internet Archive, identifier bim_eighteenth-century_cours-de-chymie-englis_lemery-nicolas_1720; that page sets the long *s* properly and needs no repair, though a stray point after *in the* is dropped. The booksellers named in its imprint are not given here because two of their initials are damaged in the scan and expanding them would be a guess. Paracelsus’s *Von der Bergsucht* is named here for what it is and is not quoted; no edition was consulted for this book. **The hazard assessments, the control measures and all the modern procedural detail are this book’s own and are not in any historical source. No text in this chapter warns its reader about metal fume, mercury vapour, delayed lung injury or cumulative neurotoxicity, because none of that was known.** One partial exception is worth recording, since it is the only one: Lémery tells his reader to avoid the light

powder that flies up when the sublimation flask is broken open, and says of the dry route he rejects that it raises an unwholesome dust. He had noticed the dust. He frames it as a nuisance rather than as the poison he elsewhere states the substance to be, and about the vapour he says nothing at all. Where a historical method and a safer modern one differ, both are given and the difference is stated.

Sources & Bibliography

The principal sources of this grimoire are listed below by period, with dates, authors or translators where known, and copyright status where it affects availability. It is not exhaustive, and it is not the only apparatus: each chapter carries its own sources line, and for several texts printed verbatim — Goodwin's papyri, Budge's rubrics, Grendon's charms, Culpeper, French — the full citation lives there rather than here. Entries are grouped by period so that the shape of the tradition's actual chronology is visible at a glance — which is, in itself, the argument of this book.

ON WHAT “VERIFIED” MEANS HERE

Each entry below was checked for author, date and status before being included. That checking was done at two different depths, and the difference is worth stating. A first pass used reference scholarship and encyclopedic sources. A second pass went to primary materials — the 1849 Rheinwald edition of Andreae’s *Vita*, Waite’s 1887 and 1924 volumes in full text, Yates, Chapel’s 2013 article — for the claims this book’s argument actually rests on: the Kybalion attribution, the dating of the *Hermetica*, Casaubon’s redating, Andreae’s *ludibrium*, Edighoffer on the Brotherhood, and the provenance of the Papyri. Entries touched only by the first pass are therefore less securely verified than those touched by the second.

Four further rules follow from that checking, and each guards against a failure this kind of book is prone to. A paraphrase acquires false authority the moment it is given quotation marks and a name, so no sentence is printed as a scholar’s words unless it was read in that scholar’s text. A text printed verbatim is set from the edition its citation names — never from a secondary copy, however close — and where a second scan was used to settle characters, the sources line says so. And correction has failure modes of its own — a lexicon cited for a sense it does not carry, a causal chain no scholar asserts, a hedge hardened into a flat denial — so repairs were held to the same standard of verification as the claims they replaced. And this book does not print quotations it has only read through corrupt OCR: where a scan’s text layer is unusable, the leaf is read by eye on the page images — as it was for Agrippa, for Trithemius and for Court de Gébelin — or the passage stays unprinted.

Where the record is genuinely unsettled — who assembled the Lesser Banishing Ritual and when, the precise origin of individual Golden Dawn exercises, the relative priority of the Greek and Latin Solomonic texts, the ownership of the Theban Magical Library, the meaning of *ludibrium* — the relevant chapter reports the dispute rather than choosing a convenient answer. Claims in the body text that carry no citation are ones where a

specific attribution could not be verified; they are written as general statements for that reason. A bibliography's usefulness depends entirely on the reader being able to trust that nothing was added to make it look longer.

Ancient: the primary material (c. 100 BCE – c. 400 CE)

Corpus Hermeticum — seventeen Greek treatises, composed c. 100–300 CE. The collection's date and compiler are unknown; first attested in Byzantium in Michael Psellos (c. 1017–1078), with surviving manuscripts late medieval and later.

Nag Hammadi Hermetica — three tractates in Codex VI: *The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (VI,6), the Prayer of Thanksgiving (VI,7) with its Scribal Note (VI,7a), and *Asclepius* 21–29 (VI,8) — a single continuous excerpt, not scattered fragments. The Coptic is ancient, but there is no public-domain edition or translation of it: the codices were found in 1945 and first published in the 1970s. The Prayer of Thanksgiving is nonetheless printed in Chapter 2, because its parallel Latin text — *Asclepius* 41 — exists in Mead's 1906 translation, which is out of copyright.

Asclepius — surviving mainly in Latin translation, with Greek and Coptic fragments.

Papyri Graecae Magicae (PGM) — extant texts from the late 4th c. BCE (PGM XL, the curse of Artemisia, an isolated outlier) and 1st c. BCE down to the 5th c. CE, Christian magical texts into the 6th; the bulk 3rd–5th c. CE. In Greek, Demotic and Old Coptic. Provenance largely the Theban material assembled by Jean d'Anastasi — vice-consul and from 1828 Consul-General of Sweden and Norway at Alexandria — acquired through agents before 1828 and dispersed to Leiden (Dutch government purchase, 1828), the British Museum, the Louvre, the Bibliothèque Nationale and Berlin. Ownership of the “Theban Magical Library” is disputed; Betz's single-collector suggestion is hedged, and Dosoo argues for multiple collectors.

Leyden papyrus X (P. Leid. I 397) and the Stockholm papyrus (P. Holm., Kungliga Biblioteket) — alchemical texts of the 4th c. CE from the same reconstructed Theban group, in the same hand or very nearly as PGM XIII. Not to be confused with Leiden W (P. Leid. I 395), which is PGM XIII itself. Both are edited in Berthelot and Ruelle, *Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs* (Paris: Steinheil, 1887–88). EDITION PUBLIC DOMAIN

Defixiones (curse and binding tablets) — the earliest from the late 6th and early 5th centuries BCE, the oldest of them Sicilian; recovered from Sicily, Athens, Asia Minor, Rome and Egypt, over a thousand texts in all. Jessica L. Lamont, *Greece & Rome* 69,

no. 1 (2022), 27–51, for the dating. Audollent, *Defixionum tabellae* (1904), remains the standard corpus. EDITION PUBLIC DOMAIN

Testament of Solomon — Greek pseudepigraphon; the core placed around the first century CE by F. C. Conybeare, “The Testament of Solomon,” *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 11 (October 1898), 1–45, whose English is quoted in Chapter 11. The dating literature since ranges from the first to the third century; the frame is Jewish, the transmission Christian. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Zosimos of Panopolis (fl. c. 300 CE) — the earliest alchemical writer whose substantial corpus survives under his own name; the source for the colour stages and for Mary the Jewess.

Pseudo-Democritus, *Physika kai mystika* — often described as among the oldest surviving alchemical writings. Ancient testimony names four books under the name, on gold, silver, stones and purple. Whether the Greek stage-names *melanosis*, *leukosis*, *xanthosis* and *iosis* all occur in it was not checked for this edition against Matteo Martelli, *The Four Books of Pseudo-Democritus* (2013), which could not be obtained. Liddell–Scott’s citations for *iosis* are the Leiden magical papyrus, Olympiodorus and Zosimos, not Democritus.

Mary the Jewess (Maria Hebraea), Greco-Roman Egypt, most likely between the 1st and 3rd centuries CE — the specialist literature declines to name a city (some scholars: no later than the 1st) — credited via Zosimos with the *tribikos*, the *kerotakis* and the *bain-marie*; the Axiom of Maria. Named among the alchemists listed in Ibn al-Nadīm, *Kitāb al-Fihrist* (10th c.) — the figure of fifty-two that popular accounts give was not checked against Dodge’s translation for this edition. The claim in George Syncellus (active c. 800; the *Chronography* c. 808–810) that she was among the initiators of Democritus is chronologically impossible.

Medieval and Arabic (8th – 15th centuries)

Kitāb Sirr al-Khalīqa wa-Ṣan‘at al-Ṭabī‘a (Book of the Secret of Creation and the Art of Nature) — compiled in Arabic in the late 8th or early 9th century; contains the oldest known recension of the Emerald Tablet. Dating contested: Ruska (1926) 6th–8th c.; Kraus (1942–43) c. 813–833; Weissner (1980) c. 750–800. Presents itself as a translation of a treatise by Apollonius of Tyana (Balīnūs).

Pseudo-Jābir ibn Ḥayyān, *Kitāb Uṣūqus al-Uss al-Thānī* (Second Book of the Element of the Foundation) — a shorter version of the Tablet: nine lines against the *Sirr al-khalīqa*’s fifteen, with lines 6, 8 and 11–15 absent and other parts corrupt. Published and analysed in Holmyard, “The Emerald Table,” *Nature* 112 (1923), 525–26, and Ruska

(1926), p. 121, who takes this version to be dependent on the *Sirr al-khalīqa* rather than earlier than it.

Ibn Umayl (Abū ‘Abd Allāh Muḥammad ibn Umayl al-Tamīmī, c. 900–960; Latin “Senior Zadiṯ filius Hamuel”), *Book of the Silvery Water and the Starry Earth* — c. 10th century; later translated into Latin as the *Tabula Chemica*. Quotes the Tablet and glosses it clause by clause (Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, *Ambix* 3 (1949), 69–90, sect. XXI at p. 81). Its own frame story — a seated figure in a *birbā*, rendered “the Pyramid” in Stapleton’s translation, holding a stone slab — concerns a different object; the Tablet text appears separately later in the treatise. He is **not** the source of the discovery narrative, which belongs to the *Sirr al-khalīqa*.

Pseudo-Aristotle, *Sirr al-Asrār* (*Secretum Secretorum*, Secret of Secrets) — 10th century; the long version carries the Tablet toward its end. Latin text in Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Oxford, 1920), pp. 115–17, where it is described as appearing “in its earliest known form.”

Jābir ibn Ḥayyān; Abū Bakr al-Rāzī — the Arabic-Islamic alchemical tradition through which much of this material reached Latin Europe. Note that al-Rāzī wrote his own *Kitāb Sirr al-asrār*, which is a different work from the pseudo-Aristotelian *Sirr al-Asrār* above.

Latin transmission of the Emerald Tablet: Robert of Chester (1144), *Book on the Composition of Alchemy* — generally considered the first Latin translation of an Arabic alchemical treatise, though the attribution to Robert rests only on a prologue that Marion Dapsens, *Studia graeco-arabica* 6 (2016), 121–40, concludes is genuinely his yet probably not written for this text; the **vulgate version**, probably 12th century, tentatively attributed to Plato of Tivoli (active c. 1134–45), surviving embedded in an anonymous Latin compilation of commentaries on the Tablet and itself the most circulated version and the basis of all later editions; Hugo of Santalla (c. 1145–51), from the *Secret of Creation* itself, surviving in a single contemporary manuscript (Paris, BnF lat. 13951) and one copy; Philip of Tripoli (13th c.), via the *Secret of Secrets*, whose more than six hundred manuscript witnesses (Williams, 2003, p. 349) are what give “by some measures” its content.

Commentaries on the Emerald Tablet: Hortulanus (Ortolanus), probably active in the first half of the 14th century — the commentary that circulated most widely in print (1541, 1545, 1560 as the *Compendium alchimiae* under Johannes de Garlandia’s name, and 1571), reading the text as laboratory recipe; Albertus Magnus, *On Minerals*, c. 1250; Roger Bacon, c. 1275–80, who believed the *Secret of Secrets* genuinely Aristotle’s; Johannes Trithemius, early 16th century, who shifted the reading toward the Pythagorean monad and the *anima mundi*; his letter to Germain de Ganay, printed 1613, is quoted in Chapter 6 from the page images.

Ars Notoria — 13th century (Véronèse's version A); the glossed version at the end of the 13th, surviving in three 14th-century MSS; the core *Flores aurei* possibly later 12th. Later absorbed as book five of the *Lemegeton*.

Clavicula Salomonis (*Key of Solomon*) — the Latin/Italian *Clavicula* is now generally placed in the **16th century**, possibly the 15th: Mathiesen (2007) argues it was translated in Italy from a Greek original that had reached Italy by the 15th century, and that no Western manuscript is securely earlier than the 16th. The older attribution to the 14th or 15th century derives from A. E. Waite rather than from modern scholarship. Surviving Western MSS are chiefly late 16th–18th century — of 122 recorded by Mathiesen only eight are 16th-century. Notable witnesses: Bodleian MS Michael 276 (Italian; undated by Mathiesen, 17th c. per Peterson) and BL Sloane MS 3847 (English, 1572). Pseudepigraphic.

Magical Treatise of Solomon (*Apotelesmatikē pragmateia Solomōntos*), also circulating as *The Little Key of the Whole Art of Hygromancy* — known from sixteen or seventeen Greek manuscripts, six of them 15th-century, including BL Harley MS 5596. Priority against the *Clavicula* is not finally settled, but the specialist literature leans to the Greek as the ancestral form, from which the earliest Western version was almost certainly translated. Armand Delatte transcribed **one Athens manuscript** in *Anecdota Atheniensia* (Liège/Paris, 1927), pp. 397–445 — not the Harley manuscript. Fuller editions: Pablo A. Torijano, *Solomon the Esoteric King* (Brill, 2002); Ioannis Marathakis, *The Magical Treatise of Solomon or Hygromanteia* (Golden Hoard, 2011).

Sworn Book of Honorius (*Liber Juratus*) — 14th century, in manuscript; untitled, but understood from its own text to be the sworn book of a Honorius. Not to be confused with the printed *Grimoire of Honorius* of 1629, which trades on the name; see Chapter 10. Dating and description from Waite (1911), below.

Renaissance and early modern (15th – 17th centuries)

Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) — Latin translation of the *Corpus Hermeticum* (treatises I–XIV), *Liber de potestate et sapientia Dei / Pimander*, completed 1463 on Cosimo de' Medici's order and dedicated to him (d. 1464), from Laurentianus LXXI, 33; first printed at Treviso by Gerardus de Lisa, 18 December 1471, in an edition Ficino neither prepared nor authorised. Lodovico Lazzarelli (1447–1500).

Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim (1486–1535), *De occulta philosophia libri tres* — Book I 1531 (Paris: Christian Wechel; Antwerp: Johannes Grapheus — the Cologne 1531 imprint often listed alongside these is unattested in the catalogues); complete three

books [Cologne]: Johannes Soter, July 1533 (VD16 A 1180). English translation by “J.F.” (probably John French), 1651. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy — earliest imprint Marburg, 1559 (VD16 A 1185), twenty-four years after Agrippa’s death; **spurious**, denounced as a forgery by Johann Weyer, who called it an “abominabilis libellus” foisted on a man some twenty-seven years dead. PUBLIC DOMAIN

George Ripley, *Compound of Alchymy* (1471) — the Twelve Gates. The fourteen stages usually given under the name of Samuel Norton (16th century) are in fact numbered in *Mercurius redivivus*, ed. Edmund Deane (Frankfurt, 1630), and not in Norton’s *Key of Alchemy* of 1578; see Chapter 5.

De Alchemia, ed. “Chrysogonus Polydorus” (probably a pseudonym for Andreas Osiander), Johann Petreius, Nuremberg, **1541** — the *editio princeps* of the Tablet as a free-standing alchemical text, and the first to print it with Hortulanus’s commentary; a different Latin version was already in print inside the *Secretum secretorum* by 1501 at the latest (Achillini’s Bologna edition), and possibly in the incunables of the 1480s. PUBLIC DOMAIN

John Dee, *Monas Hieroglyphica* (1564). Dee and Kelley’s Enochian diaries (1580s).

Johann Weyer (1515–1588), *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563, *libri V*) — argued against the witch persecutions and criticised the *Malleus Maleficarum*. The *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum* was **not** in the first edition: it was appended to the fifth (Basel, March 1577) and retained in the sixth (1583), and Weyer edited rather than authored the list. Weyer became a live-in *famulus* of Agrippa’s at fifteen. The *Pseudomonarchia* is quoted in Chapter 11 through Scot’s English; its Latin was not read on page images for this edition.

Reginald Scot, *The discoverie of witchcraft* (London, **1584**) — the most radical English attack on witch-belief of its century, and, in its fifteenth book, the carrier of Weyer’s catalogue into English. Quoted in Chapter 11 from the 1886 reprint of the first edition, read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *discoverieofwic00scot*. PUBLIC DOMAIN

King James VI of Scotland, *Daemonologie, in forme of a dialogue* (Edinburgh, **1597**) — written expressly against Scot and Weyer, both named in its preface; quoted in Chapter 11 from the page images of the Early English Books scan of the 1597 printing. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Malleus Maleficarum (first printed c. 1486) — the inquisitors’ handbook; named and described in Chapter 11 and not quoted: the standard English translation of 1928 is in copyright, and no public-domain rendering was consulted for this edition.

Paracelsus (1493 or 1494–1541; the birth year is inferred rather than documented) — iatrochemistry and the medical application of alchemy. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Heinrich Khunrath, *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae* — first printing Hamburg, **1595**; the familiar Hanau 1609 edition is the second and last, published posthumously (Khunrath d. 1605), edited by Erasmus Wolfart, with nine engraved plates. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Isaac Casaubon (1559–1614), *De rebus sacris et ecclesiasticis exercitationes XVI* (London, 1614), written against Baronius's *Annales* — argued the Greek Hermetica were composed partly out of Plato and the Platonists and partly out of Christian scripture, in Greek later than that current around the birth of Christ. His own formula is *primis illis seculis nascentis Christianismi*; he gives no numeric range. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Fama Fraternitatis Rosae Crucis — MS circulating c. 1610; published Cassel, **1614**. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Confessio Fraternitatis — Cassel: Wilhelm Wessel, **1615**, appended to Philippus a Gabella, *Secretioris Philosophiae Consideratio brevis* (reissued 1616). PUBLIC DOMAIN

Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz (*Chymical Wedding*) — **1616**; acknowledged by Johann Valentin Andreae (1586–1654) in his posthumous autobiography, and described by him as a *ludibrium*. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Johann Valentin Andreae, *Vita ab ipso conscripta* — unpublished in his lifetime; first printed in German translation by D. C. Seybold, *Selbstbiographie Joh. Valentin Andreaë's* (Winterthur, 1799), the Latin original ed. F. H. Rheinwald (Berlin, 1849). Lib. I, p. 10 for the *ludibrium* passage; Lib. II, p. 46 for “that Rosicrucian *ludibrium*.” PUBLIC DOMAIN

Michael Maier (1568?–1622; VD17 and GND give 1569), *Atalanta fugiens* (Oppenheim: Hieronymus Galler for Johann Theodor de Bry, 1617, plates engraved by Matthäus Merian the Elder; a further Oppenheim printing followed in 1618, neither title page carrying an edition statement); *Silentium Post Clamores* (Frankfurt am Main: Lucas Jennis, 1617, with a German translation the same year). Robert Fludd (1574–1637); Elias Ashmole (1617–1692). PUBLIC DOMAIN

Lemegeton (*Lesser Key of Solomon*) — compiled mid-17th century from older materials; five books: *Ars Goetia*, *Ars Theurgia Goetia*, *Ars Paulina*, *Ars Almadel*, *Ars Notoria*.

William Lilly, *Christian Astrology, modestly treated of in three Books* (London, **1647**) — the first substantial treatment of the art in English: chart erection, horary and nativities. Used in Chapter 21, from the Wellcome copy. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Meric Casaubon (ed.), *A True & Faithful Relation of What passed for many Yeers Between D^r. John Dee... and Some Spirits* (London: D. Maxwell for T. Garthwait, **1659**) — the first printing of Dee’s angelic diaries, issued with a preface holding the spirits real and evil; the editor is the son of the Isaac Casaubon of 1614, above. Used in Chapter 14.

PUBLIC DOMAIN

Christian Knorr von Rosenroth, *Kabbala Denudata* (Sulzbach and Frankfurt, **1677–84**) — the Latin anthology through which the *Zohar* reached Christian Europe, including the Idra Rabba and Idra Suta in its second volume. Named in Chapter 4 on the authority of Ginsburg and Mathers; not consulted for this book.

Georgius Agricola (Georg Bauer, 1494–1555), *De re metallica* (Basel, **1556**), published the year after his death — the standard description of sixteenth-century mining and assaying, and the source in Chapter 29 for cupellation, for the charges for *aqua valens* and for the furnace built to hold the glass *ampulla*. Quoted here in the translation of Herbert Clark Hoover and Lou Henry Hoover (London: The Mining Magazine, 1912) — the work of a mining engineer who later became President of the United States, and of his wife, who was a geologist. PUBLIC DOMAIN

“Basil Valentine” (Basilius Valentinus), *The Triumphal Chariot of Antimony*, with the commentary of Theodore Kerckringius — a persona presented as a fifteenth-century Benedictine rather than a documented person; the authorship question is genuinely open and is not settled here. Used in Chapter 29 in the English of 1893 (London: James Elliott), which its own title page describes as a rendering of Kerckring’s Latin published at Amsterdam in **1685** — so the English is at two removes from anything Valentine may have written. The 1893 translator is not named on the title page; catalogue records give A. E. Waite. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Nicolas Lémery (1645–1715), *Cours de chymie* (Paris, **1675**) — reprinted and revised for decades; the London English of 1720 announces itself as “The Fourth Edition” translated from “the Eleventh Edition in the French.” Walter Harris’s English, *A Course of Chymistry* (London: printed for Walter Kettilby, 1677), is the text used in Chapter 29 for the corrosive sublimate. The English edition of 1686 is not a reprint: it corrects Lémery’s own quantities and adds his defence of the method against its critics. PUBLIC DOMAIN

The eighteenth century

Antoine Court de Gébelin, *Monde Primitif, analysé et comparé avec le Monde Moderne*, vol. 8 (Paris, **1781**) — the essay that gave the tarot its Egyptian pedigree — *Du Jeu des Tarots*, opening at p. 365, with the *Recherches* on divination by the cards, signed “M. le

C. de M.”, following. Read on the page images of the Internet Archive scan *mondeprimitifana08cour* and quoted in Chapter 25; Waite’s page range, cited there, proves exact. PUBLIC DOMAIN

The printed French grimoires — *Grimorium Verum* (“1517,” actually mid-18th century), *Grand Grimoire*, *Grimoire of Honorius* (1629), *True Black Magic* (“Rome, 1750”), *The Black Pullet* and its relatives (late 18th century) — surveyed in Chapter 10, with every date from Waite (1911), below; none of them was seen for this edition, and their title pages are quoted from his catalogue of the imprints.

Modern: orders, editions and interpretation (19th – 21st centuries)

Éliphas Lévi, *Dogme et Rituel de la Haute Magie* (Paris, **1854–56**) — the book that joined the tarot’s twenty-two trumps to the Hebrew alphabet. Quoted in Chapter 25 in the English of A. E. Waite, *Transcendental Magic: Its Doctrine and Ritual*. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Christian D. Ginsburg, *The Kabbalah: Its Doctrines, Development, and Literature* (London, **1865**) — the spine of Chapter 4: the En Soph and the emanation of the sephiroth, the four worlds, and the case for Moses de León’s authorship of the *Zohar*, citing Jellinek (1851) and Graetz (1863). Read in the verbatim Routledge reprint of 1920. PUBLIC DOMAIN

S. L. MacGregor Mathers, *The Kabbalah Unveiled* (London: George Redway, **1887**) — three books of the *Zohar* in English, from Rosenroth’s Latin collated with the original; its introduction reprints Ginsburg’s dating essay, so the case against the text’s antiquity travelled inside the translation itself. See Chapter 4. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Alister Crowley, *Liber AL vel Legis* (received **1904**; first published in *The Equinox*, 1909) — the founding document of Thelema; quoted in Chapter 27 from the 1904 text, with Crowley’s later introduction left aside. PUBLIC DOMAIN IN THE US

A. E. Waite, *The Book of Ceremonial Magic* (London: William Rider & Son, **1911**; 1913 printing also cited here) — his hostile but exactly dated catalogue of the printed grimoires, the authority for the survey in Chapter 10. PUBLIC DOMAIN IN THE US; WAITE D. 1942

A. E. Waite, *The Pictorial Key to the Tarot* (London: William Rider & Son, **1911**) — the companion to the Waite–Smith pack of 1909; source for the Strength–Justice interchange and its refused explanation, and for the citation of Court de Gébelin. See Chapter 25. PUBLIC DOMAIN

- Margaret A. Murray, *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe: A Study in Anthropology* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, **1921**) — the witch-cult thesis, no longer held by historians and indispensable to the history of what came after it; see Chapter 27. PUBLIC DOMAIN
- A. E. Waite, *The Real History of the Rosicrucians* (London: George Redway, 1887) — source of the “reprehensible hoax” verdict on Andreae (p. 240) and of “before he was sixteen” (p. 232) PUBLIC DOMAIN; *The Brotherhood of the Rosy Cross* (London: William Rider & Son, 1924) — where Waite argues at length that the hoax hypothesis should be dropped (pp. 122 n., 207), a position already implicit in 1887 (pp. 225, 234). Citations of either book for the hoax reading misread him.
- S. L. MacGregor Mathers (trans.), *The Key of Solomon the King* (1889) — “first Translated and Edited from Ancient MSS. in the British Museum” (the British Library did not exist until 1973); seven codices, incl. Add. MS 10,862, Sloane 1307 and 3091, Harleian 3981, King’s 288, Lansdowne 1202–1203. Limited to 500 copies. PUBLIC DOMAIN
- Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn — founded 1887–88 by William Robert Woodman, William Wynn Westcott and S. L. MacGregor Mathers; Isis-Urania Temple, London, 1888; the original order fractured in 1903, successor bodies continuing for decades. Cipher Manuscripts in Trithemius cipher, decoded by Westcott in 1887.
- [S. L. MacGregor Mathers (trans., uncredited)] and Aleister Crowley (ed.), *The Book of the Goetia of Solomon the King, Translated into the English Tongue by a Dead Hand ... The Whole Edited, Verified, Introduced and Commented by Aleister Crowley* (Boleskine, Foyers, Inverness: Society for the Propagation of Religious Truth, **1904**) — Book One of the *Lemegeton* only, not the complete *Lesser Key*. Mathers, the uncredited translator, was alive until 1918; “a dead hand” is Crowley’s insult. PUBLIC DOMAIN
- Joseph H. Peterson (ed.), *The Lesser Key of Solomon: Lemegeton Clavicula Salomonis Regis* (2001), based on BL Sloane MS 3825 — the authority for the dating and manuscript basis of the whole five-book work. IN COPYRIGHT
- G. R. S. Mead, *Thrice-Greatest Hermes*, 3 vols (London and Benares: Theosophical Publishing Society, 1906) — Theosophically inflected; scholarly superseded, but the most accessible free route to the Hermetica. PUBLIC DOMAIN
- Three Initiates [William Walker Atkinson, 1862–1932], *The Kybalion* (Chicago, **1908**) — New Thought; source of the Seven Hermetic Principles. PUBLIC DOMAIN
- Karl Preisendanz, *Papyri Graecae Magicae. Die Griechischen Zauberpapyri*, 2 vols (1928, 1931) — the critical edition; vol. 1 available at the Internet Archive. A third volume was set and reached galley proof, its preface dated Pentecost 1941, when Teubner’s Leipzig house was bombed on 4 December **1943**; the proofs survived and circulate in photocopy, and the 1941 preface is reprinted in the second edition. 2nd edition with

Albert Henrichs, 1973–74. IN COPYRIGHT — Preisendanz d. 1968, Henrichs d. 2017; in the United States only volume 1 has entered the public domain (1 January 2024), volume 2 following in 2027, so the Internet Archive recommendation above is sound for US readers only. Superseded for the formularies by Faraone and Torallas Tovar (2022).

Walter Scott, *Hermetica*, 4 vols (1924–36) — foundational; editorial choices now contested. Scott died in 1925 after only vol. 1 had appeared; A. S. Ferguson (1883–1958) saw vols 2–3 through the press and wholly authored vol. 4, the *Testimonia*. Catalogue hazard: some records misattribute the work to Walter Scott the novelist (1771–1832). MIXED — Scott’s own matter is public domain, but Ferguson d. 1958, so volume 4 entire and his additions to volumes 2–3 remain in copyright in the UK and EU until 1 January 2029.

Israel Regardie, *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order*, 4 vols (1937–40) — the publication of the order’s reserved material. IN COPYRIGHT — Regardie d. 1985, so protected in the UK and EU until 2056; scans on the Internet Archive are not evidence to the contrary. The underlying Golden Dawn documents are themselves out of copyright (Mathers d. 1918, Westcott d. 1925, Woodman d. 1891); Regardie’s compilation and commentary are a separate protected layer.

Bernard Gorceix, *La Bible des Rose-Croix* (1970) — translations and commentary on all three manifestos.

Paul Arnold, *Histoire des Rose-Croix* (Paris, 1935), p. 50 — renders *ludibrium* “une farce.” Charles Webster, “Macaria: Samuel Hartlib and the Great Reformation,” *Acta Comeniana* 26 (1970), p. 149 — “derisive terms.” Against these, Yates (pp. 68, 184–85) reads it as theatrical fiction: “not a hoax, but a dramatic presentation.” Lexicography: Lewis & Short, s.v. *ludibrium*.

Renko Geffarth — archive-based study of the Gold- und Rosenkreuzer; its reviewer (Michael Driedger, *H-German*, Feb. 2010) describes it as covering circles existing “from around 1760 until sometime after 1790” — a statement of duration, not a founding date.

Frances A. Yates, *The Rosicrucian Enlightenment* (1972) — the standard modern treatment; see Brian Vickers’s critique, *Journal of Modern History* 51:2 (1979). IN COPYRIGHT

Alan F. Segal, “Hellenistic Magic: Some Questions of Definition” (1981).

Garth Fowden, *The Egyptian Hermes: A Historical Approach to the Late Pagan Mind* (1986).

Hans Dieter Betz (ed.), *The Greek Magical Papyri in Translation, Including the Demotic Spells* (University of Chicago Press, 1986; 2nd ed. 1992) — the standard English

translation. IN COPYRIGHT

Brian P. Copenhaver, *Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius* (Cambridge, 1992) — the standard modern scholarly translation. IN COPYRIGHT

David Frankfurter, “Ritual Expertise in Roman Egypt and the Problem of the Category ‘Magician’” (1997).

Roland Edighoffer, “Rosicrucianism I: First half of the 17th Century,” in Wouter J. Hanegraaff (ed.), in collaboration with Antoine Faivre, Roelof van den Broek and Jean-Pierre Brach, *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism* (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2005), 1009–1014, at 1009 and 1014; and Edighoffer, “Rosicrucianism II: 18th Century,” *ibid.*, 1014–1017, at 1015, for the 1763 date. IN COPYRIGHT

M. David Litwa, *Hermetica II: The Excerpts of Stobaeus, Papyrus Fragments, and Ancient Testimonies* (2018). IN COPYRIGHT

Nicholas E. Chapel, “The Kybalion’s New Clothes,” *Journal of the Western Mystery Tradition* No. 24, Vol. 3 (2013) — the detailed study of the work’s relation to the historical Hermetic current; source of the David Hartley (1705–1757) origin for the principle of vibration — a derivation that is Chapel’s own reconstruction, his only supporting citation being Barbara Oberg, “David Hartley and the Association of Ideas,” *Journal of the History of Ideas* 37, no. 3 (1976), 442–43, a study of associationism that does not mention Hermeticism.

C. G. Jung — the reading of the alchemical corpus as a symbolic account of individuation; 20th-century interpretation. IN COPYRIGHT

Isaac Newton — English rendering of the Emerald Tablet, Keynes MS. 28, King’s College Library, Cambridge, ff. 2r–2v; text from *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton*, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010), ALCH00017, transcribed by John A. Johnson. His Latin copy on a later leaf of the same manuscript reads *pater omnis perfectionis* where the vulgate has *telesmi*; B. J. T. Dobbs argued the English was made from a French version, probably the *Bibliothèque des philosophes* (1672–8). The variant is older than his copy: the Trithemius letter printed in 1613 already reads *Pater omnis perfectionis totius mundi hic est*. No line of transmission is asserted here. NEWTON’S WORDING
PUBLIC DOMAIN

Helena Blavatsky, *Isis Unveiled* (New York: J. W. Bouton, 1877), vol. 1, pp. 294, 306, 507; *The Secret Doctrine* (1888) — popularised the paraphrase “as above, so below,” which she quotes as an existing “Hermetic axiom” rather than presenting as her own. The earliest attestation of the maxim in this Hermetic sense is not established; the words occur in English before 1877 in unrelated devotional use, which makes “the wording is hers” harder to assert rather than easier. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Robert Steele (ed.), *Secretum secretorum cum glossis et notulis* (Opera hactenus inedita Rogeri Baconi, fasc. V; Oxford: Clarendon, 1920) — the critical edition of the Latin *Secret of Secrets*; the Emerald Table at pp. 115–17, described there as appearing in its earliest known form. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Robert Steele and Dorothea Waley Singer, “The Emerald Table,” *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine* 21 (1928), 485–501 — the source of the English of the vulgate’s second verse quoted in Chapter 6. A separate Steele and Singer article on the Tablet appeared in the *Journal of Chemical Education* 3, no. 8 (1926); the two should not be merged. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Françoise Hudry (ed.), “Le *De secretis nature* du ps.-Apollonius de Tyane, traduction latine par Hugues de Santalla du *Kitāb sirr al-ḥalīqa*,” *Chrysopoeia* 6 (1997–99), 1–154 — the critical edition of Hugo of Santalla’s translation. IN COPYRIGHT

Marion Dapsens, “De la *Risālat Maryānus* au *De Compositione alchemiae*,” *Studia graeco-arabica* 6 (2016), 121–40 — the current specialist treatment of the Robert of Chester attribution. Open access, not public domain.

Steven J. Williams, *The Secret of Secrets: The Scholarly Career of a Pseudo-Aristotelian Text in the Latin Middle Ages* (University of Michigan Press, 2003) — p. 349 for the manuscript count; and “Roger Bacon and His Edition of the Pseudo-Aristotelian *Secretum secretorum*,” *Speculum* 69, no. 1 (1994), 57–73. IN COPYRIGHT

Lawrence M. Principe and William R. Newman, “Some Problems with the Historiography of Alchemy,” in *Secrets of Nature: Astrology and Alchemy in Early Modern Europe*, ed. Newman and Anthony Grafton (MIT Press, 2001), 385–431; and Principe, *The Secrets of Alchemy* (Chicago, 2013), pp. 90–105, 98 — the argument that the inner-discipline reading descends from Mary Anne Atwood (1850) and Ethan Allen Hitchcock. Neither was reached directly for this edition; both are reported from Zuber. IN COPYRIGHT

Mike A. Zuber, *Spiritual Alchemy from the Age of Jacob Boehme to Mary Anne Atwood, 1600–1900* (PhD diss., Universiteit van Amsterdam, 2017), Introduction — the route by which the Principe–Newman positions, the list of their critics (p. 24) and the Khunrath material (pp. 50–51) were verified for this book. Open access, which is not the same as public domain.

Hereward Tilton, “Michael Maier: An Itinerant Alchemist in Late Renaissance Germany,” in *Furnace and Fugue: A Digital Edition of Michael Maier’s “Atalanta fugiens” (1618) with Scholarly Commentary*, ed. Tara Nummedal and Donna Bilak (University of Virginia Press, 2020) — the source for Maier’s laboratory work, the Carpathian mines, the *aurum potabile*, and his judgement of Khunrath. Open access, in copyright. Tilton’s

The Quest for the Phoenix (de Gruyter, 2003) is cited at p. 97 through Forshaw's note and was not reached directly.

Peter J. Forshaw, "Michael Maier and Mythoalchemy," in the same volume — for gold-making as part of Maier's repertoire and against relegating *Atalanta fugiens* to a "spiritual quest." Open access, in copyright.

Lawrence M. Principe, *The Aspiring Adept: Robert Boyle and His Alchemical Quest* (Princeton, 1998) — not reached directly; quoted through Linden, p. 234. William R. Newman, *Newton the Alchemist* (Princeton, 2019) — not reached; the 1936 Sotheby's sale and the "experimental chymistry" characterisation come from the publisher's description page, which is marketing copy rather than scholarship. The word count and the composition of the corpus are better anchored: *The Chymistry of Isaac Newton* project (W. R. Newman, gen. ed., Indiana University) gives about a million words across some hundred and thirty manuscripts, and describes the 1936 Sotheby's sale as three hundred twenty-nine lots, over a third of them alchemical. The project's own pages decline to settle what the papers were for. IN COPYRIGHT

Stanton J. Linden (ed.), *The Alchemy Reader: From Hermes Trismegistus to Isaac Newton* (Cambridge, 2003) — Introduction, p. 17, for the caution on the alchemical operations in Chapter 5; p. 16 for the coexistence of the metallic, medical and spiritual goals; p. 234, reporting Principe on Boyle. Verified for this edition from a full-text scan rather than the Cambridge printing, with the page fixed from the running heads of the adjacent leaves. IN COPYRIGHT

The Mirror of Alchimy (London: printed by Thomas Creede for Richard Olive, 1597) — the Elizabethan English of Hortulanus's commentary. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Stapleton, Lewis and Sherwood Taylor, "The Sayings of Hermes Quoted in the *Mā' al-Waraqī* of Ibn Umail," *Ambix* 3, nos 3–4 (1949), 69–90. IN COPYRIGHT

Allen G. Debus, *Alchemy and Early Modern Chemistry: Papers from Ambix* (Jeremy Mills, 2004), p. 415 — for Trithemius's metaphysical reading and its adoption by Dee, Agrippa and Gerhard Dorn. IN COPYRIGHT

The Chymistry of Isaac Newton, ed. William R. Newman (Indiana University, 2010) — diplomatic and normalised transcriptions of Newton's alchemical manuscripts, including Keynes MS. 28 (ALCH00017). Newton's wording is public domain; the project asserts rights over its editorial matter.

Julius Ruska, *Tabula smaragdina: ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der hermetischen Literatur* (Heidelberg: Winter, 1926), pp. 121, 166–67 — dates the *Sirr al-Khalīqa* 6th–8th c. Paul Kraus, *Jābir ibn Ḥayyān*, vol. II (Cairo: IFAO, 1942), pp. 274–75 — c. 813–833. Ursula Weisser, *Das "Buch über das Geheimnis der Schöpfung" von Pseudo-Apollonios*

von Tyana (Berlin/New York: de Gruyter, 1980), p. 54 — c. 750–800. Three datings, not two; “Kraus 1926” conflates Kraus with Ruska. Weisser’s text was not reached for this edition; the dating is reported from the literature.

Ronald Hutton, “Modern Pagan Festivals: A Study in the Nature of Tradition,” *Folklore* 119, no. 3 (2008), 251–74 — the standard account of the eightfold Wheel of the Year as a staged mid-20th-century assembly: quarter days alone in the 1940s liturgy, solstices c. 1953, equinoxes after 1954, equal status early 1958; Nichols instituting the Wiccan eight in his Druid order in 1964; Aidan Kelly applying Ostara, Litha and Mabon (his own account dates the calendar to 1974), spreading via *Green Egg* and reaching British usage in the 1980s. Of the eight names, Yule and the four Gaelic quarter days are old and were put to a new use; Ostara, Litha and Mabon are the modern coinages. IN COPYRIGHT

Ethan Doyle White, *Wicca: History, Belief, and Community in Modern Pagan Witchcraft* (Sussex Academic, 2015), ch. 13. IN COPYRIGHT

Christian H. Bull, *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus: The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom* (Brill, 2018) — for the dating of the *Hermetica*, the older underlying material, and Psellos as reader rather than compiler. IN COPYRIGHT

Ellic Howe, *The Magicians of the Golden Dawn* (1972) — for the Cipher Manuscripts, the grade numbering and the order’s documentary problems. IN COPYRIGHT

Graham John Wheeler, “A Microcosm of the Esoteric Revival: The Histories of the Lesser Banishing Ritual of the Pentagram,” *Correspondences: Journal for the Study of Esotericism* 8, no. 1 (2020), 5–44 — the first detailed source-analysis of the ritual, and the authority for the derivations given in Chapter 15. Open access under CC BY-NC 4.0, which is not the same as public domain.

Christopher A. Faraone and Sofia Torallas Tovar (eds), *Greek and Egyptian Magical Formularies*, vol. I (California Classical Studies, 2022) — renumbers the formularies, joins PGM VI to II, re-dates PGM I to the 3rd century, and describes Preisendanz’s second edition as obsolete. Open access, not public domain, and it qualifies the “numbering runs to LXXXI” framing of Chapter 9.

Jessica L. Lamont, “Orality, Written Literacy, and Early Sicilian Curse Tablets,” *Greece & Rome* 69, no. 1 (2022), 27–51 — open access (CC BY-NC-ND), not public domain.

Marcellin Berthelot and Charles-Émile Ruelle, *Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs* (Paris: Steinheil, 1887–88) — Zosimos, pseudo-Democritus, Leyden X and the Stockholm papyrus. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Auguste Audollent, *Defixionum tabellae* (Paris, 1904) — the curse tablets. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Paul Oskar Kristeller, *Studies in Renaissance Thought and Letters*, p. 223 — the pioneering study of Ficino's Hermetic translation. IN COPYRIGHT

What this edition could not reach

A bibliography that lists only what was found is half a bibliography. Below are the things this edition went after and did not get, with enough detail that the next person need not repeat the work. In every case the material exists and is out of copyright; what failed was access, or legibility, or both.

THE *PICATRIX*, IN ANY LANGUAGE

This is the hardest gap in the book, and it is not an accident of scanning. **No public-domain edition of the *Picatrix* exists.** The work was not printed at all before the twentieth century, and the modern editions — Ritter and Plessner's German of 1962, and the English translations — are all in copyright. What is freely available amounts to perhaps two hundred and fifty words of authentic Latin, transcribed inside Lynn Thorndike's *History of Magic and Experimental Science* (1923), plus a good deal of Thorndike describing the text in his own English.

That second category is the trap. Thorndike paraphrasing the *Picatrix* reads exactly like the *Picatrix* if it is set in the same type, and a chapter built from it would have manufactured a *Picatrix* that does not exist. The images of the decans, which are what most readers want from this book, are **not obtainable from any public-domain source**, and substituting Agrippa's images for them — which is what circulates — would be the same error in a different direction. Nothing is printed here rather than something misattributed.

THE HEBREW *SEFER RAZIEL HA-MALAKH*

Chapter 20 uses Sloane MS 3846, which is an English witness to the Latin *Liber Razielis*. The Hebrew book of nearly the same name, first printed at Amsterdam in 1701, is a different work and is not used here. No public-domain English translation of it was found, and the public-domain authorities do not even agree on its date — one line of scholarship puts the first part no earlier than the eleventh century, another reports its ascription to a thirteenth-century writer and holds that there is no criterion for dating its parts at all. That disagreement is itself worth knowing, and it is a large part of why no accessible English version was ever made.

Two habits of method are worth recording alongside these, because both cost time to learn. The 1651 Agrippa is invisible to a title search: the Early English Books collection generates its identifiers mechanically, and the volume surfaces only by wildcarding the collection prefix. And a keyword search on the Internet Archive queries *metadata*, not the contents of books — a zero result there is not a negative finding, and the only sound test is to fetch each candidate's text layer and search it locally.

A third is about which scan to fetch once you have found the book. Legibility does not track age or prestige; it tracks how the scanner's software was set up. Of Lémery's *Course of Chymistry*, the 1677 first English is the edition this book needs and its text layer reads every long *s* as an *f*, so a passage has to be repaired word by word and every repair declared. The 1720 fourth edition, scanned by a different programme, sets the long *s* correctly and can be quoted almost as it stands. That is a reason to open more than one scan even when only one edition will do — the others will settle characters the one you need has lost, which is how the five repairs in Chapter 29 were made.

Where to begin

A reader who wants to go to the primary sources rather than to summaries should start with Copenhaver for the *Hermetica*, Betz for the *Papyri*, Gorceix or a modern edition for the manifestos, and Yates for the historical context of the Rosicrucian episode. Of the public-domain texts, Mathers's *Key of Solomon* (1889) and Waite's *Real History* (1887) are freely available and remain worth reading, with the caveat that both are over a century old and neither reflects current scholarship. Preisendanz's first volume is on the Internet Archive for anyone who reads Greek, though only US readers can rely on that being lawful. Three further public-domain routes are worth naming: Mead's *Thrice-Greatest Hermes* (1906) for the *Hermetica*, Berthelot and Ruelle (1887–88) for the Greek alchemists, and Audollent (1904) for the curse tablets.

One caution about free texts, since this book has just spent a bibliography insisting on precision: **open access is not public domain**. Several of the works recommended here — Lamont, Wheeler, Bull, the Faraone and Torallas Tovar volume — are free to read and still fully in copyright, and one carries no licence at all. Free to read is a permission to read, not a permission to reproduce.

The single most useful habit, in this field more than most: when a source tells you a text is ancient, check the date yourself. It is often findable in a few minutes, and it is frequently not what you were told.

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Page numbers refer to the printed edition. Every reference below was resolved mechanically against the typeset pages rather than compiled by hand, so an entry points at every page where its subject is discussed, not only at the passage where it is introduced. Entries appear in the form a reader would look them up: people by surname, works by title. 610 entries.

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Final Warning

This grimoire contains material that should be used responsibly and ethically. Approach these practices with respect, humility and proper preparation. The path of Hermetic study is a long one, and it rewards patience far more than enthusiasm.

May this grimoire serve as a guide to Hermetic wisdom and Rosicrucian practice — and to the histories from which both were made. Use it wisely and with pure intention.